

Office Management

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Elisha Stephens

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PREFACE

Office management is the technique of planning, organizing, coordinating and controlling office activities with a view to achieve business objectives and is concerned with efficient and effective performance of the office work. The success of a business depends upon the efficiency of its office. The volume of paper work in offices has increased manifold in these days due to industrialization, population explosion, government control and application of various tax and labour laws to any business enterprise. Efficiency and effectiveness which are key words in management are achieved only through proper planning and control of activities, reduction of office costs and coordination of all activities of business.

In simple words, office management can be defined as “a distinct process of planning, organizing, staffing, directing, coordinating and controlling office in order to facilitate achievement of objectives of any business enterprise’ the definition shows managerial functions of an administrative manager.

Corporate office management jobs include the manager at each branch of a given company. The district manager (typically located at the head office) oversees all other branch managers, therefore traveling between company branch locations is often a main aspect of the job. Additionally, corporate office managers plan new organizational approaches for human resources and marketing campaigns.

The nature of business determines the environment of an office. The various office works have to be carried on under a particular condition or environment. A working environment is created and maintained for the smooth performance of office work. It is the duty and responsibility of an office manager to bring suitable environment by adopting various procedures and practice.

The office personnel must be aware of the purpose for which a particular work is carried on and the impact of such work on others’ performance. The office manager teaches the

purpose to office personal. If not so, the performance of office work does not bring the most efficient and economical use of office resources and achieve the objectives.

Office managers are in demand. As an office manager, you are an integral part of company operations that is responsible for supervising staff and maintaining office systems. Introduction to Management teaches you how to supervise others effectively. Office managers must carry out numerous administrative tasks. In some companies, you are also responsible for basic IT related tasks. Depending on the size of the company and corporate structure you work for, you could be a “jack of all trades” or have more specialized duties such as hiring and training new employees or addressing human resource issues within the office environment.

Organizing resources walks hand in hand toward achieving company goals with planning. These resources include materials, personnel, and financial backing. The next stage after planning for office managers is task delegation, such as identifying which materials are necessary and assigning those materials to chosen personnel. The best office managers consistently coordinate tasks in order to keep these resources moving toward planned goals.

Office management is not only necessary to business organization but also essential to non-business organization. In modern internet society also, there is a need of direction to the individual efforts towards common purpose or objective. The direction is given from a place i.e. office. The process can be treated as office management. A business is carried on by businessman with the help of group of persons. This group of persons has different interest, talent and motto. So, it is the function of office management to organize, guide and control the activities of such group of persons to achieve business objectives.

Office management involves the planning, design, implementation of work in an organization and its offices. This book creating a focused work environment, and guiding and coordinating the activities of office personnel to achieve business goals.

– *Elisha Stephens*

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Introduction

You know that decision making is at the very core of organization business activity. Decisions are based on the foundation of information which is supplied by the office. With increasing volume of business operations and its complexity, no business can be managed today without the assistance of clerical services provided by the office. Office acts as a storehouse and fountain of information. A well organised office is an indispensable aid to management. It facilitates management to plan its operations effectively. It would not be an exaggeration to say that office is the real brain behind every activity of a business enterprise.

It is mainly on the basis of information supplied by the office that management formulates its policies and programmes, and evaluates the results of business. The quality of managerial decision is as good as the information upon which they are based. For example, if management has to make a decision on new investment for launching a new product, its decision must be based on accurate information supplied by the office.

By stretching the example, one can understand the importance of office. A decision to make additional investment ought to “be based on such information as the estimated amount required, sources of finance cost, of capital, alternative investment proposals, etc. The office should provide the relevant information fully backed by data. After making the decision to invest, management would be interested in evaluating the results of the decisions.

This evaluation can be possible again on the basis of information provided by the office. Thus, information is the core of decision-making and decision-making is the essence of management.

An office not only provides all information on the basis of which decisions are made by management, it also provides the means of communication between different departments. This helps management to coordinate and direct the activities of different departments and persons operational in the organisation. Thus, office act as the eyes and ears of management. The office is of vital importance in a modern business enterprise due to the following reasons:

- It serves as a storehouse of information.
- It provides necessary linkage between departments.
- It aids management in decision-making
- It helps in co-ordinating activities.
- It controls cost of operations.
- It facilitates maintaining better relationship with:
 - (a) Customers,
 - (b) Employees,
 - (c) Suppliers,
 - (d) Government agencies,
 - (e) Banks, etc.

Is office work productive? While the importance of office is admitted, it may be asked whether the work done in an office is productive or not. For instance, is the work of a clerk making entries in books, a typist typing letters, or a messenger carrying messages from one person to another, productive? This is a question which is difficult to answer.

If the work done by a messenger or typist is unproductive, why are they engaged in large numbers for doing such jobs. And if it is not so, then to argue that clerks are no-productive is wrong.

Comparison between manufacturing activity and office work may give the impression that a manufacturing section is productive but the office is not, because the former yields physical product, while no tangible product is made in the office. However, to identify the real output of an office employee, we must look beyond the papers, i.e., at the overall achievements of the business enterprise, which could not have been possible without the clerical services provided by the office.

MEANING

Office manager is a profession related to office supervisory positions. People that hold office management positions conduct special studies and based on the results of these special studies, they develop reports.

Apart from developing reports, they also provide input to management on the development of policies and procedures. Office management may also provide paralegal support, and may draft correspondence for management, schedule appointments, etc.

Meaning of Office

In a fast changing society, every business venture is faced with fast ever-changing conditions. Techniques of production have undergone a rapid change and many new techniques are on the way. The ever-widening markets are a challenge by themselves. Also one has to take care of the emerging human relations in the business. Most of these problems of change can be tackled only with the help of “Information”. Recording, retaining, analysing and supplying the required information for various reasons to different persons are the basic needs of an enterprise. These activities taken together comprise an important ‘services’ function performed in the “office”. The term office is commonly used to mean a place where all paper work is undertaken. The common man’s view of an office is a place where some clerks and a few officers sit on chairs with a few files on their table doing some writing on paper. This viewpoint suggests (a) paperwork, (b) a definite place, and (c) work of a routine nature. But, office work is not confined to paper work only, and it may not be confined to a particular place.

The traditional sight of office (held by many even today) is that office work is concerned only with the records of the enterprise, i.e., making records, using records, and preserving them for future reference. Accordingly, the reason of an office is to provide only clerical assistance to other departments. It also suggests that office work does not involve any productive activity as it consists of routine clerical operations.

The traditional view does not explain all the functions performed by an office. The modern view is that office is the administrative centre of business where relevant records are prepared, preserved, and made available for the reason of efficient management of the organisation. In a wide sense, office represents service functions which, involve clerical work wherever it may be performed.

In a modern organisation, there are always some people to receive records and supply information and undertake related activities like receiving and mailing letters, typing and duplicating, maintaining files, etc. All these clerical activities constitute office services and are performed in the office. Thus, the term ‘office’ can be defined as any place where records are prepared, handled and preserved for future reference, and making them available as and when required. Needless to mention here that is the nature of work that is significant, and it is neither the place where it is done nor the persons.

Scope of the Office Activities

Essentially, office work is concerned with collect, processing and supplying information to business managers who need it for decision making. The relevant records must be prepared/ preserved and made available to the right person at the right time and in the right form. Office activities connected with records management involve receiving various documents, copying and duplicating, filing papers, classification of files, preserving, files and locating references quickly. Office work also includes processing and presenting numerical data in the form of declarations and reports, handling of inward and outward correspondence, and providing facilities for internal and external

communication. Further, the office may be required to maintain and provide public relations through press release's* and notifications, and to respond to public enquiries and complaint.

FUNCTIONS

The office manager is the coordinator of the work system. An office manager is responsible for planning, organization, and controlling the clerical aspect of the organization, including the preparation, communication, coordination and storage of data to support production and other important operations of an industrial establishment.

Often they also engage in marketing. Also, their tasks are to monitor the work processes and to evaluate the outcome. The outcomes of work are intended for what can be called the final receiving system, as for instance, client, customer, and other departments.

Furthermore, their role is to coordinate on the front and by issuing various assignments. They usually lead or manage a team of secretaries or administrative clerks. And they take care of the assignment of tasks within the department, but the more complex tasks tend come to their desk.

Positions allocated to usual classification perform a combination of the following office management functions:

- Budget development and implementation
- Purchasing
- Human resources
- Accounting
- Printing
- Records management
- Forms management
- Payroll
- Facilities management
- Space management
- Risk management
- Grants administration
- Affirmative action and equal employment opportunity
- Information technology and telecommunications
- Monitoring the management of health and safety in the company office
- Assisting senior managers in identifying health and safety needs in their departments
- Responsibility for the day to day running of the office
- Liaising with senior managers to ensure that staff in the division have appropriate information technology equipment
- Managing a range of budgets including accommodation, health and safety for company

- Plan, consult and manage office moves for the division and other units within the department

Considering the diversity of functions, someone holding an office manager position is expected to have many talents. Some of the competencies which he or she is expected to possess are problem solving and decision making abilities, integrity, assertivity, flexibility, accuracy and the ability to cope with pressure.

SEVEN WAYS TO CONTROL CHAOS IN YOUR SMALL BUSINESS

Sound familiar? If so, chaos has crept into your small business – and is probably busy spreading throughout your organization like a virus. Disorganization and confusion are irritating, but they're also just plain bad for business. Think of it as a formula, if you like: chaos increasing equals profits decreasing. What to do? Control chaos by applying these basic office management principles:

ESTABLISH OFFICE MANAGEMENT ROUTINES AND STICK TO THEM

Routine tasks need routine procedures if you want to stay organized and keep things running smoothly. Set up routines for handling paperwork and office systems. For instance, every piece of paper that comes into your office should be handled once, acted upon, and filed – not haphazardly piled on a desk.

Office systems, such as computers, will need both administration and what I call panic mode procedures.

When the system crashes or a computer-related piece of equipment fails, everyone in your office needs to know who to call and what not to do. These data management substances provide helpful tips for everything from office filing systems through computer backup procedures.

SET UP CLEARLY DELINEATED RESPONSIBILITIES

Good office management depends on people knowing who is responsible for what – it's people who are accountable who get things done. What would happen, for example, if the purchasing for your small business was done by whoever whenever? Would you be able to find a paper clip when you wanted one?

Or print off a report when you needed to? Putting one person in charge of ordering all equipment and supplies solves the problem and keeps things running smoothly. It's the same with systems administration.

You need to have one person responsible for the security of your computer system and keeping track of things such as accounts, passwords and software. Otherwise, chaos will proliferate.

KEEP RECORDS – AND KEEP YOUR BUSINESS RECORDS UPDATED

Keeping records sounds like the easiest part of good office management – until you consider the need to keep those records both accessible and updated. But my first rule for controlling chaos will help you get a grip on this; make updating records an office routine. When you get a new customer or client, for instance, it only takes a moment to enter him into your contacts database. Then it will only take another moment or two to update the record after you’ve spoken to him on the phone.

TAKE A WALK THROUGH YOUR OFFICE AND HAVE A SIT

Is your office an example of space management or space mis-management? When you walk through the office, do you have to detour around obstacles or run the risk of tripping over something? When you sit down at a desk, could you actually work comfortably there? Are things logically arranged so that the things that you would use most at the desk are closest to hand? There are a lot of things crammed into offices nowadays, from printer stands through filing cabinets. For good office management, you need to be sure that all the things in the office are arranged for maximum efficiency – and maximum safety. The Basics of Small or Home Office Design provides tips for safely meeting the power, lighting and ventilation needs of your office space.

SCHEDULE THE SCUT WORK

It’s too easy to put off things that you don’t like doing, and I don’t know very many people that enjoy scut work. Unfortunately, an office, like a kitchen, won’t function well without a certain amount of scut work being done. If you are a small business owner who’s in the position of not being able to assign whatever you view as scut work to someone else, force yourself to get to it regularly by scheduling time each week for it. Take a morning or afternoon, for instance, and spend it making the cold calls or catching up on the accounting.

DELEGATE AND OUTSOURCE

In a perfect world, everyone would only be doing what he or she had time to do and did well. As the world is not perfect, instead a lot of people are doing things that they don’t have the time or talent to do well.

Delegating and outsourcing can not only improve your small business’s office management, but free you to focus on your talents as well, thereby improving your bottom line. Virtual assistants can handle many of your office or administrative tasks.

MAKE BUSINESS PLANNING A PRIORITY

Many small business owners spend their days acting and reacting – and then wonder why they seem to be spinning their wheels. Business planning is an important component of good office management and needs to be part of your regular office management routine. Successful small business owners spend time every week on business planning,

and many use daily business planning sessions as a tool for goal setting and growth. If you have staff, involve them in business planning, either formally or informally.

Don't let chaos interfere with doing business. Once you start applying these seven principles of good office management, you'll be amazed at the difference good office management makes – and how much more business you do.

THE OFFICE MANAGEMENT DEFINITION

In the development of understanding between the Management office (office management) with administration office (office administration) often interpret interpret commensurate and both he turns used in the same sense, although in the history of its development is more widely used term administration of state affairs, while the term Management used more in the affairs of the company's performance, but recent developments in the broader management use in the affairs of State. By following the norm that, in a further description will not perbedakan term in office administration with a management office, which is more important in understanding the two terms are explained clearly. Regarding the definition office management, there are some definitions that can convey, among others:

- (1) Geogre R. Terry in his book "Office management and control" state office management cans be defined as the planning, controlling, and organizing of office work. And actualing those performing it so as to Achieve the predetermined objectives. It deals with the life cycle of business information and data from Their creation through Their maintenance, distribution, and retention, it of permanent value, or destruction if obsolete. This means that the management office can be define as planning, controlling and organizing the work of offices, as well as the mobilization of those who carry it out in order to achieve goals - goals that have been determined in advance. This question has to do with the circulation of live data and business information, and since its creation through maintenance, dissemination, and storage that has a fixed or Destruction when it becomes obsolete.
- (2) Littlefleid & Paterson performance in his book "Modern Office Management many takan that" The terms of office management will from be Used in Such a broad sense in third book, it will of be Considered to encompass the management of office work Wherever and by whomever performed "means term of office management will be used in a broad sense, so that in this book, it will he considered include the management of an office job anywhere and by anyone in doing.
- (3) Arthur H. Grager in his book, "the National Office Management Association report card.

Management Office is the Fungtion of administering the communications and records services of an organization, meaning that the management office is a function of spatial organization of the communication and service slips of an organization. From the definitions above it can be concluded, that the management office is a certain function

which is a series of activities merencanakan, organizing directing, supervising and controlling up to organize activities in an orderly manner managing achieved an employment goal, both goals in the State organizations and companies.

While understanding the office is an organizational unit that functions to provide services tatausaha activities and other activities for the purpose of management in its efforts to achieve organizational goals, using resources in order to reach destination services office that has been laid before.

OFFICE MANAGER: JOB DESCRIPTION AND ACTIVITIES

JOB DESCRIPTION

Office managers organise and supervise all of the administrative activities that facilitate the smooth running of an office.

An office manager carries out a range of administrative and IT-related tasks, depending on the employing organisation, and the work may vary from running the administrative side of a small employer's business as a sole administrator to overseeing the office work of numerous staff. Although the nature of office managers' work differs greatly across organisations, they all have the responsibility for ensuring that their office runs efficiently. Job titles vary and office managers are often called office administrators, especially at more junior levels.

TYPICAL WORK ACTIVITIES

The role varies according to the type of employer, the size of the organisation and the management structure, but activities typically include:

- Using a range of office software, including email, spreadsheets and databases;
- Managing filing systems;
- Developing and implementing new administrative systems, such as record management;
- Recording office expenditure and managing the budget;
- Organising the office layout and maintaining supplies of stationery and equipment;
- Maintaining the condition of the office and arranging for necessary repairs;
- Organising and chairing meetings with your staff - in lower paid roles this may include typing the agenda and taking minutes, but senior managers usually have an administrative assistant to do this;
- Overseeing the recruitment of new staff, sometimes including training and induction;
- Ensuring adequate staff levels to cover for absences and peaks in workload, often by using temping agencies;

- Carrying out staff appraisals, managing performance and disciplining staff;
- Delegating work to staff and managing their workload and output;
- Promoting staff development and training;
- Implementing and promoting equality and diversity policy;
- Holding meetings with senior management to review performance;
- Liaising with other administrative teams;
- Writing reports for senior management, which may include reports on finances, staff performance, service development or an annual review;
- Delivering presentations about the work of the office to senior management and other sections of the organisation;
- Involvement in management discussions on the organisation's policies and strategic development;
- Responding to customer enquiries and complaints;
- Reviewing and updating health and safety policies and ensuring they are observed;
- Arranging regular testing for electrical equipment and safety devices;
- Attending conferences and training.

SALARY AND CONDITIONS

- Range of typical starting salaries: £18,500 - £30,000.
- Range of typical salaries at senior level/with experience (e.g., after 10 - 15 years in the role): £30,000 - £50,000.
- Salaries vary significantly between organisations, and usually depend on the size of the team you manage, the responsibilities of the post, the size of the organisation and the type of industry you are employed in.
- Working hours are usually nine to five, although office managers are often expected to come in early and work late during busy periods.
- Work is office-based. In a small organisation, the office manager may share a room with other administrative staff or even manage an office alone. In bigger organisations, the office manager oversees the work of a large body of staff, who may work in a number of small rooms throughout a building or in vast, open-plan offices.
- There are few opportunities for self-employment, although starting your own business often requires taking on many of the functions of an office manager.
- Although most office manager positions are offered as full-time posts, part-time work is sometimes available. Some organisations offer job-sharing.
- Gender balance in this role varies between sectors. Industries that employ a higher percentage of women than men, such as education or health, are more likely to recruit female office managers, bearing in mind that candidates are often recruited internally. The reverse is true for male dominated professions. However, in many industries there is a fairly equal gender balance.

- Jobs are available throughout the UK. There are more jobs in towns and cities, although office managers are also needed in smaller businesses in rural locations.
- In most posts, smart, professional dress is expected, particularly in customer-facing roles.
- The work may be stressful, since an office manager is often responsible for meeting targets and deadlines, and for disciplining staff.
- Some travel during the day may be necessary, particularly in split site locations. Travel to other parts of the UK for training and conferences and, in large organisations, to other branch offices, may also be required, sometimes involving overnight absence from home. Overseas travel is rarely needed.

OFFICE MANAGER: ENTRY REQUIREMENTS

Although this area of work is open to all graduates and Diplomates, relevant degree and HND/foundation degree subjects include business, management and IT.

In particular, the following degree/HND/foundation degree subjects may improve your chances:

- Business administration/business management;
- Computing and information technology;
- Human resource management;
- Management;
- Public administration.

Many employers will consider candidates with relevant HND or foundation degree qualifications.

Experience is highly valued in office management positions, so some employers do not ask for a degree as this may block applications from experienced non-graduate candidates. Entry without a degree, HND or foundation degree is therefore possible for those who have relevant skills and work experience. A pre-entry postgraduate qualification is not usually necessary, but may be considered desirable by some employers, particularly in a business-related field.

Candidates will need to show evidence of the following skills and personal qualities:

- Good oral and written communication skills;
- Excellent interpersonal and negotiating skills;
- Good time management and organisational skills;
- Leadership ability;
- Confidence and resilience;
- Initiative;
- Problem-solving skills;
- Project management ability;
- Excellent IT skills.

Experience of working in an office is essential, so relevant work experience is important, particularly in a related industry. Graduates can gain experience through recruitment agencies or junior administrative posts.

Candidates will also need to demonstrate good team working and management skills. Taking on a volunteer project or managing a team of volunteers is a good way of acquiring these skills, particularly if you have not had the opportunity to apply them in a work environment. A familiarity with legislation in the areas of employment, equality and diversity, and data protection can also be useful. Competition varies between employment sectors, but office manager positions usually attract a large number of applications. Relevant office experience, particularly with the same organisation, can dramatically improve your chances. It is illegal for employers to discriminate against candidates on the grounds of age, gender, race, disability, sexual orientation or religious faith.

OFFICE MANAGER: TRAINING

Training opportunities depend on the employer and the nature of the post, although most employers offer at least basic training. Large organisations often provide training in-house, while smaller organisations rely more on regional and national training organisations. Informal on the job training is also common.

The type of training provided will depend on the nature of the post, but most organisations provide training in the following areas:

- Equality and diversity legislation;
- Health and safety;
- IT software including Access and Excel;
- Staff management and appraisals;
- Recruitment and selection;
- Stress management;
- Time management;
- Assertiveness.

Office managers who take on substantial extra duties, such as managing the office finances or personnel policies, may need to study for a diploma, HND or degree in the relevant subject area. In smaller companies, training courses are usually taken on your own initiative, but are often paid for by the employer. Training budgets may be restricted so it is likely that office managers will do much of their training informally and on the job.

OFFICE MANAGER: CAREER DEVELOPMENT

An office manager role is not usually an entry-level position, and you will be expected to have gained previous administrative or managerial experience, preferably in a related sector. Once in the post, career development may take a variety of routes. It may involve taking on extra responsibilities, such as managing more staff or taking on some senior

management responsibilities. Or it may involve managing a different office in the organisation, usually one which has a larger workforce or carries more responsibility. For example, the employee may move from managing a small team in the finance section, to managing the whole finance department. However, after extensive experience as an office manager, career development is likely to involve a step up into senior management, and later to head of department. Stages in career development often depend on the organisation and employment sector you work for, but most organisations encourage office managers to take on extra responsibility. This may be in such sections as finance, human resources and strategic development. Bottlenecks can occur for senior posts, particularly when there is a large number of office managers in the organisation. Developing a specialism may help if it is relevant to the post.

OFFICE MANAGER: TYPICAL EMPLOYERS

Office managers are employed across the board in the public, private and charity sectors – in short by any organisation that runs an office, from small businesses to public bodies and multinational corporations.

Typical employers include:

- NHS and private healthcare organisations;
- Educational establishments, including schools and further and higher education institutions;
- Local and central government bodies;
- Charities and community groups;
- Financial services organisations;
- Legal sector organisations;
- Social work organisations;
- Entertainment, media and leisure groups;
- Engineering firms;
- Transport companies;
- Retailers, wholesalers and distributors;
- Manufacturers across all branches of industry;
- Science organisations;
- Security services;
- Public utilities – gas, electricity, water and telecommunications providers;
- Organisations in the creative industries.

THE ROLE OF AN OFFICE MANAGER

An office manager has a wide variety of duties and functions that, when performed correctly, will help the office to operate and function at a higher level. As an office manager you are usually accountable for other employees. It's important to communicate and let everyone know what is going on within the organization.

OPERATIONS

An office manager is going to be responsible for the operations of the branch. They must make sure everything is functioning as it should.

COMMUNICATION

When you are an office manager, you have to make sure you are in communication with your employees. They must know what their roles and duties are and what you expect from them.

GOALS

Employees should have clearly defined goals and objectives that are measurable, attainable, and they should be written in an action plan.

FEEDBACK

Office managers are responsible for providing constructive criticism and feedback to employees which helps them to make the necessary corrections to their performance.

SUPPLIES

An office manager has to order supplies and equipment and make sure everyone has the tools needed to perform their jobs.

VARIANCES

Office managers also have to plan, organize, coordinate, direct and persuade during the course of their day. Ultimately the office manager has to make sure the office is hitting the stated goals and objectives and explain any variances after reviewing the branch reports.

RESPONSIBILITIES OF AN OFFICE MANAGER

An individual who holds the position of office manager has a wide array of diverse duties and responsibilities which must be performed on a daily basis. The office manager has a role in many different businesses and their exact duties and responsibilities will depend on the type of business, size of the business and role which they play within the business.

GENERAL RESPONSIBILITIES OF AN OFFICE MANAGER

There are a number of general responsibilities concomitant with the role of office manager. These will vary from business to business but many of the responsibilities include hiring and firing of employees, ordering supplies, performing payroll duties,

performing accounting duties, taking phone calls and performing general everyday tasks necessary for the efficient running of the business. Most businesses have one primary office manager however some may have two or more individuals who share the managerial duties.

SPECIFIC DUTIES OF THE OFFICE MANAGER

An office manager will perform various specific duties in their professional role. In many businesses, an office manager is the individual who is responsible for hiring and firing the staff. They will place advertisements looking for employees and also perform the interviews of potential future employees. They may also be responsible for firing any employees who do not meet the requirements of the company.

One who is an office manager may need to order supplies for the company which they work for in their role as office manager. This will be a pertinent responsibility on the part of the office manager. In order to ensure that all supplies are ordered when needed, the office manager will most likely have to perform frequent checks on the supply cabinet to make sure that items are always in stock.

Frequently the office manager is also responsible for performing payroll duties for the business. The office manager will keep track of the hours which each employee works in addition to the set pay for employees. This individual will write out payroll checks and distribute such funds to the employees on payday.

One who works as an office manager may also need to perform accounting duties for the entire business. Not only does this relate to money coming into the business but money going out as well. They will perform the accounting and may even be responsible for the tax calculations when tax season comes around. This duty may be simple or complex, depending upon the business and role of the office manager.

The office manager is an individual who may also have a hand in the general office building structure as well. The office manager may pay the office building rent as well as bills relating to electric, gas and water utilities. Should renovations take place throughout the office, the office manager is the one who will most likely oversee those projects as the employer probably will not want to be too involved with projects such as these. One who has the job of an office manager may also be responsible for performing clerical duties on a daily basis. Tasks such as answering phones, filing and typing up documents may be a daily occurrence which the office manager may need to handle. Depending on the business, these may be simple tasks which take a few minutes or lengthy ones which take a few hours time.

An office manager is often responsible for listening to complaints as well. These complaints may come from the staff members or outside parties who have issues with the business itself. It is up to the office manager to listen attentively, address the situation and come up with complete resolutions to the problem. Some issues may be addressed solely by the office manager whereas others will need to be addressed by the employers themselves.

POSITIVE TRAITS WHICH ALL OFFICE MANAGERS MUST POSSESS

One important trait which all office managers should have is that of adequate problem solving skills. Since the office manager is the individual who one goes to in order to have their complaints resolved the office manager must be a good problem solver by nature. Even if the office manager cannot solve the problem on their own, they must know who to go to so that the problem can be solved by someone, if not themselves.

An office manager should also be personable in nature. Since these are individuals who need to deal with others, both inside and outside of the office environment, it is pertinent for office managers to be good conversationalists. They must be at ease while conversing with others as this will enable them to get the job done in the most efficient way possible.

Good mathematical skills are another positive trait for office managers to possess as they will be working with numbers on a frequent basis. Not only do office managers have to perform payroll duties but they may need to perform accounting tasks as well. Those who have good mathematical skills will be able to get the job done as quickly as possible.

Another positive trait for office managers to possess is good multitasking skills. Frequently an office manager will feel himself or herself being pulled in every different direction so it is important for the office manager to know how to do multiple things at one time.

Lastly, office managers should be leaders by nature. They should be comfortable with filling a lead position and be able to resolve all problems which come their way. By being a natural leader, the office manager will be able to complete their daily duties in a timely and efficient manner.

Elements of Office Management

The following constitute the elements of office management:

Personnel: Well-trained personnel is required to perform various office activities. Office machines cannot completely replace human effort, but can only help the office staff in doing their work accurately and quickly.. Recruitment, training, and placement of office employees and their incentive constitute an important element of office management.

Objectives: Office management is worried with the attainment of certain desired objectives, through and with the cooperation of office staff. Office objectives can be classified as service, profit and social responsibilities.

Office work is expected to assist and help other functional departments in performing their work efficiently. Therefore, service is an important objective of managing office work. Performance of office work efficiently contributes to work and profitability. Social responsibilities stress the attainment of goals in accordance with certain moral and ethical codes laid down by the industry and society in which the enterprise operates.

Means: The methods which are adopted to achieve the desired objectives are called the means. The office manager must use the most suitable materials, and standard equipments, required for the performance of work by the office staff. This requires full information about nature of office machines and equipments available and their application in day to day office work.

Environment: Office environment plays a major role in the performance of office work by its staff. Office personnel spend best part of their life in working for the organisation.

The surroundings in which office employees work must be congenial. Proper lighting, ventilation, colouring of walls, and availability of other common facilities ensure better atmosphere for work.

Major Processes, of Office Management

Let us now have bird's eye view of major functions or processes of office management. There are five basic functions involved in the management of any office. They are:

Planning: It is mental exercise requiring use of imagination, foresight, and "sound judgement in determining what, when, where, how and by whom the activities are to be carried out. Planning is nothing but laying down a course of action to realise goals. Planning of office functions involves taking decisions with regard to factors affecting office work. While short-term planning involves arrangement of office functions to cope with the current situation, the long-range planning includes foreseeing future requirements of the office, such as space, layout, computer application, human resource planning, etc.

Office planning requires (i) Setting objectives, (ii) Formulating policies and programmes, (iii) Laying down procedures.

- (i) *Objectives:* Planning has no meaning without being related to objectives. The main objectives of the office are: (1) to supply right information to the right persons at right time and at the minimum cost, and (2) to provide efficient clerical service to the functional departments.
- (ii) *Policies and Programmes:* Policies are guide to administrative action. Well drawn policies and programmes go a long way in ensuring smooth functioning of office activities. Thus, declarations of promotion policy, training policy, etc. enable office workers to work harmoniously with minimum conflict. A programme refers to the sequences of activities which are required to implement policies.
- (iii) *Procedures:* A procedure or routine refers to the series of steps to be taken to complete a particular office work. It is a planned sequence of operations for handling a recurring office activity informally and consistently. In most offices a manual is prepared which contains procedures laid down for major office activities. The manual serves as a guide to the employees and ensures uniformity of working.

Organising: The organising function involves location up of departments, preparing job descriptions, designing the organisation structure with necessary authority and responsibility for each position, and establishing a proper communication system. Providing necessary equipments' and furniture for office work is also a part of the organising function.

Controlling: Plans, policies and programmes cannot be effective unless there is a control mechanism to guide and direct the execution of work. To control the implementation of planned work, the following steps are required to be taken: (a) establish norms or standards of work, (b) record actual performance (c) compare actual performance with the standards set and (d) adopt corrective measures where necessary. Control basically refers to evaluation and rectification of performance of subordinates in order to ensure the achievement of planned results.

Staffing: The staffing function relates to personnel matters. Right type of people are to be employed to man various positions. For this reason, suitable personnel must be recruited and prodream made for their training for specific jobs. Individuals selected for particular jobs must also be informed about their duties and responsibilities.

Directing and Coordinating: Directing includes several sub functions: Issue of orders and instructions to subordinates, guiding them at work, superdream of day to day operations, and motivating people for better performance. Coordinating refers to the orderly arrangement of individual and group efforts so as to secure harmony of different activities. It involves synchronisation of different operations and efforts of individuals and groups with regard to the pace, timing and sequence of work so that the planned objectives may be achieved without delay and interruptions.

How to Manage Virtual Offices Effectively

Today's world is one of globalization. For businesses, advances in technology have provided opportunities for employees to work side by side, even when thousands of miles apart. However, as the possibilities of cross-globe interaction continue to increase, the concept of virtual offices is much debated.

With announcements such as Yahoo's revoking employees' work-at-home privileges, virtual offices are often painted in a negative light and may be associated with words such as "unproductive." The counter argument that supports remote work is governed by a simple premise: There's no shame in being virtual as long as the job gets done.

The key to success is creating an environment where remote employees are able to flourish.

This requires both an adjustment of company mindset and a robust IT system. Companies that build an IT infrastructure that supports a remote environment are primed for success, and they can use their multi-location business as a selling point.

Saying that a virtual work environment does not come with challenges would be ignoring reality. Perhaps the biggest hurdle is the impact it has on employee communications. The plus side to a traditional office setting is the physical environment

it provides for collaboration, management and oversight. The communication that is fostered in such an environment is unrivaled. But IT can provide an effective solution to this challenge.

Integrate essential software into the daily Routine

Perhaps the most difficult aspect of remote work is the lack of physical interaction, so any IT infrastructure for virtual offices must establish a two-way flow of communication. Companies can take advantage of software and software-as-a-service (SaaS) systems, which help foster a productive working environment, despite geographically dispersed physical locations.

Basic products such as Skype, Basecamp, Tempo, Outlook, Dropbox, FreeConferenceCall, Google Voice and Google Hangout are all effective and relatively low-cost systems that directly affect a business' bottom line. Sourcing all work through your software of choice instills a habit in your team to always utilize the program, while also providing a setting for seamless communication.

Don't forget the importance of appropriate Hardware

Like the power of software, the hardware that a business uses has a direct impact on its virtual capabilities. Modern technology has made remote access a popular, growing phenomenon, with more than half of adult mobile phone users accessing the Internet via their mobile devices.

For the business world, this expands the possibility of employees accomplishing their work at any location. Providing smartphones, tablets and/or laptops combined with a WiFi hotspot is the simplest recipe for success. And while this may seem a no-brainer, these often-overlooked details are incredibly important for a functioning virtual office. It's important to make sure that all employees are equipped with a reliable smartphone and laptop, as well as a competent Internet access system.

It's all about the state of Mind

As mentioned before, the main challenge often associated with virtual offices is physical separation that can lead to a breakdown in communication. This is an easy fix that can be accomplished by simply adjusting your mentality. In order to make a remote environment work, you must alter your outlook so that you are approaching the situation in a realistic way.

Particularly for businesses with global employees, building time-zone relationships is essential. A virtual business will thrive only when its employees have achieved the ability to use all of their mental and technical capacities through the software, hardware, services and personnel you employ.

Creating an environment in which communication is promoted is only half the equation. The IT infrastructure you deploy must focus on the organization and centralization of information.

Security is Critical

From an IT perspective, perhaps the most challenging aspect of remote offices is establishing a secure system for communication. Allowing remote workers to access the corporate network can potentially open a business to a breach in security.

Fortunately, technology has provided solutions to this problem. Products such as Log Me In, VueZone and eKeys for eLocks are examples of effective products that are simple to integrate into an existing IT infrastructure. These products provide top-notch security, as well as peace of mind.

Despite the commonly held notion that virtual offices deter from work product and productivity, businesses can succeed and flourish in a remote environment. With the technology and tools available today, it's a much easier process than one might think. Building an IT infrastructure that supports remote work can be the key to a business' success.

Effective Performance Management

There is a famous story about a naive student in his first English literature course who was worried because he didn't know what prose was.

When he found out that prose was ordinary speech, he exclaimed, "Wow! I've been speaking prose all my life!" Managing performance well is like speaking prose. Many managers have been "speaking" and practicing effective performance management naturally all their supervisory lives, but don't know it!

Some people mistakenly assume that performance management is concerned only with following regulatory requirements to appraise and rate performance. Actually, assigning ratings of record is only one part of the overall process (and perhaps the least important part). Performance management is the systematic process of:

- Planning work and setting expectations,
- Continually monitoring performance,
- Developing the capacity to perform,
- Periodically rating performance in a summary fashion, and
- Rewarding good performance.

The revisions made in 1995 to the Governmentwide performance appraisal and awards regulations support "natural" performance management. Great care was taken to ensure that the requirements those regulations establish would complement and not conflict with the kinds of activities and actions effective managers are practicing as a matter of course.

Planning

Effective managers plan their work. Planning means setting performance expectations and goals for groups and individuals to channel their efforts toward achieving organizational objectives. Getting employees involved in the planning process will help them understand the goals of the organization, what needs to be done, why it needs to

be done, and how well it should be done. The regulatory requirements for planning employees' performance include establishing the elements and standards of their performance appraisal plans. Performance elements and standards should be measurable, understandable, verifiable, equitable, and achievable.

Through critical elements, employees are held accountable as individuals for work assignments or responsibilities. Employee performance plans should be flexible so that they can be adjusted for changing program objectives and work requirements. When used effectively, these plans can be beneficial working documents that are discussed often, and not merely paperwork that is filed in a drawer and seen only when ratings of record are required.

Monitoring

Effective managers see to it that assignments and projects are monitored continually. Monitoring well means consistently measuring performance and providing ongoing feedback to employees and work groups on their progress toward reaching their goals.

Regulatory requirements for monitoring performance include conducting progress reviews with employees where their performance is compared against their elements and standards. Ongoing monitoring provides the supervisor the opportunity to check how well employees are meeting predetermined standards and to make changes to unrealistic or problematic standards. And by monitoring continually, supervisors can identify unacceptable performance at any time during the appraisal period and provide assistance to address such performance rather than wait until the end of the period when summary rating levels are assigned.

Developing

Effective managers evaluate and address the developmental needs of their employees. Developing in this instance means increasing the capacity to perform through training, giving assignments that introduce new skills or higher levels of responsibility, improving work processes, or other methods. Providing employees with training and developmental opportunities encourages good performance, strengthens job-related skills and competencies, and helps employees keep up with changes in the workplace, such as the introduction of new technology.

Carrying out the processes of performance management provides an excellent opportunity for supervisors and employees to identify developmental needs. While planning and monitoring work, deficiencies in performance become evident and should be addressed. Areas for improving good performance also stand out, and action can be taken to help successful employees improve even further.

Rating

An effective manager will, from time to time, find it useful to summarize employee performance. This helps the manager look at and compare performance over time or

across a set of employees. Organizations need to know who their best performers are. Within the context of formal performance appraisal requirements, rating means evaluating employee or group performance against the elements and standards in an employee's performance plan and assigning a summary rating of record. The rating of record is assigned according to procedures included in the organization's appraisal program. It is based on work performed during an entire appraisal period. The rating of record has a bearing on various other personnel actions, such as granting within-grade pay increases and determining additional retention service credit in a reduction in force.

Rewarding

Effective managers understand the importance of using rewards well. Rewarding means recognizing employees, individually and as members of groups, for their performance and acknowledging their contributions to the agency's mission. A basic principle of effective management is that all behavior is controlled by its consequences. Those consequences can and should be both formal and informal and both positive and negative.

Good managers don't wait for their organization to solicit nominations for formal awards before recognizing good performance. Recognition is an ongoing, natural part of day-to-day experience. A lot of the actions that reward good performance like saying "Thank you" don't require a specific regulatory authority. Nonetheless, awards regulations provide a broad range of forms that more formal rewards can take, such as cash, time off, and many nonmonetary items. The regulations also cover a variety of contributions that can be rewarded, from suggestions to group accomplishments.

Performance Management as Prose

Good managers have been speaking and practicing effective performance management all their lives, executing each key component process well. They not only set goals and plan work routinely, they measure progress toward those goals and give feedback to employees. They set high standards, but they also take care to develop the skills needed to reach them. And they use formal and informal rewards to recognize the behavior and results that accomplish their mission. All five components working together and supporting each other achieve natural, effective performance management.

Office Organizing Tips

1. Clean out each desk drawer, to free up even more valuable storage space.
2. Clear off the top of your desk, then wipe off the surface of the desktop.
3. Keep essential items on your desktop (computer, phone, fax, card file).
4. If you work with more than one person create an in box for each person.
5. Have a master to-do list for each day at your desk.
6. Pre-Sort the mail. To-File, To-Read, To-Contact(write or call).
7. Use a variety of containers to organize office supplies, paper clips and pens.

8. Use a variety of desktop organizers or trays to organize papers that come across your desk.
9. Create a separate drawer for personal paperwork, items, etc.
10. Use storage boxes to store dated files.
11. Purchase Magazine boxes to store booklets, magazines, catalogs you want to keep.
12. Create a file for magazine articles or scan them into your computer.
13. Filing system should be simple easy and manageable.
14. Color-coding your files makes it faster to find information.
15. Do not over stuff folders. It may be time to toss some of the information in the folder.
16. Never overload filing drawer. It will make it difficult to retrieve information in the drawers.
17. Sub-divide larger files with interior file folders.
18. Tab hanging file folders in the front.
19. Return calls in batches. Leave specific messages and the time you called if the person you're trying to reach isn't available.
20. Empty workspace of everything but the project you're working on to cut down on distractions.
21. Keep an assortment of all-occasion cards and stamps in your desk.
22. Keep takeout menus from favorite restaurants so you can order ahead and pick up dinner on your way home.
23. When using more than one checking account, color coded checks are an easy way to identify each account.
24. At the end of each project or event, organize paperwork and file or store it.
25. Straighten desk at the end of the day and especially at the end of the week so that you can start each morning with a clear desk.

Totally Organized is a professional organizing company devoted to help you make the most of your day and get more quality free time.

EFFECTIVELY MANAGING MULTIPLE OFFICE LOCATIONS

According to the 2015 ECP Compensation Study, office managers who are responsible for multiple-location practices are earning, on average, 31.5% more than those managing single offices. The reason for this is likely due to the fact that multiple locations come with a great deal of work and responsibilities. Different time zones, environments, and personalities can create unique challenges for each business location. Managers need to find ways to encourage cohesiveness so everyone feels a part of the team no matter what location they work in. So how can you more effectively manage multiple locations? Consider these tips:

Embrace New Technology

The reason people are able to work so effectively from virtually anywhere today is due to solid internet connections and helpful applications that ensure we are still able to communicate effectively despite distance limitations. If you aren't able to embrace technology and how it can help your business, you are creating more work for yourself as a manager, and that list of office manager duties will only get longer and harder to navigate. Although custom-built software and VPN systems have served as helpful tools before, there are many viable options available that are robust and require far less IT and financial commitment. Here are a few more commonly used applications that help multiple locations communicate more effectively:

- Salesforce.com: Collaborate about your sales and opportunities in real-time with this popular CRM tool.
- Basecamp: This project management tool gives you the ability to manage a variety of projects with a simplistic and easy-to-use web platform.
- Google Gmail/Documents/Calendar: Give your employees access to their work documents from anywhere using Google. Having instant access to appointment information, email, and important business-related documents will enable your employees to easily get what they need right when they need it.

Make Communication King

Tools can help, but real communication tops them all. Every office should feel equally involved in how the business functions, and the only way to do that is through effective communication. A robust phone system like ShoreTel Sky should be accessible for every employee so they can connect quickly and easily. The CEO or owner of the business should make regular trips to each location to connect and hear employee concerns. A weekly team meeting where everyone participates should be a priority. And lastly, plan to have the entire team together at least once a year to participate in brainstorm sessions and team building events.

Get Systems in Order

Systems provide the ability to duplicate offices and reduce the amount of supervision needed to get work done. Establishing roles, responsibilities, and authority helps prevent possible issues caused by confused employees. Ensure each employee knows what the organizational structure of the business is, as well as what they are responsible for and measured upon. This encourages a clear sense of accountability no matter where someone is working. Implementing new technologies and systems partnered with effective communication can help you navigate the growing list of office manager duties.

At Matrix Networks, we know how to implement solutions that help businesses connect and communicate, no matter how many locations they have. Contact us today to see how we can help you increase productivity and effectively manage all branches of your business.

2

Team Leadership and Management in Office

TEAM LEADERSHIP

A lack of leadership is often seen as a roadblock to a team's performance. As Stewart and Manz put it, "More specifically, work team management or supervision is often identified as a primary reason why self-management teams fail to properly develop and yield improvements in productivity, quality, and quality of life for American workers."

Rather than focusing on ineffective teams, Larson and LaFasto looked in the opposite direction by interviewing excellent teams to gain insights as to what enabled them to function to such a high degree.

They came away with the following ceases:

- *A clear elevating goal:* They have a vision.
- *Results driven structure:* Visions have a business goal.
- Competent team members with right number and mix.
- *Unified commitment:* They are a team, not a group.
- *A collaborative climate:* Aligned towards a common purpose.
- *High standards of excellence:* They have group norms.
- *Principled leadership:* The central driver of excellence.
- *External support:* They have adequate resources.

TEAM LEADERSHIP MODEL

While there are several Team Leadership models, Hill's Team model is perhaps one of the better known ones as it provides the leader or a designated team member with a mental road map to help diagnose team problems, and then take appropriate action to correct team problems. Hill based his model on a number of research projects.

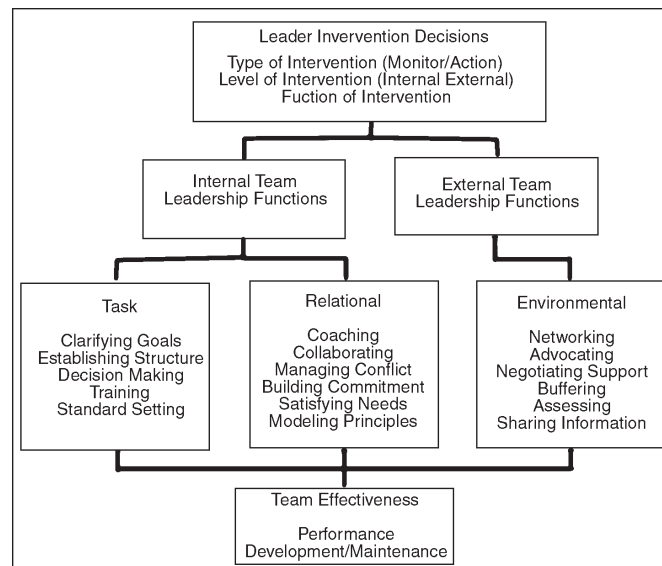


Fig. Hill's Team Leadership Model

THE FOUR LAYERS OR STEPS IN THE TEAM LEADERSHIP MODEL

- *Top layer:* Effective team performance begins with leader's mental model of the situation and then determining if the situation requires Action or just Monitoring?
- *Second Layer:* Is it at an Internal or External leadership level?
- *Third layer:* Is it Task, Relational, or an Environmental intervention? Select a function depending on the type of intervention.
- *Bottom layer:* Correctly performing the three steps creates high Performance through Development and Maintenance functions.

TEAM LEADERSHIP FUNCTION INTERVENTIONS

Internal Task Functions:

- Focus on goals by clarifying and/or getting agreement
- Restructure plans, processes, roles, etc. in order to gain desired results
- Guide the decision-making process so that better information is obtained, coordination is better, focusing on issues, etc.

- Train members through both formal and informal means
- Assess performance and confront when necessary

Internal Relationship Functions:

- Coach team members
- Use more collaborative methods to involve all team members
- Manage conflict
- Build commitment and esprit de corps through the use of ethos leadership
- Satisfy team members' needs
- Model what you expect from your team members

External Environmental Functions:

- Network to increase influence and gather information
- Advocate by representing your team so that it shows them at their best
- Get support for your team by gathering resources and recognition for your team
- Buffer the team from environmental distractions
- Assess the environment through surveys and other performance indicators to determine its impact on the organization
- Share information with the team

MENTORING

Bozeman and Feeney define mentoring as “a process for the informal transmission of knowledge, social capital, and the psychosocial support perceived by the recipient as relevant to work, career, or professional development; mentoring entails informal communication, usually face-to-face and during a sustained period of time, between a person who is perceived to have greater relevant knowledge, wisdom, or experience and a person who is perceived to have less.”

It originated from Homer's epic poem *The Odyssey*. In the poem, Odysseus, King of Ithaca went to fight in the Trojan War and entrusted the care of his kingdom to Mentor, who served as the teacher of Odysseus' son, Telemachus.

Mentoring is often thought of as the transfer of wisdom from a wise and trusted counselor who helps to guide a person's career, normally in the upper echelons of the organization. The two most common terms used to describe the person being mentored is “mentee” and “protégé,” while two lesser used terms are “apprentice” and “student.”

A mentor cares about her protégés and goes out of her or her way to see that they get the best possible chance to fulfill their career potential. It involves teaching, coaching, and helping to build a high degree of confidence. But what brings out the full magic of mentorship is some degree of affection or warm friendship... such as what an older brother might feel for his kid sister.

WHY THE NEED FOR MENTORING?

Capital Analytics found 1,000% ROI, for Sun mentoring, using their most conservative measures of job and salary grade improvement.

Mentoring has been shown to have a positive effect on one's career. One study by Gerard Roche found that of the 63.5 per cent of the 1,250 respondents who had a mentor were on the average better paid, reached their positions faster, and were more satisfied with their work and careers than their non-mentor counterparts. Kram discovered that mentoring facilitates the socialization of new hires into the organization, reduce turnover, minimize midcareer adjustments, enhance transfer of knowledge and values, and facilitate the adjustment of retirement.

WHO SHOULD BE MENTORED?

While most mentoring programmes seemed to be aimed at the best and brightest, Delong and Vijayaraghavan reported that it makes more sense to go after the large middle-base as they make up the great majority of employees as opposed to the top 10% of star A players, and the bottom 10% of incompetent C players): "Like all prize-winning supporting actors, B players bring depth and stability to the companies they work for, slowly but surely improving both corporate performance and organizational resilience... They will never garner the most revenue or the biggest clients, but they also will be less likely to embarrass the company or flunk out... these players inevitably end up being the backbone of the organization."

CONCEPTS OF LEADERSHIP

Good leaders are made not born. If you have the desire and willpower, you can become an effective leader. Good leaders develop through a never ending process of self-study, education, training, and experience. This guide will help you through that process.

To inspire your workers into higher levels of teamwork, there are certain things you must be, know, and, do. These do not come naturally, but are acquired through continual work and study. Good leaders are continually working and studying to improve their leadership skills; they are NOT resting on their laurels.

DEFINITION OF LEADERSHIP

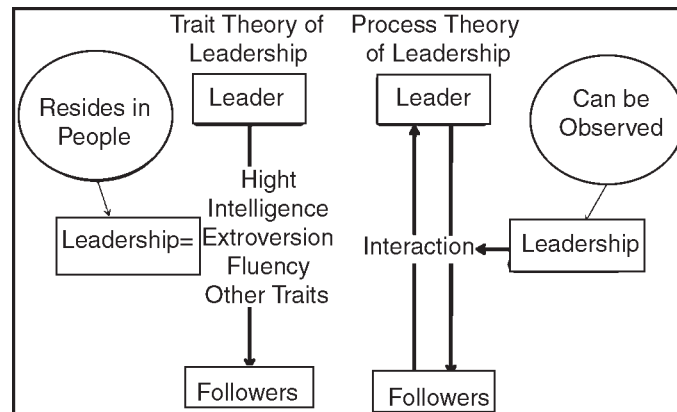
Before we get started, let's define leadership. Leadership is a process by which a person influences others to accomplish an objective and directs the organization in a way that makes it more cohesive and coherent.

This definition is similar to Northouse's definition — Leadership is a process whereby an individual influences a group of individuals to achieve a common goal.

Leaders carry out this process by applying their leadership knowledge and skills. This is called *Process Leadership*. However, we know that we have traits that can influence our actions.

This is called *Trait Leadership*, in that it was once common to believe that leaders were born rather than made.

These two leadership types are shown in the chart:



While leadership is learned, the skills and knowledge processed by the leader can be influenced by his or hers attributes or traits, such as beliefs, values, ethics, and character. Knowledge and skills contribute directly to the *process* of leadership, while the other attributes give the leader certain characteristics that make him or her unique.

Skills, knowledge, and attributes make the *Leader*, which is one of the:

FOUR FACTORS OF LEADERSHIP

There are four major factors in leadership:



Fig. Factors of Leadership

Leader

You must have an honest understanding of who you are, what you know, and what you can do. Also, note that it is the followers, not the leader or someone else who determines if the leader is successful. If they do not trust or lack confidence in their leader, then they will be uninspired.

To be successful you have to convince your followers, not yourself or your superiors, that you are worthy of being followed.

Followers

Different people require different styles of leadership. For example, a new hire requires more supervision than an experienced employee. A person who lacks motivation requires a different approach than one with a high degree of motivation. You must know your people! The fundamental starting point is having a good understanding of human nature, such as needs, emotions, and motivation. You must come to know your employees' be, know, and do attributes.

Communication

You lead through two-way communication. Much of it is nonverbal. For instance, when you "set the example," that communicates to your people that you would not ask them to perform anything that you would not be willing to do. What and how you communicate either builds or harms the relationship between you and your employees.

Situation

All situations are different. What you do in one situation will not always work in another. You must use your judgment to decide the best course of action and the leadership style needed for each situation. For example, you may need to confront an employee for inappropriate behaviour, but if the confrontation is too late or too early, too harsh or too weak, then the results may prove ineffective.

Also note that the *situation* normally has a greater effect on a leader's action than his or her traits. This is because while traits may have an impressive stability over a period of time, they have little consistency across situations. This is why a number of leadership scholars think the *Process Theory of Leadership* is a more accurate than the *Trait Theory of Leadership*.

Various forces will affect these four factors. Examples of forces are your relationship with your seniors, the skill of your followers, the informal leaders within your organization, and how your organization is organized.

BOSS OR LEADER?

Although your position as a manager, supervisor, lead, etc. gives you the authority to accomplish certain tasks and objectives in the organization, this power does not make you a leader, it simply makes you the boss. Leadership differs in that it makes the followers want to achieve high goals, rather than simply bossing people around. Thus you get Assigned Leadership by your position and you display Emergent Leadership by influencing people to do great things.

BASS' THEORY OF LEADERSHIP

Bass' theory of leadership states that there are three basic ways to explain how people become leaders. The first two explain the leadership development for a small number of people.

These theories are:

- Some personality traits may lead people naturally into leadership roles. This is the Trait Theory.
- A crisis or important event may cause a person to rise to the occasion, which brings out extraordinary leadership qualities in an ordinary person. This is the Great Events Theory.
- People can choose to become leaders. People can learn leadership skills. This is the Transformational or Process Leadership Theory. It is the most widely accepted theory today and the premise on which this guide is based.

LEADERSHIP MODELS

Leadership models help us to understand what makes leaders animation the way they do. The ideal is not to lock yourself in to a type of behaviour discussed in the model, but to realise that every situation calls for a different approach or behaviour to be taken. Two models will be discussed, the Four Framework Approach and the Managerial Grid.

Four Framework Approach

In the Four Framework Approach, Bolman and Deal suggest that leaders display leadership behaviours in one of four types of frameworks: Structural, Human Resource, Political, or Symbolic.

This model suggests that leaders can be put into one of these four categories and there are times when one approach is appropriate and times when it would not be.

That is, any style can be effective or ineffective, depending upon the situation. Relying on only one of these approaches would be inadequate, thus we should strive to be conscious of all four approaches, and not just depend on one or two. For example, during a major organization change, a Structural leadership style may be more effective than a Symbolic leadership style; during a period when strong growth is needed, the Symbolic approach may be better. We also need to understand ourselves as each of us

tends to have a preferred approach. We need to be conscious of this at all times and be aware of the limitations of just favouring one approach.

Recognizes Major Constituencies	Political Framework	Human Resource Framework	Heart of the Organization is People
Coalition			Empowerment
Problem Based			Servant
Processes	Structural Framework	Symbolic Framework	Inspiration
Analysis			Prophet
Design			Visions

Structural Framework

In an effective leadership situation, the leader is a social architect whose leadership style is analysis and design. While in an ineffective leadership situation, the leader is a petty tyrant whose leadership style is details. Structural Leaders focus on structure, strategy, environment, implementation, experimentation, and adaptation.

Human Resource Framework

In an effective leadership situation, the leader is a catalyst and servant whose leadership style is support, advocating, and empowerment. While in an ineffective leadership situation, the leader is a pushover, whose leadership style is abdication and fraud. Human Resource Leaders believe in people and communicate that belief; they are visible and accessible; they empower, increase participation, support, share information, and move decision making down into the organization.

Political Framework

In an effective leadership situation, the leader is an advocate, whose leadership style is coalition and building. While in an ineffective leadership situation, the leader is a hustler, whose leadership style is manipulation.

Political leaders clarify what they want and what they can get; they assess the distribution of power and interests; they build linkages to other stakeholders, use persuasion first, then use negotiation and coercion only if necessary.

Symbolic Framework

In an effective leadership situation, the leader is a prophet, whose leadership style is inspiration. While in an ineffective leadership situation, the leader is a fanatic or fool, whose leadership style is smoke and mirrors.

Symbolic leaders view organizations as a stage or theater to play certain roles and give impressions; these leaders use symbols to capture attention; they try to frame experience by providing plausible interpretations of experiences; they discover and communicate a vision.

Managerial Grid

The Blake and Mouton Managerial Grid, also known as the Leadership Grid uses two axes:

1. “Concern for people” is plotted using the vertical axis
2. “Concern for task or results” is plotted along the horizontal axis.

They both have a range of 0 to 9. The notion that just two dimensions can describe a managerial behaviour has the attraction of simplicity.

These two dimensions can be drawn as a graph or grid:

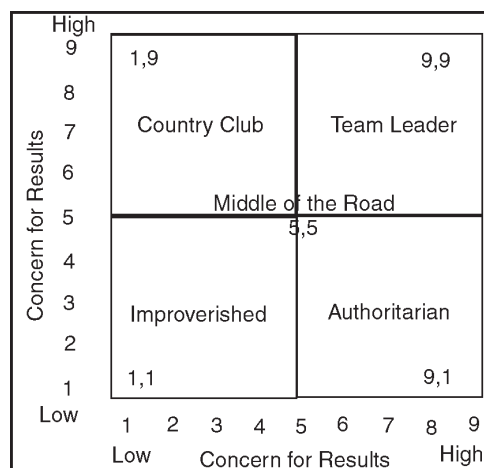


Fig. Leadership Grid

Most people fall somewhere near the middle of the two axes — Middle of the Road.

But, by going to the extremes, that is, people who score on the far end of the scales, we come up with four types of leaders:

- *Authoritarian*: Strong on tasks, weak on people skills
- *Country Club*: Strong on people skills, weak on tasks
- *Improvised*: Weak on tasks, weak on people skills
- *Team Leader*: Strong on tasks, strong on people skills

The goal is to be at least in the Middle of the Road but preferably a Team Leader — that is, to score at least between a 5,5 to 9,9.

Authoritarian Leader

People who get this rating are very much task oriented and are hard on their workers. There is little or no allowance for cooperation or collaboration. Heavily task oriented people display these characteristics: they are very strong on schedules; they expect

people to do what they are told without question or debate; when something goes wrong they tend to focus on who is to blame rather than concentrate on exactly what is wrong and how to prevent it; they are intolerant of what they see as dissent, so it is difficult for their subordinates to contribute or develop.

Team Leader

This type of person leads by positive example and endeavors to foster a team environment in which all team members can reach their highest potential, both as team members and as people. They encourage the team to reach team goals as effectively as possible, while also working tirelessly to strengthen the bonds among the various members. They normally form and lead some of the most productive teams.

Country Club Leader

This person uses predominantly reward power to maintain discipline and to encourage the team to accomplish its goals. Conversely, they are almost incapable of employing the more punitive coercive and legitimate powers. This inability results from fear that using such powers could jeopardize relationships with the other team members.

Impoverished Leader

A leader who uses a “delegate and disappear” management style. Since they are not committed to either task accomplishment or maintenance; they essentially allow their team to do whatever it wishes and prefer to detach themselves from the team process by allowing the team to suffer from a series of power struggles.

The most desirable place for a leader to be along the two axes at most times would be a 9 on task and a 9 on people — the Team Leader. However, do not entirely dismiss the other three. Certain situations might call for one of the other three to be used at times. For example, by playing the Impoverished Leader, you allow your team to gain self-reliance. Be an Authoritarian Leader to instill a sense of discipline in an unmotivated worker. By carefully studying the situation and the forces affecting it, you will know at what points along the axes you need to be in order to achieve the desired result.

Total Leadership

What makes a person want to follow a leader? People want to be guided by those they respect and who have a clear sense of direction. To gain respect, they must be ethical. A sense of direction is achieved by conveying a strong vision of the future. When a person is deciding if she respects you as a leader, she does not think about your attributes, rather, she observes what you do so that she can know who you really are. She uses this observation to tell if you are an honourable and trusted leader or a self-serving person who misuses authority to look good and get promoted. Self-serving leaders are not as effective because their employees only obey them, not follow them. They succeed in many areas because they present a good image to their seniors at the expense of their workers.

Be Know Do

The basis of good leadership is honourable character and selfless service to your organization. In your employees' eyes, your leadership is everything you do that effects the organization's objectives and their well-being.

Respected leaders concentrate on:

- What they are [be]
- What they know
- What they do.

What makes a person want to follow a leader? People want to be guided by those they respect and who have a clear sense of direction. To gain respect, they must be ethical. A sense of direction is achieved by conveying a strong vision of the future.

The Two Most Important Keys to Effective Leadership

A study by the Hay Group, a global management consultancy, there are 75 key components of employee satisfaction.

They found that:

- Trust and confidence in top leadership was the single most reliable predictor of employee satisfaction in an organization.
- Effective communication by leadership in three critical areas was the key to winning organizational trust and confidence:
 - Helping employees understand the company's overall business strategy.
 - Helping employees understand how they contribute to achieving key business objectives.
 - Sharing information with employees on both how the company is doing and how an employee's own division is doing — relative to strategic business objectives.

So in a nutshell: You must be trustworthy and you have to be able to communicate a vision of where the organization needs to go. The next section, "Principles of Leadership", ties in closely with this key concept.

Principles of Leadership

To help you be, know, and do, follow these eleven principles of leadership.

This text expand on these and provide tools for implementing them:

- *Know yourself and seek self-improvement:* In order to know yourself, you have to understand your be, know, and do, attributes. Seeking self-improvement means continually strengthening your attributes. This can be accomplished through self-study, formal classes, reflection, and interacting with others.
- *Be technically proficient:* As a leader, you must know your job and have a solid familiarity with your employees' tasks.
- *Seek responsibility and take responsibility for your actions:* Search for ways to guide your organization to new heights. And when things go wrong, they

always do sooner or later — do not blame others. Analyse the situation, take corrective action, and move on to the next challenge.

- *Make sound and timely decisions:* Use good problem solving, decision making, and planning tools.
- *Set the example:* Be a good role model for your employees. They must not only hear what they are expected to do, but also see. We must become the change we want to see - Mahatma Gandhi
- *Know your people and look out for their well-being:* Know human nature and the importance of sincerely caring for your workers.
- *Keep your workers informed:* Know how to communicate with not only them, but also seniors and other key people.
- *Develop a sense of responsibility in your workers:* Help to develop good character traits that will help them carry out their professional responsibilities.
- *Ensure that tasks are understood, supervised, and accomplished:* Communication is the key to this responsibility.
- *Train as a team:* Although many so called leaders call their organization, department, section, etc. a team; they are not really teams...they are just a group of people doing their jobs.
- *Use the full capabilities of your organization:* By developing a team spirit, you will be able to employ your organization, department, section, etc. to its fullest capabilities.

MATRIX TEAMS

As a leader, you might need to form a matrix team, lead one, or simply be part of one. Matrix teams include work groups, cross functional teams, task forces, problem solving teams, committees, special project teams, etc.

They are normally composed of a small number of people from different departments, functions, or organizations who have banded together to solve a common problem or achieve a goal through collaboration. And as Growing a Team indicated, what differs a team from a group is the ability to accomplish much more through the use of knowledge and skill sharing.

Some organizations have working groups that call themselves teams, but their work is produced by a combination of individual contributions. Teams produce work that is based on collaboration and collective effort.

Katzenbach and Smith defined a team as a small number of people with complementary skills who are committed to a common purpose, performance goals, and a common approach that they hold themselves mutually accountable:

- The small number normally ranges from 2 to 25 members, with somewhere between 5 and 9 as normally the most manageable and optimal. Communication tends to become centralized because members do not have an adequate

opportunity to speak to each other. If the group size is below 5, then the collective experience, skill, and knowledge base could be inadequate.

- Complementary skills provide synergy when the team is diverse and various ideas and multiple skills are combined. If the team is composed of like-thinking individuals, a congenital group-think often sets in that limits the number of solutions for creative problem solving.
- Common purpose is the driving force of teams. The team must develop its own purpose that must be meaningful and have ownership by all individuals. A team needs to periodically revisit its purpose in order to make it more relevant as the team develops. This type of agenda is open. On the other hand are hidden agendas that select individuals try to push forth. Hidden agendas prevent the group from turning into a true team due to the emotions and motives that are hidden under the discussion table.
- Performance goals are the acting, moving, and energizing force of the team. Specific performance goals are established, tracked, met, and evaluated in an ongoing process.
- Common approaches are the means in which members agree on how they will work together. Teams should develop their own charter or set of rules that outline the expected behaviours of its members. Members often assume roles, such as the Questioner or Devil's Advocate, Historian, Time Keeper, and Facilitator, to keep the team processes moving and on course.
- Mutually accountability is the aspect of teamwork that is normally the last to develop. It is the owning and sharing of the team's outcomes, both successes and failures.

KNOWLEDGE TUG-OF-WAR GAME

One of the main inhibitors of a team obtaining its goal optimally is knowledge hoarding rather than knowledge sharing. There are many cultural factors that inhibit knowledge transfer.

The most common of these frictions include:

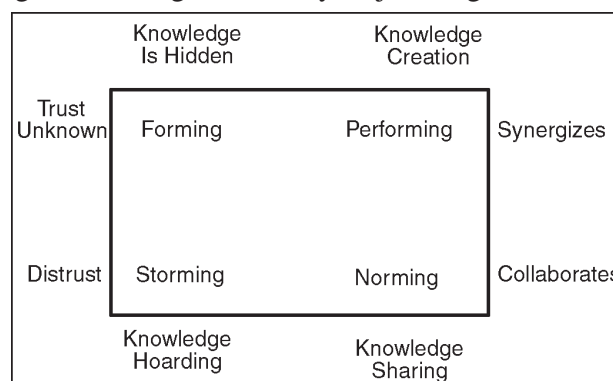
- Lack of trust
- Different cultures, vocabularies, and frames of reference
- Lack of time and meeting places; narrow idea of productive work
- Status and rewards go to knowledge owners
- Lack of absorptive capacity in recipients
- Belief that knowledge is prerogative of particular groups
- Not-invented-here syndrome
- Intolerance for mistakes or need for help

A basic tenet of communication theory states that a network's potential benefit grows exponentially as the nodes it can successfully interconnect expand numerically. For example, if two team members share information, both gain information and gain linear

growth. And if both then share their new knowledge with other team members, and in turn get questions, amplifications, and modifications, then the benefits become exponential.

FORMING, STORMING, NORMING, PERFORMING, ADJOURNING

Tuckman discovered that teams normally go through five stages of growth: Forming, Storming, Norming, Performing, and finally Adjourning.



Forming

In the this stage, team members are introduced. They state why they were chosen or volunteered for the team and what they hope to accomplish within the team.

Members cautiously explore the boundaries of acceptable group behaviour. This is a stage of transition from individual to member status, and of testing the leader's guidance both formally and informally.

Forming includes these feelings and behaviours:

- Excitement, anticipation, and optimism
- Pride in being chosen for the project
- A tentative attachment to the team
- Suspicion and anxiety about the job
- Defining the tasks and how they will be accomplished
- Determining acceptable group behaviour
- Deciding what information needs to be gathered

Activities include abstract discussions of the concepts and issues; and for some members, impatience with these discussions. There is often difficulty in identifying some of the relevant problems as there is so much going on that members get distracted. The team often accomplishes little concerning its goals. This is perfectly normal.

Storming

The team's transition from the "As-Is" to the "To-Be" is called the Storming phase. All members have their own ideas as to how the process should look, and personal

agendas are often rampant. Storming is probably the most difficult stage for the team. They begin to realise the tasks that are ahead are different and more difficult than they previously imagined. Impatient about the lack of progress, members argue about just what actions the team should take.

They try to rely solely on their personal and professional experience, and resist collaborating with most other team members.

Storming includes these feelings and behaviours:

- Resisting the tasks
- Resisting quality improvement approaches suggested by other members
- Sharp fluctuations in attitude about the team's chance of success
- Arguing among members, even when they agree on the real issues
- Defensiveness, competition, and choosing sides
- Questioning the wisdom of those who selected the project and appointed the members of the team
- Establishing unrealistic goals
- Disunity, increased tension, and jealousy

These pressures mean that team members have little energy to spend on progressing towards the intended goal. But they are beginning to understand each another. This phase can often take 3 or 4 meetings before arriving at the next phase.

Norming

The Norming phase is when the team reaches a consensus on the “To-Be” process. Everyone wants to share the newly found focus. Enthusiasm is high, and the team is often tempted to go beyond the original scope of the process. During this stage, members reconcile competing loyalties and responsibilities.

They accept the team, ground rules, roles, and the individuality of fellow members. Emotional conflict is reduced as previously competitive relationships become more cooperative.

Norming includes these feelings and behaviours:

- An ability to express criticism constructively
- Acceptance of membership in the team
- An attempt to achieve harmony by avoiding conflict
- Friendliness, confiding in each other, and sharing of personal problems
- A sense of team cohesion, spirit, and goals
- Establishing and maintaining team ground rules and boundaries

As team members work out their differences, they have more time and energy to spend on the project.

Performing

By now the team has settled its relationships and expectations. They can begin performing by diagnosing, problem solving, and implementing changes. At last, team

members have discovered and accepted other's strengths and weakness. In addition, they have learned what their roles are.

Performing includes these feelings and behaviours:

- Members have insights into personal and group processes
- An understanding of each other's strengths and weakness
- Constructive self-change
- Ability to prevent or work through group problems
- Close attachment to the team

The team is now an effective, cohesive unit. You can tell when your team has reached this stage because you start getting a lot of work done.

Adjourning

The team briefs and shares the improved process during this phase. When the team finally completes that last briefing, there is always a bittersweet sense of accomplishment coupled with the reluctance to say good-bye. Many relationships formed within these teams continue long after the team disbands.

Team Survey

You can take a team survey to see what stage your team is in.

FACTORS SEPARATING TEAMS FROM GROUPS

Roles and Responsibilities

Within a group, individuals establish a set of behaviours called roles. These roles set expectations governing relationships. Roles often serve as source of confusion and conflict.

While on the other hand, teams have a shared understanding on how to perform their role and perceive the other team members' roles.

Identity

While teams have an identity, groups do not. It is almost impossible to establish the sense of cohesion that characterizes a team without this fundamental step. A team has a clear understanding about what constitutes the team's mission and why it is important. They can describe a picture of what the team needs to achieve, and the norms and values that will guide them.

Cohesion

Teams have esprit that shows a sense of bonding and camaraderie. Esprit is the spirit, soul, and state of mind of the team. It is the overall consciousness of the team that a person identifies with and feels a part of. Individuals begin using "we" rather than "me."

Facilitate

Groups have a tendency to get bogged down with trivial issues. Ask yourself, “How much time gets wasted in meetings you attend?” Teams use facilitators to keep the team on the right path.

Communication

While members of a group are centred upon themselves, the team is committed to open communication. Team members feel they can state their opinions, thoughts, and feelings without fear. Listening is considered as important as speaking. Differences of opinion are valued and methods of managing conflict are understood. Through honest and caring feedback, members are aware of their strengths and weaknesses as team members. There is an atmosphere of trust and acceptance and a sense of community.

Flexibility

Most groups are extremely rigid. However, Teams maintain a high level of flexibility, and they perform different task and maintenance functions as needed. The responsibility for team development and leadership is shared. The strengths of each member are identified and used.

Morale

Team members are enthusiastic about the work of the team and each person feels pride in being a member of the team. Team spirit is high. To be a successful team, the group must have a strong ability to produce results and a high degree of satisfaction in working with one another.

ENCOURAGING GREAT IDEAS

All too often, creativity gets stifled when everyone follows the rules or arriving at solutions the same old way. Teams often become so task-oriented that they narrow down their focus much too soon by choosing the first likely solution, rather than adequately investigating the situation and its possibilities by brainstorming.

MOTIVATION AND LEADERSHIP

A person's motivation is a combination of desire and energy directed at achieving a goal. Influencing someone's motivation means getting them to want to do what you know must be done.

A person's motivation depends upon two things:

1. The strength of certain needs. For example, you are hungry, but you must have a task completed by a nearing deadline. If you are starving you will eat. If you are slightly hungry you will finish the task at hand.
2. The perception that taking a certain action will help satisfy those needs. For example, you have two burning needs - the desire to complete the task and

the desire to go to lunch. Your perception of how you view those two needs will determine which one takes priority. If you believe that you could be fired for not completing the task, you will probably put off lunch and complete the task. If you believe that you will not get into trouble or perhaps finish the task in time, then you will likely go to lunch.

People can be motivated by such forces as beliefs, values, interests, fear, and worthy causes. Some of these forces are internal, such as needs, interests, and beliefs. Others are external, such as danger, the environment, or pressure from a loved one. There is no simple formula for motivation — you must keep an open viewpoint on human nature.

There is a complex array of forces steering the direction of each person and these forces cannot always be seen or studied. In addition, if the same forces are steering two different people, each one may react differently. Knowing that each person may react to different needs will guide your decisions and actions in certain situations.

As a leader you have the power to influence motivation. The following guidelines form a basic view of motivation. They will help guide your decision making process:

Allow the needs of your team to coincide with the needs of your organization. Nearly everyone is influenced by the needs for job security, promotion, raises, and approval of their peers and/or leaders. They are also influenced by internal forces such as values, morals, and ethics. Likewise, the organization needs good people in a wide variety of jobs.

Ensure that your team is trained, encouraged, and has opportunities to advance. Also, ensure that the way you conduct business has the same values, moral, and ethic principles that you seek in others. If you conduct business in a dishonest manner, your team will be dishonest to you, for that will be the kind of people that you will attract.

Reward good behaviour. Although a certificate, letter, or a thank you may seem small and insignificant, they can be powerful motivators. The reward should be specific and prompt. Do not say something general, such as “for doing a good job,” rather cite the specific action that made you believe it was indeed a good job. In addition, help those who are good. We all make mistakes or need help on occasion to achieve a particular goal.

Set the example. You must be the role model that you want others to grow into.

Develop morale and esprit de corps. Morale is the mental, emotional, and spiritual state of a person. Almost everything you do will have an impact on your organization. You should always be aware how your actions and decisions might affect it. Esprit de corps means team spirit - it is defined as the spirit of the organization or collective body. It is the consciousness of the organization that allows the people within it to identify with and feel a part of. Is your workplace a place where people cannot wait to get away from; or is it a place that people enjoy spending a part of their lives?

Allow your team to be part of the planning and problem solving process. This helps with their development and allows you to coach them. Secondly, it motivates them — people who are part of the decision making process become the owners of it, thus it

gives them a personal interest in seeing the plan succeed. Thirdly, communication is clearer as everyone has a better understanding of what role they must play as part of the team. Next, it creates an open trusting communication bond. They are no longer just the doers for the organization — they are now part of it! Finally, recognition and appreciation from a respected leader are powerful motivators.

Look out for your team. Although you do not have control over their personal lives, you must show concern for them. Things that seem of no importance to you might be extremely critical to them. You must be able to empathize with them. This is from the German word, *einfuhling*, which means “to feel with”, or the ability to perceive another person’s view of the world as though that view were your own.

The Sioux Indian Tribal Prayer reads, “Great Spirit, help us never to judge another until we have walked for two weeks in his moccasins.” Also note that empathy differs from sympathy in that sympathy connotes spontaneous emotion rather than a conscious, reasoned response. Sympathizing with others may be less useful to another person if we are limited by the strong feelings of the moment.

Keep them informed. Keeping the communication channel open allow team members to have a sense of control over their lives. Make their jobs challenging, exciting, and meaningful. Make each feel like an individual in a great team, rather than a cog in a lifeless machine. People need meaningful work, even if it is tiring and unpleasant; they need to know that it is important and necessary for the survival of the organization.

Counsel people who behave in a way that is counter to the company’s goals. All the guidelines before this took the positive approach. But, sometimes this does not always work. You must let people know when they are not performing to an acceptable standard.

By the same token, you must protect them when needed. For example, if someone in your department is always late arriving for work and it is causing disruptions, then you must take action. On the other hand, if you have an extremely good department and once in a while a person is a few minutes late, then do the right thing - protect the person from the bureaucracy!

INFORMED ACQUIESCENCE VS. VALUE-BASED SELF-GOVERNANCE

The most common form of culture in modern organizations is often referred to as “informed acquiescence.” They are rule-based in that the workers learn the rules and agree to abide by them. Rules work their way from the top-down in a fairly controllable and predictable manner. Thus a large organization becomes management-orientated and in turn, a bureaucracy. And it is this bureaucracy that tends to slow things down.

However, many of the leading organizations are becoming more “value-based self-governance” in that rather than the workforce being governed by “should,” they animation upon “can”. They have a small core set of rules that are valued by the workforce. Rather than being motivated to do better, they are inspired. Motivation is controlled somewhat by outside factors, while inspired is more inside the individual

and is usually considered the greatest motivator. Being freed from the crippling pace of bureaucracy, value-based companies operate and move faster. Probably no organization is solely one or the other, yet the better and faster ones are closer to being value-based. Nordstrom is perhaps the best known example of an organization that leans heavily towards value-based self-governance.

For example, Nordstrom's rule is to "Use good judgement in all situations." Employees are encouraged to ask questions from anyone because they believe that all information should be accessible to everyone, regardless of seniority or status.

COUNSELING

Counseling has a powerful, long-term impact on people and the effectiveness of the organization. Counseling is talking with a person in a way that helps him or her solve a problem. It involves thinking, implementing, knowing human nature, timing, sincerity, compassion, and kindness. It involves much more than simply telling someone what to do about a problem.

Leaders must demonstrate the following qualities in order to counsel effectively:

- *Respect for employees:* This includes the belief that individuals are responsible for their own actions and ideas. It includes an awareness of a person's individuality by recognizing their unique values, attributes, and skills. As you attempt to develop people with counseling, you must refrain from projecting your own values onto them.
- *Self-Awareness:* This quality is an understanding of yourself as a leader. The more you are aware of your own values, needs, and biases, the less likely you will be to project your feelings onto your employees.
- *Credibility:* Believability is achieved through both honesty and consistency between both the leader's statements and actions. Credible leaders are straightforward with their subordinates and behave in such a manner that earns the subordinates' respect and trust.
- *Empathy:* Or compassion entails understanding a subordinate's situation. Empathetic leaders will be better able to help subordinates identify the situation and then develop a plan to improve it.

The reason for counseling is to help employees develop in order to achieve organizational goals. Sometimes, the counseling is directed by policy, and at other times, leaders should choose to counsel to develop employees. Regardless of the nature of the counseling, leaders should demonstrate the qualities of an effective counselor and employ the skills of good communication. While the reason for counseling is to develop subordinates, leaders often categorize counseling based on the topic of the session. Major categories include performance counseling, problem counseling, and individual growth counseling. While these categories help leaders to organize and focus counseling sessions, they must not be viewed as separate and distinct types of counseling. For example a counseling session which mainly focuses on resolving a problem may also

have a great impact on improving job performance. Another example is a counseling session that focuses on performance may also include a discussion of opportunities for growth. Regardless of the topic of the counseling session, you should follow the same basic format to prepare for and conduct counseling.

Steps for counseling

- Identify the problem. Ensure you get to the heart of the problem. Sakichi Toyoda, the founder of Toyota, invented a technique called the Five Whys. When confronted with a problem you ask “why” five times. By the time the fifth why is answered, you should be at the root cause of the problem. For example: Tom’s work has not up to standards
 - *Why?*: After discussing it with Tom it turns out he has too much of a workload
 - *Why?*: Tom is considered one of the experts, hence he often gets extra work dumped on him
 - *Why?*: Susan, the other expert, was promoted and no one else is capable of replacing her
 - *Why?*: We failed to train and develop the other team members
 - *Why?*: We did not see the necessity of cross-training
 - *Why?*: We did not see the necessity of cross-training
- Analyse the forces influencing the behaviour. Determine which of these forces you have control over and which of the forces the worker has control over. Determine if the force has to be modified, eliminated, or enforced.
- Plan, coordinate, and organize the session. Determine the best time to conduct the session so that you will not be interrupted or forced to end too early.
- Conduct the session using sincerity, compassion, and kindness. This does not mean you cannot be firm or in control. Your reputation is on the line; the problem must be solved so that your department can continue with its mission. Likewise, you must hear the person out.
- During the session, determine what the worker believes causes the counterproductive behaviour and what will be required to change it. Also, determine if your initial analysis is correct.
- Try to maintain a sense of timing of when to use directive or nondirective counseling.
- Using all the facts, make a decision and/or a plan of action to correct the problem. If more counseling is needed, make a firm time and date for the next session.
- After the session and throughout a sufficient time period, evaluate the worker's progress to ensure the problem has indeed been solved.

There are two types of counseling - directive and nondirective. In directive counseling, the counselor identifies the problem and tells the counselee what to do about it.

Nondirective counseling means the counselee identifies the problem and determines the solution with the help of the counselor.

The counselor has to determine which of the two, or some appropriate combination, to give for each situation. For example, "Put that cigarette out now as this is a nonsmoking area," is a form of directive counseling. While a form of nondirective counseling would be, "So the reason you are not effective is that you were up late last night. What are you going to do to ensure that this does not affect your performance again?"

Hints for counseling sessions:

- Let the person know that the behaviour is undesirable, not the person.
- Let the person know that you care about him or her as a person, but that you expect more from them.
- Do not punish employees who are unable to perform a task. Punish those who are able to perform the task but are unwilling or unmotivated to succeed.
- Counseling sessions should be conducted in private immediately after the undesirable behaviour. Do not humiliate a person in front of others.
- Ensure that the employee understands exactly what behaviour led to the counseling or punishment.
- Do not hold a grudge. When it is over, it is over! Move on!

PERFORMANCE APPRAISALS

Skills + Knowledge + Attitudes = Observable Behaviour
Observable Behaviour = Performance Appraisal Rating

Performance Appraisals are the measurement of a specific range of skills, knowledge, and attitudes in relation to certain objective standards. The ratings are based upon observations or empirical data in relationship to a set of predefined standards.

Although we sometimes make decisions based upon our own personal feelings or gut-level instincts, appraisals must be based upon how well a person has performed to a set standard.

The objective of performance appraisals is to help employees improve their performance and grow as individuals so that the organization can meet its present and future goals in a timely and cost effective manner. Is this how most organizations use them? No. They are used for protection against lawsuits, to justify different levels of pay increases, or to provide once-a-year feedback.

In other words, a lot of managers and supervisors view them as an additional burden required by Human Resources. When in fact, they should be viewed as a performance tool. Just as a leader uses speaking skills to encourage the troops and analytical skills to forecast budgets; performance appraisals should be used to encourage great performance and create goals to improve weak competencies.

For many, the performance appraisal is tied in to their pay as a reward system. Tony Hope, a visiting professor at the French Business school INSEAD, spoke of rewards at the Institute of Personnel and Development's Compensation conference.

He believes that we need to stop this practice as trust and commitment cannot be fostered while cost-control imperatives dominate organizational thinking.

"Just as we have seen that knowledge workers don't respond to a regime of command and control in management style, so they won't perform according to pay systems that are individually based," says Professor Hope, "Organizations must hang on to their best people and these people are exactly those that are least impressed by internal competition within tight budgets...New and powerful forces that are shaping organizations mean that people management professionals are going to have to find ways of collectively rewarding effort. It will be less pay for performance and more pay for participation."

Performance appraisals are normally given at annual or semi-annual time periods.

They need to provide specific feedback to the individual as to what competencies need improvement:

- *Skills:* What areas do I need to train in?
- *Knowledge:* What areas do I need to learn more about?
- *Attitude:* Are my inner drives coinciding with the organization's goals?
- *Rewards:* What am I doing right so I can do more of it?

Performance Appraisals do not take the place of daily feedback mechanisms. If an individual is shocked or surprised by the evaluation that he or she has received, then you as a leader have not performed your job.

An evaluation is the overall scorecard that sums up a person's performance over the rating period, while daily one-on-ones, meetings, and other feedback devices are the tools that leaders use to motivate their employees on to higher performance.

The performance appraisal or evaluation is one of the most powerful motivational tools available to a leader.

It has three main objectives:

1. To measure performance fairly and objectively against job requirements. This allows effective workers to be rewarded for their efforts and ineffective workers to be put on the line for poor performance.
2. To increase performance by identifying specific development goals. "If you don't know where you are going, any road will take you there" - Lewis Carroll. The appraisal allows the worker to target specific areas for job growth. In addition, it should be a time to plan for better performance on the job.
3. To develop career goals so that the worker may keep pace with the requirements of a fast paced organization. More and more, every job in an organization becomes more demanding with new requirements. Just because a worker is performing effectively in her job today, does not mean she will be able to perform effectively tomorrow. She must be allowed to grow with the job and the organization.

A lot of people consider giving performance appraisals as being quite uncomfortable. However, it is not the judging of people that is really uncomfortable, rather it is the judging of bad performance that is uncomfortable.

Thus, eliminate poor performance in the first place, and performance appraisals become a lot more pleasant to give. Now of course you are not going to eliminate poor performance completely; however, with a little bit of planning it can be greatly reduced.

Performance has often been described as “purposeful work” — that is, a job exists to achieve specific and defined results. And what bad performers really do is perform “work activities”, rather than activities that contribute to effective performance.

The first step in performance planning is to determine the results that you want the performer to achieve. After all, workers generally want to know what they need to do, how well you need them to do it, and how well they are actually doing it.

In addition, a worker should not walk blindly into a performance appraisal. Past counseling sessions, feedback, and one-on-ones should give her a pretty clear understanding of what to expect from the appraisal. If you blind-side her, you have not done your job as a leader. Helping your team grow is not a once or twice yearly task, but a full-time duty.

The appraisal should be a joint effort. No one knows the job better than the person performing it. By turning the appraisal into a real discussion, rather than a lecture, the leader may learn some insightful information that could help boost his or her performance in the future. Before the meeting, have the worker complete her own self-appraisal. Although you might think they will take advantage of this by giving themselves unearned high marks, studies have shown that most workers rate themselves more critically than the leader would have.

SHOULD PERFORMANCE APPRAISALS BE SCRAPPED?

There has been some talk of completely doing away with performance appraisals as they sometimes do more harm than good. Yet performance appraisals are tools and like any other tool, they can be used correctly or incorrectly. Part of the problem might be with its name — “Performance Appraisal,” which has sort of a judgmental sound to it. Perhaps “Performance Planning and Review” might be a better term for it.

Part-time employees at Trader Joe’s are reviewed every three months, which is an unusually frequent rate of evaluation. In addition, the part-time employees of Trader Joe’s are paid higher wages, as are their full-time workers, than what you will find in the normal grocery store.

What is interesting about all of this is that they have been bought three times, and NOT because they are losing money — they make more money per square foot of business than the average grocery store.

The new leadership teams have never said that they need to pay them what the rest of the industry pays. Why? Because they see the value in their workers! Rather than giving lip-service to “employees our are most valuable asset,” they actually walk-the-talk. Yet, one of the arguments for scrapping performance appraisals is that ALL workers’ pay should be aligned with the labour market — they do not deserve annual pay raises

as it inflates the wage and salary structure. Traditionally, roles have remained the same while goals change. Yet, due to the rapid changes that occur on a day-to-day basis, the roles are actually changing, even though they might remain fixed on paper. Performance appraisals often fail to factor in the changing relationships between goals and roles that are often in a high state of metamorphosis. That is, our attention remains fixed on steadfast goals, while ignoring ever-changing roles.

This type of thinking shows up in a lot of industries as they view their workers' jobs as set roles, even though the world is rapidly changing. For example, the 2004 grocery strike in California forced many shoppers to look at alternatives, thus they started shopping at Traders Joe's.

And many of these shoppers never went back to their regular stores because they enjoy the experience they have at Trader Joe's. Yet Trader Joe's was not always like this — it started out more like a Seven-Eleven, but because of the competition it went in search of its present niche and recognized along the way that its employee's roles also needed to change.

So even though they still deal in the same commodity as the larger grocery stores — food — they not only changed the way they bought food, but also in the way they deliver that food to the customer.

Thus, the real argument is not really about scrapping Performance Appraisals, but rather ensuring that once goals are set, that all roles are properly accounted for so that the target can indeed be met.

GROWING A TEAM AND LEADERSHIP MANAGEMENT

Leaders should not think of themselves as simply managers, supervisors, etc.; but rather as "team leaders." Thinking of yourself as a manager or supervisor places you in a position of traditional authority based solely on respect for the position, which places you in a position of power.

By understanding the personal work preferences and motivations of your team members, you as an individual, rather than your position, will earn their real respect and trust.

All the tools discussed so far in this guide, such as counseling and planning, provide the basic structure for developing a team. But to go from a group to a team requires a few extra steps.



This means that the people under you are not simply followers who blindly go where you go, but rather are a group of people who are supportive of collaboration in order to achieve a common goal through mutual knowledge and skill sharing.

WHAT IS A TEAM?

A team is a group of people coming together to collaborate. This collaboration is to reach a shared goal or task for which they hold themselves mutually accountable. A group of people is not necessarily a team. A team is a group of people with a high degree of interdependence geared towards the achievement of a common goal or completion of a task rather than just a group for administrative convenience. A group, by definition, is a number of individuals having some unifying relationship.

Team members are deeply committed to each other's personal growth and success. That commitment usually transcends the team. A team outperforms a group and outperforms all reasonable expectations given to its individual members. That is, a team has a synergistic effect — one plus one equals a lot more than two.

SHARED MENTAL MODELS

Team members not only cooperate in all aspects of their tasks and goals, they share in what are traditionally thought of as management functions, such as planning, organizing, setting performance goals, assessing the team's performance, developing their own strategies to manage change, and securing their own resources.

These shared mental models or knowledge structures allows each teammate to generate predictions and expectations about their teammates' roles and task demands, which in turn, allow them to make adjustments in order to maintain effective team performance.

Major Benefits for the Organization:

- Teams maximizes the organization's human resources. Each member of the team is coached, helped, and led by all the other members of the team. A success or failure is felt by all members, not just the individual. Failures are not blamed on individual members, which gives them the courage to take chances. Successes are felt by every team member, this helps them to set and achieve bigger and better successes. In addition, failure is perceived as a learning lesson.
- A Team's output is superior, even when the odds are not in its favour. This is due to the synergistic effect of a team — a team can normally outperform a group of individuals.
- There is continuous improvement. No one knows the job, tasks, and goals better than the individual team members. To get real change, you need their knowledge, skills, and abilities. When they pull together as a team, they will not be afraid to show what they can do. Personal motives will be pushed to the side to allow the team motive to succeed.

FROM GROUP TO TEAM — GETTING THERE

Be Enthusiastic — it's Contagious

Become enthusiastic about one aspect at a time. Start by initially looking for a quick problem to be solved. Most teams trace their advancement to key performance oriented events that forged them together. Potential teams can set such events in motion by immediately establishing a few challenging, yet achievable goals.

First, find a problem and start to talk about it with the team; do not delegate it to an individual or small group, make it a project for everybody. Choose a simple, but distracting work-related problem and solicit everybody's views and suggestions. Next, get the problem solved. Demand urgency against a clear target.

There is no need to allocate large amounts of resource or time to this, simply raise the problem and make a fuss. When a solution comes, praise it by rewarding the whole team. Also, ensure that the aspects of increased efficiency, productivity, and/or calm are highlighted since this will establish the criteria for success. When the problem has been solved, find another one and repeat.

Develop a Sense of Urgency

Team members need to believe the team has an urgent and worthwhile purpose. Establishing a sense of urgency and direction will help them know what their expectations are.

The more urgent and meaningful the need to reach a goal, the more likely it is that a real team will start to emerge. The best teams define their performance expectations, but are flexible enough to allow changes to shape their own purpose, goals, and approach.

Set Clear Rules of Behaviour

Teams develop rules of conduct to help them achieve their purpose and performance goals.

Some rules you might want to consider:

- *Attendance:* No interruptions to take phone calls
- *Discussion:* No sacred cows
- *Confidentiality:* Personal revelations must remain among the team
- *Analytic approach:* Facts are friendly
- *Constructive confrontation:* No finger pointing
- *The most important:* Everyone does real work

Keep Them Informed

Challenge your team with fresh facts and information. New information causes a potential team to redefine and enrich its understanding of the objectives, thereby helping the team to set clearer goals.

Grow Together

Teams must spend a lot of time together, especially in the beginning. Yet potential teams often fail to do so. The time spent together must be both scheduled and unscheduled. Creative insights as well as personal bonding require impromptu and casual interactions.

Reinforcement Works Wonders

Exploit the power of positive feedback, recognition, and reward. Positive reinforcement works as well in a team context as elsewhere. For example, by being alert to a shy person's initial efforts to speak up, allows you to encourage continued contributions.

Other methods include:

- Focus on both development and performance. Make teamwork the norm for all actions. Model teamwork in the way you conduct business and the way you interact with your colleagues.
- Use all your leadership tools, such as coaching, counseling, mentoring, tutoring, and concentrating on improving performance.
- Use informal processes, such as the way you communicate, showing respect, and appreciating and celebrating their achievements.
- Your feelings must show commitment, loyalty, pride, and trust in your team.
- Share the credit.
- Create subcommittees for key areas and give them decision making authority.
- Take turns having a different member facilitate or lead the meetings.
- Talk last in discussions, after you've heard from the others.
- Be clear about when you're expressing your own personal opinion, that of the organization, or that of the whole team.

Leadership shows itself in the inspired action of team members. Traditionally, organizations have assessed leaders by their actions and behaviours.

But, the best way to assess leadership is by the degree to which people surrounding leaders are inspired. It is this inspiration that leads organizations on to excellent performance, rather than mediocre performance.

TEAM ELEMENTS

As a leader, there are a number of elements that you must help to create in a team. Teams learn and demonstrate behaviours that are not exhibited by mere groups.

These characteristics represent the essential elements of an effective team. Your team will not normally form on its own, rather there is almost always someone who was the catalyst for bringing the team together.

This someone must be you. It's okay for you to be the focal point at the beginning, but at some point in time the ownership of the team needs to shift to the other members as a whole.

Common Elements

A team goal - Although your team might have a number of goals, one of them must stand out. For example, “To produce 10% more widgets than last year without hiring additional personnel.” A supporting goal might be, “To provide 40 hours of yearly training for each member.” Everyone must know, agree upon, and be committed to accomplishing the team goal.

Productive participation of all members - This has four levels:

1. Contributing data and knowledge
2. Sharing in the decision making process and reaching consensus
3. Making the decision
4. Making an imposed decision work
 - *Communication*: Open, honest, and effective exchange of information between members.
 - *Trust*: Openness in critiquing and trusting others.
 - *A sense of belonging*: Cohesiveness by being committed to an understood mandate and team identity.
 - *Diversity*: This must be valued as an asset. It is a vital ingredient that provides the synergistic effect of a team.
 - *Creativity and risk taking*: If no one individual fails, then risk taking becomes a lot easier.
 - *Evaluation*: The ability to self correct.
 - *Change compatibility*: Being flexible and assimilating change.
 - *Participatory leadership*: Everyone must help lead to one degree or another.

STEPS TO TEAM PROBLEM SOLVING

- *Step 1*: Define the goal. A team needs to know what to focus on. You can lay out the basic goal, "reduce workplace accidents" for example, but it is important to let the team define and expand the goal.
- *Step 2*: Not only must the "what" be solved, but also the "why." The team should identify what's in it for both the organization and the team. This is best accomplished by asking "What is the benefit?" In addition, creating a specific target that builds enthusiasm helps to make the objective appealing.
- *Step 3*: Define the obstacles that will prevent the team from achieving what it wants. Focus on internal obstacles, not on the external environment. It becomes too easy to say, "We can't do anything about it." Internal factors are within their reach.
- *Step 4*: The team now plans its actions or objectives. Lay out four or five concrete steps, and write them down. Not "we'll try" actions, such as "We'll try to serve customers better." Rather, you want actions that can be tracked and monitored. You cannot measure a "try" action. You want observable behaviours,

such as "Greet all customers with a smile and a good morning" or "Customers will be served within 1 minute upon their arrival."

- *Step 5:* Formulate actions to address.
- *Step 6:* Take action now! This is the most critical step. It is what differentiates an effective team from a group. Groups have lots of meetings before, if ever, taking action -- teams get it done! Get commitment from individual team members to take action on specific items.

TEAM LEADERSHIP

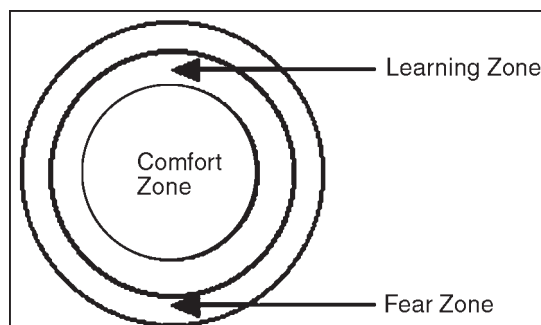
Keep the Purpose, Goals, and Approach Relevant and Meaningful

All teams must shape their own common purpose, goals and approach. While a leader must be a working member of the team who contributes, she also stands apart from the team by virtue of her position as leader.

A team expects their leader to use that perspective and distance to help them clarify and commit to their mission, goals, and approach. Do not be afraid to get your hands dirty, but always remember what you are paid to do.

Build Commitment and Confidence

Work to build the commitment and confidence level of each individual and the team as a whole. Effective team leaders are vigilant about skills. Their goal is to have members with technical, functional, problem solving, decision making, interpersonal, and teamwork skills. To get there, encourage them to take the risks needed for growth and development. You can also challenge them by shifting their assignments and role patterns. Get them out of their comfort zone and into the learning zone, but not so far that they go into the fear zone:



Staying in our comfort zone makes change and learning difficult as we have nothing pushing or pulling us. However, if we go too far out of our comfort zone, we enter the fear zone where no learning takes place because of the extreme discomfort. When we enter the learning zone, we become slightly uncomfortable as we are slightly out of place, therefore we change in order to fit in.

Manage Relationships with Outsiders

Team leaders are expected by people outside of the team, as well as the members within, to manage much of the team's contacts and relationships with the rest of the organization. You must communicate effectively the team's purpose, goals, and approach to anyone who might help or hinder it.

In addition, you need the courage to intercede on the team's behalf when obstacles that might cripple or demoralize the team get placed in their way.

Create Opportunities for Others

One of the challenges is providing performance opportunities, assignments, and credit to the team and the people within it.

You cannot grab all the best opportunities, you must share it with your team. This will help you to fulfill one of your primary responsibilities as a leader — growing the team.

Create a vision

A vision is the most important aspect of making a team successful. Teams perish when they don't clearly see the vision — why they are doing what they do and where they are going. You must motivate the team towards the fulfillment of the goals. Workers want to be successful and they know the only way to do that is by following and achieving great goals.

Are you Ready to be a Team Leader?

- You are comfortable in sharing leadership and decision making with your employees.
- You prefer a participative atmosphere.
- The environment is highly variable or changing quickly and you need the best thinking and input from all your employees.
- Members of your team are compatible with each other and can create a collaborative rather than a competitive environment.
- You need to rely on your employees to resolve problems.
- Formal communication channels are not sufficient for the timely exchange of information and decisions.

COMMON PROBLEMS

- Leaders select too many members in their own image. As a result, teams become unbalanced with too many people overlapping in the same areas, while there are skill gaps in other areas.
- Leaders do not understand their own strengths, abilities, and preferences.
- Individuals in unbalanced teams feel their talents and abilities are not being used.

- Leaders feel they do not know how to motivate people. This is because they do not know them and their individual needs.
- Team members feel that the team does not work smoothly. They believe individual work preferences conflict rather than complement each other.

Its time to do some rebuilding if you are facing any of the following problems:

- Loss of productivity or output
- Complaints
- Conflicts between personnel
- Lack of clear goals
- Confusion about assignments
- Lack of innovation or risk taking
- Ineffective meetings
- Lack of initiative
- Poor communication
- Lack of trust
- Employees feel that their work is not recognized
- Decisions are made that people do not understand or agree with

Include the team on the rebuilding process. First have a diagnostic meeting. This meeting should be off-site so that there are no interruptions and to show them you are truly committed to building a team. This part of the process is not to fix any problems but to bring forth what is both good and bad with the team in order to formulate future plans. You need to find out what is working or not working and where they are with their working relationships with each other, other teams, and you. If the team is large, it might help to break them down into smaller discussion groups in order to have more lively discussions or to pair them up and have them report back to the team.

Consider the first part of the diagnostic meeting as a brainstorming session. Do not throw out any problems or ideas that you feel are irrelevant. After all the data have been made public, have the team determine what is correct and relevant.

Next, categorize the issues, such as planning, scheduling, resources, policies, tasks or activities the group must perform, interpersonal conflict, etc. Once all the information has been categorized, develop action plans to solve the problems. And finally and most importantly, follow up on the plans to ensure they are being accomplished.

PRESENTATION

Presentations and reports are ways of communicating ideas and information to a group. But unlike a report, a presentation carries the speaker's personality better and allows immediate interaction between all the participants.

A good presentation has:

- *Content:* It contains information that people need. But unlike reports, which are read at the reader's own pace, presentations must account for how much information the audience can absorb in one sitting.

- *Structure*: It has a logical beginning, middle, and end. It must be sequenced and paced so that the audience can understand it. Where as reports have appendices and footnotes to guide the reader, the speaker must be careful not to loose the audience when wandering from the main point of the presentation.
- *Packaging*: It must be well prepared. A report can be reread and portions skipped over, but with a presentation, the audience is at the mercy of a presenter.
- *Human Element*: A good presentation will be remembered much more than a good report because it has a person attached to it. But you still need to analyse if the audience's needs would not be better met if a report was sent instead.

THE VOICE

The voice is probably the most valuable tool of the presenter. It carries most of the content that the audience takes away.

One of the oddities of speech is that we can easily tell others what is wrong with their voice, e.g. too fast, too high, too soft, etc., but we have trouble listening to and changing our own voices.

There are four main terms used for defining vocal qualities:

1. *Volume*: How loud the sound is. The goal is to be heard without shouting. Good speakers lower their voice to draw the audience in, and raise it to make a point.
2. *Tone*: The characteristics of a sound. An airplane has a different sound than leaves being rustled by the wind. A voice that carries fear can frighten the audience, while a voice that carries laughter can get the audience to smile.
3. *Pitch*: How high or low a note is. Pee Wee Herman has a high voice, Barbara Walters has a moderate voice, while James Earl Jones has a low voice.
4. *Pace*: This is how long a sound lasts. Talking too fast causes the words and syllables to be short, while talking slowly lengthens them. Varying the pace helps to maintain the audience's interest.
5. *Colour*: Both projection and tone variance can be practiced by taking the line "This new policy is going to be exciting" and saying it first with surprise, then with irony, then with grief, and finally with anger. The key is to over-act. Remember Shakespeare's words "All the world's a stage" — presentations are the opening night on Broadway!

There are two good methods for improving your voice:

1. Listen to it! Practice listening to your voice while at home, driving, walking, etc. Then when you are at work or with company, monitor your voice to see if you are using it how you want to.
2. To really listen to your voice, cup your right hand around your right ear and gently pull the ear forward. Next, cup your left hand around your mouth and direct the sound straight into your ear. This helps you to really hear your

voice as others hear it...and it might be completely different from the voice you thought it was! Now practice moderating your voice.

THE BODY

Your body communicates different impressions to the audience. People not only listen to you, they also watch you. Slouching tells them you are indifferent or you do not care...even though you might care a great deal! On the other hand, displaying good posture tells your audience that you know what you are doing and you care deeply about it. Also, a good posture helps you to speak more clearly and effectively.

Throughout your presentation, display:

- *Eye contact:* This helps to regulate the flow of communication. It signals interest in others and increases the speaker's credibility. Speakers who make eye contact open the flow of communication and convey interest, concern, warmth, and credibility.
- *Facial Expressions:* Smiling is a powerful cue that transmits happiness, friendliness, warmth, and liking. So, if you smile frequently you will be perceived as more likable, friendly, warm, and approachable. Smiling is often contagious and others will react favourably. They will be more comfortable around you and will want to listen to you more.
- *Gestures:* If you fail to gesture while speaking, you may be perceived as boring and stiff. A lively speaking style captures attention, makes the material more interesting, and facilitates understanding.
- *Posture and body orientation:* You communicate numerous messages by the way you talk and move. Standing erect and leaning forward communicates that you are approachable, receptive, and friendly. Interpersonal closeness results when you and your audience face each other. Speaking with your back turned or looking at the floor or ceiling should be avoided as it communicates disinterest.
- *Proximity:* Cultural norms dictate a comfortable distance for interaction with others. You should look for signals of discomfort caused by invading other's space. Some of these are: rocking, leg swinging, tapping, and gaze aversion. Typically, in large rooms, space invasion is not a problem. In most instances there is too much distance.

To counteract this, move around the room to increase interaction with your audience. Increasing the proximity enables you to make better eye contact and increases the opportunities for others to speak.

- *Voice:* One of the major criticisms of speakers is that they speak in a monotone voice.

Listeners perceive this type of speaker as boring and dull. People report that they learn less and lose interest more quickly when listening to those who have not learned to modulate their voices.

ACTIVE LISTENING

Good speakers not only inform their audience, they also listen to them. By listening, you know if they are understanding the information and if the information is important to them. Active listening is NOT the same as hearing! Hearing is the first part and consists of the perception of sound.

Listening, the second part, involves an attachment of meaning to the aural symbols that are perceived. Passive listening occurs when the receiver has little motivation to listen carefully. Active listening with a purpose is used to gain information, to determine how another person feels, and to understand others.

Some good traits of effective listeners are:

- Spend more time listening than talking.
- Do not finish the sentence of others.
- Do not answer questions with questions.
- Aware of biases. We all have them. We need to control them.
- Never daydream or become preoccupied with their own thoughts when others talk.
- Let the other speaker talk. Do not dominate the conversation.
- Plan responses after others have finished speaking...NOT while they are speaking. Their full concentration is on what others are saying, not on what they are going to respond with.
- Provide feedback but do not interrupt incessantly.
- Analyse by looking at all the relevant factors and asking open-ended questions. Walk the person through analysis.
- Keep the conversation on what the speaker says...NOT on what interest them.

Listening can be one of our most powerful communication tools! Be sure to use it!

Part of the listening process is getting feedback by changing and altering the message so the intention of the original communicator is understood by the second communicator. This is done by paraphrasing the words of the sender and restating the sender's feelings or ideas in your own words, rather than repeating their words. Your words should be saying, "This is what I understand your feelings to be, am I correct?" It not only includes verbal responses, but also nonverbal ones. Nodding your head or squeezing their hand to show agreement, dipping your eyebrows to show you don't quite understand the meaning of their last phrase, or sucking air in deeply and blowing out hard shows that you are also exasperated with the situation.

Carl Roger listed five main categories of feedback.

They are listed in the order in which they occur most frequently in daily conversations:

1. *Evaluative:* Makes a judgment about the worth, goodness, or appropriateness of the other person's statement.
2. *Interpretive:* Paraphrasing - attempt to explain what the other persons statement mean.
3. *Supportive:* Attempt to assist or bolster the other communicator

4. *Probing*: Attempt to gain additional information, continue the discussion, or clarify a point.
5. *Understanding*: Attempt to discover completely what the other communicator means by her statements.

NERVES

The main enemy of a presenter is tension, which ruins the voice, posture, and spontaneity. The voice becomes higher as the throat tenses. Shoulders tighten up and limits flexibility while the legs start to shake and causes unsteadiness. The presentation becomes “canned” as the speaker locks in on the notes and starts to read directly from them.

First, do not fight nerves, welcome them! Then you can get on with the presentation instead of focusing in on being nervous. Actors recognize the value of nerves...they add to the value of the performance.

This is because adrenaline starts to kick in. It's a left over from our ancestors' “fight or flight” syndrome. If you welcome nerves, then the presentation becomes a challenge and you become better.

If you let your nerves take over, then you go into the flight mode by withdrawing from the audience. Again, welcome your nerves, recognize them, let them help you gain that needed edge! Do not go into the flight mode! When you feel tension or anxiety, remember that everyone gets them, but the winners use them to their advantage, while the losers get overwhelmed by them.

Tension can be reduced by performing some relaxation exercises:

- Before the presentation: Lie on the floor. Your back should be flat on the floor. Pull your feet towards you so that your knees are up in the air. Relax. Close your eyes. Feel your back spreading out and supporting your weight. Feel your neck lengthening. Work your way through your body, relaxing one section at a time - your toes, feet, legs, torso, etc. When finished, stand up slowly and try to maintain the relaxed feeling in a standing position.
- If you cannot lie down: Stand with you feet about 6 inches apart, arms hanging by your sides, and fingers unclenched. Gently shake each part of your body, starting with your hands, then arms, shoulders, torso, and legs. Concentrate on shaking out the tension. Then slowly rotate your shoulders forwards and the backwards. Move on to your head. Rotate it slowly clockwise, and then counter-clockwise.
- Mental Visualization: Before the presentation, visualize the room, audience, and you giving the presentation. Mentally go over what you are going to do from the moment you start to the end of the presentation.
- During the presentation: Take a moment to yourself by getting a drink of water, take a deep breath, concentrate on relaxing the most tense part of your body, and then return to the presentation saying to your self, “I can do it!”

- You do NOT need to get rid of anxiety and tension! Channel the energy into concentration and expressiveness.
- Know that anxiety and tension is not as noticeable to the audience as it is to you.
- Know that even the best presenters make mistakes. The key is to continue on after the mistake. If you pick up and continue, so will the audience. Winners continue! Losers stop!
- Never drink alcohol to reduce tension! It affects not only your coordination but also your awareness of coordination. You might not realise it, but your audience will!

QUESTIONS

Although some people get a perverse pleasure from putting others on the spot, and some try to look good in front of the boss, most people ask questions from a genuine interest. Questions do not mean you did not explain the topic good enough, but that their interest is deeper than the average audience.

Always allow time at the end of the presentation for questions. After inviting questions, do not rush ahead if no one asks a question. Pause for about 6 seconds to allow the audience to gather their thoughts. When a question is asked, repeat the question to ensure that everyone heard it. When answering, direct your remarks to the entire audience. That way, you keep everyone focused, not just the questioner. To reinforce your presentation, try to relate the question back to the main points.

Make sure you listen to the question being asked. If you do not understand it, ask them to clarify. Pause to think about the question as the answer you give may be correct, but ignore the main issue. If you do not know the answer, be honest, do not waffle. Tell them you will get back to them...and make sure you do! Answers that last 10 to 40 seconds work best. If they are too short, they seem abrupt; while longer answers appear too elaborate. Also, be sure to keep on track. Do not let off-the-wall questions sidetrack you into areas that are not relevant to the presentation.

If someone takes issue with something you said, try to find a way to agree with part of their argument. For example, “Yes, I understand your position...” or “I’m glad you raised that point, but...” The idea is to praise their point and agree with them. Audiences sometimes tend to think of “us verses you.” You do not want to risk alienating them.

PREPARING THE PRESENTATION

Great presentations require some preplanning. First, read Meetings for an outline of preparing and conducting a meeting, such as acquiring a room, informing participants, etc. A presentation follows the same basic guidelines as preparing for a meeting.

The second step is to prepare the presentation. A good presentation starts out with introductions and an icebreaker such as a story, interesting statement or fact, joke, quotation, or an activity to get the group warmed up. The introduction also needs an

objective, that is, the purpose or goal of the presentation. This not only tells you what you will talk about, but it also informs the audience of the purpose of the presentation.

Next, comes the body of the presentation. Do NOT write it out word for word. All you want is an outline. By jotting down the main points on a set of index cards, you not only have your outline, but also a memory jogger for the actual presentation.

To prepare the presentation, ask yourself the following:

- What is the purpose of the presentation?
- Who will be attending?
- What does the audience already know about the subject?
- What is the audience's attitude towards me?

A 45 minutes talk should have no more than about seven main points. This may not seem like very many, but if you are to leave the audience with a clear picture of what you have said, you cannot expect them to remember much more than that.

There are several options for structuring the presentation:

- *Timeline:* Arranged in sequential order.
- *Climax:* The main points are delivered in order of increasing importance.
- *Problem/Solution:* A problem is presented, a solution is suggested, and benefits are then given.
- *Classification:* The important items are the major points.
- *Simple to complex:* Ideas are listed from the simplest to the most complex. Can also be done in reverse order.

You want to include some visual information that will help the audience understand your presentation. Develop charts, graphs, slides, handouts, etc.

After the body, comes the closing. This is where you ask for questions, provide a wrap-up and thank the participants for attending.

Notice that you told them what they are about to hear, told them, and told them what they heard.

And finally, the important part - practice, practice, practice. The main purpose of creating an outline is to develop a coherent plan of what you want to talk about. You should know your presentation so well, that during the actual presentation, you should only have to briefly glance at your notes to ensure you are staying on track. This will also help you with your nerves by giving you the confidence that you can do it. Your practice session should include a "live" session by practicing in front of coworkers, family, or friends. They can be valuable at providing feedback and it gives you a chance to practice controlling your nerves. Another great feedback technique is to make a video or audio tape of your presentation and review it critically with a colleague.

HABITS

We all have a few habits, and some are more annoying than others. For example, if we say "uh," "you know," or put our hands in our pockets and jingle our keys too often during a presentation, it distracts from the message we are trying to get across.

The best way to break one of these distracting habits is with immediate feedback. This can be done with a small group of coworkers, family, or friends. Take turns giving small off-the-cuff talks about your favourite hobby, work project, first work assignment, etc. The talk should last about five minutes. During a speaker's first talk, the audience should listen and watch for annoying habits.

After the presentation, the audience should agree on the worst two or three habits that take the most away from the presentation. After agreement, each audience member should write these habits on a 8 1/2" x 11" sheet of paper. Use a magic marker and write in BIG letters.

The next time the person gives her or his talk, each audience member should wave the corresponding sign in the air whenever they hear or see the annoying habit. For most people, this method will break a habit by practicing at least once a day for one to two weeks.

TIPS AND TECHNIQUES FOR GREAT PRESENTATIONS

- Do not read straight from them. The audience does not know if they should read along with you or listen to you read.
- Do not put both hands in your pockets for long periods of time. This tends to make you look unprofessional. It is OK to put one hand in a pocket but ensure there is no loose change or keys to jingle around. This will distract the listeners.
- Do not wave a pointer around in the air like a wild knight branding a sword to slay a dragon. Use the pointer for what it is intended and then put it down, otherwise the audience will become fixated upon your "sword", instead upon you.
- Do not lean on the podium for long periods. The audience will begin to wonder when you are going to fall over.
- Speak to the audience...NOT to the visual aids, such as flip charts or overheads. Also, do not stand between the visual aid and the audience.
- Speak clearly and loudly enough for all to hear. Do not speak in a monotone voice. Use inflection to emphasize your main points.
- The disadvantages of presentations is that people cannot see the punctuation and this can lead to misunderstandings. An effective way of overcoming this problem is to pause at the time when there would normally be punctuation marks.
- Use coloured backgrounds on overhead transparencies and slides as the bright white light can be harsh on the eyes. This will quickly cause your audience to tire. If all of your transparencies or slides have clear backgrounds, then tape one blank yellow one on the overhead face. For slides, use a rubber band to hold a piece of coloured cellophane over the projector lens.
- Learn the name of each participant as quickly as possible. Based upon the atmosphere you want to create, call them by their first names or by using Mr., Mrs., Miss, Ms.

- Tell them what name and title you prefer to be called.
- Listen intently to comments and opinions. By using a lateral thinking technique, the audience will feel that their ideas, comments, and opinions are worthwhile.
- Circulate around the room as you speak. This movement creates a physical closeness to the audience.
- List and discuss your objectives at the beginning of the presentation. Let the audience know how your presentation fits in with their goals. Discuss some of the fears and apprehensions that both you and the audience might have. Tell them what they should expect of you and how you will contribute to their goals.
- Vary your techniques
- Get to the presentation before your audience arrives; be the last one to leave.
- Be prepared to use an alternate approach if the one you've chosen seems to bog down. You should be confident enough with your own material so that the audience's interests and concerns, not the presentation outline, determines the format. Use your background, experience, and knowledge to interrelate your subject matter.
- When writing on flip charts use no more than 7 lines of text per page and no more than 7 word per line. Also, use bright and bold colours, and pictures as well as text.
- Consider the time of day and how long you have got for your talk. Time of day can affect the audience.
After lunch is known as the graveyard section in training circles as audiences will feel more like a nap than listening to a talk.
- Most people find that if they practice in their head, the actual talk will take about 25 per cent longer. Using a flip chart or other visual aids also adds to the time. Remember - it is better to finish slightly early than to overrun.

COMMUNICATION AND LEADERSHIP MANAGEMENT

Communication is the exchange and flow of information and ideas from one person to another; it involves a sender transmitting an idea, information, or feeling to a receiver. Effective communication occurs only if the receiver understands the exact information or idea that the sender intended to transmit.

Many of the problems that occur in an organization are either the direct result of people failing to communicate and/or processes, which leads to confusion and can cause good plans to fail.

Studying the communication process is important because you coach, coordinate, counsel, evaluate, and supervise throughout this process. It is the chain of understanding that integrates the members of an organization from top to bottom, bottom to top, and side to side.

THE COMMUNICATION PROCESS

- *Thought*: First, information exists in the mind of the sender. This can be a concept, idea, information, or feelings.
- *Encoding*: Next, a message is sent to a receiver in words or other symbols.
- *Decoding*: lastly, the receiver translates the words or symbols into a concept or information that he or she can understand.

During the transmitting of the message, two elements will be received: content and context. Content is the actual words or symbols of the message that is known as language — the spoken and written words combined into phrases that make grammatical and semantic sense. We all use and interpret the meanings of words differently, so even simple messages can be misunderstood. And many words have different meanings to confuse the issue even more.

Context is the way the message is delivered and is known as paralanguage — it is the nonverbal elements in speech such as the tone of voice, the look in the sender's eyes, body language, hand gestures, and state of emotions that can be detected.

Although paralanguage or context often cause messages to be misunderstood as we believe what we see more than what we hear; they are powerful communicators that help us to understand each other. Indeed, we often trust the accuracy of nonverbal behaviours more than verbal behaviours.

Some leaders think they have communicated once they told someone to do something, "I don't know why it did not get done. I told Jim to do it." More than likely, Jim misunderstood the message. A message has NOT been communicated unless it is understood by the receiver. How do you know it has been properly received? By two-way communication or feedback. This feedback tells the sender that the receiver understood the message, its level of importance, and what must be done with it. Communication is an exchange, not just a give, as all parties must participate to complete the information exchange.

BARRIERS TO COMMUNICATION

Anything that prevents understanding of the message is a barrier to communication.

Many physical and psychological barriers exist:

- *Culture, background, and bias*: We allow our past experiences to change the meaning of the message. Our culture, background, and bias can be good as they allow us to use our past experiences to understand something new, it is when they change the meaning of the message that they interfere with the communication process.
- *Noise*: Equipment or environmental noise impedes clear communication. The sender and the receiver must both be able to concentrate on the messages being sent to each other.
- *Ourselves*: Focusing on ourselves, rather than the other person can lead to confusion and conflict. The "Me Generation" is out when it comes to effective

communication. Some of the factors that cause this are defensiveness, superiority, and ego.

- *Perception*: If we feel the person is talking too fast, not fluently, does not articulate clearly, etc., we may dismiss the person. Also our preconceived attitudes affect our ability to listen. We listen uncritically to persons of high status and dismiss those of low status.
- *Message*: Distractions happen when we focus on the facts rather than the idea. Our educational institutions reinforce this with tests and questions. Semantic distractions occur when a word is used differently than you prefer. For example, the word chairman instead of chairperson, may cause you to focus on the word and not the message.
- *Environmental*: Bright lights, an attractive person, unusual sights, or any other stimulus provides a potential distraction.
- *Smothering*: We take it for granted that the impulse to send useful information is automatic. Not true! Too often we believe that certain information has no value to others or they are already aware of the facts.
- *Stress*: People do not see things the same way when under stress. What we see and believe at a given moment is influenced by our psychological frames of references — our beliefs, values, knowledge, experiences, and goals.

These barriers can be thought of as filters, that is, the message leaves the sender, goes through the filters, and is then heard by the receiver. These filters muffle the message. And the way to overcome filters is through active listening and feedback.

ACTIVE LISTENING

Hearing and listening are not the same thing. Hearing is the animation of perceiving sound. It is involuntary and simply refers to the reception of aural stimuli. Listening is a selective activity which involves the reception and the interpretation of aural stimuli. It involves decoding the sound into meaning.

Listening is divided into two main categories: passive and active. Passive listening is little more than hearing. It occurs when the receiver of the message has little motivation to listen carefully, such as when listening to music, story telling, television, or when being polite. People speak at 100 to 175 words per minute, but they can listen intelligently at 600 to 800 WPM. Since only a part of our mind is paying attention, it is easy to go into mind drift — thinking about other things while listening to someone. The cure for this is active listening — which involves listening with a purpose.

It may be to gain information, obtain directions, understand others, solve problems, share interest, see how another person feels, show support, etc. It requires that the listener attends to the words and the feelings of the sender for understanding.

It takes the same amount or more energy than speaking. It requires the receiver to hear the various messages, understand the meaning, and then verify the meaning by offering feedback.

The following are a few traits of active listeners:

- Spend more time listening than talking.
- Do not finish the sentences of others.
- Do not answer questions with questions.
- Are aware of biases. We all have them. We need to control them.
- Never daydreams or become preoccupied with their own thoughts when others talk.
- Let the other speakers talk. Do not dominate the conversations.
- Plan responses after the others have finished speaking, NOT while they are speaking.
- Provide feedback, but do not interrupt incessantly.
- Analyse by looking at all the relevant factors and asking open-ended questions. Walk others through by summarizing.
- Keep conversations on what others say, NOT on what interests them.
- Take brief notes. This forces them to concentrate on what is being said.

FEEDBACK

The purpose of feedback is to alter messages so the intention of the original communicator is understood by the second communicator. It includes verbal and nonverbal responses to another person's message.

Providing feedback is accomplished by paraphrasing the words of the sender. Restate the sender's feelings or ideas in your own words, rather than repeating their words. Your words should be saying, "This is what I understand your feelings to be, am I correct?" It not only includes verbal responses, but also nonverbal ones.

Nodding your head or squeezing their hand to show agreement, dipping your eyebrows shows you don't quite understand the meaning of their last phrase, or sucking air in deeply and blowing it hard shows that you are also exasperated with the situation. Carl Rogers listed five main categories of feedback. They are listed in the order in which they occur most frequently in daily conversations.

Notice that we make judgments more often than we try to understand:

- *Evaluative:* Making a judgment about the worth, goodness, or appropriateness of the other person's statement.
- *Interpretive:* Paraphrasing — attempting to explain what the other person's statement means.
- *Supportive:* Attempting to assist or bolster the other communicator.
- *Probing:* Attempting to gain additional information, continue the discussion, or clarify a point.
- *Understanding:* Attempting to discover completely what the other communicator means by her statements.

Imagine how much better daily communications would be if listeners tried to understand first, before they tried to evaluate what someone is saying.

NON-VERBAL BEHAVIOURS OF COMMUNICATION

To deliver the full impact of a message, use nonverbal behaviours to raise the channel of interpersonal communication:

- *Eye contact:* This helps to regulate the flow of communication. It signals interest in others and increases the speaker's credibility. People who make eye contact open the flow of communication and convey interest, concern, warmth, and credibility.
- *Facial Expressions:* Smiling is a powerful cue that transmits happiness, friendliness, warmth, and liking. So, if you smile frequently you will be perceived as more likable, friendly, warm and approachable. Smiling is often contagious and people will react favourably. They will be more comfortable around you and will want to listen more.
- *Gestures:* If you fail to gesture while speaking you may be perceived as boring and stiff. A lively speaking style captures the listener's attention, makes the conversation more interesting, and facilitates understanding.
- *Posture and body orientation:* You communicate numerous messages by the way you talk and move. Standing erect and leaning forward communicates to listeners that you are approachable, receptive and friendly. Interpersonal closeness results when you and the listener face each other. Speaking with your back turned or looking at the floor or ceiling should be avoided as it communicates disinterest.
- *Proximity:* Cultural norms dictate a comfortable distance for interaction with others. You should look for signals of discomfort caused by invading the other person's space. Some of these are: rocking, leg swinging, tapping, and gaze aversion.
- *Vocal:* Speaking can signal nonverbal communication when you include such vocal elements as: tone, pitch, rhythm, timbre, loudness, and inflection. For maximum teaching effectiveness, learn to vary these six elements of your voice. One of the major criticisms of many speakers is that they speak in a monotone voice. Listeners perceive this type of speaker as boring and dull.

SPEAKING HINTS

- When speaking or trying to explain something, ask the listeners if they are following you.
- Ensure the receiver has a chance to comment or ask questions.
- Try to put yourself in the other person's shoes — consider the feelings of the receiver.
- Be clear about what you say.
- Look at the receiver.
- Make sure your words match your tone and body language.
- Vary your tone and pace.

- Do not be vague, but on the other hand, do not complicate what you are saying with too much detail.
- Do not ignore signs of confusion.

ON COMMUNICATION PER SE — A FEW RANDOM THOUGHTS

On Discussing Communication

But what forms of human behaviour are not messy? Learning is not *antiseptic*, yet it is discussed all the time — we do not leave it to the academics, such as Bloom, Knowles, Dugan, or Rossett. Leadership and management seems to be even messier, yet we categorize it, build models of it, index it, chop it and slice it and dice it, build pyramids out of it, and generally have a good time discussing it.

But when it comes to *communication*, we call it too messy to play with and leave it up to Chomsky, Pinker, and others to write about so that we can read about it. Yet we all communicate almost every single day of our lives, which is much more than as suggested, ever do with learning or leadership.

Paul Ekman

In the mid 1960s, Paul Ekman studied emotions and discovered six facial expressions that almost everyone recognizes world-wide: happiness, sadness, anger, fear, disgust, and surprise. Although they were controversial at first they are now widely accepted. One of the controversies still lingering is the amount of context needed to interpret them.

For example, if someone reports to me that they have this great ideal that they would like to implement, and I say that would be great, but I look on them with a frown, is it possible that I could be thinking about something else? The trouble with these extra signals is that we do not always have the full context. What if the person emailed me and I replied great. Would it evoke the same response?

Emotions

Trust your instincts. Most emotions are difficult to imitate. For example, when you are truly happy, the muscles used for smiling are controlled by the limbic system and other parts of the brain, which are not under voluntary control. When you force a smile, a different part of the brain is used — the cerebral cortex, hence different muscles are used. This is why a clerk, who might not have any real interest in you, has a *fake* look when he forces a smile.

Of course, some actors learn to control all of their face muscles, while others draw on a past emotional experience to produce the emotional state they want. But this is not an easy trick to pull off all the time. There is a good reason for this — part of our emotions evolved to deal with other people and our empathic nature. If these emotions could easily be faked, they would do more harm than good. So our emotions not only

guide our decisions, they can also be communicated to others to help them in their decisions — of course their emotions will be the ultimate guide, but the emotions they discover in others become part of their knowledge base.

Mehrabian and the 7%-38%-55% Myth

We often hear that the content of a message is composed of:

- 55% from the visual component
- 38% from the auditory component
- 7% from language

However, the percentages only apply in a very narrow context. A researcher named Mehrabian was interested in how listeners get their information about a speaker's general attitude in situations where the facial expression, tone, and/or words are sending conflicting signals.

Thus, he designed a couple of experiments. In one, Mehrabian and Ferris researched the interaction of speech, facial expressions, and tone. Three different speakers were instructed to say "maybe" with three different attitudes towards their listener. Next, photographs of the faces of three female models were taken as they attempted to convey the emotions of like, neutrality, and dislike.

Test groups were then instructed to listen to the various renditions of the word "maybe," with the pictures of the models, and were asked to rate the attitude of the speaker. Note that the emotion and tone were often mixed, such as a facial expression showing dislike, with the word "maybe" spoken in a positive tone.

Significant effects of facial expression and tone were found in that the study suggested that the combined effect of simultaneous verbal, vocal and facial attitude communications is a weighted sum of their independent effects with the coefficients of .07, .38, and .55, respectively. Mehrabian and Ferris also wrote about a deep limitation to their research, "These findings regarding the relative contribution of the tonal component of a verbal message can be safely extended only to communication situations in which no additional information about the communicator/addressee relationship is available."

Thus, what can be concluded is that when people communicate, listeners derive information about the speaker's attitudes towards the listener from visual, tonal, and verbal cues; yet the percentage derived can vary greatly depending upon a number of other factors, such as actions, context of the communication, and how well they know that person.

STRATEGY AND TACTICS

Strategy is the creation of a unique and valuable market position supported by a system of activities that fit together in a complementary way. It is about making choices, trade-offs, and deliberately choosing to be different. It should not be confused with "operational effectiveness" — what is good for everybody and what every business should be doing, e.g., performing the same activities your competitors perform, TQM,

benchmarking, or being a learning organization. Thus, when developing strategies, the goal is to be different from your competitors. However, this does not mean that you are willing to do anything. But to determine where the opportunities lie that you can best exploit.

All “strategic plans” need to tie in with the “strategic organization plan.” That is, in going back to the definition of strategy, the leaders of the organization should create the unique and valuable market position; while your goal is to support the organization with activities that fit together in a complementary way.

Now that does not mean you cannot do things differently or set your own goals. It simply means that you need to keep your leaders visions and goals in mind when setting the your goals. For example, if the leaders have ethics and diversity at the forefront of their strategic vision, you cannot put e-learning and knowledge management at the forefront of your strategic goals.

However, that does not mean you cannot use e-learning and knowledge management technologies to bring about ethical and diversity goals.

VISIONING

Visioning is the start of any strategic plan. Once your leaders have set the organizational strategic plans, you need to determine how best your department can bring about changes that will support those plans. And while their strategic plans needs to be “unique,” you need to think along the same lines.

In addition, a visioning strategy takes a four-prong approach:

1. *Internal Audit:* Where are you now?
2. *Reading and Research:* Where can you grow?
3. *Organization Vision:* Where is the organization going?
4. *Vision:* Where do you want to grow?

Note that first three steps can be performed in just about any order; however, the last step will normally be last in the process as it is based upon the other three prongs.

TACTICAL

Strategies are forward-looking. They provide the guidelines for growth. With strategies, you are in reality, speaking of future performance gaps and how you are going to overcome them.

Tactical is more or less present or noworientated. It is about present performance gaps and how you are going to overcome them in order to support the strategies.

When Peters writes of “enhancing”, he is speaking of the strategic plans that will grow the employees to meet tomorrow’s challenges.

When he writes of “insure against the decline of,” he is speaking of the tactical impediments that are presently challenging employees from meeting expected performance standards. In order to grow, you must be able to ward off present roadblocks. Thus, tactical plans are about providing performance stability so that change may take

affect for growth. Strategies normally look an average of about six-years into the future. Tactics look ahead just far enough to secure objectives set by strategy. Thus, tactics is characterized by adroitness, ingenuity, or skill. Note that tactics is from the Greek “taktika” — matters pertaining to arrangement. On the other hand, strategy has its roots in “office of a General” or “to lead”.

COMMAND AND CONTROL

There are four basic functions used within organizations to achieve their visions and goals: Command, Control, Leadership, and Management:

1. *Command*: Forming and imparting visions:
 - Well formed visions
 - Clear goals and objectives for achieving the visions
 - Quality, low volume communications throughout the organization
 - Involvement to ensure results
2. *Leadership*: Achieving visions through people:
 - Standard Bearer
 - Developing
 - Integrating
3. *Management* - Implementing processes for achieving the visions:
 - Planning
 - Organizing
 - Budgeting
4. *Control*: Ensuring resources went where they were supposed to go:
 - Routine, high volume communications
 - Coordination between activities
 - Structure to reduce uncertainty

With Control and Management the ultimate goal is “efficiency”—addressing how well the process was accomplished; while with Command and Leadership the ultimate goal is “effectiveness” — achieving goals and mission. Generally, to achieve “form,” one must conceptualize “processes”; while to achieve “results,” one must conceptualize “tasks.” Thus, command and leadership decide what the organization should be doing, while control and management ensure that the resources used to achieve the results are used efficiently.

FRAMEWORKS OF COMMAND AND CONTROL

Command and Leadership use the following framework:

- *Creating*: Creating a vision or task to achieve results.
- *Planning*: How will you achieve the result.
- *Implementing*: Putting the plan into action.
- *Followup*: Ensuring that it gets done.

Related to the Command and Control framework is OODA.

Control and Management uses the following framework:

- *Observe:* See what has happened.
- *Compare:* What actually happened to what was supposed to happen.
- *Decide:* Does the comparison show that the objectives were met and determine what needs changing?
- *Follow-up:* Ensure the change actually happened.

LEADING MANAGEMENT

GOALS

Your thinking skills can be considered directional skills because they set the direction for your organization. They provide vision, purpose, and goal definition. These are your eyes and ears to the future, allowing you to recognize the need for change, when to make it, how to implement it, and how to manage it.

You find vision by reaching for any available reason to change, grow, and improve. Just as you perform preventive maintenance on your car, you must perform preventive maintenance on your organization.

Do NOT believe in the old adage, “If it ain’t broke, don’t fix it,” for the people who do, go broke! Treat every project as a change effort. Treat every job as a new learning experience. Good organizations convey a strong vision of where they will be in the future. As a leader, you have to get your people to trust you and be sold on your vision. Using the leadership tools described in this guide and being honest and fair in all you do will provide you with the ammo you need to gain their trust.

To sell them on your vision, you need to possess energy and display a positive attitude that is contagious. People want a strong vision of where they are going. No one wants to be stuck in a dead-end company going nowhere...or a company headed in the wrong direction.

They want to be involved with a winner! And your people are the ones who will get you to that goal. You cannot do it alone!

When setting goals, keep these points in mind:

- They should be realistic and attainable.
- They should improve the organization.
- All the people should be involved in the goal-setting process.
- A programme should be developed to achieve each goal.

There are four characteristics of goal setting:

1. *Goal Difficulty:* Increasing your employees’ goal difficulty increases their challenges and enhances the amount of effort expended to achieve them. The more difficult goals lead to increased performance if they seem feasible. If they seem too high, employees will give up when they fail to achieve them.
2. *Goal Specificity:* When given specific goals, employees tend to perform higher. Telling them to do their best or giving no guidance increases ambiguity about

what is expected. Employees need a set goal or model in order to display the correct behaviour.

3. *Feedback*: Providing feedback enhances the effects of goal setting. Performance feedback keeps their behaviour directed on the right target and encourages them to work harder to achieve the goal.
4. *Participation in Goal Setting*: Employees who participate in the process, generally set higher goals than if the goals were set for them. It also affects their belief that the goals are obtainable and increases their motivation to achieve them.

THE SIX STEPS OF GOAL SETTING

Although finding a vision can be quite a creative challenge, the process of getting that vision implemented can be fairly easy if you follow the six steps of:

1. Vision
2. Goals
3. Objectives
4. Tasks
5. Timelines
6. Followup

Step 1 – Vision

The first step in setting goals and priorities is to personally develop what the organization should look like at some point in the future — a vision. A junior leader, such as a supervisor or line manager, will mainly be concerned with a department, section, or small group of people. While senior leaders set the vision for the entire organization. However, both types of visions need to support the organization's goals.

The mission of the organization is crucial in determining your vision. Your vision needs to coincide with the big picture. The term “vision” suggests a mental picture of what the future organization will look like. The concept also implies a later time horizon.

This time horizon tends to be mid to long term in nature, focusing normally on 2 to 7 years in the future for visions affecting the entire organization. However, leaders such as supervisors or line managers tend to have shorter time horizon visions, normally 6 months to a year. The concept of a vision has become a popular term within academic, government, defence, and corporate circles. This has spawned many different definitions of vision.

But, the vision you want should be a picture of where you want your department to be at a future date. For example, try to picture what your department would look like if it was perfect, or what the most efficient way to produce your product would look like, or perhaps if your budget was reduced by 10 per cent, how you could still achieve the same quality product. Vilfredo Pareto, a 19th century economist, theorized that most effects come from relatively few causes; that is, 80 per cent of the effects come from 20 per cent of the possible causes. For example, 20 per cent of the inventory items in the

supply chain of an organization accounts for 80 per cent of the inventory value. This is known as the *Pareto principle* or the *80-20 rule*.

Some leaders fall into the time wasting trap of going after the 80 per cent of items that only have a value of 20 per cent of the total net worth. Your visions need to picture the 20 per cent that will have the greatest impact on your organization.

Although it is nice to have small victories every now and then by going after that easy 80 per cent, spend the majority of your time focusing on the few things that will have the greatest impact. That is what a good leader does. Once you have your vision, it needs to be framed in general, unmeasurable terms and communicated to your team. Your team then develops the ends, ways, and means to achieve the vision.

Step 2 – Goals

The second step involves establishing goals, with the active participation of the team. Goals are also stated in unmeasurable terms, but they are more focused. For example, “The organization must reduce transportation costs.” This establishes the framework of the your vision.

Step 3 – Objectives

Definable objectives provide a way of measuring the movement towards vision achievement. This is the real strategy of turning visions into reality. It is the crossover mechanism between your forecast of the future and the envisioned, desired future. Objectives are stated in precise, measurable terms such as “By the end of the next quarter, the shipping department will use one parcel service for shipping items under 100 pounds and one motor carrier for shipping items over a hundred pounds.” The aim is to get general ownership by the entire team.

Step 4 – Tasks

The fourth step is to determine tasks. Tasks are the means for accomplishing objectives. Tasks are concrete, measurable events that must occur. An example might be, “The transportation coordinator will obtain detailed shipping rates from at least 10 motor carriers.”

Step 5 – Timelines

This step establishes a priority for the tasks. Since time is precious and many tasks must be accomplished before another can begin, establishing priorities helps your team to determine the order in which the tasks must be accomplished and by what date. For example, “The shipping rates will be obtained by May 9.”

Step 6 – Followup

The final step is to followup, measure, and check to see if the team is doing what is required. This kind of leader involvement validates that the stated priorities are worthy

of action. For the leader it demonstrates her commitment to see the matter through to a successful cease. Also, note that validating does not mean to micro-manage. Micro-management places no trust in others, where as followingup determines if the things that need to get done are in fact getting done.

SUPERVISION FOR LEADERS

Supervision is keeping a grasp on the situation and ensuring that plans and policies are implemented properly. It includes giving instructions and inspecting the accomplishment of a task.

There is a narrow band of adequate supervision. On one side of the band is over-supervision; and on the other side is under-supervision. Over-supervision stifles initiative, breeds resentment, and lowers morale and motivation. Under-supervision leads to miscommunication, lack of coordination, and the perception by subordinates that the leader does not care. However, all employees can benefit from appropriate supervision by seniors with more knowledge and experience who tend to see the situation more objectively.

Evaluating is part of supervising. It is defined as judging the worth, quality, or significance of people, ideas, or things. It includes looking at the ways people are accomplishing a task. It means getting feedback on how well something is being done and interpreting that feedback. People need feedback so that they can judge their performance. Without it, they will keep performing tasks wrong, or stop performing the steps that makes their work great.

Use checklists to list tasks that need to be accomplished. Almost all of us have poor memories when it comes to remembering a list of details. For example, "A" priorities must be done today, "B" priorities must be done by tomorrow, and "C" priorities need to be followed up within a few days.

Double check on important things by following through. Strange things can happen if you are not aware of them. Paperwork gets lost, plans get changed, and people forget. If you have a system of checks and double checks, you will discover mistakes, have time to correct them, and minimize any disruptions.

Following through may seem to be a waste of your time and energy, but in the long run, it pays off. You will spend less time and energy correcting mistakes and omissions made long ago.

INSPIRING YOUR EMPLOYEES

Getting people to accomplish something is much easier if they have the inspiration to do so. Inspire means "to breathe life into." And in order to perform that, we have to have some life ourselves.

Three main actions will aid you in accomplishing this:

1. *Be passionate:* In organizations where there is a leader with great enthusiasm about a project, a trickle-down effect will occur. You must be committed to

the work you are doing. If you do not communicate excitement, how can you expect your people to get worked up about it?

2. *Get your employees involved in the decision making process:* People who are involved in the decision making process participate much more enthusiastically than those who just carry out their boss's order. Help them contribute and tell them you value their opinions. Listen to them and incorporate their ideas when it makes sense to so.
3. *Know what your organization is about!:* The fundamental truth, as General Creighton W. Abrams used to say in the mid-1970s, is that "the Army is not made up of people.

The Army is people. Every decision we make is a people issue." Your organization is the same. It may make a product or sell a service, but it is still people! A leader's primary responsibility is to develop people and enable them to reach their full potential. Your people may come from diverse backgrounds, but they all have goals they want to accomplish. Create a "people environment" where they truly can be all they can be.

TRAINING AND COACHING

Training and coaching are two different things, although some people use them interchangeably. Training is a structured lesson designed to provide the employee with the knowledge and skills to perform a task. Coaching, on the other hand, is a process designed to help the employee gain greater competence and to overcome barriers so as to improve job performance.

You might picture it as when you were in school. During physical education, the gym teacher taught you how to play basketball. Next you went out for the school team. You had a basic understanding of the game and its rules, but the coach personally taught you the finer points of the game.

Training and coaching go hand-in-hand. First you train people with lots of technical support, and then you coach them with motivational pointers. Both training and coaching help to create the conditions that cause someone to learn and develop.

People learn by the examples of others, by forming a picture in their minds of what they are trying to learn, by gaining and understanding necessary information, by applying it to their job, or practice.

Both coaching and training have a few points in common:

- Evaluate to determine knowledge, skill, and confidence levels.
- Define objectives that can be measured periodically. It helps to break them down into step-by-step actions.
- Clarify direction, goals, and accountability. To foster accountability, involve the person or team in the decision making.
- Encourage peer coaching by reminding them that everyone has a stake in each other's success.

- Coaching is more than telling people how to do something, It involves giving advice, skill-building, creating challenges, removing performance barriers, building better processes, learning through discovery, etc.
- Deal with emotional obstacles by helping them through change, reviewing and pointing out ways that they hold themselves back, comforting them when they become confused, etc.
- Give feedback by pointing and hinting towards solutions; try to stay away from critiquing errors.
- Lead by example! demonstrate the desired behaviours.

Learning

The first condition of learning is that the person must be motivated to learn. You cannot teach knowledge or skills to people who are not motivated to learn. They must feel the need to learn what you are teaching. Most employees are motivated to do a good job.

They want to be able to perform their tasks correctly. Their motivation is being able to perform their job to standards in return for a paycheck, benefits, challenges, job satisfaction, etc.

The next condition of learning is to involve them in the process. Keep their attention by actively involving their minds and emotions in the learning process.

Have them participate through active practice of the skill or through discussion. You cannot keep their attention with a long lecture. Normally, people pay attention for a short time - less than 30 minutes.

They need to use what is being taught or their minds will wander. If you lecture for an hour, very little will be remembered.

Instead, give a brief lecture, demonstrate, and then have them practice. Provide feedback throughout the practice period until they can do it on their own. If it is a large complicated task, then break it down into short learning steps.

The Five Points of Leadership Power

Al Capone once said that “You can get much farther with a kind word and a gun than you can with a kind word alone.” However, while almost anyone can use power, it takes skill to use leadership.

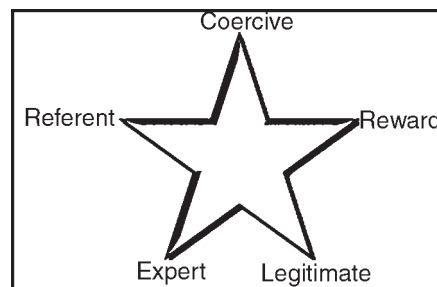
Leadership power is much more than the use of force. Leadership is influencing others to truly WANT to achieve a goal, while power forces others to achieve a goal.

Power refers to a capacity that a person has to influence the behaviour of another so that he or she acts in accordance with the boss’ wishes.

This power is a capacity or potential as it implies a potential that need not be actualized to be effective. That is, a power may exist, but does not have to be used to be effective. For example, an officer in the Army has certain powers over enlisted personnel, but that power does not have to be used to be effective.

The mere knowledge of an officer's power by an enlisted person has some influence over him or her.

A person has the potential for influencing five points of power over another:



1. *Coercive Power*: Power that is based on fear. A person with coercive power can make things difficult for people. These are the persons that you want to avoid getting angry. Employees working under coercive managers are unlikely to be committed, and more likely to resist the manager.
2. *Reward Power*: Compliance achieved based on the ability to distribute rewards that others view as valuable. Able to give special benefits or rewards to people. You might find it advantageous to trade favours with him or her.
3. *Legitimate Power*: The power a person receives as a result of his or her position in the formal hierarchy of an organization. The person has the right, considering his or her position and your job responsibilities, to expect you to comply with legitimate requests.
4. *Expert Power*: Influence based on special skills or knowledge. This person earns respect by experience and knowledge. Expert power is the most strongly and consistently related to effective employee performance.
5. *Referent Power*: Influence based on possession by an individual of desirable resources or personal traits. You like the person and enjoy doing things for him or her.

HUMAN BEHAVIOUR AND LEADERSHIP

As a leader, you need to interact with your followers, peers, seniors, and others; whose support you need in order to accomplish your goals.

To gain their support, you must be able to understand and motivate them. To understand and motivate people, you must know human nature. Human nature is the common qualities of all human beings. People behave according to certain principles of human nature.

Human needs are an important part of human nature. Values, beliefs, and customs differ from country to country and even within group to group, but in general, all people have a few basic needs. As a leader you must understand these needs because they can be powerful motivators.

MASLOW'S HIERARCHY OF NEEDS

Unlike others researchers in the earlier days of psychology, Abraham Maslow's based his theory of *human needs* on creative people who used all their talents, potential, and capabilities. His methodology differed from most other psychological researchers at the time in that these researchers mainly observed mentally unhealthy people.

Maslow felt that human needs were arranged in a hierarchical order that could be divided into two major groups: basic needs and metaneeds:

- Basic Needs are physiological, such as food, water, and sleep; and psychological, such as affection, security, and self-esteem. These basic needs are also called "deficiency needs" because if they are not met by an individual, then that person will strive to make up the deficiency.
- Metaneeds or *being needs*. These include justice, goodness, beauty, order, unity, etc. Basic needs normally take priority over these meta needs. For example, a person who lacks food or water will not normally attend to justice or beauty needs.

These needs are normally listed in a hierarchical order in the form of a pyramid to show that the basic needs must be met before the higher order needs:

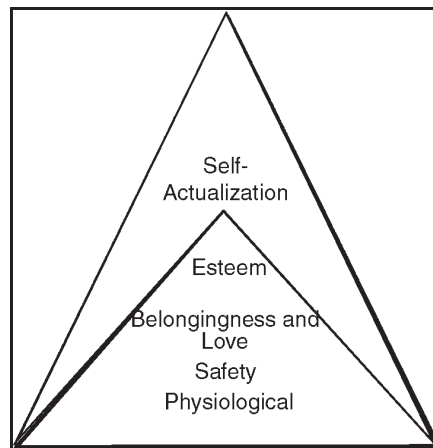


Fig. Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs- Early Years

- *Self-actualization*: Know exactly who you are, where you are going, and what you want to accomplish. A state of well-being.
- *Esteem*: Feeling of moving up in world, recognition, few doubts about self.
- *Belongingness and love*: Belong to a group, close friends to confide with.
- *Safety*: Feel free from immediate danger.
- *Physiological*: Food, water, shelter, sex.

Maslow posited that people want and are forever striving to meet various goals. Because the lower level needs are more immediate and urgent, then they come into play as the source and direction of a person's goal if they are not satisfied. A need higher in the hierarchy will become a motive of behaviour as long as the needs, it have been satisfied. Unsatisfied lower needs will dominate unsatisfied higher needs and must

be satisfied before the person can climb up the hierarchy. Knowing where a person is located on the pyramid will aid you in determining effective motivators. For example, motivating a middle-class person with a certificate will have a far greater impact than using the same motivator to effect a minimum wage person from the ghetto who is desperately struggling to meet the first couple of needs.

It should be noted that almost no one stays in one particular hierarchy for an extended period. We constantly strive to move up, while at the same time various forces outside our control try to push us down. Those on top get pushed down for short time periods, i.e., death of a loved-one or an idea that does not work, while those on the bottom get pushed up, i.e., come across a small prize. Our goal as leaders therefore is to help people obtain the skills and knowledge that will push them up the hierarchy on a more permanent basis. People who have their basic needs met become much better workers as they are able to concentrate on fulfilling the visions put forth to them, rather than consistently struggling to make ends meet.

Criticisms and Strengths

Note however, that the statements may be considered generalizations. Maslow's theory has often been criticized because we can find exceptions to it, such as the military, police, firefighters, etc. who will risk their safety for the well-being of others or parents who will sacrifice their basic needs for their children. However, there are very few theories that are not flawed in that once we start drilling down to individualistic levels, then the theory or generalization often starts to fall apart. For example, even Newton's theory of physics, which later became laws, fell apart once we were able to drill down to the atomic level. Maslow's theory remains a classic because rather than looking at psychology as strictly the study of the mentally ill, his theory was based upon healthy persons. And being one of the first humanistic ones, it has its share of flaws.

Expansion of the Pyramid

In Maslow's later years, he became more interested in the higher order or metaneeds and tried to further distinguish them. Maslow theorized that the ultimate goal of life is self-actualization, which is almost never fully attained but rather is something we try to always strive for. He later theorized that this level does not stop, it goes on to self-transcendence, which carries us to the spiritual level, e.g. Gandhi, Mother Theresa, Dalai Lama, or even poets, such as Robert Frost. Maslow's self-transcendence level recognizes the human need for ethics, creativity, compassion and spirituality. Without this spiritual or transegoic sense, we are simply animals or machines.

This expansion of the higher order needs is shown here:

Note that the four meta needs can be pursued in any order, depending upon a person's wants or circumstances, as long as the basic needs have all been met:

- *Self-transcendence*: A transegoic level that emphasizes visionary intuition, altruism, and unity consciousness.

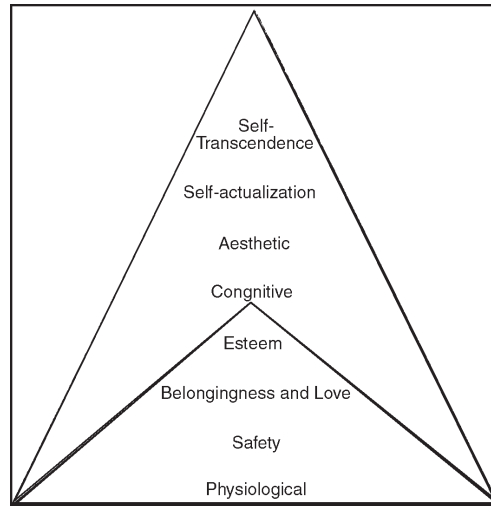


Fig. Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs- Later Years

- *Self-actualization*: Know exactly who you are, where you are going, and what you want to accomplish. A state of well-being.
- *Aesthetic*: To do things not simply for the outcome but because it's the reason you are here on earth — at peace, more curious about the inner workings of all things.
- *Cognitive*: To be free of the good opinion of others — learning for learning alone, contribute knowledge.
- *Esteem*: Feeling of moving up in world, recognition, few doubts about self.
- *Belongingness and love*: Belong to a group, close friends to confide with.
- *Safety*: Feel free from immediate danger.
- *Physiological*: Food, water, shelter, sex.

Note: Transegoic means a higher, psychic, or spiritual state of development. The trans is related to transcendence, while the ego is based on Freud's work. We go from preEGOic levels to EGOic levels to transeGOic. The EGO in all three terms are used in the Jungian sense of consciousness as opposed to the unconscious. Ego equates with the personality.

In addition, just as in his earlier model, we may be in a state of flux — we shift between levels. For example there may be peak experiences for temporary self-actualizations and self-transcendence. These are our spiritual or creative moments.

Characteristics of self-actualizing people:

- Have better perceptions of reality and are comfortable with it.
- Accept themselves and their own natures.
- Lack of artificiality.
- They focus on problems outside themselves and are concerned with basic issues and eternal questions.
- They like privacy and tend to be detached.

- Rely on their own development and continued growth.
- Appreciate the basic pleasures of life.
- Have a deep feeling of kinship with others.
- Are deeply democratic and are not really aware of differences.
- Have strong ethical and moral standards.
- Are original, inventive, less constricted and fresher than others

Going Beyond Maslow

While the research of Maslow's theory has undergone limited empirical scrutiny, it still remains quite popular due to its simplicity and being the start of the movement away from a totally behaviourist/reductionistic/mechanistic approach to a more humanistic one.

In addition, a lot of concerns are directed at his methodology in that he picked a small number of people that he declared self-actualizing and came to the cease about self-actualization. However, he understood this and thought of his work as simply a method of pointing the way, rather than being the final say. In addition, he hoped that others would take up the cause and complete what he had begun.

Which brings us to the next models. Other researchers have taken up his cause and furthered refined them, mostly in the area of organizations and work. Herzberg, Alderfer, and McGregor's research are all closely tied to Maslow's theory.

HERZBERG'S HYGIENE AND MOTIVATIONAL FACTORS

Frederick Herzberg was considered one of the most influential management consultants and professors of the modern postwar era. Herzberg was probably best known for his challenging thinking on work and motivation. He was considered both an icon and legend among visionaries such as Abraham Maslow, Peter Drucker, and Douglas MacGregor.

Herzberg is best known for his list of factors that are based on Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs, except his version is more closely related to the working environment:

Herzberg's Hygiene and Motivational Factors

Hygiene or Dissatisfiers:

- Working conditions
- Policies and administrative practices
- Salary and Benefits
- Supervision
- Status
- Job security
- Co-workers
- Personal life

Motivators or Satisfiers:

- Recognition
- Achievement
- Advancement
- Growth
- Responsibility
- Job challenge

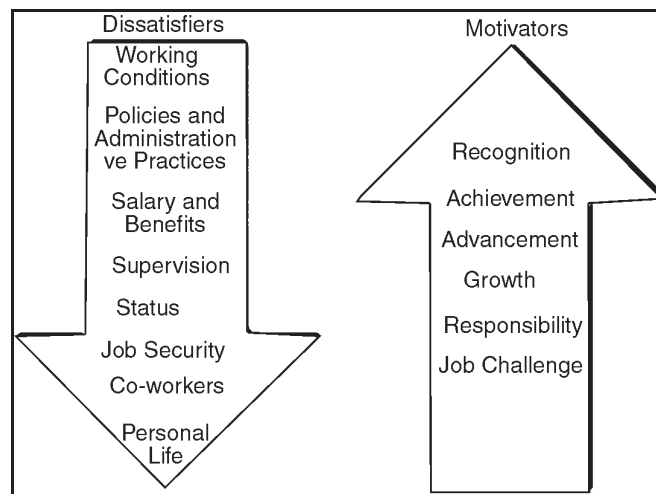


Fig. Herzberg's Hygiene and Motivational Factors

Hygiene or dissatisfiers factors must be present in the job before motivators can be used to stimulate a person. That is, you cannot use motivators until all the hygiene factors are met. Herzberg's needs are specifically job related and reflect some of the distinct things that people want from their work as opposed to Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs which reflect all the needs in a person's life.

Building on this model, Herzberg coined the term job enrichment — the process of redesigning work in order to build in motivators by increasing both the number of tasks that an employee performs and the control over those tasks. It is associated with the design of jobs and is an extension of job enlargement.

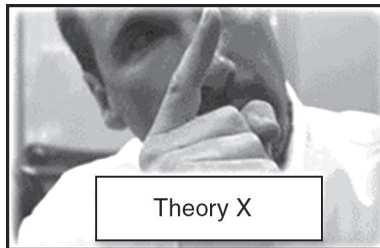
MCGREGOR'S THEORY X AND THEORY Y

Douglas McGregor developed a philosophical view of humankind with his Theory X and Theory Y — two opposing perceptions about how people view human behaviour at work and organizational life. McGregor felt that organizations and the managers within them followed either one or the other approach:

Theory X:

- People have an inherent dislike for work and will avoid it whenever possible.
- People must be coerced, controlled, directed, or threatened with punishment in order to get them to achieve the organizational objectives.

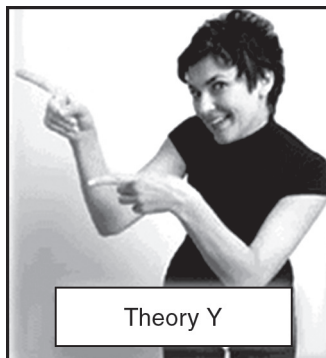
- People prefer to be directed, do not want responsibility, and have little or no ambition.
- People seek security all else.



In an organization with Theory X assumptions, management's role is to coerce and control employees.

Theory Y:

- Work is as natural as play and rest.
- People will exercise self-direction if they are committed to the objectives.
- Commitment to objectives is a function of the rewards associated with their achievement.
- People learn to accept and seek responsibility.
- Creativity, ingenuity, and imagination are widely distributed among the population. People are capable of using these abilities to solve an organizational problem.
- People have potential.



In an organization with Theory Y assumptions, management's role is to develop the potential in employees and help them to release that potential towards common goals.

Theory X is the view that traditional management has taken towards the workforce. Most organizations are now taking the enlightened view of theory Y. A boss can be viewed as taking the theory X approach, while a leader takes the theory Y approach.

Notice that Maslow, Herzberg, and McGregor's theories all tie together:

- Herzberg's theory is a micro version of Maslow's theory that is focused in the work environment.
- McGregor's Theory X is based on workers caught in the lower levels of

Maslow's theory due to bad management practices, while his Theory Y is for workers who have gone level 3 with the help of management.

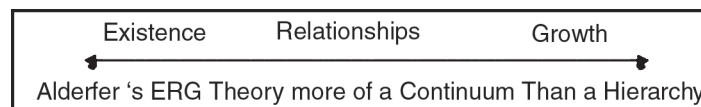
- McGregor's Theory X is also based on workers caught in Herzberg's Hygiene Dissatisfiers, while Theory Y is based on workers who are in the Motivators or Satisfiers section.

ALDERFER'S EXISTENCE/RELATEDNESS/GROWTH

Clayton Alderfer's Existence/Relatedness/Growth Theory of Needs postulates that there are three groups of needs:

1. *Existence*: This group of needs is concerned with providing the basic requirements for material existence, such as physiological and safety needs. This need is satisfied by money earned in a job so that one may buy food, shelter, clothing, etc.
2. *Relationships*: This group of needs centres upon the desire to establish and maintain interpersonal relationships. Since people normally spend approximately half of their waking hours on the job, this need is normally satisfied to some degree by their coworkers.
3. *Growth*: These needs are met by personal development. A person's job, career, or profession provides significant satisfaction of growth needs.

Alderfer's ERG theory states that more than one need may be influential at the same time. If the gratification of a higher-level need is frustrated, the desire to satisfy a lower-level need will increase. He identifies this phenomenon as the "frustration and shy aggression dimension." Its relevance on the job is that even when the upper-level needs are frustrated, the job still provides for the basic physiological needs upon which one would then be focused. If, at that point, something happens to threaten the job, the person's basic needs are significantly threatened. If there are no factors present to relieve the pressure, the person may become desperate and panicky. Notice that Alderfer's ERG theory is built upon Maslow's, however it does differ. First he collapses it from five needs to three. And unlike Maslow, he did not see these needs as being a hierarchy in which one climbs up, but rather being more of a continuum:



While there has not been a lot of research on Alderfer's theory, most contemporary theories and related studies tend to give it stronger support than Maslow's theory.

LEADERSHIP AND DIRECTION

PLANNING WITH THE SHEWHART CYCLE

While the letters and cycle look easy, it actually takes a lot of work by all the team members to complete the cycle correctly. One of Shewhart's students, W. Edwards

Deming later used it, thus the PDCA cycle is often known as the Deming Wheel Smith, Hawkins, 2004). Deming also used a modified version — PDSA.

A dream is just a dream. A goal is a dream with a plan and a deadline. And that goal will remain a dream unless you create and execute a plan of action to accomplish it. Every goal that gets accomplished has a good plan behind of it. — Harvey Mackay

Plan

Good plans start with a brainstorming session that includes all the people involved with the project. This allows everyone to be part of the solution, in addition to gathering the best ideas.

Two key questions must be asked:

1. What are all the ingredients necessary for its successful execution?
2. What are all the possible forces or events that could hinder or destroy it?

As much as possible, get all the answers to these questions. Listen carefully to the judgment of your team. Then plan the positive forces and events, and then take action to prevent any obstructions that might hinder the project.

A detailed plan normally includes the who, what, when, where, how, and why:

- Who does it involve and who will do what?
- What are we going to do? What will happen if we do not do it?
- When does it start and end?
- Where will it take place?
- How will it take place?
- Why must we do it?

Also, the plan must be organized. Organizing is the process of creating and maintaining the conditions for effectively executing plans. It involves systematically defining and arranging each task with respect to the achievement of the objective.

It includes three major steps:

1. Determine all tasks.
2. Set up a structure to accomplish all tasks.
3. Allocate resources.

All essential information must be brought out. It is also important to consider timing — when each task must be started and completed.

A helpful approach is to use “backward planning.” Look at each goal and decide what must be done to reach it. In this way you plan from the moment of the project ending point and then work your way back to the present in order to determine what must be done.

Backward planning simply means looking at the big picture first, and then planning all tasks, conditions, and details in a logical sequence to make the big picture happen. Include all the details of support, time schedule, equipment, coordination, and required checks. Your team must think of every possible situation that will help or hinder the project. Once the process of mentally building the project has begun, the activities will

come easily to mind. Now, organize all these details into categories, such as needs, supplies, support, equipment, coordination, major tasks, etc. List all the details under the categories. Create a to-do list for each category. This list will become the checklist to ensure everything is progressing as planned.

Do

Your team cannot do everything at once; some tasks are more important than others while others have to be accomplished before another task can start.

Set priorities for each checkpoint and assign someone to perform each task on the list. Develop a system for checking each other and ensuring that each task is accomplished on time.

Plan for obtaining all the required resources and allocate them out. Not having the required resources can stop a project dead in its tracks. For this reason you must closely track and monitor costly or hard to get resources.

Trial the plan through a prototype. This allows you to actually check the plan on a small scale.

Check

Throughout the project's execution there are three things that you must be involved in: standards, performance, and adjustments. The standard means, "is this project being completed or accomplished as planned? Are all the check marks being completed as stated in the planning process? The standard, which is set, must mean the same to you and your people. Performance is measured by completing the tasks and objectives correctly. While the standard relates to the project, performance relates to the people working on the project. If performance does not meet standards, then adjustments can be made in two ways — improve the performance or lower the standards. Most of the time, improving the performance is the appropriate choice. However, a leader may face a situation where the standard is unrealistic, which means it may be lowered. This is usually caused by poor estimates or the inability to obtain the proper resources.

Act

Now you are ready to execute the plan. If your plans are solid, things will go smoothly. If your plans are faulty, then you might have a very long and hard project ahead of you!

PROBLEM SOLVING

There are seven basics steps to problem solving:

1. *Identify the problem:* You cannot solve something if you do not know what the problem is. Ensure you have identified the real problem, not an effect of another problem. One method is the "five why's." You ask why five times. By the time you get to the fifth why, you should have found the ultimate cause of the problem.

2. *Gather information:* Investigate the problem and uncover any other hidden effects that the problem may have caused.
3. *Develop courses of action:* Notice that courses is plural. For every problem there are usually several possible courses of action. Identify as many as you can. There are always at least two: fix it or don't fix it. Brainstorming with your team will normally generate the most and best courses of action.
4. *Analyse and compare courses of action:* Rank the courses of action as to their effectiveness. Some actions may fix other problems, while others may cause new problems.
5. *Make a decision:* Select the best course of action to take.
6. *Make a plan:* Use the planning tool covered in the first part of the section.
7. *Implement the plan:* Take the steps to put the plan into action.

THE PROBLEM WITH PROBLEM SOLVING TECHNIQUES

Problem solving is simply a method of fighting fires; it does not move the organization forward and it does not create iPods, Google, paper drinking cups made of recycled paper, or Halo 2s.

Of course during the actual building of these great products, problem solving is indeed required. The shortest problem solving technique is probably OODA: Observation, Orientation, Decision, Action; while the longest one is probably the one stated.

Yet how many “problems” really require that you follow any of these methods? Some problems you simply see and then solve — they do not require elaborate methodologies.

On the other hand, these problem solving methodologies are sometimes too simple for complicated problems. The ability to solve many problems is based on a person's skill set rather than it is on a heuristic procedure.

That is, the real key to solving novel problems is often a deeper conceptual understanding of the target domain.

For example, neither of the two problem solving techniques will help non-engineers solve an engineering problem when it comes to building a bridge as they do not have the basic concepts.

And in turn, many problem solving techniques will not help an expert engineer when it comes to solving a bridge building problem as the models are too simplistic in nature to be of much help.

In addition, these problem solving techniques can often be misleading to novices. Novices think that by following the heuristic, they will arrive at the correct solution; however, difficult problems often require a trial and error method.

Yet novices will stubbornly stick to a failing solution, whereas experts with deep conceptual understandings will quickly see that a solution is not working and respond

with a completely new procedure. Their problem solving has everything to do with adaptability and deep knowledge structures and nothing to do with the simple problem solving methods.

Thus, when using any problem solving technique, realise that they all have limitations and that the two most useful tools are brainstorming and learning all you can about the problem at hand in order to gain a deeper conceptual understanding.

3

Executive Development and Employment in Office Management

Manager effectiveness has an enormous impact on a firm's success. Therefore, companies must provide instruction for managers and high-potential management candidates in order to help them perform current and future jobs with the utmost proficiency. Management development has long been an important component of corporate strategic planning. In fact, many companies consider the identification and development of next-generation managers to be their top human resource challenge.

Management development is important for new managers because these individuals really need instruction on how to perform their new supervisory jobs. Even so, companies often allow employees to make the transition to management with little or no training, leaving them with feelings of frustration, inadequacy, and dismay. More experienced managers also benefit from management development. A majority of first-line managers have their sights set on higher-level management jobs. Given these ambitions, companies need to provide lower-level and mid-level managers with formal development programs in order to help them climb the corporate ladder.

Most training experts criticize lectures because they are passive learning devices, focusing on one-way communication to learners who do not have the opportunity to clarify material. Lectures generally fail to gain and maintain learner attention unless they are given by someone who is able to make the material meaningful and promote questions and discussions. Lectures are most appropriate for situations where simple knowledge acquisition is the goal (e.g., describing company history during a new employee orientation session). However, lectures are not well suited to serve as the

sole training method for teaching management skills, because the format does not provide trainees with feedback or the opportunity for practice. As the name suggests, the case method requires management trainees to analyse cases or scenarios depicting realistic job situations. Cases often are structured like a play that opens in the middle of a story and uses flashbacks to describe the action that led up to the opening scene, where an employee has just made a key decision. The rest of the case lays out the documentation and data available to the decision maker at the time of the decision. Questions are posed at the end of the case that ask the trainees to analyse the situation and recommend a solution. For instance, they may be asked to state the nature of the problem, identify the events that led to the problem, and indicate what the individual should do to resolve the problem. The case method rests on the assumption that people are most likely to retain and use what they learn if they reach an understanding through “guided discovery.” Trainers act as guides or facilitators. Cases typically do not have right or wrong answers. Therefore, the aim of the method is not to teach trainees the “right” answer, but rather to teach them how to identify potential problems and recommend realistic actions.

Critics of this method balk at the lack of direction trainees receive when analyzing a case. What if they arrive at a poor decision? Moreover, trainees do not get the opportunity to practice their skills. For instance, after analyzing a case involving a subordinate who has repeatedly arrived at work late, the trainees may conclude that the manager should have said something sooner and must now provide counsel. However, the case method does not afford trainees the opportunity to practice their counselling skills.

As an instructional technique, role-playing presents a hypothetical problem involving human interaction. Trainees spontaneously act out that interaction face-to-face. Participants are then given feedback by the trainer and the rest of the group on their performance so they may gain insight regarding the impact of their behaviour on others. The issues addressed during feedback typically revolve around these types of questions:

- What was correct about the participant’s behaviour?
- What was incorrect about the participant’s behaviour?
- How did the participant’s behaviour make the other participants feel?
- How could the trainee have handled the situation more effectively?

Role-playing may be used to develop skill in any area that involves human interaction. The method is most often used for teaching human relations skills and sales techniques. Role-playing provides management trainees with an opportunity to practice the skill being taught. It thus goes beyond the case method, which merely requires the trainee to make a decision regarding how to handle a situation. These two methods are often used in conjunction with one another. That is, after analyzing a case and recommending a solution, trainees are asked to act out the solution in the form of a role-play. Critics of the role-playing method point out that role-players are often given little guidance beforehand on how to handle transactions. This may cause them to make mistakes, resulting in embarrassment and a loss of self-confidence. When their mistake-ridden role-play is finished, they sit, never getting the opportunity to do it correctly.

Behaviour Modelling

Behaviour modelling is based on the idea that workers learn best when they see how a task should be performed and then practice the task with feedback until they are competent. This method is similar to role-playing in that the trainees act out situations playing certain roles. However, the methods differ in two important ways. First, behaviour modelling teaches trainees a preferred way to perform a task. Second, the interactions occurring during behaviour modelling are practice sessions, not role plays. The trainees practice only the right way. If they make a mistake, the trainer immediately corrects them and asks them to repeat the step correctly.

A behaviour modelling program typically consists of the following steps:

1. Present an overview of the material. This usually consists of a brief lecture that describes training objectives and the importance of the skill to be learned.
2. Describe the procedural steps. The trainee learns the one best way (or at least an effective way) to handle a situation. Case and role-playing methods, on the other hand, stress the variety of effective ways to handle a situation and do not emphasize any one particular approach.
3. Model or demonstrate the procedural steps. The trainee is shown a “model” of how the task is to be performed correctly. The model usually is presented in the form of a video-tape or live demonstration.
4. Allow guided practice. Trainees then practice the modelled behaviours. As previously stated, these sessions are similar to role-plays, except that trainees are given feedback by the instructor (or classmates) during the skill practice session, rather than after. This procedure forces trainees to correct mistakes as soon as they are made, assuring them an opportunity to practice the correct way of performing the task. Practice sessions start with simple problems, similar to those depicted in the model. Later practice sessions are made more realistic by adding complexity to the situation.
5. Provide on-the-job reinforcement. Participants’ managers often go through identical training programs to ensure that they will understand what their employees are learning and, hence, support these new behaviours back on the job.

Behaviour modelling has become very popular. Research examining its effectiveness has been quite favourable. Behaviour modelling works because it successfully incorporates each of the aforementioned learning principles: it captures and maintains trainees’ attention and provides ample opportunity for practice and feedback.

EMPLOYEE MOTIVATION

Motivation is the activation or energization of goal-orientated behaviour. Motivation is said to be intrinsic or extrinsic. The term is generally used for humans but, theoretically, it can also be used to describe the causes for animal behaviour as well.

This substance refers to human motivation. Various theories, motivation may be rooted in the basic need to minimize physical pain and maximize pleasure, or it may include specific needs such as eating and resting, or a desired object, hobby, goal, state of being, ideal, or it may be attributed to less-apparent reasons such as altruism, selfishness, morality, or avoiding mortality. Conceptually, motivation should not be confused with either volition or optimism. Motivation is related to, but distinct from, emotion.

MOTIVATION CONCEPTS

Intrinsic and Extrinsic Motivation

Intrinsic motivation has been studied by social and educational psychologists since the early 1970s. Research has found that it is usually associated with high educational achievement and enjoyment by students. Intrinsic motivation has been explained by Fritz Heider's attribution theory, Bandura's work on self-efficacy, and Ryan and Deci's cognitive evaluation theory.

Students are likely to be intrinsically motivated if they:

- Attribute their educational results to internal factors that they can control,
- Believe they can be effective agents in reaching desired goals,
- Are interested in mastering a topic, rather than just rote-learning to achieve good grades.

Extrinsic motivation comes from outside of the performer. Money is the most obvious example, but coercion and threat of punishment are also common extrinsic motivations.

While competing, the crowd may cheer on the performer, which may motivate him or her to do well. Trophies are also extrinsic incentives. Competition is in general extrinsic because it encourages the performer to win and beat others, not to enjoy the intrinsic rewards of the activity.

Social psychological research has indicated that extrinsic rewards can lead to overjustification and a subsequent reduction in intrinsic motivation. In one study demonstrating this effect, children who expected to be rewarded with a ribbon and a gold star for drawing pictures spent less time playing with the drawing materials in subsequent observations than children who were assigned to an unexpected reward condition and to children who received no extrinsic reward.

Self-Control

The self-control of motivation is increasingly understood as a subset of emotional intelligence; a person may be highly intelligent according to a more conservative definition, yet unmotivated to dedicate this intelligence to certain tasks.

Yale School of Management professor Victor Vroom's "expectancy theory" provides an account of when people will decide whether to exert self control to pursue a particular goal.

Drives and desires can be described as a deficiency or need that activates behaviour that is aimed at a goal or an incentive. These are thought to originate within the individual and may not require external stimuli to encourage the behaviour. Basic drives could be sparked by deficiencies such as hunger, which motivates a person to seek food; whereas more subtle drives might be the desire for praise and approval, which motivates a person to behave in a manner pleasing to others.

By contrast, the role of extrinsic rewards and stimuli can be seen in the example of training animals by giving them treats when they perform a trick correctly. The treat motivates the animals to perform the trick consistently, even later when the treat is removed from the process.

MOTIVATIONAL THEORIES

The Incentive Theory of Motivation

A reward, tangible or intangible, is presented after the occurrence of an action with the intent to cause the behaviour to occur again. This is done by associating positive meaning to the behaviour. Studies show that if the person receives the reward immediately, the effect would be greater, and decreases as duration lengthens.

Repetitive action-reward combination can cause the action to become habit. Motivation comes from two sources: oneself, and other people. These two sources are called intrinsic motivation and extrinsic motivation, respectively.

Applying proper motivational techniques can be much harder than it seems. Steven Kerr notes that when creating a reward system, it can be easy to reward A, while hoping for B, and in the process, reap harmful effects that can jeopardize your goals.

A reinforcer is different from reward, in that reinforcement is intended to create a measured increase in the rate of a desirable behaviour following the addition of something to the environment.

Drive-Reduction Theories

There are a number of drive theories. The Drive Reduction Theory grows out of the concept that we have certain biological drives, such as hunger. As time passes the strength of the drive increases if it is not satisfied. Upon satisfying a drive the drive's strength is reduced. The theory is based on diverse ideas from the theories of Freud to the ideas of feedback control systems, such as a thermostat.

Drive theory has some intuitive or folk validity. For instance when preparing food, the drive model appears to be compatible with sensations of rising hunger as the food is prepared, and, after the food has been consumed, a decrease in subjective hunger.

There are several problems, however, that leave the validity of drive reduction open for debate. The first problem is that it does not explain how secondary reinforcers reduce drive. For example, money satisfies no biological or psychological needs, but a pay check appears to reduce drive through second-order conditioning.

Secondly, a drive, such as hunger, is viewed as having a “desire” to eat, making the drive a homuncular being - a feature criticized as simply moving the fundamental problem behind this “small man” and his desires.

In addition, it is clear that drive reduction theory cannot be a complete theory of behaviour, or a hungry human could not prepare a meal without eating the food before he finished cooking it. The ability of drive theory to cope with all kinds of behaviour, from not satisfying a drive or adding additional drives for “tasty” food, which combine with drives for “food” in order to explain cooking render it hard to test.

Cognitive Dissonance Theory

Suggested by Leon Festinger, this occurs when an individual experiences some degree of discomfort resulting from an incompatibility between two cognitions. For example, a consumer may seek to reassure himself regarding a purchase, feeling, in retrospect, that another decision may have been preferable.

Another example of cognitive dissonance is when a belief and a behaviour are in conflict. A person may wish to be healthy, believes smoking is bad for one’s health, and yet continues to smoke.

Key Experiences and Motivation

Gad Yair from The Hebrew University has developed a line of research on Key Experiences, especially relating to educational events. His approach to motivation follows his longstanding interest in outstanding motivating events - either short term and contextual or long-term. He first published a series of papers using the Experience Sampling Method.

This has led to his major study of key experiences, motivation and long-term outcomes. Key experiences in higher education and on the role of those experiences in educational turning points are readily available over the net.

The concept of key educational experiences refers to singular, short and intense educational encounters that proved to have strong and long-lasting effects on adults. These encounters are at times associated with a specific person who led them [e.g. teacher, parent, youth leader], at others with the structure of the episode itself [e.g. progress towards a peak event which is then associated with insight and hindsight].

Indeed, many respondents speak of their key educational experiences in terms of sight: Exceptional activities cause prior blinders to be suddenly lifted off, producing clear vision and insight, notably about students’ own selves.

THEORIES

Need Hierarchy Theory

Abraham Maslow’s theory is one of the most widely discussed theories of motivation.

The theory can be summarized as follows:

- Human beings have wants and desires which influence their behaviour. Only unsatisfied needs influence behaviour, satisfied needs do not.
- Since needs are many, they are arranged in order of importance, from the basic to the complex.
- The person advances to the next level of needs only after the lower level need is at least minimally satisfied.
- The further the progress up the hierarchy, the more individuality, humanness and psychological health a person will show.

The needs, listed from basic to most complex are as follows:

- Physiology
- Safety/Security/Shelter/Health
- Belongingness/Love/Friendship
- Self-esteem/Recognition/Achievement
- Self actualization

Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory

Frederick Herzberg's two-factor theory, AKA intrinsic/extrinsic motivation, concludes that certain factors in the workplace result in job satisfaction, but if absent, they don't lead to dissatisfaction but no satisfaction.

The factors that motivate people can change over their lifetime, but "respect for me as a person" is one of the top motivating factors at any stage of life.

He distinguished between:

- Motivators; which give positive satisfaction, and
- Hygiene factors; that do not motivate if present, but, if absent, result in demotivation.

The name Hygiene factors is used because, like hygiene, the presence will not make you healthier, but absence can cause health deterioration.

The theory is sometimes called the "Motivator-Hygiene Theory" and/or "The Dual Structure Theory." Herzberg's theory has found application in such occupational fields as information systems and in studies of user satisfaction.

Alderfer's ERG theory

Alderfer, expanding on Maslow's hierarchy of needs, created the ERG theory. Physiological and safety, The lower order needs, are placed in the existence category, while love and self esteem needs are placed in the relatedness category. The growth category contains our self-actualization and self-esteem needs.

Self-determination Theory

Self-determination theory, developed by Edward Deci and Richard Ryan, focuses on the importance of intrinsic motivation in driving human behaviour. Like Maslow's

hierarchical theory and others that built on it, SDT posits a natural tendency towards growth and development. Unlike these other theories, however, SDT does not include any sort of “autopilot” for achievement, but instead requires active encouragement from the environment. The primary factors that encourage motivation and development are autonomy, competence feedback, and relatedness.

Broad Theories

The latest approach in Achievement Motivation is an integrative perspective as lined out in the “Onion-Ring-Model of Achievement Motivation” by Heinz Schuler, George C. Thornton III, Andreas Frintrup and Rose Mueller-Hanson. It is based on the premise that performance motivation results from the way broad components of personality are directed towards performance.

As a result, it includes a range of dimensions that are relevant to success at work but which are not conventionally regarded as being part of performance motivation. Especially it integrates formerly separated approaches as Need for Achievement with e.g. social motives like Dominance.

The Achievement Motivation Inventory is based on this theory and assesses three factors relevant to vocational and professional success.

Goal-setting Theory

Goal-setting theory is based on the notion that individuals sometimes have a drive to reach a clearly defined end state. Often, this end state is a reward in itself. A goal's efficiency is affected by three features: proximity, difficulty and specificity.

An ideal goal should present a situation where the time between the initiation of behaviour and the end state is close. This explains why some children are more motivated to learn how to ride a bike than mastering algebra. A goal should be moderate, not too hard or too easy to complete. In both cases, most people are not optimally motivated, as many want a challenge.

At the same time people want to feel that there is a substantial probability that they will succeed. Specificity concerns the description of the goal in their class.

The goal should be objectively defined and intelligible for the individual. A classic example of a poorly specified goal is to get the highest possible grade. Most children have no idea how much effort they need to reach that goal.

Models of Behaviour Change

Social-cognitive models of behaviour change include the constructs of motivation and volition. Motivation is seen as a process that leads to the forming of behavioural intentions. Volition is seen as a process that leads from intention to actual behaviour. In other words, motivation and volition refer to goal setting and goal pursuit, respectively. Both processes require self-regulatory efforts. Several self-regulatory constructs are needed to operate in orchestration to attain goals. An example of such a motivational

and volitional construct is perceived self-efficacy. Self-efficacy is supposed to facilitate the forming of behavioural intentions, the development of action plans, and the initiation of action. It can support the translation of intentions into action.

Unconscious Motivation

Some psychologists believe that a significant portion of human behaviour is energized and directed by unconscious motives. Maslow, “Psychoanalysis has often demonstrated that the relationship between a conscious desire and the ultimate unconscious aim that underlies it need not be at all direct.”

In other words, stated motives do not always match those inferred by skilled observers. For example, it is possible that a person can be accident-prone because he has an unconscious desire to hurt himself and not because he is careless or ignorant of the safety rules. Similarly, some overweight people are not hungry at all for food but for fighting and kissing. Eating is merely a defensive reaction to lack of attention. Some workers damage more equipment than others do because they harbor unconscious feelings of aggression towards authority figures.

Psychotherapists point out that some behaviour is so automatic that the reasons for it are not available in the individual’s conscious mind. Compulsive cigarette smoking is an example. Sometimes maintaining self-esteem is so important and the motive for an activity is so threatening that it is simply not recognized and, in fact, may be disguised or repressed. Rationalization, or “explaining away”, is one such disguise, or defence mechanism, as it is called. Another is projecting or attributing one’s own faults to others.

“I feel I am to blame”, becomes “It is her fault; she is selfish”. Repression of powerful but socially unacceptable motives may result in outward behaviour that is the opposite of the repressed tendencies. An example of this would be the employee who hates his boss but overworks himself on the job to show that he holds him in high regard.

Unconscious motives add to the hazards of interpreting human behaviour and, to the extent that they are present, complicate the life of the administrator. On the other hand, knowledge that unconscious motives exist can lead to a more careful assessment of behavioural problems. Although few contemporary psychologists deny the existence of unconscious factors, many do believe that these are activated only in times of anxiety and stress, and that in the ordinary course of events, human behaviour — from the subject’s point of view — is rationally purposeful.

Intrinsic Motivation and The 16 Basic Desires Theory

Starting from studies involving more than 6,000 people, Professor Steven Reiss has proposed a theory that find 16 basic desires that guide nearly all human behaviour.

The desires are:

- Acceptance, the need for approval
- Curiosity, the need to learn

- Eating, the need for food
- Family, the need to raise children
- Honour, the need to be loyal to the traditional values of one's clan/ethnic group
- Idealism, the need for social justice
- Independence, the need for individuality
- Order, the need for organized, stable, predictable environments
- Physical Activity, the need for exercise
- Power, the need for influence of will
- Romance, the need for sex
- Saving, the need to collect
- Social Contact, the need for friends
- Status, the need for social standing/importance
- Tranquility, the need to be safe
- Vengeance, the need to strike back/to win

In this model, people differ in these basic desires. These basic desires represent intrinsic desires that directly motivate a person's behaviour, and not aimed at indirectly satisfying other desires.

People may also be motivated by non-basic desires, but in this case this does not relate to deep motivation, or only as a means to achieve other basic desires.

CONTROLLING MOTIVATION

The control of motivation is only understood to a limited extent. There are many different approaches of motivation training, but many of these are considered pseudoscientific by critics. To understand how to control motivation it is first necessary to understand why many people lack motivation.

Employee Motivation

Workers in any organization need something to keep them working. Most times the salary of the employee is enough to keep him or her working for an organization. However, sometimes just working for salary is not enough for employees to stay at an organization. An employee must be motivated to work for a company or organization. If no motivation is present in an employee, then that employee's quality of work or all work in general will deteriorate.

Keeping an employee working at full potential is the ultimate goal of employee motivation. There are many methods to help keep employees motivated. Some traditional ways of motivating workers are placing them in competition with each other.

Drugs

Some authors, especially in the transhumanist movement, have suggested the use of "smart drugs", also known as nootropics, as "motivation-enhancers". The effects of

many of these drugs on the brain are emphatically not well understood, and their legal status often makes open experimentation difficult.

APPLICATIONS

Education

Motivation is of particular interest to educational psychologists because of the crucial role it plays in student learning. However, the specific kind of motivation that is studied in the specialized setting of education differs qualitatively from the more general forms of motivation studied by psychologists in other fields.

Motivation in education can have several effects on how students learn and how they behave towards subject matter.

It can:

- Direct behaviour towards particular goals
- Lead to increased effort and energy
- Increase initiation of, and persistence in, activities
- Enhance cognitive processing
- Determine what consequences are reinforcing
- Lead to improved performance.

Because students are not always internally motivated, they sometimes need situated motivation, which is found in environmental conditions that the teacher creates.

There are two kinds of motivation:

1. Intrinsic motivation occurs when people are internally motivated to do something because it either brings them pleasure, they think it is important, or they feel that what they are learning is significant.
2. Extrinsic motivation comes into play when a student is compelled to do something or animation a certain way because of factors external to him or her.

Note also that there is already questioning and expansion about this dichotomy on motivation, e.g., Self-Determination Theory. Motivation has been found to be a pivotal area in treating Autism Spectrum Disorders, as in Pivotal Response Therapy. Motivation is also an important element in the concept of Andragogy.

Sudbury Model Schools' Approach to Motivation

Sudbury Model schools adduce that the cure to the problem of procrastination, of learning in general, and particularly of scientific illiteracy is to remove once and for all what they call the underlying disease: compulsion in schools. They contend that human nature in a free society recoils from every attempt to force it into a mold; that the more requirements we pile onto children at school, the surer we are to drive them away from the material we are trying to force down their throats; that after all the drive and motivation of infants to master the world around them is legendary. They assert that

schools must keep that drive alive by doing what some of them do: nurturing it on the freedom it needs to thrive. Sudbury Model schools do not perform and do not offer evaluations, assessments, transcripts, or recommendations, asserting that they do not rate people, and that school is not a judge; comparing students to each other, or to some standard that has been set is for them a violation of the student's right to privacy and to self-determination.

Students decide for themselves how to measure their progress as self-starting learners as a process of self-evaluation: real life-long learning and the proper educational evaluation for the 21st Century, they adduce. Sudbury Model schools, this policy does not cause harm to their students as they move on to life outside the school. However, they admit it makes the process more difficult, but that such hardship is part of the students learning to make their own way, set their own standards and meet their own goals.

The no-grading and no-rating policy helps to create an atmosphere free of competition among students or battles for adult approval, and encourages a positive co-operative environment amongst the student body.

Business

At lower levels of Maslow's hierarchy of needs, such as physiological needs, money is a motivator, however it tends to have a motivating effect on staff that lasts only for a short period. At higher levels of the hierarchy, praise, respect, recognition, empowerment and a sense of belonging are far more powerful motivators than money, as both Abraham Maslow's theory of motivation and Douglas McGregor's theory X and theory Y demonstrate.

Maslow has money at the lowest level of the hierarchy and shows other needs are better motivators to staff. McGregor places money in his Theory X category and feels it is a poor motivator.

Praise and recognition are placed in the Theory Y category and are considered stronger motivators than money:

- Motivated employees always look for better ways to do a job.
- Motivated employees are more quality oriented.
- Motivated workers are more productive.

The average workplace is about midway between the extremes of high threat and high opportunity. Motivation by threat is a dead-end strategy, and naturally staff are more attracted to the opportunity side of the motivation curve than the threat side.

Motivation is a powerful tool in the work environment that can lead to employees working at their most efficient levels of production.

Nonetheless, Steinmertz also discusses three common character types of subordinates: ascendant, indifferent, and ambivalent whom all react and interact uniquely, and must be treated, managed, and motivated accordingly. An effective leader must understand how to manage all characters, and more importantly the manager must utilize avenues

that allow room for employees to work, grow, and find answers independently. The assumptions of Maslow and Herzberg were challenged by a classic study at Vauxhall Motors' UK manufacturing plant. This introduced the concept of orientation to work and distinguished three main orientations: instrumental, bureaucratic and solidaristic. Other theories which expanded and extended those of Maslow and Herzberg included Kurt Lewin's Force Field Theory, Edwin Locke's Goal Theory and Victor Vroom's Expectancy theory. These tend to stress cultural differences and the fact that individuals tend to be motivated by different factors at different times.

The system of scientific management developed by Frederick Winslow Taylor, a worker's motivation is solely determined by pay, and therefore management need not consider psychological or social aspects of work. In essence, scientific management bases human motivation wholly on extrinsic rewards and discards the idea of intrinsic rewards. In contrast, David McClelland believed that workers could not be motivated by the mere need for money — in fact, extrinsic motivation could extinguish intrinsic motivation such as achievement motivation, though money could be used as an indicator of success for various motives, e.g., keeping score. In keeping with this view, his consulting firm, McBer and Company, had as its first motto "To make everyone productive, happy, and free." For McClelland, satisfaction lay in aligning a person's life with their fundamental motivations. Elton Mayo found out that the social contacts a worker has at the workplace are very important and that boredom and repetitiveness of tasks lead to reduced motivation. Mayo believed that workers could be motivated by acknowledging their social needs and making them feel important. As a result, employees were given freedom to make decisions on the job and greater attention was paid to informal work groups. Mayo named the model the Hawthorne effect. His model has been judged as placing undue reliance on social contacts at work situations for motivating employees.

In *Essentials of Organizational Behaviour*, Robbins and Judge examine recognition programmes as motivators, and identify five principles that contribute to the success of an employee incentive programme:

- Recognition of employees' individual differences, and clear identification of behaviour deemed worthy of recognition
- Allowing employees to participate
- Linking rewards to performance
- Rewarding of nominators
- Visibility of the recognition process

TEN TIPS FOR QUESTIONNAIRES ON EMPLOYEE MOTIVATION

1. What is the 'primary aim' of your company?

Your employees may be more motivated if they understand the primary aim of your business. Ask questions to establish how clear they are about your company's principles, priorities and mission.

2. What obstacles stop employees performing to best effect?
Questionnaires on employee motivation should include questions about what employees are tolerating in their work and home lives. The company can eliminate practices that zap motivation.
3. What really motivates your staff?
It is often assumed that all people are motivated by the same things. Actually we are motivated by a whole range of factors. Include questions to elicit what really motivates employees, including learning about their values. Are they motivated by financial rewards, status, praise and acknowledgment, competition, job security, public recognition, fear, perfectionism, results...
4. Do employees feel empowered?
Do your employees feel they have job descriptions that give them some autonomy and allow them to find their own solutions or are they given a list of tasks to perform and simply told what to do?
5. Are there any recent changes in the company that might have affected motivation?
If your company has made redundancies, imposed a recruitment freeze or lost a number of key people this will have an effect on motivation. Collect information from employees about their fears, thoughts and concerns relating to these events. Even if they are unfounded, treat them with respect and honesty.
6. What are the patterns of motivation in your company?
Who is most motivated and why? What lessons can you learn from patches of high and low motivation in your company?
7. Are employee goals and company goals aligned?
First, the company needs to establish how it wants individuals to spend their time based on what is most valuable. Secondly this needs to be compared with how individuals actually spend their time. You may find employees are highly motivated but about the “wrong” priorities.
8. How do employees feel about the company?
Do they feel safe, loyal, valued and taken care of? Or do they feel taken advantage of, dispensable and invisible? Ask them what would improve their loyalty and commitment.
9. How involved are employees in company development?
Do they feel listened to and heard? Are they consulted? And, if they are consulted, are their opinions taken seriously? Are there regular opportunities for them to give feedback?
10. Is the company’s internal image consistent with its external one?
Your company may present itself to the world as the ‘caring airline’, ‘the forward thinking technology company’ or the ‘family hotel chain’. Your employees would have been influenced, and their expectations set, to this image when they joined your company. If you do not mirror this image within

your company in the way you treat employees you may notice motivation problems. Find out what the disparity is between the employees image of the company from the outside and from the inside.

TIPS ON STRUCTURE, FORMAT AND STYLE OF EMPLOYEE QUESTIONNAIRES

Use the questionnaire guidelines when creating content and subject matter for your employee motivation and satisfaction questionnaires and surveys. Here are some additional tips about questionnaires and surveys structure, format and style: Create a clear, readable 'inviting' structure. Use 'white-out' boxes for answers, scores, and for check-boxes, which clearly show the parts which need completing. Use a clear 11 or 12 point typeface.

10 point is difficult to read for some people. Avoid italics and fancy graphics - they just make the document more difficult and more time-consuming to read. Look at the writing tips and techniques for other useful pointers in creating good printed communications. Apply the same principles if your survey questionnaire form is online.

Where possible try to use specific questions with multiple-choice answers, rather than general 'open-ended' questions. Specific questions improve clarity and consistency of understanding among respondents, and a multiple-choice format enables the answers to be converted into scores which can be loaded into a spreadsheet and very easily analysed.

General or vague questions on the other hand tend to lead to varying interpretation among respondents; also, by inviting an open-ended answer you will generate lots of narrative-based and subjective opinions, which might be very interesting, but will be very time-consuming to read, and even more time-consuming to analyse, especially if you are surveying a large group of employees.

Here is an example:

- *Open-ended question:* What do you think of the Performance Appraisal System?
- *Multiple-choice question:* Rate the effectiveness of the Performance Appraisal System in providing you with clear and agreed training and development:
Good/Okay/Not Good/Poor

Use four options in multiple-choice questions rather than three or five. Three and five options typically offer a middle 'don't know' or 'average' selection. Using four, with no middle cop-out will ensure that everybody decides one way or the other: satisfactory or not, which is what you need to know.

Mid-way 'average' non-committal answers are not helpful, so avoid giving respondents that option. If you go to the trouble of creating, managing and analysing a huge staff survey surely it's a good idea to produce as much meaningful data as possible. Certain questions are suitable for numerical or percentage scoring by respondents, in which case use such a system. For example: Score-based question: Score the extent to

which you enjoy your work: 1-5 = don't enjoy, 6-10 = enjoy. Check with a sample of respondents that they understand the draft questions in the way you intend, before you print and issue the questionnaire to all six hundred or however many staff. Designing questionnaires and communications in isolation can produce strange results - not just politicians get out of touch - so check you are actually on the same planet, in terms of your aims, language and meaning, as the people whose views you seek.

Make sure you explain to all staff beforehand that you'll be publishing the survey findings, and then afterwards ensure you do so. If your MD/CEO is not fully behind your initiative, then go work for a different company whose MD/CEO properly supports the concept of consulting the folk whose efforts underpin his success. Allow people to complete the survey questionnaires anonymously. If helpful to you and you have a purpose for doing so, you can ask people to identify which department/region/office they belong to, assuming such information is genuinely useful to you and you can handle the analysis. KISS - Keep It Simple Stupid. Break complex questions into digestible parts. Keep the survey to a sensible length - probably 20 minutes to complete it is a sensible limit of most people's tolerance. You can always follow up later in the year with another survey, especially if people enjoy completing it, and they see that the feedback and analysis process is helpful to them as well as the employer.

By all means at the end of the questionnaire invite and allow space for 'any other comments', or better still try to guide respondents towards a particular question.

On which point, wherever it is necessary to ask an open-ended question, use the words 'what' and 'how' rather than 'why', if you want to discover motives and reasons. What and How will focus respondents on the facts objectively, whereas 'why' tends to focus respondents on defending themselves.

MANAGING, OR LEADING?

In this excellent guide substance by motivation expert Blaire Palmer, ten central points of employee motivation are exposed and explained, many with real case study references and examples.

EMPLOYEE MOTIVATION PRINCIPLES - A SHORT CASE STUDY - SOUNDS FAMILIAR?

When Michael started his own consultancy he employed top people; people he'd worked with in the past who had shown commitment, flair and loyalty and who seemed to share his values. But a few months down the line one of his team members started to struggle. Jo was putting in the hours but without enthusiasm. Her confidence was dropping; she was unfocused and not bringing in enough new business.

Michael explained to Jo the seriousness of the situation. Without new business he would lose the company and that would mean her job. He showed her the books to emphasise his point. He again ran through her job description and the procedures she

was expected to follow. He told her that he was sure she was up to the job but he really needed her to bring in the new business or they would all be out on their ear. Jo told Michael that she understood. She was doing her best but she'd try harder.

But a month later nothing had changed. After an initial burst of energy, Jo was back to her old ways. No matter how experienced a leader you are, chances are at times you have struggled to motivate certain individuals. You've tried every trick in the book. You've sat down one-to-one with the individual concerned and explained the situation. You've outlined the big vision again in the hope of inspiring them.

You've given them the bottom line: "Either you pull your finger out or your job is on the line". You've dangled a carrot in front of them: "If you make your targets you'll get a great bonus". And sometimes it works. But not every time. And there have been casualties. Ultimately if someone can't get the job done they have to go.

The granddaddy of motivation theory, Frederick Herzberg, called traditional motivation strategies 'KITA'. He used the analogy of a dog. When the master wants his dog to move he either gives it a nudge from behind, in which case the dog moves because it doesn't have much choice, or he offers it a treat as an inducement, in which case it is not so much motivated by wanting to move as by wanting choc drops! KITA does the job but it's hard work. It means every time you want the dog to move you have to kick it.

Wouldn't it be better if the dog wanted to move by itself?

Transferring this principle back in to the workplace, most motivation strategies are 'push' or 'pull' based. They are about keeping people moving either with a kick from behind or by offering choc drops.

BETTER WAYS TO MOTIVATE EMPLOYEES

Blaire Palmer's experience has enabled her to work with a wide range of individuals and groups from a variety of backgrounds. Some of these people are highly motivated themselves, but struggle to extend this state of mind to the people they manage.

Other people are at the receiving end of KITA motivation strategies that aren't working on them. These people know they 'should' be more engaged with their work. Sometimes they fake it for a few months but it's not sustainable. Blaire identifies some common assumptions about motivation and presents some new paradigms that can help motivate more effectively.

By adding these coaching tools and motivation principles to your capabilities you should find the job of leading those around you, and/or helping others to do the same, more of a joyful and rewarding activity. Instead of spending all your time and energy pushing and cajoling you will be able to focus on leading your team, and enabling them to achieve their full potential - themselves. Ultimately, motivation must come from within each person. No leader is ever the single and continuing source of motivation for

a person. While the leader's encouragement, support, inspiration, and example will at times motivate followers, the leader's greatest role in motivating is to recognise people for who they are, and to help them find their own way forward by making best use of their own strengths and abilities.

In this way, achievement, development, and recognition will all come quite naturally to the person, and it is these things which are the true fuels of personal motivation.

By necessity these case studies initially include some negative references and examples, which I would urge you to see for what they are. How not to do things, and negative references, don't normally represent a great platform for learning and development.

In life it's so important always to try to accentuate the positive - to encourage positive visualisation the negatives for what they are; silly daft old ways that fail, and focus on the the positives in each of these examples. There are very many.

'EVERYONE IS LIKE ME'

One of the most common assumptions we make is that the individuals who work for us are motivated by the same factors as us. Perhaps you are motivated by loyalty to the company, enjoying a challenge, proving yourself to others or making money. One great pitfall is to try to motivate others by focusing on what motivates you.

Marie, a director in her company, was being coached. She was a perfectionist. Every day she pushed herself to succeed and was rewarded with recognition from her peers. But she was unable to get the same standard of work from her team members.

In the first few weeks of her coaching she would say, "If only people realised how important it was to put in 110% and how good it felt to get the acknowledgment, then they would start to feel more motivated".

But it wasn't working. Instead people were starting to become resentful towards Marie's approach. Acknowledgment was a prime motivator for Marie so to help her consider some other options, she was helped to brainstorm what else might motivate people in their work.

Marie's list grew: 'learning new skills', 'accomplishing a goal as part of a team', 'creativity', 'achieving work-life balance', 'financial rewards' and 'the adrenaline rush of working to tight deadlines'. Marie began to see that perhaps her team were indeed motivated - it was simply that the team members were motivated in a different ways to her own.

If the leader can tap into and support the team members' own motivations then the leader begins to help people to realise their full potential.

'NO-ONE IS LIKE ME'

Since the 1980's, research has shown that although we know that we are motivated by meaningful and satisfying work, we assume others are motivated mainly by financial rewards.

Chip Heath, associate professor at Stanford University carried out research that found most people believe that others are motivated by 'extrinsic rewards', such as pay or job security, rather than 'intrinsic motivators', like a desire to learn new skills or to contribute to an organisation.

Numerous surveys show that most people are motivated by intrinsic factors, and in this respect we are mostly all the same.

Despite this, while many leaders recognise that their own motivation is driven by factors that have nothing to do with money, they make the mistake of assuming that their people are somehow different, and that money is central to their motivation.

If leaders assume that their team members only care about their pay packet, or their car, or their monthly bonus, this inevitably produces a faulty and unsustainable motivational approach.

Leaders must recognise that people are different only in so far as the different particular 'intrinsic' factor(s) which motivate each person, but in so far as we are all motivated by 'intrinsic' factors, we are all the same.

'PEOPLE DON'T LISTEN TO ME'

When some people talk, nearly everyone listens: certain politicians, business leaders, entertainers; people we regard as high achievers. You probably know people a little like this too. You may not agree with what they say, but they have a presence, a tone of voice and a confidence that is unmistakable. Fundamentally these people are great sales-people. They can make an unmitigated disaster sound like an unqualified victory. But do you need to be like this to motivate and lead?

Certainly not. Many people make the mistake of thinking that the only people who can lead others to success and achieve true excellence, and are the high-profile, charismatic, 'alpha-male/female' types. This is not true.

James was a relatively successful salesman but he was never at the top of his team's league table. In coaching sessions he would wonder whether he would ever be as good as his more flamboyant and aggressive colleagues. James saw himself as a sensitive person and was concerned that he was too sensitive for the job.

James was encouraged to look at how he could use his sensitivity to make more sales and beat his teammates. He reworked his sales pitch and instead of focusing his approach on the product, he based his initial approach on building rapport and asking questions.

He made no attempt to 'sell'. Instead he listened to the challenges facing the people he called and asked them what kind of solution they were looking for. When he had earned their trust and established what they needed he would then describe his product. A character like James is also typically able to establish highly reliable and dependable processes for self-management, and for organising activities and resources, all of which are attributes that are extremely useful and valued in modern business. When he began to work according to his natural strengths, his sales figures went through the roof.

Each of us has qualities that can be adapted to a leadership role and/or to achieve great success. Instead of acting the way we think others expect us to, we are more likely to get others behind us and to succeed if we tap in to our natural, authentic style of leadership and making things happen. The leader has a responsibility to facilitate this process.

'SOME PEOPLE CAN'T BE MOTIVATED'

While it's true that not everyone has the same motivational triggers, as already shown, the belief that some people cannot be motivated is what can lead to the unedifying 'pep-talk and sack them' cycle favoured by many X-Theory managers.

Typically managers use conventional methods to inspire their teams, reminding them that they are 'all in this together' or that they are 'working for the greater good' or that the management has 'complete faith in you', but when all this fails to make an impact the manager simply sighs and hands the troublesome employee the termination letter.

The reality is that motivating some individuals does involve an investment of time. When his manager left the company, Bob was asked by the site director, Frank, to take over some extra responsibility. As well as administrative work he would be more involved in people management and report directly to Frank. Frank saw this as a promotion for Bob and assumed that he would be flattered and take to his new role with gusto. Instead Bob did little but complain. He felt he had too much to do, he didn't trust the new administrator brought in to lighten his workload, and he felt resentful that his extra responsibility hadn't come with extra pay. Frank was a good manager and told Bob that he simply had to be a little more organised, and that he had complete belief in Bob to be able to handle this new challenge. But Bob remained sullen.

So Frank took a different approach: He tried to see the situation from Bob's point of view. Bob enjoyed his social life, but was no longer able to leave the office at 5pm. Bob was dedicated to doing a good job, but was not particularly ambitious, so promotion meant little to him. Bob was also expected to work more closely now with a colleague with whom he clashed. Then Frank looked at how Bob might perceive him as his boss. He realised Bob probably thought Frank's hands-off management style meant he didn't care. To Bob it might look as if Frank took no direct interest except when he found fault. Finally, Frank looked at the situation Bob was in to see if there was anything bringing out the worst in him.

He realised two weeks of every month were effectively 'down-time' for Bob, followed by two weeks where he was overloaded with work. Having set aside his assumptions about Bob and armed with a more complete picture from Bob's point of view, Frank arranged for the two of them to meet to discuss a way forward. Now the two were able to look at the real situation, and to find a workable way forward. While there is no guarantee that this approach will always work, 'seeking to understand', as Stephen Covey's *Seven Habits of Highly Effective People* puts it, is generally a better first step than 'seeking to be understood'.

BUT I AM LISTENING'

We are always told how valuable listening is as a leadership tool and encouraged to do more of it. So, when we remember, we listen really hard, trying to catch every detail of what is being said and maybe follow up with a question to show that we caught everything. This is certainly important. Checking your email, thinking about last night's big game and planning your weekend certainly stop you from hearing what is being said.

But there is another important aspect to listening and that is: Listening Without Judgement. Often when an employee tells us why they are lacking motivation we are busy internally making notes about what is wrong with what they are saying. This is pre-judging. It is not listening properly.

Really listening properly means shutting off the voice in your head that is already planning your counter-argument, so that you can actually hear, understand and interpret what you are being told. This is not to say that 'the employee is always right', but only when you can really understand the other person's perception of the situation are you able to help them develop a strategy that works for them.

Listening is about understanding how the other person feels - beyond merely the words that they say.

'IF THEY LEAVE I'VE FAILED'

What happens if, at their meeting, Bob admits to Frank that he doesn't see his future with that company? What if he says the main reason he is demotivated is that he isn't really suited to the company culture, and would be happier elsewhere? Has Frank failed?

Not necessarily. It's becoming more widely accepted that the right and sustainable approach is to help individual employees to tap in to their true motivators and understand their core values. Katherine Benziger's methodologies are rooted in this philosophy: Employees who 'falsify type' are unhappy, stressed, and are unable to sustain good performance.

Effort should be focused on helping people to align company goals with individual aspirations. Look at Adam's Equity Theory to help understand the complexity of personal motivation and goals alignment.

Motivation and goals cannot be imposed from outside by a boss - motivation and goals must be determined from within the person, mindful of internal needs, and external opportunities and rewards.

Sometimes the person and the company are simply unsuited. In a different culture, industry, role or team that individual would be energised and dedicated, whereas in the present environment the same person doesn't fit.

Sometimes 'success' doesn't look the way we expect it to. A successful outcome for an individual and for a company may be that a demotivated person, having identified what sort of work and environment would suit them better, leaves to find their ideal job elsewhere.

You succeed as a leader by helping and enabling people to reach their potential and to achieve fulfilment. If their needs and abilities could be of far greater value elsewhere, let them go; don't force them to stay out of loyalty. Helping them identify and find a more fitting role elsewhere not only benefits you and them - it also enables you to find a replacement who is really suited and dedicated to the job.

True leaders care about the other person's interests - not just your own interests and the interests of your organization.

'THE SAME FACTORS THAT DEMOTIVATE, MOTIVATE'

When asked what brought about lack of motivation at work, the majority of people in research carried out by Herzberg blamed 'hygiene factors' such as working conditions, salary and company policy. When asked what motivated them they gave answers such as 'the sense of achievement', 'recognition', 'the opportunity to grow and advance' and 'greater responsibility'.

Herzberg's findings about human motivation have been tested and proven time and gain. His theory, and others like it, tell us that the factors that demotivate do not necessarily motivate when reversed. The conventional solution to dissatisfaction over pay levels would be to increase pay in the belief that people would then work harder and be more motivated.

However, this research shows that whilst increasing wages, improving job security and positive working relationships have a marginal impact, the main factors that characterise extreme satisfaction at work are: achievement, recognition, interesting work, responsibility, advancement and growth.

So it follows that leaders who focus on these aspects - people's true motivational needs and values - are the true leaders. Help people to enrich their work and you will truly motivate.

'PEOPLE WILL RISE TO TOUGH CHALLENGES'

Many managers hope to motivate by setting their people challenging targets. They believe that raising the bar higher and higher is what motivates.

Tracey was an effective and conscientious account manager. Her boss habitually set her increasingly tough objectives, which Tracey generally achieved. However, in achieving her targets last month Tracey worked several eighteen-hour days, travelled extensively overseas, and had not had a single weekend break. Sometimes Tracey would mention to her boss that the effort was taking its toll on her health and happiness. When Tracey handed in her latest monthly report, her boss said, 'You see? It's worth all the hard work. So, don't complain about it again.'

Her boss's belief was that Tracey would get a sense of satisfaction from completing an almost impossible workload. He was relying on her sense of duty - which she had in

bucket-loads - to get the job done. But this is the KITA style of motivation. It doesn't really acknowledge a dedication to the job or a sense of pride. Its leverage or 'motivation' is simply a lack of choice. Job enlargement is different to Job enhancement. Herzberg's research shows that improving the 'meaningfulness' of a job has the motivational impact, not simply increasing the amount of pressure or volume of the tasks. Achievement for achievement's sake is no basis for motivation - a person's quality of life must benefit too.

'I TRIED IT AND IT DIDN'T WORK'

When you try new things - new motivational ideas, especially which affect relationships and feelings - it is normal for things initially to get a little worse. Change can be a little unsettling at first. But keep the faith. People are naturally sceptical of unconventional motivational approaches. They may wonder why you have suddenly taken such an interest in them. They may feel you are giving them too much responsibility or be concerned that changes in the way they work may lead to job losses. Herzberg's research is among other evidence, and modern experience, that after an initial drop in performance, people quickly adjust and respond to more progressive management and motivational attitudes.

Supporting and coaching people through this stage of early doubt is vital. Encourage and help people to grow and develop, and performance improvement is inevitable.

'THIS TYPE OF MOTIVATION TAKES TOO MUCH TIME'

You might wonder where you would find the time to motivate people using these approaches. It is true that this style of leadership, sustainable motivation, commitment and focus is in the beginning more time consuming than 'KITA' methods; this is bound to be, since KITA methods require far less thought. Engaging fully with your staff, understanding their wants, desires and values, getting to know them as individuals and developing strategies that achieve a continuous release of energy is more intensive and takes time to work.

But consider the advantages. This investment of time means you will eventually have less to do. Instead of constantly urging your people along and having to solve all the problems yourself, you'll be the leader of a group performing at a higher level of ability and productivity, giving you the chance to step back from fire-fighting and to consider the bigger picture.

Herzberg was not alone in identifying that leaders need invest in the development of their teams, and also of their own successors. Douglas McGregor's X-Y Theory is pretty central to all this too. So is Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs, from the individual growth perspective. Hersey's and Blanchard's Situation Leadership® model also emphasises clearly how important team development is for leaders and organizations. And Bruce Tuckman's 'Forming, Storming, Norming, Performing' model. All of these

renowned theories clearly demonstrate the need for teams, and the individuals within them, to be positively led and developed.

Your responsibility as leader is to develop your team so that it can take on more and more of your own responsibility. A mature team should be virtually self-managing, leaving you free to concentrate on all the job-enhancing strategic aspects that you yourself need in order to keep motivated and developing.

Executive Development

Executive development is the whole of activities aimed at developing the skills and competencies of those that (will) have executive positions in organisations. While “executive” and “manager” and “leader” are often used interchangeably, “executive” is commonly used to signify the top 5% to 10% of the organization. Similarly, “development” and “training” and “education” are often used as synonyms, however “development” is generally seen as the more encompassing of the three in terms of activities that build skills and competencies. While it is typical to find organizations that have dedicated corporate training & development people and processes, it is not always the case that an organization will have a dedicated executive development set of activities. In some organizations (typically large multi-nationals), there is a separate executive development team, in other organizations executive development is handled as one of many activities by the larger corporate training group, and in yet other scenarios there is no executive development activity to speak of.

In contrast to other corporate training & development activities, which have as their core purpose to build tactical skills for employees, executive development plays a different role for the organization. Indeed some executive development is conducted for the purpose of building tactical skills (sometimes referred to as “hard skills” such as business fundamentals- finance, marketing, operations and also “soft skills” such as communication and team building), yet executive development is also used to evaluate future potential future executives as well as a mechanism for the CEO and the executive team to cascade their strategies, goals, and even elements of the culture to the rest of the management team and ultimately the organization. In the best of cases, executive development not only helps an organization execute its key strategies, it can also help provide input to the strategy creation process. In this way, executive development is much more strategic than typical corporate training & development which is used for most employees of an organization.

Philosophies and Practices

There is a wide range of practices in the field of executive development today. On one hand, there are organizations that have for many years, if not decades, had very thorough executive development functions that conduct a wide variety of high profile and highly regarded set of activities (GE’s Crotonville is the classic example). On the other end of the spectrum, there are some organizations that have curtailed many of the

executive development activities and spending in the wake of the economic crisis of 2008/2009. As one looks across different companies, and against the backdrop of different periods, there exists a wide variety of executive development activity.

Also, the main philosophy of executive development is quite different depending on the organization. For some, the development process has and continues to play a very strategic role in the organization- it is with and through executive development activities that organizational strategies are formed, communicated, and reinforced with senior management. In other organizations, development of executives is seen as an inherently positive activity, which, akin to insurance, is probably better to have than not. In organizations where development has not had an opportunity to prove its value, it may be seen as a waste of time and rarely something that the organization commits its leaders' precious time toward.

Reporting & Structure

Most often the executive development function reports into the head of Talent Management, the head of HR, or into the Chief Learning Officer (CLO). In rare cases, it reports into an operating executive (i.e. COO). Executive development can be very effective under any reporting structure – what is key is executive level sponsorship and access to senior line leaders who can help ensure development is aligned with and supports the company's strategy. Most often, the head of executive development will have additional resources working alongside him/her. These may be in the form of direct reports, and/or HR business partners and shared resources in the Talent Management function. While the majority of executive development professionals are the more senior talent management professionals in the organization (based on expertise, education such as graduate degree, and tenure), in some cases and perhaps more frequently organizations are putting "outsiders" in charge of executive development who have not spent the bulk of their career in Talent Management or Human Resources (some examples include CBS Corporation and the U.S. Navy). Among the reasons for this are to bring a fresh perspective into the role and to bring strategy and operational expertise into the function. On the supplier side, there exists a rich ecosystem of development professionals; essentially any part of the executive development process can be procured from an outside firm or set of individual consultants and coaches.

Primary Activities

Executive Development activities generally fall into two broad categories: Assessment and Development as outlined below.

Assessment

- **Capability Requirements** – Provide input into the organization's strategy formulation process by identifying what is required of executives from a capability perspective

- Capability Assessment – Measure existing capabilities against required capabilities
- Gap Analysis – Identify gap between requirements and current assessment, with an eye toward what capabilities can be “built” (development) vs. “bought” external hiring

Development

- Segment executive population– Create groupings of executives, by level, geography, business unit, or other affiliation (C-suite track, high potential’s, critical roles etc.)
- Architect – Create development activities and experiences for the different segmentations
- Deliver – Coordinate across the ecosystem of internal and external partners to deliver development experiences and manage execution of executive development initiatives, etc.
- Measure & Refine – Conduct post activity ROI (typically Kirkpatrick Level I-IV), make course corrections, summarize and report results

Some of the adjacent Talent Management activities that executive development may have involvement with include the succession planning process (typically not CEO or CEO -1, but below), executive onboarding (ideally both external hiring and internal changes), structuring on the job developmental assignments, and working with alumni of development programs, and alumni of the organization.

Developmental Options

Executive development professionals have a wide variety of activities they can choose to deploy including in order of most commonly found:

- OTJ (On the job) stretch assignments, line and staff roles, rotational assignments
- Executive coaching
- Mentoring
- Custom workshops and activities
- Action learning
- Business school open enrollment courses
- Online courses and resources

Best Practices

The following are a set of best practices most often found in organizations that have long standing development activities which are highly regarded in and outside of the organization.

- Articulate a clear and compelling vision – Leaders have many competing priorities, and need a compelling set of reasons to support development

activities. The development team needs to build a compelling case and consistent themes across its development strategy.

- Build support across key sponsors - Executive development professionals need to have a deep set of contacts both inside of the organization and across many functions and outside with thought leaders and experts. Many organizations have found that Advisory Boards, which seek to create a formal process of soliciting the input from stakeholders as highly effective. Relationships with internal executives, who are increasingly used as “faculty” to delivery development, are important to nurture. A strong professional network is the “currency” of the development professional.
- Ground development in business challenges – When in doubt, development that is rooted in solving current and significant business challenges will always prevail over development that is designed to round out a leader or a group of professionals.
- Shorten the timeline – Especially in light of budget cutbacks that are all too common in organizations today, it is important that development is focused on solving current operating cycle issues and challenges. Development plans that span many quarters risk never being fully implemented.
- Market successes – Successful development professionals, like any other professionals in the organization, are quite good at highlighting their impact for the organization and making sure to create “buzz” for their work and activities.

Whether through formal ROI studies or informal anecdotal reviews that are circulated to strategic individuals, it is key to promote success.

Executive Development 2.0

Below are key factors that are impacting the field of executive development:

- Time frame – The speed with which organizations need to revise strategies, launch new products and services, expand their global footprint, etc. continues to accelerate; more rapid means of enabling the organization and its leaders to make these changes are required from the development function.
- Share of mind – Executives are incredibly taxed with an increasing set of responsibilities; mid-level management has been reduced and the number of stakeholders (community, environment, government, etc.) has increased, all putting incredible pressure on leaders. Development that is not of immediate value risks elimination.
- Budget – The current economic situation has put great pressure on all expenses across the organization, executive development is no exception. Centralized development budgets are all targets, while certain activities such as executive coaching that may be paid out of a business unit budget may be more insulated from cutbacks.

- “Bottom line” HR – As many organizations have become more results oriented and quantitative for all support functions, there is increased pressure for HR and all of its components to “raise its game” and prove in business terms its impact.

These factors are creating a new operating context for executive development professionals. In response to this new environment, The Institute of Executive Development has articulated a vision of what Executive Development 2.0 will look like:

- The purpose of the function is to drive the organizational strategy (not solely build skills)
- The content will be based on current business imperatives
- The timeline is focused on the immediate 12 months, not longer
- The format will include more on the job and action learning (vs. formal workshops and programs)
- The audience will include stakeholders such as customers and partners
- The budget will be measured more in terms of investment of executive’s time (vs. funds)

While executive development continues to become enriched by many approaches, one approach, adult development and its subfield Positive Adult Development is beginning to create opportunities for what has been essentially reserved for academic research to become an increasing part of executive practices.

Executive Development Programme: Concept, Objectives and Methods!

Concepts and objectives

While drawing a distinction between training and development, we introduced, in brief, the concept of development. Based on that concept, we can now elaborate it in more detail. The term ‘development’ implies overall development in a person. Accordingly, executive development means not only improvement in job performance, but also improvement in knowledge, personality, attitude, behaviourism of an executive, etc.

It means that executive development focuses more on the executive’s personal growth. Thus, executive development consists of all the means that improve his/her performance and behaviour. Executive development helps understand cause and effect relationship, synthesizes from experience, visualizes relationships or thinks logically. That is why some behavioural scientists suggest that the executive development is predominantly an educational process rather than a training process.

Flippo has viewed that “executive/management development includes the process by which managers and executives acquire not only skills and competency in their present jobs but also capabilities for future managerial tasks of increasing difficulty and scope”.

According to S.B. Budhiraja, former Managing Director of Indian Oil Corporation. “Any activity designed to improve the performance of existing managers and to provide for a planned growth of managers to meet future organisational requirements is called management development”.

It is now clear from the above definitions of executive/management development that it is based on certain assumptions.

We can derive these as follows:

1. Executive development, being a predominantly educational process, is a continuous and life-long process. It is not like training as a one-shot programme but an on-going continuous programme throughout the career of an executive or manager.
2. Like any kind of learning, executive development is based on the assumption that there always exists a gap between what an executive performs and what he/she can. Executive development harnesses this untapped potential.

Objectives of Executive Development

The main objectives of any programme of executive development are to:

1. Improve the performance of managers at all levels.
2. Identify the persons in the organisation with the required potential and prepare them for higher positions in future.
3. Ensure availability of required number of executives / managers succession who can take over in case of contingencies as and when these arise in future.
4. Prevent obsolescence of executives by exposing them to the latest concepts and techniques in their respective areas of specialisation.
5. Replace elderly executives who have risen from the ranks by highly competent and academically qualified professionals.
6. Improve the thought processes and analytical abilities.
7. Provide opportunities to executives to fulfill their career aspirations.
8. Understand the problems of human relations and improve human relation skills.

A Dasgupta has given the level-wise objectives of the executive/ management development as follows:

Top Management

1. To improve thought processes and analytical ability in order to uncover and examine problems and take decisions in the best interests of the country and organisation;
2. To broaden the outlook of the executive in regard to his role, position and responsibilities in the organisation and outside;
3. To think through problems this may confront the organisation now or in the future;

4. To understand economic, technical and institutional forces in order to solve business problems; and
5. To acquire knowledge about the problems of human relations.

Middle Line Management

1. To establish a clear picture of executive functions and responsibilities;
2. To bring about an awareness of the broad aspects of management problems, and an acquaintance with and appreciation of interdepartmental relations.
3. To develop the ability to analyse problems and to take appropriate action;
4. To develop familiarity with the managerial use of financial accounting, psychology, business statistics;
5. To inculcate knowledge of human motivation and human relationships; and
6. To develop responsible leadership.

Middle Functional Executives and Specialists

1. To increase knowledge of business functions and operations in specific fields in marketing production, finance, personnel;
2. To increase proficiency in management techniques such as work study, inventory control, operations research, quality control;
3. To stimulate creative thinking in order to improve methods and procedures;
4. To understand the functions performed in a company;
5. To understand industrial relations problems; and
6. To develop the ability to analyse problems in one's area or functions.

Importance of executive Development

Executives, or say, managers manage/run organisations. It is managers who plan, organise, direct and control the resources and activities in every organisation. An organisation is like a vehicle of which managers are drivers. Without competent managers, other valuable resources such as men, material, machine, money, technology and others remain of not much significance for the organisation. Thus, managers are a vital cog in the success of any organisation. That's why executive/ management development has become indispensable to modern organisations.

The importance of executive development is appreciated in more orderly manner in the succeeding paragraphs:

1. Change in organisations has become *sine quo non* with rapid changes in the total environment. A manager, therefore, requires to be imparted training to abreast of and cope with on-going changes in his / her organisation. Otherwise, the manager becomes obsolete. In this context, Dale Yoder views that "without training, the executives lose their punch and drive and they die on the vine. Training and development are the only ways of overcoming the executive dropouts".

2. With the recognition that managers are made not born, there has been noticeable shift from owner managed to professionally managed enterprises, even in family business houses like Tata. That is also indicated by the lavish expenditure incurred on executive training by most of the enterprises these days.
3. Given the knowledge era, labour management relations are becoming increasingly complex. In such situation, managers not only need job skills but also behavioural skills in union negotiations, collective bargaining, grievance redressal, etc. These skills are learned through training and development programmes.
4. The nature and number of problems change along with increase in the size and structure of enterprise from small to large. This underlines the need for developing managerial skills to handle the problems of big, giant and complex organisations.

Inaugurating the Tata Management Training Centre at Pune in 1965, Mr. J.R.D Tata extolled the importance of management training in these words.

“Trained managers are vital to the economic development of the country... This business of executive development has been one of the most crucial, essential end, at the same time, one of the most difficult elements in providing continuity and efficient management”.

As regards the importance of management development, the renowned behavioural scientist Peter Drucker opines that, “an institution that cannot produce its own managers will die. From an overall point of view, the ability of an institution to produce managers is more important than its ability to produce goods efficiently and cheaply”. In short, the importance of executive/ management development in an organisation can best be put as: anything minus management development in an organisation mounts to nothing.

The process

Like any learning programme, executive development also involves a process consisting of certain steps. Though sequencing these various steps in a chronological order is difficult, behavioural scientists have tried to list and sequence them in six steps.

These steps, also called the components of the executive development programme, have been- discussed in the succeeding paragraphs.

Identifying Development Needs

Once the launching of an executive development programme (EDP) is decided, its implementation begins with identifying the developmental needs of the organisation concern.

For this, first of all, the present and future developmental needs for executives/ managers ascertained by identifying how many and what type of executives will be

required in the organisation at present and in future. This needs to be seen in the context of organisational as well as individual, i.e. manager needs. While organisational needs may be identified by making organisational analysis in terms of organisation's growth plan, strategies, competitive environment, etc., individual needs to be identified by the individual career planning and appraisal.

Appraisal of Present Managerial Talent

The second step is an appraisal of the present managerial talent for the organisation. For this purpose, a qualitative assessment of the existing executives/managers in the organisation is made. Then, the performance of every executive is compared with the standard expected of him.

Inventory of Executive Manpower

Based on information gathered from human resource planning, an inventory is prepared to have complete information about each executive in each position. Information on the executive's age, education, experience, health record, psychological test results, performance appraisal data, etc. is collected and the same is maintained on cards and replacement tables. An analysis of such inventory shows the strengths and also discloses the deficiencies and weaknesses of the executives in certain functions relative to the future needs of the concern organisation. From this executive inventory, we can begin the fourth step involved in the executive development process.

Conducting Development Programmes

At this stage, the manager actually participates in development programmes. It is worth mentioning that no single development programme can be adequate for all managers. The reason is that each manager has a unique set of physical, intellectual and emotional characteristics. As such, there can be different development programmes to uniquely suit to the needs of an executive/ manager. These development programmes may be on-the-job or off-the-job programmes organised either by the organisation itself or by some outside agencies.

Evaluating Development Programmes

Just as with employee training programme, executive development programme is evaluated to see changes in behaviour and executive performance. Evaluation of programme enables to appraise programme's effectiveness, highlight its weaknesses and aids to determine whether the development should be continued or how it can be improved.

Office Management

Office management is generally described as organizing and administering the auxiliary, day-to-day chores of the front office—chores that are often the responsibility

of an office manager. Possible duties of an office manager include ordering and purchase approval of office supplies and services, hiring and supervision of front office workers, handling customer service, managing accounting functions, and analyzing sales—but office management can be virtually anything the company owner wants it to be. According to chief executive officers responding to a survey from *Inc.* magazine, good office management and office managers are the grease that keep the wheels of business rolling smoothly. In a similar vein, an author in *Medical Economics* magazine wrote that the main function of an office manager of a medical practice is to “free you [the doctor] from hassles and let you concentrate on medicine.”

There is no traceable history of office management. The job of “office manager” is generally found in smaller companies where the owner depends on a single person who performs a variety of tasks to keep the office functioning. As a company grows into a corporation, office managers seem to disappear, while other departments such as purchasing and human resources expand. The office manager is usually not considered to be a member of the management team. She or he probably would not participate in management strategy sessions on how to increase sales, but would participate in sessions on how to cut operating expenses.

In the area of supplies and services, an office manager is usually responsible for buying short-term supplies such as photocopy paper, envelopes, and letterhead, longer-term purchases such as telephone systems, and other ongoing necessities such as making sure the postal meter has enough postage. This person usually handles the company’s service purchases, such as long distance telephone service and photocopier service agreements. Ideally, office managers will be given the authority to accept bids and negotiate contracts so that they may tell salespeople that they make the decisions. Office managers must also be savvy enough to recognize fraudulent business practices.

Another responsibility of office managers is staffing. They will recruit, interview, and hire employees for the office. Office managers need to know how to select the right people and train them. For example, the telephone receptionist will need to be skilled in telephone etiquette and customer service.

Office managers sometimes take on the role of monitoring customer service. They may listen to calls, or answer the phone themselves. They may also ask the customers directly how the company is doing in this area. They then report their findings to the company owner on a regular basis. They also know enough to turn over particularly thorny problems to the company owner immediately so faithful customers do not become angry if they think the company owner is ignoring them and passing them off to an office manager. The key to being successful as a customer service manager is to convince customers that all collected information—good and bad—will go directly to the president for review.

Accounting functions are often handled by office managers, provided they have some background in handling money, or can be trained to do so. They may keep track of accounts payable and accounts receivable, assign vendor bills to be paid during specific

weeks, prepare outgoing bills as customer orders or jobs are finished, and control the company's petty cash. Many office managers are reluctant to actually sign checks, however, as that could make them appear to be a link in the chain of financial liability if the company were to run into financial problems. Conversely, many owners are reluctant to turn over checkwriting duties to their office managers, fearing for embezzlement. Owners who do charge their office managers with this responsibility typically set a limit on the amount of the checks, based on the company's average daily expenses. Some owners also secure fidelity bond coverage for their office managers; a fidelity bond is purchased from an insurance company and will pay the insured company for money or property lost from the dishonest actions—including embezzlement, forgery, and theft—of its bonded employees.

Office managers also frequently take on the job of time accounting, particularly for small service companies such as advertising agencies or law firms that depend on the billing of time as a source of revenue. The office manager collects the time sheets from billable employees in order to assign the hours to specific jobs. This task is slowly being replaced by software that automatically tracks and assigns time.

A final possible area of responsibility for office managers is to compile and analyze sales information. This might involve calculating the profitability of the company and specific projects or tracking various expenditures. This knowledge is critical to the performance of a company, but too detailed for the company owner to know off the top of his or her head. An office manager performing these duties must be able to retrieve all the necessary documents and be able to analyze the information.

An office manager position can sometimes lead a person up the corporate ladder without a formal business degree. The experience gained from organizing and running the front office successfully can provide a person with a variety of transferable skills.

4

Useful Automation Material System in Office

COMPUTER

A computer is a programmable machine that receives input, stores and manipulates data, and provides output in a useful format.

Although mechanical examples of computers have existed through much of recorded human history, the first electronic computers were developed in the mid-20th century. These were the size of a large room, consuming as much power as several hundred modern personal computers. Modern computers based on integrated circuits are millions to billions of times more capable than the early machines, and occupy a fraction of the space.

Simple computers are small enough to fit into small pocket devices, and can be powered by a small battery. Personal computers in their various forms are icons of the Information Age and are what most people think of as “computers”. However, the embedded computers found in many devices from MP3 players to fighter aircraft and from toys to industrial robots are the most numerous.

The ability to store and execute lists of instructions called programmes makes computers extremely versatile, distinguishing them from calculators. The Church-Turing thesis is a mathematical statement of this versatility: any computer with a certain minimum capability is, in principle, capable of performing the same tasks that any other computer can perform. Therefore computers ranging from a netbook to a

supercomputer are all able to perform the same computational tasks, given enough time and storage capacity.

HISTORY OF COMPUTING

The first use of the word "computer" was recorded in 1613, referring to a person who carried out calculations, or computations, and the word continued to be used in that sense until the middle of the 20th century. From the end of the 19th century onwards though, the word began to take on its more familiar meaning, describing a machine that carries out computations.

The history of the modern computer begins with two separate technologies-automated calculation and programmability-but no single device can be identified as the earliest computer, partly because of the inconsistent application of that term. Examples of early mechanical calculating devices include the abacus, the slide rule and arguably the astrolabe and the Antikythera mechanism. Hero of Alexandria built a mechanical theater which performed a play lasting 10 minutes and was operated by a complex system of ropes and drums that might be considered to be a means of deciding which parts of the mechanism performed which actions and when. This is the essence of programmability.

The "castle clock", an astronomical clock invented by Al-Jazari in 1206, is considered to be the earliest programmable analog computer. It displayed the zodiac, the solar and lunar orbits, a crescent moon-shaped pointer travelling across a gateway causing automatic doors to open every hour, and five robotic musicians who played music when struck by levers operated by a camshaft attached to a water wheel. The length of day and night could be re-programmed to compensate for the changing lengths of day and night throughout the year.

The Renaissance saw a re-invigoration of European mathematics and engineering. Wilhelm Schickard's 1623 device was the first of a number of mechanical calculators constructed by European engineers, but none fit the modern definition of a computer, because they could not be programmed. In 1801, Joseph Marie Jacquard made an improvement to the textile loom by introducing a series of punched paper cards as a template which allowed his loom to weave intricate patterns automatically.

The resulting Jacquard loom was an important step in the development of computers because the use of punched cards to define woven patterns can be viewed as an early, albeit limited, form of programmability.

It was the fusion of automatic calculation with programmability that produced the first recognizable computers. In 1837, Charles Babbage was the first to conceptualize and design a fully programmable mechanical computer, his analytical engine. Limited finances and Babbage's inability to resist tinkering with the design meant that the device was never completed.

In the late 1880s, Herman Hollerith invented the recording of data on a machine readable medium. Prior uses of machine readable media had been for control, not data. "After some initial trials with paper tape, he settled on punched cards..." To process

these punched cards he invented the tabulator, and the keypunch machines. These three inventions were the foundation of the modern information processing industry. Large-scale automated data processing of punched cards was performed for the 1890 United States Census by Hollerith's company, which later became the core of IBM.

By the end of the 19th century a number of technologies that would later prove useful in the realization of practical computers had begun to appear: the punched card, Boolean algebra, the vacuum tube and the teleprinter.

During the first half of the 20th century, many scientific computing needs were met by increasingly sophisticated analog computers, which used a direct mechanical or electrical model of the problem as a basis for computation.

However, these were not programmable and generally lacked the versatility and accuracy of modern digital computers. Alan Turing is widely regarded to be the father of modern computer science. In 1936 Turing provided an influential formalisation of the concept of the algorithm and computation with the Turing machine.

Of his role in the modern computer, Time magazine in naming Turing one of the 100 most influential people of the 20th century, states: "The fact remains that everyone who taps at a keyboard, opening a spreadsheet or a word-processing programme, is working on an incarnation of a Turing machine".

The inventor of the programme-controlled computer was Konrad Zuse, who built the first working computer in 1941 and later in 1955 the first computer based on magnetic storage. George Stibitz is internationally recognized as a father of the modern digital computer. While working at Bell Labs in November 1937, Stibitz invented and built a relay-based calculator he dubbed the "Model K", which was the first to use binary circuits to perform an arithmetic operation. Later models added greater sophistication including complex arithmetic and programmability.

Table. Defining Characteristics of some Early Digital Computers of the 1940s

Name	First operational	Numeral system	Computing mechanism	Programming	Turing complete
Zuse Z3 (Germany)	May 1941	Binary	Electro-mechanical	Program-controlled by punched film stock (but no conditional branch)	Yes (1998)
Atanasoff-Berry Computer (US)	1942	Binary	Electronic	Not programmable—single purpose	No
Colossus Mark 1 (UK)	February 1944	Binary	Electronic	Program-controlled by patch cables and switches	No
Harvard Mark I – IBM ASCC (US)	May 1944	Decimal	Electro-mechanical	Program-controlled by 24-channel punched paper tape (but no conditional branch)	No
Colossus Mark 2 (UK)	June 1944	Binary	Electronic	Program-controlled by patch cables and switches	No
ENIAC (US)	July 1946	Decimal	Electronic	Program-controlled by patch cables and switches	Yes
Manchester Small-Scale Experimental Machine (Baby) (UK)	June 1948	Binary	Electronic	Stored-program in Williams cathode ray tube memory	Yes

Modified ENIAC (US)	September 1948	Decimal	Electronic	Program-controlled by patch cables and switches plus a primitive read-only stored programming mechanism using the Function Tables as program ROM	Yes
EDSAC (UK)	May 1949	Binary	Electronic	Stored-program in mercury delay line memory	Yes
Manchester Mark 1 (UK)	October 1949	Binary	Electronic	Stored-program in Williams cathode ray tube memory and magnetic drum memory	Yes
CSIRAC (Australia)	November 1949	Binary	Electronic	Stored-program in mercury delay line memory	Yes

A succession of steadily more powerful and flexible computing devices were constructed in the 1930s and 1940s, gradually adding the key features that are seen in modern computers. The use of digital electronics and more flexible programmability were vitally important steps, but defining one point along this road as “the first digital electronic computer” is difficult.

Notable achievements include:

- Konrad Zuse’s electromechanical “Z machines”. The Z3 was the first working machine featuring binary arithmetic, including floating point arithmetic and a measure of programmability. In 1998 the Z3 was proved to be Turing complete, therefore being the world’s first operational computer.
- The non-programmable Atanasoff–Berry Computer which used vacuum tube based computation, binary numbers, and regenerative capacitor memory. The use of regenerative memory allowed it to be much more compact than its peers, since intermediate results could be stored and then fed back into the same set of computation elements.
- The secret British Colossus computers which had limited programmability but demonstrated that a device using thousands of tubes could be reasonably reliable and electronically reprogrammable. It was used for breaking German wartime codes.
- The Harvard Mark I, a large-scale electromechanical computer with limited programmability.
- The U.S. Army’s Ballistic Research Laboratory ENIAC, which used decimal arithmetic and is sometimes called the first general purpose electronic computer. Initially, however, ENIAC had an inflexible architecture which essentially required rewiring to change its programming.

Several developers of ENIAC, recognizing its flaws, came up with a far more flexible and elegant design, which came to be known as the “stored programme architecture” or von Neumann architecture. This design was first formally described by John von Neumann in the paper *First Draft of a Report on the EDVAC*, distributed in 1945.

A number of projects to develop computers based on the stored-programme architecture commenced around this time, the first of these being completed in Great

Britain. The first to be demonstrated working was the Manchester Small-Scale Experimental Machine, while the EDSAC, completed a year after SSEM, was the first practical implementation of the stored programme design. Shortly thereafter, the machine originally described by von Neumann's paper—EDVAC—was completed but did not see full-time use for an additional two years.

Nearly all modern computers implement some form of the stored-programme architecture, making it the single trait by which the word “computer” is now defined. While the technologies used in computers have changed dramatically since the first electronic, general-purpose computers of the 1940s, most still use the von Neumann architecture.

Beginning in the 1950s, Soviet scientists Sergei Sobolev and Nikolay Brusentsov conducted research on ternary computers, devices that operated on a base three numbering system of -1, 0, and 1 rather than the conventional binary numbering system upon which most computers are based. They designed the Setun, a functional ternary computer, at Moscow State University. The device was put into limited production in the Soviet Union, but supplanted by the more common binary architecture.

Computers using vacuum tubes as their electronic elements were in use throughout the 1950s, but by the 1960s had been largely replaced by transistor-based machines, which were smaller, faster, cheaper to produce, required less power, and were more reliable. The first transistorised computer was demonstrated at the University of Manchester in 1953. In the 1970s, integrated circuit technology and the subsequent creation of microprocessors, such as the Intel 4004, further decreased size and cost and further increased speed and reliability of computers.

By the late 1970s, many products such as video recorders contained dedicated computers called microcontrollers, and they started to appear as a replacement to mechanical controls in domestic appliances such as washing machines.

The 1980s witnessed home computers and the now ubiquitous personal computer. With the evolution of the Internet, personal computers are becoming as common as the television and the telephone in the household.

Modern smartphones are fully programmable computers in their own right, and as of 2009 may well be the most common form of such computers in existence.

ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF COMPUTER

Advantages are: communication is improved, pay bill's online, people have access to things they would not have had before Computers make life easier.

The disadvantages are: scams, fraud, people not going out as much, we do not yet know the effects of computers and pregnancy or the emissions that computers make. bad posture from sitting too long at a desk, repetitive strain injuries and the fact that most organisations expect everyone to own a computer.

TYPES OF COMPUTER

Since the invention of computers from first generation and fourth generation computers, they have been classified according to their types and how they operate that is input, process and output information. You will get a brief discussion on various types of Computers.

Computer types can be divided into 3 categories according to electronic nature. Types of computers are classified according to how a particular Computer functions.

These computer types are:

- Analogue Computers
- Digital Computers
- Hybrid Computers

ANALOGUE COMPUTERS

Analogue types of Computer uses what is known as analogue signals that are represented by a continuous set of varying voltages and are used in scientific research centres?, hospitals and flight centres.

With analogue types of computer no values are represented by physical measurable quantities e.g. voltages. Analogue computer types programme arithmetic and logical operations by measuring physical changes i.e. temperatures or pressure.

DIGITAL COMPUTER TYPE

With these types of computers operation are on electrical input that can attain two inputs, states of ON=1 and state of OFF = 0. With digital type of computers data is represented by digital of 0 and 1 or off state and on state. Digital computer type recognizes data by counting discrete signal of (0 or 1), they are high speed programmable; they compute values and stores results. After looking at the Digital computer type and how it functions will move to the third computer type.

HYBRID TYPE OF COMPUTER

Hybrid computer types are very unique, in the sense that they combined both analogue and digital features and operations.

With Hybrid computers operate by using digital to analogue convertor and analogue to digital convertor. By linking the two types of computer you come up with this new computer type called Hybrid.

PERSONAL COMPUTER

In its more general usage, a personal computer is a microcomputer designed for use by one person at a time. Prior to the PC, computers were designed for companies who attached terminals for multiple users to a single large computer whose resources were shared among all users.

The advent of the era of the personal computer was acknowledged by Time magazine in 1982, when they broke with tradition by choosing the PC as their “Man of the Year.” By the late 1980s, technology advances made it feasible to build a small computer that an individual could own and use. The term “PC” has been traditionally used to describe an “IBM-compatible” personal computer in contradistinction to an Apple Macintosh computer. The distinction is both technical and cultural and harkens back to the early years of personal computers, when IBM and Apple were the two major competitors.

Originally, the “IBM-compatible” PC was one with an Intel microprocessor architecture and an operating system such as DOS or Windows that written to use that microprocessor. The Apple Macintosh uses a Motorola microprocessor architecture and a proprietary operating system.

The “IBM-compatible” PC was associated with business and use, while the “Mac,” known for its more intuitive user interface, was associated with graphic design and desktop publishing. Although the distinctions have become less clear-cut in recent years, people often still categorize a personal computer as either a PC or a Mac.

OFFICE FURNITURE AND EQUIPMENT

Office Equipments

Every firm needs some equipments also. Several types, of machines have been devised to assist the staff in disposal of the routine work speedily, economically and accurately. But these mechanical devices should be used with caution. They displace human labour and are more useful for those countries where labour is scarce. In a country like India their, uses are limited. Anyway, in a large firm they may be adopted to improve efficiency.

Adoption of machines may be helpful in the following cases:

- (a) Where it is not possible for the office staff to complete the work manually, on account of the volume and pressure of work;
- (b) Where efficiency, accuracy and speed are necessary and which cannot be obtained manually;
- (c) Where there are jobs of repetitive, lengthy and monotonous nature;
- (d) Where it may be more economical to use machines rather than men but it should be kept in mind that volume of work should be enough so that the machines may not be kept idle otherwise the overhead expenses may turn their use uneconomical; and
- (e) Where labour is scarce.

Mechanical devices which are commonly used by various business firms may be of the following broad categories:

Furniture

Every firm requires furniture and fixtures for the office. It may require furniture for its executives and general office. Selection of suitable furniture is highly important.

In practice, enough care is taken in the selection of the furniture for the executives and no proper attention is given to the furniture of the general office.

But it is highly important to pay adequate attention to it also as it affects the efficiency of the vast majority of employees, in the office. Uniformity, standardisation and symmetry must be maintained in the arrangement of furniture in the general office. The furniture may be required for special purposes also, such as conference hall, recreation room, retiring room, club, libraries, reception rooms, dining halls and medical departments etc. Selection of furniture for such special purposes requires proper attention.

Economy in the purchase of office furniture may be made but not at the cost of efficiency. It should be noted that a small item like the chair can cause a substantial difference in the quality and quantity of work obtained from an employee. Material, height, size, appearance and colour of the furniture matter a lot. Furniture of poor quality should not be purchased as it may involve huge expenditure on repairs and replacements later.

Copying and Duplicating Machines

They include typewriters, various duplicating machines such as hectograph, mimeograph, multigraph and office offset duplicating, electrostatic etc. and imprinting machines such as addressing machines, impression stamps, and signature machines etc.

(a) *Typewriter*: It is a popular equipment used almost in every business enterprise.

It is used for neat and speedier writing. With its help limited number of carbon copies can also be obtained. Now electronic typewriters and computers are also available which are helpful for accurate, neat, and speedier typing. They may be used for obtaining a large number of copies.

(b) *Duplicating machines*: When a large number of copies are to be obtained and they cannot be had with the help of typewriters duplicating and electrostatic machines are used with their help one or two hundred copies may be obtained easily, speedily and economically. These duplicating machines are of the following types:

(i) Hectograph, also known as gelatine duplicator, which may be of flat bed type or rotary type or liquid spirit process type.

(ii) Mimeograph duplicator is helpful in getting larger number of copies. In this process, the original document is written or typed on a wax-sheet known as stencil. The stencil is put in the mimeograph machine and the copies are obtained.

(iii) Multigraph is helpful in giving more than one thousand copies. It is a miniature printing machine used in the office for duplicating purposes.

(iv) Now variety of xeroxing or electrostatic machines are available and used for very neat copies in large number. Laser printers are used for very fine copy and prints.

(c) *Imprinting Machines*: There are several imprinting machines used in the offices. They are helpful in marking impressions on a number of copies. These devices or machines are of the following types.

- Addressing machines are used by the concerns which have to despatch several letters, invoices, bills, notices etc. to large number of addresses. Besides, their use for addressing envelopes, they may be used for preparing inventory records, 'pay-roll sheets, shareholders' lists or dividend warrants or monthly statements of account etc.
- Impression stamps made of rubber or metal are also used to repeat the same impression on different documents. Stamps with impressions such as, 'Cancelled', 'Paid', 'Outdated', 'Despatched' etc. may be used for the purpose.
- Signature machines may be used for putting impression of signature on letters, notices or cheques etc.

Cash Handling Machines

There are several mechanical devices used for handling cash and cheques. They are as follows:

- Cash registers are the machines which maintain record about cash received. Some models are such which issue receipts to the customers with the record of the amount received while others do not issue any receipt but simply add the amounts received and the total is shown in the meter attached to the machine. These cash registers prevent misappropriation of cash by the cashier.
- Coin handling machines help in giving change to the customers automatically. They also handle the coins received from the customers.
- Coin sorters are used for classifying different coins according to their denomination out of the mixed heap of the various coins. They also count them and record the total amount of the coins.
- Cheque Writing Machines and Cheque Protectors are used for writing cheques where a large number of cheques are to be written every day. The cheque protectors are used with a view to prevent any fraud. The cheques are written by it in such a manner that no alteration or erasure is possible.

Computation and Accounting Machines

These machines are used for calculation, tabulation and accounting purposes. They are used specially in those concerns where the volume of work is so much that it cannot be copied manually. Some of the important machines commonly used for the purpose are as follows:

- *Cromptometre*: It makes various calculations such as addition, subtraction, multiplication and division with complete accuracy and speed.
- Tabulating machines are used for tabulation of huge figures quickly and accurately. Two types of tabulating machines are in use, i.e., one which uses punch cards and other in which banks of keys are used. These machines have three processes such as punching, storing and tabulating. They are used for analysis and classification of huge data for specific purposes.

- Billing machines have combination of typewriter and calculator. Various calculations such as discounts, addition etc. are performed by it and several copies also can be obtained simultaneously.
- Accounting machines of different types are now used to record business transactions in the books of account. They are used for recording cash receipts and payments, posting accounts in the ledger, making entries in the journal, preparation of statements of account, or advice notes, preparation of wage sheets, cost sheets. Inventory records or stores records etc.

Miscellaneous Machines

There are several other mechanical devices available which help in the various office routines; There are numerous machines handling correspondence. When the typist is not available, dictaphone may be used in which the dictator simply speaks which is recorded in the machine. Later on, the typist can use earphone attached to the machine and words are conveyed to him by it. He can then type through it. He can regulate its speed according to need. Similarly, Sealing Machine seals letter or parcels with wax neatly and speedily. Stamp-affixing Machine is helpful in affixing the stamps on large number of letters quickly. Stapling Machine may be used for fastening together the correspondence papers. A Franking Machine may be used for putting stamps in ink on the envelopes being posted.

Folding Machine may be used for folding various circulars and letters etc. quickly and neatly. Gumming Machine may be used for affixing a strip of strongly gummed, tough paper, in any required length.

There are Time Recording Machines which may be used for accurate recording of the time of arrival and departure of the workers of the office or factory. Pay-roll Machine may be used for the purpose of distribution of pay to a large number of workers. It counts the proper amount of money to be placed in each envelope meant for each worker and fills the envelope. It may also make the required calculations. Then, there are intercommunication Machines which help in consultation among different members of that staff without leaving their seats. They save time and help in quick discussion and consultation among them.

APPLICATION SOFTWARE

Application software is a subclass of computer software that employs the capabilities of a computer directly and thoroughly to a task that the user wishes to perform.

This should be contrasted with system software which is involved in integrating a computer's various capabilities, but typically does not directly apply them in the performance of tasks that benefit the user. In this context the term application refers to both the application software and its implementation. A simple, if imperfect analogy in the world of hardware would be the relationship of an electric light bulb to an electric power generation plant.

The power plant merely generates electricity, not itself of any real use until harnessed to an application like the electric light that performs a service that benefits the user. Typical examples of software applications are word processors, spreadsheets, and media players. Multiple applications bundled together as a package are sometimes referred to as an application suite.

Some might bundle together a word processor, a spreadsheet, and several other discrete applications.

The separate applications in a suite usually have a user interface that has some commonality making it easier for the user to learn and use each application.

And often they may have some capability to interact with each other in ways beneficial to the user.

For example, a spreadsheet might be able to be embedded in a word processor document even though it had been created in the separate spreadsheet application. User-written software tailors systems to meet the user's specific needs. User-written software include spreadsheet templates, word processor macros, scientific simulations, graphics and animation scripts.

HARDWARE

All the elements that go together to make up a PC fall into one of two categories, hardware or software. This section is about hardware, the stuff upon which software runs.

One of the definitions of 'hardware' according to Webster's dictionary is 'major items of equipment or their components used for a particular purpose'.

Everything you can see and touch in your PC is hardware. Complete PCs can be purchased for about \$300 today, and the prices keep falling! All the items that make up a PC can be purchased individually at computer or web supply stores.

PRINTER

A printer is a piece of hardware for a computer. It is a device that must be connected to a computer which allows a user to print items on paper, such as letters and pictures. It can also work with digital cameras to print directly without the use of a computer.

TYPES OF PRINTER

Today, the following types of printers are in regular use:

- Inkjet printers, also sometimes called *bubble jet printers* use coloured ink they put on a paper.
- Plotters are large format inkjet printers, or printers that use special pens.
- Laser printers transfer tiny particles of toner onto the paper.
- Dot-matrix printers are now almost extinct. They used a ribbon and made a lot of noise. There were models with 9 pins and models with 24 pins.

- Dye sublimation printers produce very high quality images. Three colours are used. Cyan, Magenta and Yellow. Each colour is printed one at a time from celophane sheets. The image is sealed with a clear top layer. Some small photographic printers made by Kodak and Canon use this process

HARD DISK DRIVE

The hard disk drive is the main, and usually largest, data storage device in a computer. The operating system, software titles and most other files are stored in the hard disk drive.

The hard disk drive is also known as:

- HDD, hard drive, hard disk, fixed drive, fixed disk, fixed disk drive

Important Hard Disk Drive Facts:

- The hard drive is sometimes referred to as the “C: drive” due to the fact that Microsoft Windows designates the “C” drive letter to the primary partition on the primary hard drive in a computer by default. While this is not a very technically correct term to use, it is still common. For example, some computers have multiple drive letters representing areas across one or more hard drives.

Hard Disk Drive Description:

- A hard drive is usually the size of a paperback book but much heavier. The sides of the hard drive have pre drilled, threaded holes for easy mounting in the 3.5 inch drive bay in the computer case. Mounting is also possible in a larger 5.25 inch drive bay with an adapter available at computer supply stores. The hard drive is mounted so the end with the connections faces inside the computer. The back end of the hard drive contains a port for a cable that connects to the motherboard. The type of cable used will depend on the type of drive but is almost always included with a hard drive purchase. Also here is a connection for power from the power supply. Most hard drives also have jumper settings on the back end that define how the motherboard is to recognize the drive when more than one is present. These settings vary from drive to drive so check with your hard drive manufacturer for details.

FLASH DRIVE

A flash drive is a small storage device that can be used to transport files from one computer to another. They are slightly larger than a stick of gum, yet many of these devices can carry all your homework for an entire year! You can keep one on a key chain, carry it around your neck, or attach it to your book bag.

USING A FLASH DRIVE

A flash drive is easy to use. Once you have created a paper or other work, simply plug your flash drive into a USB port. The USB port will appear on the back of a

desktop computer's PC tower or on the side of a laptop. Most computers are set up to give an audible notice such as a chime when a new device is plugged in. This is normal.

When you option to save your work by selecting "Save As," you will find that your flash drive appears as an additional drive.

WHY CARRY A FLASH DRIVE?

You should always carry a backup copy of any important work you've completed. As you create a paper or large project, make a backup on your flash drive and save it separate from your computer.

A flash drive will also come in handy if you are able to print out homework at school. You can write a paper at home, save it to your flash drive, then plug the drive into a USB port on a school computer. Then simply open the document and print it out. Check with your teacher or librarian to see if this is an option.

A flash drive is also handy for working on your paper or project on several computers at once. Carry your flash drive to your friend's house for a joint project or for group study.

Another reason to use a flash drive is that they are sturdier than floppy disks. A flash drive will survive teenage abusers much more successfully than floppy disks or CDs.

STORED PROGRAMME ARCHITECTURE

The defining feature of modern computers which distinguishes them from all other machines is that they can be programmed. That is to say that a list of instructions can be given to the computer and it will store them and carry them out at some time in the future.

In most cases, computer instructions are simple: add one number to another, move some data from one location to another, send a message to some external device, etc. These instructions are read from the computer's memory and are generally carried out in the order they were given.

However, there are usually specialized instructions to tell the computer to jump ahead or backwards to some other place in the programme and to carry on executing from there. These are called "jump" instructions. Furthermore, jump instructions may be made to happen conditionally so that different sequences of instructions may be used depending on the result of some previous calculation or some external event.

Many computers directly support subroutines by providing a type of jump that "remembers" the location it jumped from and another instruction to return to the instruction following that jump instruction.

Programme execution might be likened to reading a book. While a person will normally read each word and line in sequence, they may at times jump back to an earlier place in the text or skip sections that are not of interest. Similarly, a computer may sometimes go back and repeat the instructions in some section of the programme

over and over again until some internal condition is met. This is called the flow of control within the programme and it is what allows the computer to perform tasks repeatedly without human intervention. Comparatively, a person using a pocket calculator can perform a basic arithmetic operation such as adding two numbers with just a few button presses. But to add together all of the numbers from 1 to 1,000 would take thousands of button presses and a lot of time—with a near certainty of making a mistake. On the other hand, a computer may be programmed to do this with just a few simple instructions.

For example:

```
mov #0,sum; set sum to 0
mov #1,num; set num to 1
loop: add num,sum; add num to sum
add #1,num; add 1 to num
cmp num,#1000; compare num to 1000
ble loop; if num <= 1000, go back to 'loop'
halt; end of programme. stop running
```

Once told to run this programme, the computer will perform the repetitive addition task without further human intervention. It will almost never make a mistake and a modern PC can complete the task in about a millionth of a second.

However, computers cannot “think” for themselves in the sense that they only solve problems in exactly the way they are programmed to.

An intelligent human faced with the task might soon realise that instead of actually adding up all the numbers one can simply use the equation,

$$1 + 2 + 3 + \dots + n = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$$

and arrive at the correct answer with little work. In other words, a computer programmed to add up the numbers one by one as in the example would do exactly that without regard to efficiency or alternative solutions.

Programmes

In practical terms, a computer programme may be just a few instructions or extend to many millions of instructions, as do the programmes for word processors and web browsers for example. A typical modern computer can execute billions of instructions per second and rarely make a mistake over many years of operation.

Large computer programmes consisting of several million instructions may take teams of programmers years to write, and due to the complexity of the task almost certainly contain errors. Errors in computer programmes are called “bugs”. Bugs may be benign and not affect the usefulness of the programme, or have only subtle effects.

But in some cases they may cause the programme to “hang”—become unresponsive to input such as mouse clicks or keystrokes, or to completely fail or “crash”. Otherwise

benign bugs may sometimes may be harnessed for malicious intent by an unscrupulous user writing an “exploit”—code designed to take advantage of a bug and disrupt a computer’s proper execution.

Bugs are usually not the fault of the computer. Since computers merely execute the instructions they are given, bugs are nearly always the result of programmer error or an oversight made in the program’s design.

In most computers, individual instructions are stored as machine code with each instruction being given a unique number. The command to add two numbers together would have one opcode, the command to multiply them would have a different opcode and so on.

The simplest computers are able to perform any of a handful of different instructions; the more complex computers have several hundred to choose from—each with a unique numerical code. Since the computer’s memory is able to store numbers, it can also store the instruction codes.

This leads to the important fact that entire programmes can be represented as lists of numbers and can themselves be manipulated inside the computer in the same way as numeric data. The fundamental concept of storing programmes in the computer’s memory alongside the data they operate on is the crux of the von Neumann, or stored programme, architecture.

In some cases, a computer might store some or all of its programme in memory that is kept separate from the data it operates on. This is called the Harvard architecture after the Harvard Mark I computer. Modern von Neumann computers display some traits of the Harvard architecture in their designs, such as in CPU caches.

While it is possible to write computer programmes as long lists of numbers and while this technique was used with many early computers, it is extremely tedious and potentially error-prone to do so in practice, especially for complicated programmes. Instead, each basic instruction can be given a short name that is indicative of its function and easy to remember—a mnemonic such as ADD, SUB, MULT or JUMP.

These mnemonics are collectively known as a computer’s assembly language. Converting programmes written in assembly language into something the computer can actually understand is usually done by a computer programme called an assembler.

Machine languages and the assembly languages that represent them tend to be unique to a particular type of computer. For instance, an ARM architecture computer cannot understand the machine language of an Intel Pentium or the AMD Athlon 64 computer that might be in a PC.

Though considerably easier than in machine language, writing long programmes in assembly language is often difficult and is also error prone. Therefore, most practical programmes are written in more abstract high-level programming languages that are able to express the needs of the programmer more conveniently.

High level languages are usually “compiled” into machine language using another computer programme called a compiler. High level languages are less related to the

workings of the target computer than assembly language, and more related to the language and structure of the problem(s) to be solved by the final programme.

It is therefore often possible to use different compilers to translate the same high level language programme into the machine language of many different types of computer. This is part of the means by which software like video games may be made available for different computer architectures such as personal computers and various video game consoles.

The task of developing large software systems presents a significant intellectual challenge. Producing software with an acceptably high reliability within a predictable schedule and budget has historically been difficult; the academic and professional discipline of software engineering concentrates specifically on this challenge.

FUNCTION

A general purpose computer has four main components: the arithmetic logic unit (ALU), the control unit, the memory, and the input and output devices. These parts are interconnected by busses, often made of groups of wires.

Inside each of these parts are thousands to trillions of small electrical circuits which can be turned off or on by means of an electronic switch. Each circuit represents a bit of information so that when the circuit is on it represents a “1”, and when off it represents a “0”. The circuits are arranged in logic gates so that one or more of the circuits may control the state of one or more of the other circuits.

The control unit, ALU, registers, and basic I/O are collectively known as a central processing unit. Early CPUs were composed of many separate components but since the mid-1970s CPUs have typically been constructed on a single integrated circuit called a *microprocessor*.

Control Unit

The control unit manages the computer’s various components; it reads and interprets the programme instructions, transforming them into a series of control signals which activate other parts of the computer. Control systems in advanced computers may change the order of some instructions so as to improve performance.

A key component common to all CPUs is the programme counter, a special memory cell that keeps track of which location in memory the next instruction is to be read from.

The control system’s function is as follows—note that this is a simplified description, and some of these steps may be performed concurrently or in a different order depending on the type of CPU:

- Read the code for the next instruction from the cell indicated by the programme counter.
- Decode the numerical code for the instruction into a set of commands or signals for each of the other systems.

- Increment the programme counter so it points to the next instruction.
- Read whatever data the instruction requires from cells in memory. The location of this required data is typically stored within the instruction code.
- Provide the necessary data to an ALU or register.
- If the instruction requires an ALU or specialized hardware to complete, instruct the hardware to perform the requested operation.
- Write the result from the ALU back to a memory location or to a register or perhaps an output device.

Since the programme counter is just another set of memory cells, it can be changed by calculations done in the ALU. Adding 100 to the programme counter would cause the next instruction to be read from a place 100 locations further down the programme. Instructions that modify the programme counter are often known as "jumps" and allow for loops and often conditional instruction execution.

It is noticeable that the sequence of operations that the control unit goes through to process an instruction is in itself like a short computer programme-and indeed, in some more complex CPU designs, there is another yet smaller computer called a microsequencer that runs a microcode programme that causes all of these events to happen.

Arithmetic/logic Unit (ALU)

The ALU is capable of performing two classes of operations: arithmetic and logic.

The set of arithmetic operations that a particular ALU supports may be limited to adding and subtracting or might include multiplying or dividing, trigonometry functions and square roots.

Some can only operate on whole numbers whilst others use floating point to represent real numbers-albeit with limited precision. However, any computer that is capable of performing just the simplest operations can be programmed to break down the more complex operations into simple steps that it can perform.

Therefore, any computer can be programmed to perform any arithmetic operation-although it will take more time to do so if its ALU does not directly support the operation. An ALU may also compare numbers and return boolean truth values depending on whether one is equal to, greater than or less than the other. Logic operations involve Boolean logic: AND, OR, XOR and NOT. These can be useful both for creating complicated conditional statements and processing boolean logic.

Superscalar computers may contain multiple ALUs so that they can process several instructions at the same time. Graphics processors and computers with SIMD and MIMD features often provide ALUs that can perform arithmetic on vectors and matrices.

Memory

A computer's memory can be viewed as a list of cells into which numbers can be placed or read. Each cell has a numbered "address" and can store a single number. The

computer can be instructed to “put the number 123 into the cell numbered 1357” or to “add the number that is in cell 1357 to the number that is in cell 2468 and put the answer into cell 1595”. The information stored in memory may represent practically anything. Letters, numbers, even computer instructions can be placed into memory with equal ease. Since the CPU does not differentiate between different types of information, it is the software’s responsibility to give significance to what the memory sees as nothing but a series of numbers.

In almost all modern computers, each memory cell is set up to store binary numbers in groups of eight bits. Each byte is able to represent 256 different numbers; either from 0 to 255 or -128 to +127. To store larger numbers, several consecutive bytes may be used.

When negative numbers are required, they are usually stored in two’s complement notation. Other arrangements are possible, but are usually not seen outside of specialized applications or historical contexts. A computer can store any kind of information in memory if it can be represented numerically. Modern computers have billions or even trillions of bytes of memory.

The CPU contains a special set of memory cells called registers that can be read and written to much more rapidly than the main memory area. There are typically between two and one hundred registers depending on the type of CPU. Registers are used for the most frequently needed data items to avoid having to access main memory every time data is needed. As data is constantly being worked on, reducing the need to access main memory greatly increases the computer’s speed.

Computer main memory comes in two principal varieties: random-access memory or RAM and read-only memory or ROM. RAM can be read and written to anytime the CPU commands it, but ROM is pre-loaded with data and software that never changes, so the CPU can only read from it. ROM is typically used to store the computer’s initial start-up instructions. In general, the contents of RAM are erased when the power to the computer is turned off, but ROM retains its data indefinitely.

In a PC, the ROM contains a specialized programme called the BIOS that orchestrates loading the computer’s operating system from the hard disk drive into RAM whenever the computer is turned on or reset. In embedded computers, which frequently do not have disk drives, all of the required software may be stored in ROM. Software stored in ROM is often called firmware, because it is notionally more like hardware than software. Flash memory blurs the distinction between ROM and RAM, as it retains its data when turned off but is also rewritable. It is typically much slower than conventional ROM and RAM however, so its use is restricted to applications where high speed is unnecessary.

In more sophisticated computers there may be one or more RAM cache memories which are slower than registers but faster than main memory. Generally computers with this sort of cache are designed to move frequently needed data into the cache automatically, often without the need for any intervention on the programmer’s part.

Input/output (I/O)

I/O is the means by which a computer exchanges information with the outside world. Devices that provide input or output to the computer are called peripherals. On a typical personal computer, peripherals include input devices like the keyboard and mouse, and output devices such as the display and printer. Hard disk drives, floppy disk drives and optical disc drives serve as both input and output devices. Computer networking is another form of I/O. Often, I/O devices are complex computers in their own right with their own CPU and memory. A graphics processing unit might contain fifty or more tiny computers that perform the calculations necessary to display 3D graphics. Modern desktop computers contain many smaller computers that assist the main CPU in performing I/O.

Multitasking

While a computer may be viewed as running one gigantic programme stored in its main memory, in some systems it is necessary to give the appearance of running several programmes simultaneously. This is achieved by multitasking i.e. having the computer switch rapidly between running each programme in turn.

One means by which this is done is with a special signal called an interrupt which can periodically cause the computer to stop executing instructions where it was and do something else instead.

By remembering where it was executing prior to the interrupt, the computer can return to that task later. If several programmes are running “at the same time”, then the interrupt generator might be causing several hundred interrupts per second, causing a programme switch each time. Since modern computers typically execute instructions several orders of magnitude faster than human perception, it may appear that many programmes are running at the same time even though only one is ever executing in any given instant. This method of multitasking is sometimes termed “time-sharing” since each programme is allocated a “slice” of time in turn.

Before the era of cheap computers, the principle use for multitasking was to allow many people to share the same computer. Seemingly, multitasking would cause a computer that is switching between several programmes to run more slowly — in direct proportion to the number of programmes it is running. However, most programmes spend much of their time waiting for slow input/output devices to complete their tasks.

If a programme is waiting for the user to click on the mouse or press a key on the keyboard, then it will not take a “time slice” until the event it is waiting for has occurred. This frees up time for other programmes to execute so that many programmes may be run at the same time without unacceptable speed loss.

Multiprocessing

Some computers are designed to distribute their work across several CPUs in a multiprocessing configuration, a technique once employed only in large and powerful

machines such as supercomputers, mainframe computers and servers. Multiprocessor and multi-core personal and laptop computers are now widely available, and are being increasingly used in lower-end markets as a result.

Supercomputers in particular often have highly unique architectures that differ significantly from the basic stored-programme architecture and from general purpose computers. They often feature thousands of CPUs, customised high-speed interconnects, and specialized computing hardware. Such designs tend to be useful only for specialized tasks due to the large scale of programme organization required to successfully utilize most of the available resources at once. Supercomputers usually see usage in large-scale simulation, graphics rendering, and cryptography applications, as well as with other so-called “embarrassingly parallel” tasks.

Networking and the Internet

Computers have been used to coordinate information between multiple locations since the 1950s. The U.S. military’s SAGE system was the first large-scale example of such a system, which led to a number of special-purpose commercial systems like Sabre. In the 1970s, computer engineers at research institutions throughout the United States began to link their computers together using telecommunications technology. This effort was funded by ARPA and the computer network that it produced was called the ARPANET. The technologies that made the Arpanet possible spread and evolved.

In time, the network spread beyond academic and military institutions and became known as the Internet. The emergence of networking involved a redefinition of the nature and boundaries of the computer. Computer operating systems and applications were modified to include the ability to define and access the resources of other computers on the network, such as peripheral devices, stored information, and the like, as extensions of the resources of an individual computer.

Initially these facilities were available primarily to people working in high-tech environments, but in the 1990s the spread of applications like e-mail and the World Wide Web, combined with the development of cheap, fast networking technologies like Ethernet and ADSL saw computer networking become almost ubiquitous. In fact, the number of computers that are networked is growing phenomenally. A very large proportion of personal computers regularly connect to the Internet to communicate and receive information. “Wireless” networking, often utilizing mobile phone networks, has meant networking is becoming increasingly ubiquitous even in mobile computing environments.

COMPONENTS OF A COMPUTER SYSTEM

We all know that computers are complex devices, machines made out of an amalgam of electronic parts and components. But which computer components are essential for

a computer to run? Modern PCs can still function fully without Bluetooth or a floppy disk drive. Here is a list of computer components that a computer system cannot do without.

MOTHERBOARD

The motherboard is a very basic unit in any computer system. This is the computer component to which all other internal computer components are attached. It links all the other main components of a computer system together. Consequently, motherboards are sometimes referred to as the “heart” of a computer system.

CPU

The central processing unit or CPU is the computer component responsible for running programmes and applications on the computer. Without a CPU in your computer, you will not be able to do any tasks — you cannot boot to an operating system, you cannot play music, videos and games, and you cannot do any word processing. For a computer to function, it has to have a CPU.

RAM

Random Access Memory or RAM is another vital computer component. It is the storage media where a computer temporarily stores files and information that it can pull at random when running programmes and applications. Together with the CPU, RAM determines the computer’s speed. A computer with a large RAM and a mediocre CPU can actually run faster than a computer with a powerful CPU but low RAM.

HDD

As opposed to the RAM, the hard disk drive or HDD stores computer files and data long-term. Even without power, the hard drive still retains the files stored inside it.

The hard drive can store important system files like the operating system, programme files and other data. It can also be used to store mp3s and videos. If the computer runs out of RAM, it will temporarily use the hard drive as a virtual memory bank.

VIDEO CARD

A video card allows a computer to display images on the computer monitor. It helps speed up the rendering of images onscreen and contributes to clearer and detailed pictures. PC gamers and multimedia software users will find a high-end dedicated graphics card helpful in running graphics-intensive programmes smoothly.

PSU

The power supply unit or PSU supplies all computer components with power. It converts the high voltages from an AC power outlet to lower voltages that are safe for internal computer components. Without a PSU, a computer and its components will not

be able to power up. A computer can also benefit from an optical drive to read and play CDs and DVDs, a network card and router for connecting to the Internet, and peripheral devices such as printers and scanners.

The motherboard, CPU, RAM, HDD, video card and PSU are, however, the main components that make up a computer system.

CONTROL UNIT

A control unit is one of the two components of the central processing unit. The function of the control unit is to extract information which is stored in the memory and to decode and execute those instructions.

It also takes help from the arithmetic logic unit, whenever required. The control unit is very important for computers functioning.

The control unit has outputs which take charge of the activities of the entire device. Some regard the control unit to be an FSM or finite state machine which is used for hardware and software applications.

Control Unit and Microprogram

There was a time when the manufacturing of control units was a difficult process, especially in designing it. But today the scenario has changed.

A control unit is executed in the form of microprograms which remain in control stores. There is a micro sequencer which chooses the words and certain portions of those words which directly manage the various computer parts. These parts are arithmetic and logic units, buses, instruction registers, registers and input/output. Today the latest computers may possess subsidiary controllers for every subsystem, which would be supervised by the main control unit.

Functions of Control Unit

A control unit can be described as a sort of circuitry that supervises and controls the path of information that runs over the processor and organizes the various activities of those units that lie inside it.

- It carries out many tasks such as decoding, fetching, handling the execution and finally storing the results.
- It controls the execution of instructions in a sequential order.
- It guides the flow of data through the different parts of the computer.
- It interprets the instructions.
- It regulates the time controls of the processor.

INPUT/OUTPUT

In computing, input/output, or I/O, refers to the communication between an information processing system and the outside world possibly a human, or another information processing system. Inputs are the signals or data received by the system,

and outputs are the signals or data sent from it. The term can also be used as part of an action; to “perform I/O” is to perform an input or output operation. I/O devices are used by a person to communicate with a computer.

For instance, a keyboard or a mouse may be an input device for a computer, while monitors and printers are considered output devices for a computer. Devices for communication between computers, such as modems and network cards, typically serve for both input and output.

Note that the designation of a device as either input or output depends on the perspective. Mouse and keyboards take as input physical movement that the human user outputs and convert it into signals that a computer can understand. The output from these devices is input for the computer.

Similarly, printers and monitors take as input signals that a computer outputs. They then convert these signals into representations that human users can see or read.

For a human user the process of reading or seeing these representations is receiving input. These interactions between computers and humans is studied in a field called human–computer interaction. In computer architecture, the combination of the CPU and main memory is considered the brain of a computer, and from that point of view any transfer of information from or to that combination, for example to or from a disk drive, is considered I/O.

The CPU and its supporting circuitry provide memory-mapped I/O that is used in low-level computer programming in the implementation of device drivers. An I/O algorithm is one designed to exploit locality and perform efficiently when data reside on secondary storage, such as a disk drive.

Interface

I/O Interface is required whenever the I/O device is driven by the processor. The interface must have necessary logic to interpret the device address generated by the processor. Handshaking should be implemented by the interface using appropriate commands like and the processor can communicate with I/O device through the interface.

If different data formats are being exchanged, the interface must be able to convert serial data to parallel form and vice-versa. There must be provision for generating interrupts and the corresponding type numbers for further processing by the processor if required

A computer that uses memory-mapped I/O accesses hardware by reading and writing to specific memory locations, using the same assembler language instructions that computer would normally use to access memory.

Higher-Level Implementation

Higher-level operating system and programming facilities employ separate, more abstract I/O concepts and primitives. For example, most operating systems provide application programmes with the concept of files. The C and C++ programming

languages, and operating systems in the Unix family, traditionally abstract files and devices as streams, which can be read or written, or sometimes both. The C standard library provides functions for manipulating streams for input and output.

In the context of the ALGOL 68 programming language, the *input* and *output* facilities are collectively referred to as *transput*. The *ALGOL 68* transput library recognizes the following standard files/devices: stand in, stand out, stand errors and stand back.

An alternative to special primitive functions is the I/O monad, which permits programmes to just describe I/O, and the actions are carried out outside the programme. This is notable because the I/O functions would introduce side-effects to any programming language, but now purely functional programming is practical.

Addressing Mode

There are many ways through which data can be read or stored in the memory. Each method is an addressing mode, and has its own advantages and limitations.

There are many type of addressing modes such as direct addressing, indirect addressing, immediate addressing, index addressing, based addressing, based-index addressing, implied addressing, etc.

Direct Address

In this type of address of the data is a part of the instructions itself. When the processor decodes the instruction, it gets the memory address from where it can be read/store the required information.

Here the Addr operand points to a memory location which holds the data and copies it into the specified Register.

Indirect Address

Here the address can be stored in a register. The instructions will have the register which has the address. So to fetch the data, the instruction must be decoded appropriate register selected. The contents of the register will be treated as the address using this address appropriate memory location is selected and data is read/written.

5

File and Records Management

FILE MANAGEMENT

The reason of good file management is to keep the paper flowing to its final destination. Piles of paper, are lost papers looking for a home! Creating a filing system that works for your LA is like finding the pot of gold at the end of a rainbow. A good filing system will organize your operations, enhance your professional image and increase productivity. When it comes to files and piles, people have three fears. Do any of these haunt you? Afraid to make a decision - If you don't know what to call a piece of paper, you'll end up calling it nothing. If it doesn't have a name, it doesn't get a home. Such orphans collect in unnamed stacks, piles, drawers and in boxes. Afraid to discard anything - You might need it someday. Better to keep it, even if you can't lay your hands on it when you need it.

Afraid you'll never see it again - Filing an item in some systems is like flinging it into a black hole. If that describes your system, stacks and piles are indeed a lot safer. The point of filing is, easy placement and access to information.

Definition

LA Record – Any document, paper, letter, book, map, photograph, sound or video recording, microfilm, magnetic tape, electronic medium or other information recording medium, regardless of physical form or characteristic and regardless of whether public access to it is open or restricted under laws of the province, created or received by a LA or any of its officers or employees pursuant to law, including bylaws, or in the transaction

of public business. This does not include convenience copies, blank forms, stocks of publications, or library or museum materials.

Essential (Vital) Record – Any LA record necessary for the resumption or continuation of government operations in an emergency or disaster, to the recreation of the legal and financial status of the government, or the protection and fulfilment of obligations to the people of the province.

Record Series – A group of records with the same function and the same retention period.

Retention era – The minimum time that must pass after the creation, recording, or receipt of a record, or the fulfilment of certain actions associated with a record, before it is eligible for destruction.

Records Control Schedule – Document prepared by or under the authority of the Records Management Officer listing the records maintained by a LA or elected office, their retention periods, and other records' disposition information that the records management programme in LA or elective office may require.

Records Retention Schedule – A document adopted by the LA Council in concert with provincial and national laws establishing mandatory retention periods for LA records.

Records Management – Application of techniques to the creation, use, maintenance, retention, preservation and disposal of records for reasons of reducing costs and improving efficiency of record keeping.

Records Retention Impression

Every LA must retain certain records in order to carry out business. One feature of a records retention process is a retention schedule, which provides guidelines for how long any document must be retained. There should be at least one individual in each LA whose primary responsibility is the recording, storing and management of all documents. This person becomes the Records Coordinator.

An implemented records retention programme provides significant benefits in the areas of economy and efficiency:

1. It provides certainty that no record is destroyed prematurely and that valuable and legally required records are retained in compliance with legal retention requirements within standard associational practices for the retention and destruction of records.
2. It enables authorized employees to destroy, with confidence, records no longer of value.
3. The elimination of obsolete records provides faster and more efficient retrieval of files.
4. It improves productivity through faster access to information.
5. The elimination of obsolete records cuts the cost of filing equipment and office space.
6. The elimination of obsolete records reduces the need and costs of off-site storage.

Steps to get better File Management

Separate Working from Archival Material – There are two basic types of files, temporary (working) and permanent (archival). Determining when and how often a file will be used should tell you which type it is. Temporary files include the following:

1. Action items - frequently used items requiring regular decisions and action.
2. Project items - plans, notes and documents related to current projects.
3. Reading items - must-read materials from any source.
4. Tickler files - organizing material for future use on a specific day.
5. Chronological file - tracking correspondence sequentially.

Label Working records – Label action, project and reading files by reason or function, e.g. Grants, Council Reports, Complaint Resolution. Use broad, generic headings that are meaningful to you. If the files are shared, the categories and headings must make sense to everyone involved. That may mean that all Administration files are labelled on the first line as Administration with a subheading of Agreements. The second line would identify who or which association the agreement is with. That means it would be filed in the master files under ADMINISTRATION. Anyone needing access to ADMINISTRATION files could look through a master index to see what is kept in that file drawer. Sub-headings under ADMINISTRATION could be Agreements, Forms, Policies, etc.

How the Retention Programme mechanism

Active records are retained within the department to ensure they are readily accessible. On a biannual basis, all records within a department or didream are reviewed to determine which records are no longer active. The inactive records are removed from the active files and organized into the following categories:

1. Inactive original documents, and
2. Inactive historical documents.

After the records have been boxed, prepare a complete index of the contents of each box. Include the following information in the index:

1. File Series (as stated in the Retention Schedule) to which the individual records belong.
2. Description of the individual records within the File Series. This description needs to contain sufficient information so that any person would know what the box contains. Do not use acronyms. Use simple language and provide as much detail as is necessary.
3. The dates of the earliest and latest records in the box.
4. Any other pertinent information that would be beneficial for locating the records.
5. Prepare a label for the box with a brief description of the contents. Put a number on the box.
6. Add the number of the box and the brief description to the index.

7. Make a copy of the index and place it inside the box and deliver the original of the index to the appropriate Records Coordinator.

Inactive Original papers – The retention period and destruction date for each inactive document is determined using an adopted Retention Schedule.

1. Locate the Retention Schedule entry for each type or group of documents.
2. Determine the Destruction Date based on the Retention Period and the date the documents were created.
3. Destruction Dates occurring in February through December are to be ‘rounded up’ to the following January. For example, similar documents created in July, August and December of 1995, and January of 1996 that have a two-year retention period would all have a Destruction Date of January 1998.
4. After determining the Retention Period and Destruction Date, combine files with like destruction dates in a standard box allowing a minimum of two inches of space to remain in a full box.
5. All documents in any box to be stored in inactive storage shall have the same destruction date under the current schedule.

Have the Records Coordinator (or designed) review the index and label information for accuracy and completeness of the description and destruction date. When this information has been verified, the box will be sent to secure storage. Each Records Coordinator maintains the master index lists for his/her department or didream. The Records Coordinator also administers retrieval and replacement of boxes of records from storage.

Inactive Historical papers – During the biannual review, identify inactive documents that have long-standing value as documents and contain important historical information. Transmit the original historical document to the Records Coordinator for placement in the archive. Place a copy of the document in the file to ensure the completeness of the file.

Auditing for fulfilment – At the end of the time set for each department’s review of their records, the Records Coordinator will provide the Department Manager with a report on the employees in that department and whether or not they completed the review.

The Department Manager will contact any employee who has not completed the review, encourage those employees to comply with the Policy, and continue to audit any lack of compliance. The Department Manager will take appropriate steps to ensure the compliance of all employees with the Policy.

Retrieval of Records in Storage – When inactive records are required, the Records Coordinator can arrange for the records to be retrieved from storage and delivered to the requesting department. Only the Records Coordinators and Department Managers are authorized to request retrieval of records and they can only make this request for records from their department. Completion of Retention Period and Destruction of Documents – Annually, the Records Coordinator will provide a list of all records that

have been retained for the required period and are due for destruction. The list will be circulated to all Department Heads including the Mayor or Chairman.

After approval of the Request for Destruction by the reviewing bodies, the corresponding boxes will be destroyed. A final report will be generated stating by what legal authority and method they were destroyed.

Microfilm, Electronic Files and Other Non-Paper Media – Review, storage, retrieval and return of records currently retained on micrographic or other non-paper media shall be carried out in the same manner as for records on paper.

Records currently retained on any non-paper media shall be reviewed by the employee responsible for the records of the department and sent to storage consistent with the instructions for paper records.

Records slated for destruction according to the Retention Schedule shall be deleted, erased or obliterated from the medium by proper methods for the particular medium. Documentation for the destruction of records on non-paper media shall be prepared and retained as with paper media records.

After all records contained on microfilm or microfiche have been destroyed, the film or fiche itself shall be destroyed. After all records contained on magnetic tape, disks, diskettes or other magnetic medium have been destroyed, they may be reused or recycled.

Preparation of Records for Microfilming or Transfer to Magnetic Tape – Certain records may be microfilmed or transferred to magnetic tape before the hard copies are destroyed, (according to the proposed destruction date, as per the Retention Schedule). Hard copies of records that are stated to be destroyed at the same time shall be transferred onto the same microfilm reel, microfiche, magnetic tape, or other magnetic media.

The records contained on such film, fiche, tape or other magnetic media shall eventually be destroyed at the appropriate time according to the Schedule in effect on the destruction date.

Efficiently Manage Office Paperwork

While we can and should have digital versions of almost every kind of paperwork, some must remain in hard copy to be considered valid. This includes any document that's notarized or carries another form of raised seal, and anything that needs to bear original signatures. But many experts — including attorneys, accountants and insurance agents — encourage us to keep hard copies of other documents as well, at least for a while:

- Tax returns and any related documentation should be kept for a minimum of three years, according to the IRS. Some exceptions apply, so check with your tax professional. Employment tax records should be kept for at least four years.
- Tax and legal pros suggest keeping paper and digital versions of anything related to taxes/finances, legal, employment, medical or insurance for at least

seven years. That includes bank and credit card statements, and receipts for large purchases to show precisely what you bought and that it was business related. This applies to contracts, agreements and other legal documents.

- And, really, you should keep at least a scanned copy of everything that doesn't fall into that special paper-only category we talked about earlier — forever. Why? Because the Tax Man can come calling pretty much anytime they please, and you want to have the documentation they need. So, in short, keep it all! (Get more specific guidance on what to keep or toss.)

Of course, that creates organization and storage problems. Here are seven tools to help you cope with the proliferation of paper and pixels:

1. *Printer:* Despite our desire to save trees and reduce eWaste, a printer is still an office necessity for when original documents are required. Choose models that are energy- and toner cartridge-efficient, and print only what's necessary.
2. *Scanner:* A scanner is invaluable in taming the paper monster. "Scanned copies should generally be sufficient, but make sure you scan them correctly," cautions Anthony Criscuolo, CFP®, a financial planner and client services manager with Palisades Hudson Financial Group in Fort Lauderdale. "Ensure you can read all of the information from the document. All too often people quickly scan documents, but the pages feed in slanted and data gets lost, or double-sided pages only get scanned on the front. It's important to review your scans and compare to the original data. You don't want to wait until you're in the middle of an IRS audit to realize your scanner skipped a page somehow and you're missing the data you need." Bonus tip: Consider adding passwords to electronic documents that contain sensitive information.
3. *Filing Systems:* An effective filing system is mission critical. Most people choose flat or vertical filing cabinets and color-coded or otherwise structured file folders to keep things in order and easy to find. A professional organizer can help you figure out a system that works for you and your records. You can also stash flash drives here.
4. *Digital Camera:* If you're on the go, a digital camera — or the camera on your cell phone — makes it easy to snap photos of receipts and documents on the fly. "Once you've captured them, recording them and creating reports just take a few more steps. If you record and store all your receipts electronically, you won't have to create a contingency plan for lost documentation," says David Ehrenberg, founder and CEO of Early Growth Financial Services in San Jose, CA.
5. *Data Storage:* Digital documents should be stored on your business computer network (network-attached storage), on a separate hard drive or in the cloud. Back up these files regularly. "I've seen hard drives crash, and hurricanes and other random acts of God prevent people from accessing their documents," says Vincenzo Villamena, a CPA and managing partner with New York-based

boutique CPA firm Online Taxman. “If you have everything on electronic file, backed up and stored so that it can survive an apocalypse, you will be fine.”

6. *Shredder*: “Definitely shred items containing financial information and account numbers, but only shred records after scanning them,” says JeFreda Brown, CEO of Pinson, AL-based Goshen Business Group. It’s a good idea to shred medical records, too. “Even though the legal requirement is to retain hard copy records for a certain amount of time and then dispose of them, I still would recommend converting them to electronic records before shredding.”
7. *Lockbox or Safe*: And for those originals you just have to keep as paper, store them in your bank safe deposit box or invest in a fireproof lockbox or safe to ensure they survive a disaster, natural or otherwise. It’s a good idea to keep any external hard drives here, too.

You may think putting this much thought — and money — into keeping your files straight is overkill. But Criscuolo says poor record-keeping is a common error many small business owners make.

“Not being organized with documents throughout the year is a big mistake,” he says. “Establish a culture of organization and compliance so come tax time, all of the important documents are well organized, scanned and ready to be provided to the tax preparer. This should help avoid missing anything important such as items of income or deduction and should help keep costs down by making for an efficient tax process for your accountant.”

Manage Your Documents Effectively

Companies today create more content than ever before. Content production increased as businesses began to realize the full benefits of customer relationship management (CRM) systems, cloud storage, and other software as a service (SaaS) tools. Mobilized employees now leverage collaborative software to create on the spot presentations, while social media provides businesses with a steady stream of feedback from which business insights can be gleaned. What has resulted is a situation where companies find themselves awash with data. Companies, with a potential treasure trove of information at their disposal, now find it difficult to locate relevant content amongst the mass of files and folders. Indeed today’s knowledge worker wastes an outrageous amount of time searching for documents with weekly estimates ranging from 6.5 to 8.8 hours per week. Amidst widespread data retrieval issues, the need for effective document management has never been greater.

Document Management Software

The failure of traditional file and folder structures to effectively manage today’s Big Data has highlighted the need for document management software. The sheer volume of content that companies have at their disposal has rendered naming convention programs ineffective. It has become clear that the solution to document management

issues lies in effective use of technology. However, companies have an important decision to make about the type of document management system to employ. Software that requires employees to manually tag each individual file or folder is not a realistic document management solution. In today's rapid-paced business world, speed is of the essence. A document manager that disrupts employee workflow has no place in this hectic environment. Similarly, the age of asset management tools that require a separate upload as content is created is coming to a close. The multifaceted nature of business today means knowledge workers already utilize a multitude of enterprise tools and SaaS solutions. With content stored in a variety of locations, it is no longer practical for employees to perform a separate upload to a specifically-purposed document management system.

Document Management Best Practices

To bring real value to an enterprise, document management software must adapt to the already established business processes. For a document management system to succeed it must integrate seamlessly with other enterprise solutions to create a leaner, more effective workflow. Such is the extent of the document management problem that selection of the correct tool to tackle this issue has become vital.

The successful implementation of document management software can have wide-ranging benefits across a company. An effective document management solution can revolutionize workflow, increase productivity, and even facilitate sales enablement at a company. Alternatively, Chief Information Officers (CIOs) or other strategic decision makers who introduce a document management software solution that fails to deliver the anticipated benefits may pay for it with their jobs. With the increasingly important document management software selection process in mind, we have developed a number of best practices to guide companies towards successful document management.

Document Management Pain Points

The first step in successful document management software implementation is an identification of the specific document-related needs within the organization that needs addressing. Organizational efficiency may be hampered by the time employees spend searching for information.

Perhaps the current document management solution is proving particularly costly or employees could be struggling to collaborate effectively amidst the mass of files and folders. Whatever the particular document management pain point is within an organization, the first step towards a solution is an explicitly stated identification of the issues document management software can solve.

Document Management Goals

The next step in effective document management software implementation is to create a set of goals which the project must meet to be deemed a success.

Document management goals might include a decrease in document searching time, improved collaborative efforts, and high adoption rates within the user group. Companies may also set compliance goals such as meeting industry standard storage regulations.

Document Management System Requirements

Before companies select their document management software solution, they should outline a set of requirements the software should meet. Effective document management software should include a search function, be mobile accessible, enhance employee collaboration, meet industry security standards, and integrate seamlessly with other enterprise tools.

Document Search

Research has shown that effective search trumps organization. As content and media libraries have increased, the importance of effective document search has grown. CIOs should think twice before selecting an enterprise document management solution that does not come equipped with a search feature that not only crawls files by name but also searches within the documents themselves for relevant information.

Mobile Access

With an increasingly mobile workforce, a locally installed electronic data management solution will no longer suffice. Globally dispersed teams will also require instant collaborative access to content for a document management system to succeed within the organization.

Document Management Security

Security needs must not be overlooked when choosing a document management system. Companies must insist that industry standards are adhered to by their document management vendor. Anything less can put valuable company information in jeopardy. While the onus is on the vendor to ensure the security of company documents, CIOs and other strategic decision makers should insist on the highest document management security standards and simply refuse to deal with vendors who do not meet these standards.

Document Management Permission Settings

Companies should also make sure that any prospective document management software comes with easily administered permission settings. If not, CIOs must consider how much of a time commitment it will involve to establish the appropriate permissions on the document management software.

Integration

The final core requirement for CIOs to consider in the document management software selection process is how effectively any prospective solution can integrate with other

enterprise tools. The array of tools that employees have at their disposal today is such that any document management system that does not successfully integrate with other platforms will simply not receive the buy in from the user group to make it a success.

There are many factors for CIOs to consider before selecting a document management solution. While the selection process can be difficult, strategic decision-makers can maximize their chances of document management success by adhering to a set of minimum requirements.

Document Management Software Piloting

One of, if not the most important step in document management software implementation is the pilot process. CIOs should take the time to identify key pilot users who understand technology and workflow. If this group buys into the document management system, the CIO can count on a group of solution evangelists going forward. To measure the success of the piloted document management software, there should be a utilization report conducted on who is using the new system. The impact of the system can then be measured against the clearly stated document management goals. If the document management software is meeting expectations, the CIO can move on to the next step – winning executive buy in.

Executive Buy In

With a group of document management software evangelists ready to fight his corner, the CIO is well-placed for a successful implementation process. There is however one vitally important area of the company the CIO still must approach. The CIO should present the successfully piloted document management software solution before top company executives. CIOs can then demonstrate how key document management goals were achieved during the pilot process. With fact-based evidence of document management success, the CIO is best placed to win executive buy in.

Document Management Software Roll Out And Reporting

With executive support secured for a cloud based document management system, CIOs can begin the roll-out process and instigate regular follow up and reporting to accurately track the progress of the document management solution. Clear lines of communication between the CIO and the teams working with the recently implemented document management software is vital throughout this phase.

FILING Management

Preservation of letters, papers and important documents is an important part of office routine. It is necessary so that they may be easily available in future for reference. Preservation of such paper in an orderly manner is known as filing. Scientific filing is essential for every office but in practice it is not given due importance. Requirements of filing differ from concern to concern but it must be scientifically maintained. It may

be helpful to the concern in future in several ways. All the papers and important documents would remain safe and secure so that they may be easily traced when necessary. When there is a need for past records or formulation of policy, scientific filing helps in availability of relevant papers easily.

It may be useful in future for the purposes of testimony. It saves time which is lost in hunting for buried informations.

There are several methods which are used for filing the papers. Use of one or other method depends upon individual requirements.

We may discuss various methods under two heads: traditional system of filing; and modern system of filing.

Modern System of Filing

The traditional system of filing does not fulfil the requirements of the modern business houses, therefore, several modern devices have been adopted for filing the papers. The modern system of filing can be conveniently classified into two categories, viz., horizontal filing and vertical filing.

Traditional System of Filing

Several traditional or old methods of filing are still being used, specially by small concerns. In practice, five such systems of filing have been used:

- *Guard books* and *metal holders* have been used to the papers. In Guard books papers are pasted in chronological order and in other case the papers are held together by metal holders.
- *Spike filing* is one of the oldest methods under which documents are attached to the projecting metal spike rods which may be kept horizontally or vertically. Under this system also the papers do not remain safe.
- *Docketing or pigeon holding* is another old system of filing which is still used in Post Offices and some business concerns. Under this system, a cupboard with nest of pigeonholes is provided with labels pasted on them. The papers to be kept in them are folded and brief description about the contents is written over them known as “docket”. When the docketing for the day is completed, the documents are kept in the various pigeon-holes specified. This system is also not free from limitations and the papers are not maintained properly and safely. Moreover, this system is quite cumbersome for big offices which are required to handle large number of letters and other papers etc.
- *Box or pocket filing* is another traditional system of filing. Under this system, card-board boxes are used for filing the papers. Spring clips are fitted in the boxes to hold the papers together. These boxes are normally 3 to 4 inches deep. They protect files from dust and damage but they cannot be used for keeping papers permanently specially when they get old, the security of the papers is lost.

- *Press copy book* is used by some concerns. Under this system, all letters which are to be despatched are copied out in a book. This is very helpful in future as an evidence for the letters despatched. The books may be classified either on geographical or alphabetical order in case of large concerns.

Horizontal Filing

Under this system, the papers are kept in files horizontally or, say, one over other. For this cardboard covers or drawers are used and specially designed cabinets may also be used. The horizontal files may be of two types:

- (a) flat files, with loose sheet system, and
 - (b) lever files with lever-arch system.
- (a) *Flat Files*: Under this system, the papers are first punched and then inserted in the files with two metal hinges. Separate files are maintained either for each customer or for each subject. As a matter of fact, this is an improved system of old box filing. It is defective in the sense that it is difficult to take out any particular paper. All the papers on the top of that particular paper have to be removed first before it may be withdrawn. But at the same time the papers are kept secured and can be traced easily. Further, the papers get arranged in a chronological order automatically. These files may be kept in the cupboard one over the other, but recently drawers have been introduced for the purpose. This has improved the security of the papers as well as files.
- (b) *Lever Files*: Under this system, files are made of thick cardboard containing levers. The paper which has to be filed is punched, then lever is moved upwards which opens the springs or metal arches. The paper is inserted therein and the lever is pressed down to fasten the paper. It is easier and more convenient to keep or remove papers from such files. If any paper is to be taken out, all the papers on top of it need not be taken out as in case of flat files. “Era” files of cardboard type and “Shannon” files of cabinet type are examples of such files available in the market.

Vertical Filing

This is known as vertical filing because the papers are kept vertically or, say, in standing upright position under this system. This is the latest system of filing and it removes the defect of horizontal filing. The papers to-be kept are first inserted in the folders arranged in alphabetical or numerical order. The folders are then kept in cabinets with several drawers specially designed for the purpose. Each drawer is fitted with a wooden block or piece of metal for the purpose of holding the folders in compact form.

The drawer can be slid backward or forward. The index or guide cards with projecting tabs divide the folders in the desired way. This facilitates easy and rapid reference of any folder containing the relevant papers. Under this system, the papers remain secured and there is scope for expansion. It is economical also.

The Art of Filing

Have you ever kept a client or your boss waiting on the phone while you've searched the piles of papers on your desk for an important document? If you have, then your boss and your client may not have a good opinion of you, because in a key encounter, you've let them down.

And if it's your job to help people, how much of other people's time are you wasting if you can't find the documents and papers you need, when you need them?

You owe it to yourself to file effectively, however boring this may seem. Imagine how much more impressive it would have been if – when asked – you'd smiled, accessed a well-organized filing system, immediately found the document, and quickly given the answer!

Managing Time

Even in the age of email and the Internet, we still deal with many paper documents and files. There's a flurry of data pouring in from all directions that we need to process and, usually, store to retrieve later.

We want to be able to lay our hands on the information we need – at the right moment, when we need it – so it can be used for further analysis or report writing, or perhaps for creating a presentation.

All too often, though, we waste our own time (and often the time of other people) searching for data that's actually sitting somewhere on our desk or in an office filing cabinet. This adds to our stress, and makes the task of putting the data to use more difficult than it ought to be. So we need to get more organized and efficient with our file management if we're going to get our work done in a timely manner.

Managing Information Efficiently

When you receive a document from a co-worker, vendor, or customer, it's tempting to "just put it away" in a pile on your desk or drawer for the time being.

"Hmm. looks interesting, but I'll take a closer look at this later, when I've got more time." Sound familiar? After a while, many such documents build up, leading to a lot of clutter. It's highly unlikely that you'll ever find time to go back and get all of that information organized, especially considering that you're usually under pressure with other things.

You can spend hours of precious time searching for documents that you've filed away somewhere, because it's easy to forget where you put it – or even to forget that you have the document in the first place. So how can you go about simplifying your work? Get better at managing files.

Effective File Management

Effective filing boils down to this: store the information in folders – by category, and in a sequence that makes sense to you.

Here are some tips to help manage your files:

- Avoid saving unnecessary documents – Don't make a habit of saving everything that finds its way to you. Take a few seconds to glance through the content, and save a file only if it's relevant to your work activity. Having too many unnecessary documents adds to clutter and makes it harder to find things in the future. Be selective about what you keep!
- Follow a consistent method for naming your files and folders – For instance, divide a main folder into subfolders for customers, vendors, and co-workers. Give shortened names to identify what or whom the folders relate to. What's more, you can even give a different appearance or look to different categories of folders – this can make it easy to tell them apart at first glance.
- Store related documents together, whatever their type – For example, store reports, letters, presentation notes, spreadsheets, and graphics related to a particular project in a single folder – rather than having one folder for presentations for all projects, another folder for spreadsheets for all projects, and so forth. This way, it's much quicker to find documents for a particular project.
- Separate ongoing work from completed work – Some people prefer to keep current or ongoing work on their desk until a job is completed. Then, once it's done, they move it to the appropriate location, where files of the same category are stored. At periodic intervals (for example, weekly or every two weeks), move files you're no longer working on to the folders where your completed work is stored.
- Avoid overfilling folders – If you have a large number of files in one folder, or a large number of subfolders in a main folder, break them into smaller groups (subfolders or sub-subfolders). For instance, you can divide a folder called "Business Plan" into subfolders called "BP2008," "BP2009," and "BP2010." Likewise, you can divide a folder for a client named Delta Traders into subfolders named "Delta Traders sales presentations" and "Delta Traders contracts." The idea is to place every file into a logical folder or subfolder, rather than have one huge list of files.

Having said this, there is usually little point in creating a folder for fewer than about five documents.

- Make digital copies of paper documents with a scanner – This is useful if you don't have much space to store paper documents, or if you want to archive documents without destroying them completely. (This won't be appropriate for all types of documents, for example, with legal contracts or documents with original signatures. So use your best judgment here.)

Prioritizing Your Files for Action

Take these approaches further by customizing your file management. This can help you prioritize your work, which can lead to better efficiency.

- Organize documents by dates – Write a date on the document. This will help you organize your documents into date-order, without having to open the folder and read through all documents.
- Use “Tickler” files – Tickler files, also known as the “43 folders” method, are a unique system that’s used by many people for organizing files. Create 12 folders (one for each month of the year) and an additional 31 subfolders (for each day of the month). Fill each folder with the documents that you need to work with on that day. At the beginning of each day, open the folder for that day. Take all the items out of the folder and move them into a “today” folder or onto your desktop. Then move the empty folder into the corresponding slot for the next month. If you can’t complete some work items by the end of the day, transfer them to the folder for the next convenient day. This system of file management helps you keep track of everything you need to do, and it also doubles as a diary.

RECORDS MANAGEMENT

Records management (RM), also known as the records and information management or RIM, is the professional practice of managing the records of an organization throughout their life cycle, from the time they are created to their eventual disposal. This includes identifying, classifying, storing, securing, retrieving, tracking and destroying or permanently preserving records.

The purpose of records management is part of an organization’s broader function of Governance, Risk, and Compliance (or “GRC”) and is primarily concerned with the managing the evidence of an organization’s activities as well as the reduction or mitigation of risk associated with It.

An organization’s records preserve its corporate memory. In determining how long to retain records, their capacity for re-use is important. Many are simply kept as evidence of a transaction. Others document what happened and why.

A record is something that represents *proof of existence* and that can be used to recreate or prove state of existence, regardless of medium or characteristics. A record is either created or received by an organization in pursuance of or in compliance with legal obligations, or in the transaction of business. Records can be either tangible objects, such as paper documents like birth certificates, driver’s licenses, and physical medical x-rays, or digital information, such as electronic office documents, data in application databases, web site content, and electronic mail (email).

Current issues in records management

Compliance and legal issues

While public administration, healthcare and the legal profession have a long history of records management, the corporate sector has generally shown less interest. This has

changed in recent years due to new compliance requirements, driven in part by scandals such as the Enron/Andersen affair and more recent problems at Morgan Stanley. Corporate records compliance issues including retention period requirements and the need to disclose information as a result of litigation have come to be seen as important. Statutes such as the US Sarbanes-Oxley Act have resulted in greater standardization of records management practices. Since the 1990s the shift towards electronic records has seen a need for close working relations between records managers and IT managers, particularly including the legal aspects, focused on compliance and risk management.

Security

Privacy, data protection, and identity theft have become issues of increasing interest. The role of the records manager in the protection of an organization's records has grown as a result. The need to ensure personal information is not retained unnecessarily has brought greater focus to retention schedules and records disposal.

Transparency

The increased importance of transparency and accountability in public administration, marked by the widespread adoption of Freedom of Information laws, has led to a focus on the need to manage records so that they can be easily accessed by the public. For instance, in the United Kingdom, Section 46 of the Freedom of Information Act 2000 required the government to publish a Code of Practice on Records Management for public authorities. Similarly, European Union legislation on Data Protection and Environmental Information, requiring organisations to disclose information on request, create a need for effective management of such records.

Adoption and implementation

Implementing required changes to organisational culture is a major challenge, since records management is often seen as an unnecessary or low priority administrative task that can be performed at the lowest levels within an organization. Reputational damage caused by poor records management has demonstrated that records management is the responsibility of all individuals within an organization.

An issue that has been very controversial among records managers has been the uncritical adoption of Electronic document and records management systems (EDRMS). One well known RM thinker, Steve Bailey, has stated:

“As far as the average user is concerned, the EDRMS is something they didn't want, don't like and can't use. As such, its no wonder that so few users accept them – as one person once said to me “making me use an EDRMS is like asking a plasterer to use a hammer!””

“And now, finally, it is time to turn our eyes to the records management profession itself. In my opinion, we have come within a whisker of allowing our blind obsession with EDRMS to turn us into an intellectually-sterile, vendor-led profession. For the

best part of a decade we have allowed others to do the thinking for us and have come to rely on EDRMS as our intellectual-crutch. But make no mistake about it, the blame for this rests squarely with us. Like children following the Pied Piper, we allowed ourselves to be so enchanted by the tune being played that we were led, without question or debate, wherever the technology took us.” (RMS Debate: The case against EDRMS Has EDRMS been a success? The case for the prosecution, RMS Conference, Edinburgh 22 April 2.007)

Impact of internet and social Media

Another issue of great interest to records managers is the impact of the internet and related social media, such as wikis, blogs, forums, and companies such as Facebook and Twitter, on traditional records management practices, principles, and concepts, since many of these tools allow rapid creation and dissemination of records and, often, even in anonymous form.

Records life Cycle Management

A difficult challenge for many enterprises is tied to the tracking of records through their entire information life cycle so that it's clear, at all times, where a record exists or if it still exists at all. The tracking of records through their life cycles allows records management staff to understand when and how to apply records related rules, such as rules for legal hold or destruction.

Conversion of paper records to electronic Form

As the world becomes more digital in nature, an ever growing issue for the records management community is the conversion of existing or incoming paper records to electronic form. Such conversions are most often performed with the intent of saving storage costs, storage space, and in hopes of reducing records retrieval time.

Tools such as document scanners, optical character recognition software, and electronic document management systems are used to facilitate such conversions.

Education and Certification

Many colleges and universities offer degree programs in library and information sciences which cover records management. Furthermore, there are professional organizations such as the Records and Information Management Professionals Australasia (RIMPA) and the Institute of Certified Records Managers which provides a separate, non-degreed, professional certification for practitioners, the Certified Records Manager designation or CRM. Additional educational opportunities in the form of a certificate program are also available from AIIM International, ARMA, and from the Information and Records Management Society in Great Britain and Ireland. Education and training courses and workshops on scientific and technical records full life-cycle management and the Quality Electronic Records Practices Standards (Q-

ERPS) are available from the Collaborative Electronic Notebook Systems Association (CENSA). The University of South Australia offers a Graduate Certificate, a graduate diploma, and an MSc in Business Information Management and Library and Information Management with a specialist stream in records management. The Australian National University offer a six-week e-learning course worldwide, in Electronic Document and Records Management. In addition, Columbia University offers its Masters of Science in Information & Digital Resource Management (IDRM).

A recent addition to records management education in the United States is the MARA - Master of Archives and Records Administration degree program, offered by the San Jose State University School of Information. Another is the Archives and Records Management specialization offered by the University of Michigan School of Information as part of their MSI (Masters of Science in Information) degree. Wayne State University in Detroit offers an on-line Records and Information Management graduate level certification program.

Schools in Canada also provide specialized education opportunities in records management. The Faculty of Information at the University of Toronto allows students in the Master of Information program to concentrate their studies in Archives and Records Management.

The School of Information Studies at McGill University also includes an Archival Management stream that is enriched in records management coursework. The University of British Columbia offers a Masters of Archival Studies including a concentration in Records Management.

Electronic records management Systems

An Electronic Document and Records Management System (EDRM) is a computer program (or set of programs) used to track and store records. The term is distinguished from imaging and document management systems that specialize in paper capture and document management respectively. ERM systems commonly provide specialized security and auditing functionality tailored to the needs of records managers.

The National Archives and Records Administration (NARA) has endorsed the U.S. Department of Defense standard 5015.2 as an “adequate and appropriate basis for addressing the basic challenges of managing records in the automated environment that increasingly characterizes the creation and use of records.” Records Management Vendors can be certified as compliant with the DoD 5015.2-STD after verification from the Joint Interoperability Test Command which builds test case procedures, writes detailed and summary final reports on 5015.2-certified products, and performs on-site inspection of software.

The National Archives in the UK has published two sets of functional requirements to promote the development of the electronic records management software market (1999 and 2002). It ran a program to evaluate products against the 2002 requirements. While these requirements were initially formulated in collaboration with central

government, they have been taken up with enthusiasm by many parts of the wider public sector in the UK and in other parts of the world. The testing program has now closed; The National Archives is no longer accepting applications for testing. The National Archives 2002 requirements remain current.

The European Commission has published “MoReq”, the Model Requirements for Electronic Records and Document Management in 2001. Although not a formal standard, it is widely regarded and referred to as a standard. This was funded by the Commission’s IDA program, and was developed at the instigation of the DLM Forum. A major update of MoReq, known as MoReq2, was published in February 2008. This too was initiated by the DLM Forum and funded by the European Commission, on this occasion by its IDABC program (the successor to IDA). A software testing framework and an XML schema accompany MoReq2; a software compliance testing regime was agreed at the DLM Forum conference in Toulouse in December 2008.

The National Archives of Australia (NAA) published the Functional Specifications for Electronic Records Management Systems Software (ERMS), and the associated Guidelines for Implementing the Functional Specifications for Electronic Records Management Systems Software, as exposure drafts in February 2006.

Archives New Zealand published a ‘discretionary best practice’ Electronic Recordkeeping Systems Standard (Standard 5) in June 2005, issued under the authority of Section 27 of the Public Records Act 2005.

Commercial Records Centers

Commercial records centers are facilities which provide services for the storage for paper records for organizations. In some cases, they also offer storage for records maintained in electronic formats. Commercial records centers provide high density storage for paper records and some offer climate controlled storage for sensitive non-paper and critical (vital) paper media. There is a trade organization for commercial records centers (for example, PRISM International), however, not all service providers are members.

Key records management Terminology

Not all documents are records. A *record* is a document consciously retained as evidence of an action. Records management systems generally distinguish between records and non-records (convenience copies, rough drafts, duplicates), which do not need formal management. Many systems, especially for electronic records, require documents to be formally *declared as a record* so they can be managed. Once declared, a record cannot be changed and can only be disposed of within the rules of the system.

Records may be covered by *access controls* to regulate who can access them and under what circumstances. Physical controls may be used to keep confidential records secure - personnel files, for instance, which hold sensitive personal data, may be held in a locked cabinet with a control log to track access. Digital records systems may include

role-based access controls, allowing permissions (to view, change and/or delete) to be allocated to staff depending on their role in the organisation. An *audit trail* showing all access and changes can be maintained to ensure the integrity of the records.

Just as the records of the organization come in a variety of formats, the storage of records can vary throughout the organization. File maintenance may be carried out by the owner, designee, a records repository, or clerk. Records may be managed in a centralized location, such as a records center or repository, or the control of records may be decentralized across various departments and locations within the entity. Records may be formally and discretely identified by coding and housed in folders specifically designed for optimum protection and storage capacity, or they may be casually identified and filed with no apparent indexing. Organizations that manage records casually find it difficult to access and retrieve information when needed. The inefficiency of filing maintenance and storage systems can prove to be costly in terms of wasted space and resources expended searching for records.

An *inactive record* is a record that is no longer needed to conduct current business but is being preserved until it meets the end of its retention period, such as when a project ends, a product line is retired, or the end of a fiscal reporting period is reached.

These records may hold business, legal, fiscal, or historical value for the entity in the future and, therefore, are required to be maintained for a short or permanent duration. Records are managed according to the retention schedule. Once the life of a record has been satisfied according to its predetermined period and there are no legal holds pending, it is authorized for final disposition, which may include destruction, transfer, or permanent preservation.

A *disaster recovery plan* is a written and approved course of action to take after a disaster strikes that details how an organization will restore critical business functions and reclaim damaged or threatened records.

An *active record* is a record needed to perform current operations, subject to frequent use, and usually located near the user. In the past, 'records management' was sometimes used to refer only to the management of records which were no longer in everyday use but still needed to be kept - 'semi-current' or 'inactive' records, often stored in basements or offsite. More modern usage tends to refer to the entire 'lifecycle' of records - from the point of creation right through until their eventual disposal.

The ISO 15489-1: 2001 standard ("ISO 15489-1:2001") defines *records management* as "[the] field of management responsible for the efficient and systematic control of the creation, receipt, maintenance, use and disposition of records, including the processes for capturing and maintaining evidence of and information about business activities and transactions in the form of records".

The ISO 15489-1:2001 defines *records* as "information created, received, and maintained as evidence and information by an organization or person, in pursuance of legal obligations or in the transaction of business". While there are many purposes of and benefits to records management, as both these definitions highlight, a key feature

of records is their ability to serve as evidence of an event. Proper records management can help preserve this feature of records. It should be noted that the format and media of records is generally irrelevant for the purposes of records management from the perspective that records must be identified and managed, regardless of their form.

The ISO considers management of both physical and electronic records. Also, section DL1.105 of the United States Department of Defense standard DoD 5015.02-STD (2007) defines Records Management as *“the planning, controlling, directing, organizing, training, promoting, and other managerial activities involving the life cycle of information, including creation, maintenance (use, storage, retrieval), and disposal, regardless of media.”*

Practicing records Management

A Records Manager is someone who is responsible for records management in an organization.

ISO 15489-1:2001 states that records management includes:

- Setting policies and standards
- Assigning responsibilities and authorities
- Establishing and promulgating procedures and guidelines
- Providing a range of services relating to the management and use of records
- Designing, implementing and administering specialized systems for managing records
- Integrating records management into business systems and processes

Thus, the practice of records management may involve:

- Planning the information needs of an organization
- Identifying information requiring capture
- Creating, approving, and enforcing policies and practices regarding records, including their organization and disposal
- Developing a records storage plan, which includes the short and long-term housing of physical records and digital information
- Identifying, classifying, and storing records
- Coordinating access to records internally and outside of the organization, balancing the requirements of business confidentiality, data privacy, and public access.
- Executing a retention policy on the disposal of records which are no longer required for operational reasons; according to organizational policies, statutory requirements, and other regulations this may involve either their destruction or permanent preservation in an archive.

Records-management principles and automated records-management systems aid in the capture, classification, and ongoing management of records throughout their lifecycle. Such a system may be paper-based (such as index cards as used in a library), or may involve a computer system, such as an electronic records-management application.

Defensible Solutions

A *defensible solution* is one that can be supported with clearly documented policies, processes and procedures that drive how and why work is performed, as well as one that has clearly documented proof of behavior patterns, proving that an organization follows such documented constraints to the best of their ability.

While *defensibility* applies to all aspects of records life cycle, it is considered most important in the context of records destruction, where it is known as “*defensible disposition*” or “*defensible destruction*,” and helps an organization explicitly justify and prove things like who destroys records, why they destroy them, how they destroy them, when they destroy them, and where they destroy them.

Records life Cycle

The *records life cycle* (or *records lifecycle*) consists of discrete phases covering the life span of a record from its creation to its final disposition. In the creation phase, records growth is expounded by modern electronic systems. Records will continue to be created and captured by the organization at an explosive rate as it conducts the business of the organization. Correspondence regarding a product failure is written for internal leadership, financial statements and reports are generated for public and regulatory scrutiny, the old corporate logo is retired, and a new one – including color scheme and approved corporate font – takes its place in the organization’s history.

Examples of records phases include those for *creation* of a record, *modification* of a record, *movement* of a record through its different states while in existence, and *destruction* of a record.

Throughout the records life cycle, issues such as security, privacy, disaster recovery, emerging technologies, and mergers are addressed by the RIM professional responsible for organizational RIM programs. RIM professionals are instrumental in controlling and safeguarding the information assets of the entity. They understand how to manage the creation, access, distribution, storage, and disposition of records and information in an efficient and cost-effective manner using RIM methodology, principles, and best practices in compliance with records and information laws and regulations.

Records classification

Records managers use classification or categorization of record types as a means of working with records. Such classifications assist in functions such as creation, organization, storage, retrieval, movement, and destruction of records.

At the highest level of classification are physical versus electronic records. Physical records are those records, such as paper, that can be touched and which take up physical space.

Electronic records, also often referred to as digital records, are those records that are generated with and used by information technology devices. Classification of records is achieved through the design, maintenance, and application of taxonomies, which

allow records managers to perform functions such as the categorization, tagging, segmenting, or grouping of records according to various traits.

Enterprise records

Enterprise records represent those records that are common to most enterprises, regardless of their function, purpose, or sector. Such records often revolve around the day-to-day operations of an enterprise and cover areas such as but not limited litigation, employee management, consultant or contractor management, customer engagements, purchases, sales, and contracts.

The types of enterprises that generate and work with such records include but are not limited to for-profit companies, non-profit companies, and government agencies.

Industry records

Industry records represent those records that are common and apply only to a specific industry or set of industries. Examples include but are not limited to medical industry specific records (e.g. HIPAA), pharmaceutical industry specific records, and food industry specific records.

Legal hold records

Legal hold records are those records that are mandated, usually by legal counsel or compliance personnel, to be held for a period of time, either by a government or by an enterprise, and for the purposes of addressing potential issues associated with compliance audits and litigation. Such records are assigned *Legal Hold* traits that are in addition to classifications which are as a result of enterprise or industry classifications.

Legal hold data traits may include but are not limited to things such as legal hold flags (e.g. Legal Hold = True or False), the organization driving the legal hold, descriptions of why records must be legally held, what period of time records must be held for, and the hold location.

Managing physical Records

Managing physical records involves different disciplines or capabilities and may draw on a variety of forms of expertise.

Identifying Records

If an item is presented as a legal record, it needs to be authenticated. Forensic experts may need to examine a document or artifact to determine that it is not a forgery, and that any damage, alteration, or missing content is documented. In extreme cases, items may be subjected to a microscope, x-ray, radiocarbon dating or chemical analysis. This level of authentication is rare, but requires that special care be taken in the creation and retention of the records of an organization.

Storing Records

Records must be stored in such a way that they are accessible and safeguarded against environmental damage. A typical paper document may be stored in a filing cabinet in an office. However, some organisations employ file rooms with specialized environmental controls including temperature and humidity. Vital records may need to be stored in a disaster-resistant safe or vault to protect against fire, flood, earthquakes and conflict.

In extreme cases, the item may require both disaster-proofing and public access, such as the original, signed US Constitution. Civil engineers may need to be consulted to determine that the file room can effectively withstand the weight of shelves and file cabinets filled with paper; historically, some military vessels were designed to take into account the weight of their operating procedures on paper as part of their ballast equation (modern record-keeping technologies have transferred much of that information to electronic storage). In addition to on-site storage of records, many organizations operate their own off-site records centers or contract with commercial records centres.

Retrieval of Records

In addition to being able to store records, enterprises must also establish the proper capabilities for retrieval of records, in the event they are needed for a purpose such as an audit or litigation, or for the case of destruction. Record retrieval capabilities become complex when dealing with electronic records, especially when they have not been adequately tagged or classified for discovery.

Circulating Records

Tracking the record while it is away from the normal storage area is referred to as circulation. Often this is handled by simple written recording procedures. However, many modern records environments use a computerized system involving bar code scanners, or radio-frequency identification technology (RFID) to track movement of the records. These can also be used for periodic auditing to identify unauthorized movement of the record.

Disposal of Records

Disposal of records does not always mean destruction. It can also include transfer to a historical archive, museum, or private individual. Destruction of records ought to be authorized by law, statute, regulation, or operating procedure, and the records should be disposed of with care to avoid inadvertent disclosure of information. The process needs to be well-documented, starting with a records retention schedule and policies and procedures that have been approved at the highest level. An inventory of the records disposed of should be maintained, including certification that they have been destroyed. Records should never simply be discarded as refuse. Most organizations use processes

including pulverization, paper shredding or incineration. Commercially available products can manage records through all processes active, inactive, archival, retention scheduling and disposal. Some also utilize RFID technology for the tracking of the physical file.

Managing electronic Records

The general principles of records management apply to records in any format. Digital records (almost always referred to as electronic records), however, raise specific issues. It is more difficult to ensure that the content, context and structure of records is preserved and protected when the records do not have a physical existence. This has important implications for the authenticity, reliability, and trustworthiness of records.

Much research is being conducted on the management of electronic records. The International Research on Permanent Authentic Records in Electronic Systems (InterPARES) Project is one example of such an initiative. Based at the School of Library, Archival and Information Studies at the University of British Columbia, in Vancouver, British Columbia, Canada, the InterPARES Project is a collaborative project between researchers all across the world committed to developing theories and methodologies to ensure the reliability, accuracy, and authenticity of electronic records.

Functional requirements for computer systems to manage electronic records have been produced by the US Department of Defense, the The United Kingdom's National Archives and the European Commission, whose MoReq (Model Requirements for the Management of Electronic Records) specification has been translated into at least twelve languages funded by the European Commission.

Particular concerns exist about the ability to access and read electronic records over time, since the rapid pace of change in technology can make the software used to create the records obsolete, leaving the records unreadable. A considerable amount of research is being undertaken to address this, under the heading of digital preservation. The Public Record Office Victoria (PROV) located in Melbourne, Australia published the Victorian Electronic Records Strategy (VERS) which includes a standard for the preservation, long-term storage and access to permanent electronic records. The VERS standard has been adopted by all Victorian Government departments. A digital archive has been established by PROV to enable the general public to access permanent records. Archives New Zealand is also setting up a digital archive.

Electronic tax Records

Electronic Tax Records are computer-based/non-paper versions of records required by tax agencies like the Internal Revenue Service. There is substantial confusion about what constitutes acceptable digital records for the IRS, as the concept is relatively new.

6

Office Organisational Management

STEPS IN OFFICE ORGANISATION

The following steps are considered useful while designing the office organisation:

1. Establishment of office objectives.
2. Linking office objectives with organisational objectives.
3. Formulating plans, policies, procedures, methods.
4. Defining the nature of activities to be performed.
5. Sub-division of the activities into units and sub-units.
6. Evaluation of the activities and grouping the same into sections or departments.
7. Granting authority and fixing responsibility.
8. Preparation of a chart of organisation structure indicating the positions to be held by staff, and their relationships.

ORGANISATION DIAGRAM

An organisation chart is a diagram which indicates the positions in the organisation, and depicts the relationship between individuals and different departments. It enables one to have a clear picture of who is what in the organisation, what are his functions, to whom he is responsible and who is responsible to him?

Front Office: Organisational Structure

The department of the front office performs quite a few functions/operations. It becomes necessary to have a well-defined organisational structure for smooth operations.

The organisational structure of the front office depends on many factors (Principles of Hotel Front Office Operations, Sue Baker, et. al.) have described them thus:

- **Size of the Hotel:** Bigger the hotel, the more specialised the staff is required to be. Whereas in the smaller hotels, one employee/staff member may perform a wide variety of duties.
- **Type of Guests:** The needs of Guests usually differ on the basis of their purpose of visit, i.e., business client prefers less time to be spent on checking-in and checking-out, and it is quite possible they won't mind carrying their own luggage. So the emphasis is more on staff in the front desk section than at the concierge.
- **Standard of Service:** High-class hotels usually provide more personal services for guests and, therefore, they expect greater specialisation from their staff.
- **Type of Hotel:** A hotel situated in the airport area knows that a guest may check-in or check-out at any time during the 24 hours of a day. So more emphasis needs to be there on front desk as a full team is needed to be on duty at all times.

Even though the organisational structure of a hotel depends on the above stated factors, typically all the hotels follow somewhat similar organisational structure.

Front Office Accounting

All through the day the hotel has many transactions with its resident guests. The transactions pertain to various services that the guest can avail, be it room service or laundry service. On most of the occasion the guest does not make any payments after availing the available service at the hotel and the amount is posted on his/her bill. The process of posting keeps the guests billing up to date. The process can be performed either manually or by a computer. Once the posting has been done, it is important to recheck whether the correct amount has been posted on the correct guest folio and also to the account of right department. As a supervisor you are required to check these details regularly because guests check in and out daily and the guests' transactions take place regularly. During the day time the front office section is quite busy with a lot of other activities but during night it is comparatively less burdened with work. So this is the night time to match bills and receipts. The staff doing this job is called night auditors. Usually, the night auditors check the posting of bills from other departments but more particularly the credit limit. These credit limits can be that of the hotel or of a credit card or even that of a company's account floor limits. Thus, the accounts of the resident guests are maintained regularly so as to ensure speedy settlement of bills.

Organizational Control Techniques

Control techniques provide managers with the type and amount of information they need to measure and monitor performance. The information from various controls must be tailored to a specific management level, department, unit, or operation. To ensure

complete and consistent information, organizations often use standardized documents such as financial, status, and project reports. Each area within an organization, however, uses its own specific control techniques, described in the following sections.

Financial controls

After the organization has strategies in place to reach its goals, funds are set aside for the necessary resources and labour. As money is spent, statements are updated to reflect how much was spent, how it was spent, and what it obtained. Managers use these financial statements, such as an income statement or balance sheet, to monitor the progress of programs and plans. Financial statements provide management with information to monitor financial resources and activities. The income statement shows the results of the organization's operations over a period of time, such as revenues, expenses, and profit or loss. The *balance sheet* shows what the organization is worth (assets) at a single point in time, and the extent to which those assets were financed through debt (liabilities) or owner's investment (equity).

Financial audits, or formal investigations, are regularly conducted to ensure that financial management practices follow generally accepted procedures, policies, laws, and ethical guidelines. Audits may be conducted internally or externally. Financial ratio analysis examines the relationship between specific figures on the financial statements and helps explain the significance of those figures:

- Liquidity ratios measure an organization's ability to generate cash.
- Profitability ratios measure an organization's ability to generate profits.
- Debt ratios measure an organization's ability to pay its debts.
- Activity ratios measure an organization's efficiency in operations and use of assets.

In addition, *financial responsibility centers* require managers to account for a unit's progress toward financial goals within the scope of their influences. A manager's goals and responsibilities may focus on unit profits, costs, revenues, or investments.

Budget Controls

A budget depicts how much an organization expects to spend (expenses) and earn (revenues) over a time period. Amounts are categorized according to the type of business activity or account, such as telephone costs or sales of catalogs. Budgets not only help managers plan their finances, but also help them keep track of their overall spending. A budget, in reality, is both a planning tool and a control mechanism. Budget development processes vary among organizations according to who does the budgeting and how the financial resources are allocated. Some budget development methods are as follows:

- Top-down budgeting. Managers prepare the budget and send it to subordinates.
- Bottom-up budgeting. Figures come from the lower levels and are adjusted and coordinated as they move up the hierarchy.
- Zero-based budgeting. Managers develop each new budget by justifying the projected allocation against its contribution to departmental or organizational goals.

- Flexible budgeting. Any budget exercise can incorporate flexible budgets, which set “meet or beat” standards that can be compared to expenditures.

Marketing Controls

Marketing controls help monitor progress toward goals for customer satisfaction with products and services, prices, and delivery. The following are examples of controls used to evaluate an organization’s marketing functions:

- Market research gathers data to assess customer needs—information critical to an organization’s success. Ongoing market research reflects how well an organization is meeting customers’ expectations and helps anticipate customer needs. It also helps identify competitors.
- Test marketing is small-scale product marketing to assess customer acceptance. Using surveys and focus groups, test marketing goes beyond identifying general requirements and looks at what (or who) actually influences buying decisions.
- Marketing statistics measure performance by compiling data and analysing results. In most cases, competency with a computer spreadsheet program is all a manager needs. Managers look at *marketing ratios*, which measure profitability, activity, and market shares, as well as *sales quotas*, which measure progress toward sales goals and assist with inventory controls.

Unfortunately, scheduling a regular evaluation of an organization’s marketing program is easier to recommend than to execute. Usually, only a crisis, such as increased competition or a sales drop, forces a company to take a closer look at its marketing program. However, more regular evaluations help minimize the number of marketing problems.

Human Resource Controls

Human resource controls help managers regulate the quality of newly hired personnel, as well as monitor current employees’ developments and daily performances. On a daily basis, managers can go a long way in helping to control workers’ behaviors in organizations. They can help direct workers’ performances toward goals by making sure that goals are clearly set and understood. Managers can also institute policies and procedures to help guide workers’ actions. Finally, they can consider past experiences when developing future strategies, objectives, policies, and procedures. Common control types include performance appraisals, disciplinary programs, observations, and training and development assessments. Because the quality of a firm’s personnel, to a large degree, determines the firm’s overall effectiveness, controlling this area is very crucial.

Computers and Information Controls

Almost all organizations have confidential and sensitive information that they don’t want to become general knowledge. Controlling access to computer databases is the key to this area. Increasingly, computers are being used to collect and store information

for control purposes. Many organizations privately monitor each employee's computer usage to measure employee performance, among other things. Some people question the appropriateness of computer monitoring. Managers must carefully weigh the benefits against the costs—both human and financial—before investing in and implementing computerized control techniques. Although computers and information systems provide enormous benefits, such as improved productivity and information management, organizations should remember the following limitations of the use of information technology:

- **Performance limitations.** Although management information systems have the potential to increase overall performance, replacing long-time organizational employees with information systems technology may result in the loss of expert knowledge that these individuals hold. Additionally, computerized information systems are expensive and difficult to develop. After the system has been purchased, coordinating it—possibly with existing equipment—may be more difficult than expected. Consequently, a company may cut corners or install the system carelessly to the detriment of the system's performance and utility. And like other sophisticated electronic equipment, information systems do not work all the time, resulting in costly downtime.
- **Behavioral limitations.** Information technology allows managers to access more information than ever before. But too much information can overwhelm employees, cause stress, and even slow decision making. Thus, managing the quality and amount of information available to avoid information overload is important.
- **Health risks.** Potentially serious health-related issues associated with the use of computers and other information technology have been raised in recent years. An example is carpal tunnel syndrome, a painful disorder in the hands and wrists caused by repetitive movements (such as those made on a keyboard).

Regardless of the control processes used, an effective system determines whether employees and various parts of an organization are on target in achieving organizational objectives.

Check-In Process

Check-in process is a critical process, since a lot of vital information is exchanged between the guest and the hotel staff during this process, irrespective of the fact whether check-in process is manual or computerised. The manual process starts when a guest either walk-in (without reservation) or one with prior reservation walks into the hotel looking for desired or requested accommodation, i.e., depending upon the availability of room the walk-in guest is assigned room whereas the guest with prior reservation is usually assigned the room for which he has requested.

The minimum information you usually require for manual registration is name of the guest, number of persons in the group, the expected length of stay and mode of

payment. The room is assigned to the guests and usually a porter or bellboy carries their luggage and show the guests their assigned rooms. The front desk in the meantime processes the information received and generate the guest account for the mentioned period of stay. However, the process of assigning rooms commences even before the arrival of the guest. After the major check-outs of the day, the front office generates a list/printout regarding number of guests staying with the hotel. Then after comparing the reservation requests for the day with this report, assigns the remaining unoccupied rooms to the walk-in guest. In case of computerised check-in procedure, only the walk-in guests need to provide their personal information whereas guests with reservation need to confirm the information available in the computers of the reception/front desk. Once the guest is allotted assigned room, the computer automatically updates the information and for the desired length of stay, room(s) will be shown as occupied. The help of the front office manager is sought rarely, particularly in the case of over-bookings, i.e., when two or more guests arrive for the same room, the manager can either assign another room to the guest or can try to up scale the room type. However, if the hotel is unable to adjust the extra guest special arrangement for the guest at a different hotel of similar standing should be made.

Lately, a guest registration system using Point of System (PoS) to hasten check-in process is gaining popularity. This system enables the guest to register at self-service terminals in the lobby or at self-service terminals at the airport or en-route to the hotel. New innovations have also helped transfer the credit cards to room keys. According to Tom Van Dyke one popular system asks the guest to insert his or her magnetic stripe credit card into a check-in terminal which calls up the property's computerised reservations list filed by arrival date and last name.

When the reservations match is found, the room selecting function of the hotel's Property Management System generates a room assignment and prints a check-in form. The guest removes the completed form, signs it and then is directed to the key pick-up area at or near the front desk. He cites the example of the Sheraton Meadowlands in New Jersey which works with Avis Rent-A-Car so that guests picking up cars at any of the New York areas three major airports can simultaneously check-in to a room at the Sheraton. Whatever may be the method of check-in, the basic idea of check-in is to collect information about the guest.

Check-Out Process

Check out point is the last contact a guest will have with the property and experience at this point will determine what kind of impression will a guest carry with him/her. In other words, if it is smooth guest will carry pleasant memories. Thus, to make this point more efficient and error proof, you shall divide it in to three parts:

- a. Guest vacating the room;
- b. Guest settling the bill; and
- c. Guest departing.

Guest vacating the room usually depends upon the hotel's check out time. Usually the check out time is 12 noon. Sometimes depending on the availability of the room and the type of client the check out time can be extended for the guest on special request. Following a routine check out time helps the hotel since the housekeeping can prepare the room for the next guest. Still there are small hotels which provide the guests with flexi-check-out time. In these cases next guest allotted this room has to wait in the lobby because the upkeep of the room takes time.

As the above illustration suggests, bill settlement is the next important component of check out process. Usually the bills are updated during the night so as to provide the bills for guests checking out early in the day. It is advisable to ask the guest before time when he or she would be checking out to ensure that the staff has some idea when the guest would be checking out and have a bill ready at services rendered by different departments of the hotel.

Yet the settlement of the bill can take some time, as the guest would like to recheck the bill before making the payment or may the payment be credited to the account of the company whom the guest is representing. The actual guest departure, however, takes place only when the guest returns the keys and leaves the premises. The guest is provided with transportation if required and paid for. The guest folio created is updated for future use.

Organizational Theory and Structures

Most common project management form is of a project team working within an existing functional organization. The project team draws member from various functional sections and uses them to work on the project until it is completed.

The Project within an Existing Organization

Project team working within an existing organization structure, once completed project team disbanded or absorbed back into main organization. Function of many elements including:

- The size of the project to the organization
- The relative status and importance of the project
- The resources that are made available
- The strategic fit of the project with the overall strategic objectives of the organization.

The Functional Structure

In functional arrangement, power or status is defined by a vertical hierarchy through the OBS. Projects are likely to improve systems, procedures, methods or products, and they would tend to be internal rather than external projects. May be established for limited periods in order to address specific demands. Functional structure common in large organizations typical examples.

- Central government
- Local government
- Police forces
- The armed forces
- Most large private companies.

Typically of large organizations have continuous rolling programmes of similar repetitive or semi-repetitive work. Benefits of functional structure:

- Offer clear reliable reporting system and responsibilities are clearly defined.
- Mirror traditional authority structures – section heads with lines of authority running down chain of command to individual operational units
- Simple and straightforward and is compatible with basic human instincts. Specialize in area rather than develop range of different advanced skills.
- Repetitive so people can use their experience from one aspect to the next aspect, Knowledge transfer
- Specialist knowledge shared around between the various functional members. Build up a library of specialist knowledge
- Direct relationships with various support services. Functional managers agree works programmes and timetables directly with support services such as IT
- Preferred by highly inflexible organizations like government departments, hospital services. Clearly defined roles and responsibilities clearly defined chain of command.

Disadvantages of function structure:

- Inflexible. Result functional units difficult to innovate and respond to change
- Functional output tend to be primary objective of organization. Project structure attempts to operate within the functional structure considered as secondary importance
- Cross-functional activities are discouraged. Functional people stick to own specialization, avoid being involved in cross-functional activities
- Functional people tend to see function as their future. Career path tied to function rather than projects
- Functional sections develop sub-groups. Tend to develop boundaries act as barriers to effective communication
- Cannot easily respond to fluctuations in workload
- Demand a greater degree of central support.

The main drawback with a pure functional structure is the development of operational or organizational islands.

Organizational Island is a segment of the organization within the overall organizational structure, tend to act as a semi-independent sector. Control and communication tend to flow down through various functional divisions. Little communication and co-operation across the functional divisions, this is inefficient as cross-transfer of co-operation allow formation of horizontal units.

Pure Project Structure

Self contained section or unit within an otherwise purely functional structure. Typically used for projects that are difficult to plan accurately and where resource requirement and provision levels cannot be accurately established beforehand. Project team disbanded upon completion of its project and individual project team members will return to the pool for use on other projects. Benefits of Pure project structure:

- System is flexible and responsive to change
- Innovation and evolution are not restricted
- Operational cost quickly adjusted
- Project manager in charge of any particular project is sole charge of project complete authority and control over project resources. No requirement for negotiating with functional manager or project sponsor
- Project staff clear reporting change
- Communication lines much shorter
- Informal communication lines shorter develop more quickly and efficiently
- Authority with the project
- Project team member do not have any functional loyalties
- Centralized support much simpler and the overall sizes of support function smaller
- Easier to incorporate external consultants.
- Possible to execute a series of related projects.

Projects point of view, pure project system appears to be the best supporting structure.

Disadvantages of Pure Project structure:

- Several projects running concurrently duplication of effort
- Initial operating costs may be high considerable time before projects completed
- Centralize direction is needed, from of command hierarchy. Higher levels of authority may have difficulty interfacing
- Project managers (by definition) tend to think ahead
- A sense of competition develop between various project teams
- Project team members tend to have underlying concern about long term commitment
- Project deadlines may create a culture 'cut corners'; maintain good performance records
- Difficult to compare the performance of individual projects
- Most staff in project structure has some form of original functional specialization prolonged absence from functional section lead to specialization becoming diluted over time.

The Project External to the Existing Organization

External Project teams can be comprised as follows:

- All internal people, but be managed by an external project management consultant

- A mixture of internal people and external consultants, all of who are managed by the consultant project manager
- All external consultants, some or all of whom have been appointed by consultant project manager.

Surrogacy in this sense refers to the extent to which the client wishes to delegate control or authority to running the project.

External (Executive) Project Management Structure

External project managers more applicable to smaller organizations with variable workload. Project manager is the only team lead full authority and control over all components of the project team. Including control and co-ordination of the design team. Number of distinctive characteristics:

Multidisciplinary and shared loyalty group characteristic: Form of fees for their external project management system tend to be strongly multidisciplinary. Susceptible to shared loyalty characteristics, working for his own practice or company not the same as the objectives of the client conflict of loyalties between individual parts of the system more susceptible to the problems of differentiation and sentence than internal project management teams.

Fee structures: Open competitive fee structure, negotiated fee are now generally accepted. Use fee bid package approach. Look at a outline of project make a bid in form of a plan or proposal. Hourly or percentage basis. Typical fee schedule.

- Completion of pre-contract works
- Completion of post-contract work
- Completion of final account.

External contractual linkages: Wide range of contractual agreement systems, higher degree of risk of non-performance.

Take one of 3 primary forms.

Completion contracts – one-off contract specified goods, service agreed cost by specified date.

Term contracts – long term agreement agrees to supply good agreed rate to an agreed standard for a fixed term.

Service-level agreement – (SLAs) where level of service is set rather than the performance.

Priced and arranged in 2 primary ways.

Competitive contract – put out tender.

Negotiated contract-not involved in direct competition, client negotiates price and condition with contractor.

Contracts can take a number of different forms:

Fixed price contract-cost of project agreed and fixed in some way in advance.

Cost or cost-plus contract-fixed fees vs. price used insufficient design or product information cost plus-contract fee is % of overall cost on final account.

Reimbursement contract. Contractor perform the project at contractor expense and claim amount plus a fee every month.

Target Price contract – target price plus a fee.

Contract types can take number of different forms.

Standard forms of contract – Precise terms & conditions relate clearly to specific performance, aim establish absolute requirement form completion of the contract.

- Clauses carefully worded to cover all aspects of the contract layout established procedures for virtually all eventualities.
- Specific provisions within standard forms of contract, such as direct terms and conditions relating to loss and expense and extensions of time.
- Set out specific level of damages for non compliance with various events ie late completion.
- Breaches-Clearly state remedial action & right in the event of non compliance (damages clause).
- Professional services contract – implied terms interpret according to professional body, actual loss incurred.
- Supply contracts.
- Subcontract agreements.
- Proforma contracts.
- Damages not set out beforehand & based on actual loss incurred.
- Less protection to the client therefore more risk.
- Carry professional indemnity insurance in event of negligence.
- Either state directly or imply a liability for the consultant to act within the professional standards that are set by the relevant professional body.
- Breaches/negligence or other act professional failed to act according to standards set out by the professional body.
- Most professional bodies produce a book of professional practice, which lays out the minimum standards and codes of conduct that members must observe.
- Consultant is commissioned under a professional services contract that pertains to a given professional body, then any practice under the contract is deemed to be executed in accordance with that book of standards.
- Typical contractual links in an external system.
 - Client to project manager and other design team members.
 - Client to main contractor.
 - Client to service authorities.
 - Client to nominated subcontractors and suppliers.
 - Client to local authority.

Statutory Contracts Health and Safety

- Implied common law, contract right or 3rd party.
- Maybe formal signed.

- Heavy favour authority little company do except comply with requirement i.e. Safety features on machinery must copy with HSE.

Proforma Contracts

- Generally written by one party for imposition on another party.
- Typical examples are contracts for services by monopoly or near monopoly organisations.
- The terms and conditions are largely written up by the service providers.
- The onus of responsibility is therefore borne by the client.
- Very risk clients point of view offer virtually no protection in the event of a default.

External no-contractual linkages: Two type of linkage essential these are authority links and communication links.

Authority links – define the power and control structure that operates with in system.

Communication links – Configuration management system (CMS) define the authority and communication channels within a project system.

External project management advantages:

- It is flexible and adaptive.
- Can respond rapidly to change.
- Use of external specialists can bring new ideas and approaches into the organization.
- No in house specialization can be outsourced.
- Appropriate structure can be established relatively quickly and easily staffed with the optimal range of specialist.
- Disbanded quickly and easily if workload or demand change.
- specialism demands can be met assembled from range of external specialists best fit of skills.
- Internal risks such as key people being unavailable can be avoided.

External project management disadvantages:

- External specialist expensive.
- External specialist no loyalty to the organization or commitment to project.
- Recourse against poor performance difficult level of authority control can be exercised is limited.
- Whole new administrative and control system is required as soon as external contract are involved.
- More rigid and controlled communication systems required communication across the organizational boundary. External specialist.
- Additional internal sections may be required.
- Risk profile of the organization in general and of the project in particular change significantly.
- Possibility of arbitration and litigation enters the risk equation.
- Complex job of the project manager becomes more complex still.

7

Office Time Management

If you search for time management books on Amazon, you'll find 106,960 results demonstrating the universal need for help managing this limited resource. Teaching people how to manage their time is an industry in itself, but every one of us can benefit from the valuable skills they provide.

We all struggle with managing our time and controlling those things that steal our time. Things like unproductive emails, Internet search rabbit trails or conversations that go off on time-wasting tangents are all examples of things we do that rob us of one of the most valuable resources we have – our time.

Personal time management dictates how well we can juggle our work responsibilities with our home and social obligations. However, time management skills for entrepreneurs and business leaders alike are critical to organizational success. The most successful organizations have figured out the importance of helping people spend time on those things that align with strategic objectives.

A recent McKinsey Quarterly report suggests that of 1500 executives interviewed, only 52 percent of them spent their time on strategic objectives and that time management is increasingly becoming an organizational issue that needs management.

“Leadership time...too often gets treated as though it were limitless, with all good opportunities receiving high priority regardless of the leadership capacity to drive them forward.”

Organizational time management is a cultural issue that needs to be addressed at the strategic level. When the organization's senior leaders are held accountable for how they use their time, other levels of employees will follow suit.

“Few organizations treat executive time as the finite and measurable resource it is.” Follow these six tips and find that time is not an enemy.

CONFRONT THE PERCEPTION

There is a misguided perception that time is infinite for executives and very often all employees. Confronting and challenging this perception is the first step in improving corporate time management.

CREATE TIME BUDGETS

Budgeting and allocating employee time is as important as budgeting and allocating financial resources to organizational programs and initiatives. Create time budgets by determining what percentage of time employees should spend on key responsibilities. This can be as simple as a daily time schedule. For example, I worked with an executive who was only available for business meetings in the morning so he could spend his afternoons working on key responsibilities. He set the standard for time management for the rest of the company. “Time is the scarcest resource, and unless it is managed, nothing else can be managed.” Peter Drucker, management consultant and author

Stop Doing Too Many Things

We all get trapped with this one. We have a great idea for a new project or program to support global strategy and often neglect the important step of looking at current projects and initiatives that may no longer add value or contribute to organizational priorities. It’s important to intentionally look at and routinely review what initiatives are no longer viable in order to free up resources for new initiatives.

Reprioritize

Learning the skill of reprioritizing and knowing which piece of paper to push to the front of the pile are skills all leaders must learn to master. An urgent matter today may resolve itself by tomorrow. Staying aware and intentionally prioritizing are critical.

Have Strong Administrative Support

Good admins are worth every penny because of their ability to help executives balance competing priorities and manage their limited time. These support people can help an executive stay focused on key priorities by handling other issues and tasks in the office. Delegating those things an admin can take care of gives valuable time to the executives.

Keep a Time Log

Spend a few weeks keeping a time log. Make a list of those things you do that are the most important to meeting corporate objectives and pay attention to how much time you spend doing them. Make a category for time killers. This exercise is typically an

eye opener and helps to identify those things that rob our valuable time. Business competition today is ever-increasing and organizations of all types need to know their valuable resources are spent doing those things that help to achieve objectives. Spending a little time thinking about how time is used in your organization can turn into some of the most productive time you spend!

How to manage your time

Start by recording how you spend your time currently. Simply use a planner or diary to note down your activities throughout the day in order to monitor where your time is going. At the end of the week, set aside some time to review your schedule. Now, how much time was wasted? This is where you need to be strict. Consciously cutting out unproductive conversations, numerous tea/coffee breaks, or any of the other little time wasters in your schedule takes some will power but it is worth it. Of course, you still need human contact and a cup of joe every now and again, but being aware of how much time you are spending on those things will help you to control your activities.

Appointments: Unnecessary appointments may also have wasted your time. How many regular meetings do you have with colleagues? Again, you should be strict here, but how many of those were actually necessary or productive? Controlling your appointments is a vital step in time management.

Colleagues: Well-meaning colleagues can be a further source of wasted time. In the spirit of camaraderie, you should want to help your colleagues if there is a problem that needs your attention. If the task is not something directly related to your position, then perhaps refer them to someone who would be in a better position to help. Water cooler gossip is another source of time wastage. Pointless, or even friendly, conversations can easily fill your schedule if you don't employ strict time management.

Workload: Take another look at your schedule. How much time is spent on work that someone else could/should be doing? Menial tasks, such as photocopying, stamping letters, or filing work, are often duties of clerical or secretarial staff. Even if you have been doing these tasks for years, training or requesting that someone else takes on this duty (where appropriate) will save you much time in the long run (although you may have to spend some time to monitor and teach someone how to do it at first).

Managers: It's unfortunate that sometimes one's superiors contribute to wasted time. Within the proper bounds of respect and good humour, helping your manager to see how they are unnecessarily taking up your time can help to ease the strain on your schedule. Poorly defined tasks and unclear communication is a key source of time wastage. If your manager doesn't define duties clearly then you will end up going back to them with questions. Try to get clarity from the start.

Being prepared: Being well prepared for essential meetings and appointments will help you to save time. How many times have you attended meetings without a clear idea of what it is about, or without having read the necessary documentation beforehand? It's probably a safe bet that those very same meetings were unproductive (which probably

led to a follow up meeting). If, on the other hand, you take the time to prepare for each scheduled appointment then it will be a success. Decisions can be made and actions assigned only if you have clear thoughts on the issue and are aware of what's going on.

Deadlines: Of all the things that are knocking your balance, deadlines are probably having the biggest effect. And it is probably the most difficult thing for you to change. Organising your projects in terms of priority and not just the closeness of the deadline will help you to keep a balance.

What if the deadline is just downright impossible, though? In that case, you should reason with your superiors to get the deadline extended. Failing that, forcefully requesting more resources to achieve the task will make the deadline more practical. You could also consider getting the Deliverable altered so as to be more achievable, even if the due date doesn't change. Your only remaining weapon is just to make it clear from the start that the deadline is impossible, although as a dedicated worker you will of course put your all into it.

Communications: Being organized in terms of communications is also vital. Paperwork can easily get out of hand. A simple and effective system is necessary here. You only need two folders for paperwork - the 'to do' folder, and the 'to file' folder. Anything else can be thrown away. Taking immediate action when you receive paperwork is vital to being organized. Sort your paperwork into the appropriate folder and schedule time to deal with the folders regularly.

Emails can be equally cumbersome. Studies have shown that keeping email programs open is actually disruptive to efficiency. Rather, you should check emails regularly (five or six times a day) and deal with the incoming emails appropriately. Having separate folders in your inbox for different types of emails will keep you organized.

Telephone calls can easily waste your time. Rather than waiting on hold, it is wise to find out an appropriate time to call someone, or even request that they call you. You could even schedule a specific time to call someone to avoid the problems of missed calls.

You should also make sure that secretarial staff are aware of how to deal with calls. They should know when to refer the calls to your colleagues, and when it is appropriate to take a message rather than put the call through to you.

Benefits

Is managing your time really worth the hassle? Resoundingly, yes, it is. On a day-to-day level, it will make your routine more practical and organized. It will make your long-term view clearer, as you know that you are in control of upcoming projects and tasks. For your career, it will help you achieve your goals quicker.

It even has health benefits. It's scientifically proven that we get highly stressed when we don't achieve tasks and goals that we wanted to reach. Stress, in turn, is detrimental to sleep, digestion and mental activities. On the other hand, a balanced workload and controlled use of time will negate stress and make you more capable.

Top Tips

1. Make a record - how are you spending your time? What can be cut out? Also, always write down your 'to do' list and organize it according to priority.
2. Managing communications - make effective telephone calls (don't stay on hold, leave clear messages etc.), keep a tidy inbox with multiple folders for different types of emails, don't let yourself be disturbed by colleagues if inappropriate.
3. Managing meetings - attend only meetings that it is necessary or advantageous to attend. Make sure you are prepared for it so that it achieves something (otherwise a follow-up meeting becomes a requisite - another timewaster).
4. Be organized - a tidy desk, a tidy to do list, and a tidy email inbox show a tidy and organized mind and person.
5. Prioritize - even if you have multiple projects on the go and numerous tasks to achieve, a clearly defined list of priorities will keep you on top of things and will help you to meet deadlines.
6. Delegate tasks - don't be afraid to pass duties onto other capable people. The time spent teaching someone else to do one of your tasks is soon made up for.
7. Say no - sometimes well-meaning colleagues, or people outside of your company, make demands on your time unnecessarily (meetings, conferences, solving other people's problems etc.). A polite 'no' will help you to keep control of your time.
8. Maintain a record - a diary or planner will help you to keep an eye on where your time is going. If it is being spent badly, you can change things. Making a written note of how you spend your time is one of the key steps. Don't miss it out.

How to Manage Your Time Effectively

As you've no doubt discovered, managing your time is very challenging during college. There are a million things to do! Time management is a means of asserting greater control over your use of time and energy, rather than allowing tasks and demands to control you. It's a given that you'll never be able to do everything that you think you should. By using time management techniques, you ensure that the activities that you don't do are those of your choice — your lowest priorities.

Time management uses two primary tools:

- Lists of activities and tasks
- Schedules

These tools allow you to analyze, understand, organize and prioritize your use of time — not to make you a schedule and task slave, but to make you the master of your time. Only by adopting a systematic approach to time can a busy person escape the tyranny of time pressure.

Lists

Lists are a key tool in effective time and task management. People without lists are often plagued by worry over whether they've remembered all their important tasks. You can't possibly hold everything in your head, and you'll drive yourself crazy if you try. Make lists of everything you need to get done. The most effective time managers have multiple lists: a list of college tasks, a list of work tasks, a list for social activities, a list for today, a list for tomorrow, a list for next week, a list for someday... You get the idea.

Prioritize the tasks and activities on your lists. Mark items H, M or L for high, medium or low priority. Increase your motivation and get a sense of accomplishment by checking off items as you get things done. Your lists help you decide what to do at the moment, what to schedule for later, what to get someone else to do, and what to put off for later.

If you can't stand to face a particular task or activity at the moment, don't worry over your avoidance. Instead, agree with yourself to tackle the difficult or unpleasant item when you feel stronger. Shift temporarily to another priority item. You can get two or three other items done in the time you might have spent fighting yourself over the difficult item.

Schedules

Schedules allow you to understand and plan your use of time. You won't have to stick to any particular schedule, but having a schedule is important in gaining control over your time. You can vary and alter your schedule as you see fit. The schedule allows you to do so by choice and to understand the consequences of scheduling choices that you make.

The benefits of using a schedule include:

- Written plans make responsibilities seem more manageable and less overwhelming.
- Scheduled tasks are more likely to be completed.
- If you are current on important tasks, you will avoid worry and last-minute rushing.

The first step is to make a weekly schedule that charts your regular activities. Use a grid-style chart — days of the week as columns and each hour of the day for rows. Make multiple blank copies of your chart, so you can create alternate and revised versions.

Include work, commuting/travel, family, volunteer activities, exercise, regularly scheduled functions (clubs, church, etc.), socializing with friends, chores and errands, adequate time for sleep, preparing and eating meals, shopping, leisure activities, personal care, and other regular activities and tasks. Don't forget to schedule time to make and review lists and schedules! Be realistic about how much time you spend on each activity. If there is very little or no blank, uncommitted time in your schedule grid, you will need

to reevaluate how you are allocating your time. You need uncommitted time to allow flexibility to accommodate unanticipated events, tasks and activities.

Evaluating Your Time Management

Analyze how you are spending your time. Look over your schedule grid and make a list to calculate how much time you spend on each kind of activity. Next to each activity, calculate and write in the number of hours per week devoted to that activity. Multiply daily activities by seven days and workday activities by five days to arrive at weekly hours:

- Classes
- Study
- Reading
- Work
- Commuting/travel
- Family
- Volunteer activities
- Exercise
- Clubs, church, etc.
- Socializing with friends
- Chores/errands
- Sleep
- Preparing and eating meals
- Shopping
- Leisure activities
- Personal care

At the bottom of your list, total weekly hours for all regular activities. There are 168 hours in a week. Subtract your total weekly activity hours from 168 to calculate your total uncommitted weekly hours: $168 - \text{activity hours} = \text{uncommitted hours}$. Knowing how you spend your time should aid you in planning and predicting project completion:

- How much time have you set aside to meet your study goals?
- Does your time allocation reflect the priority of your study and other goals?
- Can your uncommitted hours be reallocated to meet your study and other priorities?
- List three activities you would like to do in your uncommitted time.

Further time-analysis techniques:

- Monitor your time by keeping a log
- Reflect on how you spend your time.
- Know when you are productive.
- Be aware of when you are using your time unproductively, but not relaxing either.

Using Your Lists and Schedules to Manage Your Time

Now you can use your schedule and lists in order to organize and prioritize your pre-wedding tasks and activities, for instance, in the context of competing activities of work, family, etc. You'll be able to use time-management techniques to avoid becoming swamped.

Use a daily or weekly planner to write down appointments, activities and meetings. Always know what's ahead for the day. Go to sleep knowing you're prepared for tomorrow.

You also need a long-term planner. Use a monthly chart so that you can always plan ahead. Long-term planners also serve to remind you to plan your free time constructively.

Plan for an effective schedule:

- Allow sufficient time for sleep, a well-balanced diet, and leisure activities.
- Prioritize tasks.
- Prepare for activities and tasks ahead of time.
- Plan to use "dead time."
- Schedule a weekly review.
- Be careful not to become a slave to your schedule. Remember, you are in charge of your schedule.
- When you decide to substitute an activity in your schedule, just be sure to reschedule the original activity or task to a new time.

Types of Schedules

Consider using the following array of schedules to organize your time:

- Medium-term calendar — This is the overview, so don't include too much detail. Enter important dates (e.g., important events, projects, meetings, holidays, breaks, etc.) Post this schedule in your office area for referral and review, and to chart your progress
- General weekly schedule grid — Plan your activities in blocks of hours throughout the week. Fill in all ongoing activities.
- Actual weekly schedule — Modify and detail, working from your general weekly schedule.
- Daily schedule or "to do list" — Complete the night before or the first thing each morning. Include things you intend to accomplish that day, including tasks, appointments and errands. Check off items you have completed.

Periodically evaluate your time usage, then modify according to your priorities:

- Are you using your time to best achieve your goals?
- Are you doing what you planned when you said you would?
- Can you identify areas when you can use your time more efficiently?

If all this time management seems like a lot of work, it is. But it's even more work to live a hectic life without at least some of these techniques. An investment in time management will pay off for you beginning the very first week.

HOW TO MANAGE TIME AND WORK IN OFFICE

Chances are good that, at some time in your life, you've taken a time management class, read about it in books, and tried to use an electronic or paper-based day planner to organize, prioritize and schedule your day. "Why, with this knowledge and these gadgets," you may ask, "do I still feel like I can't get everything done I need to?" The answer is simple. Everything you ever learned about managing time is a complete waste of time because it doesn't work.

Before you can even begin to manage time, you must learn what time is. A dictionary defines time as "the point or period at which things occur." Put simply, time is when stuff happens. There are two types of time: clock time and real time. In clock time, there are 60 seconds in a minute, 60 minutes in an hour, 24 hours in a day and 365 days in a year. All time passes equally. When someone turns 50, they are exactly 50 years old, no more or no less.

In real time, all time is relative. Time flies or drags depending on what you're doing. Two hours at the department of motor vehicles can feel like 12 years. And yet our 12-year-old children seem to have grown up in only two hours.

Which time describes the world in which you really live, real time or clock time? The reason time management gadgets and systems don't work is that these systems are designed to manage clock time. Clock time is irrelevant. You don't live in or even have access to clock time. You live in real time, a world in which all time flies when you are having fun or drags when you are doing your taxes.

The good news is that real time is mental. It exists between your ears. You create it. Anything you create, you can manage.

It's time to remove any self-sabotage or self-limitation you have around "not having enough time," or today not being "the right time" to start a business or manage your current business properly.

There are only three ways to spend time: thoughts, conversations and actions. Regardless of the type of business you own, your work will be composed of those three items.

As an entrepreneur, you may be frequently interrupted or pulled in different directions. While you cannot eliminate interruptions, you do get a say on how much time you will spend on them and how much time you will spend on the thoughts, conversations and actions that will lead you to success.

Practice the following techniques to become the master of your own time:

1. Carry a schedule and record all your thoughts, conversations and activities for a week. This will help you understand how much you can get done during the course of a day and where your precious moments are going. You'll see how much time is actually spent producing results and how much time is wasted on unproductive thoughts, conversations and actions.
2. Any activity or conversation that's important to your success should have a time assigned to it. To-do lists get longer and longer to the point where they're

unworkable. Appointment books work. Schedule appointments with yourself and create time blocks for high-priority thoughts, conversations, and actions. Schedule when they will begin and end. Have the discipline to keep these appointments.

3. Plan to spend at least 50 percent of your time engaged in the thoughts, activities and conversations that produce most of your results.
4. Schedule time for interruptions. Plan time to be pulled away from what you're doing. Take, for instance, the concept of having "office hours." Isn't "office hours" another way of saying "planned interruptions?"
5. Take the first 30 minutes of every day to plan your day. Don't start your day until you complete your time plan. The most important time of your day is the time you schedule to schedule time.
6. Take five minutes before every call and task to decide what result you want to attain. This will help you know what success looks like before you start. And it will also slow time down. Take five minutes after each call and activity to determine whether your desired result was achieved. If not, what was missing? How do you put what's missing in your next call or activity?
7. Put up a "Do not disturb" sign when you absolutely have to get work done.
8. Practice not answering the phone just because it's ringing and e-mails just because they show up. Disconnect instant messaging. Don't instantly give people your attention unless it's absolutely crucial in your business to offer an immediate human response. Instead, schedule a time to answer email and return phone calls.
9. Block out other distractions like Facebook and other forms of social media unless you use these tools to generate business.
10. Remember that it's impossible to get everything done. Also remember that odds are good that 20 percent of your thoughts, conversations and activities produce 80 percent of your results.

LEVERAGE

To lift a heavy object, you have a choice: use leverage or not. You can try to lift the object directly – risking injury – or you can use a lever, such as a jack or a long plank of wood, to transfer some of the weight, and then lift the object that way.

Which approach is wiser? Will you succeed without using leverage? Maybe. But you can lift so much more with leverage, and do it so much more easily!

So what has this got to do with your life and career?

The answer is "a lot". By applying the concept of leverage to business and career success, you can, with a little thought, accomplish very much more than you can without it. Without leverage, you may work very hard, but your rewards are limited by the hours you put in. With leverage, you can break this connection and, in time, achieve very much more.

LEVERS OF SUCCESS

So how can you apply leverage to your career? And how can you achieve much more, while – if you choose to – reducing the number of hours that you work?

To do this, you'll need to learn how to use the leverage of:

- Time.
- Resources.
- Knowledge and education.
- Technology.

Time Leverage

Using the leverage of time is the most fundamental strategy for success. There are only so many hours in a day that you can work. If you use only your own time, you can achieve only so much. If you leverage other people's time, you can increase productivity to an extraordinary extent.

To leverage your own time:

- Practice effective time management. Eliminate unnecessary activities, and focus your effort on the things that really matter.
- As part of this, learn how to prioritize, so that you focus your energy on the activities that give the greatest return for the time invested.
- Use goal setting to think about what matters to you in the long term, set clear targets, and motivate yourself to achieve those targets.

To leverage other people's time:

- Learn how to delegate work to other people.
- Train and empower others.
- Bring in experts and consultants to cover skill or knowledge gaps.
- Outsource non-core tasks to people with the experience to do them more efficiently.

Providing that you do things properly, the time and money that you invest in leveraging other people's time is usually well spent. Remember, though, that you'll almost always have to "pay" up front in some way in order to reap the longer-term benefits of using leverage.

Resource Leverage

You can also exert leverage by getting the most from your assets, and taking full advantage of your personal strengths.

You have a wide range of skills, talents, experiences, thoughts, and ideas. These can, and should, be used in the best combination. What relevant skills and strengths do you have that others don't? How can you use these to best effect, and how can you improve them so that they're truly remarkable? What relevant assets do you have that others don't? Can you use these to create leverage? Do you have connections that others don't have? Or financial resources? Or some other asset that you can use to greater effect?

A good way of thinking about this is to conduct a personal SWOT analysis, focusing on identifying strengths and assets, and expanding from these to identify the opportunities they give you.

Knowledge and Education Leverage

Another significant lever of success is applied knowledge. Combined with education and action, this can generate tremendous leverage.

Learning by experience is slow and painful. If you can find more formal ways of learning, you'll progress much more quickly. What's more, if you select a good course, you'll have a solid foundation to your knowledge, and one that doesn't have high-risk gaps. This is why people working in life-or-death areas need long and thorough training. After all, would you want to be operated on by an unqualified surgeon?

While few of us operate in quite such immediately critical areas, by determining what you need to know, and then acquiring that knowledge, you can avoid many years of slow, painful trial and error learning. In the same way, it's inefficient if many people in an organization have to learn how to do their work by trial and error. A much better way is for organizations to capture the knowledge gained by the first few in some way and pass it on to others. This is the core of the "knowledge management" concept. Premium Members of the Career Excellence Club can hear more about this in our Book *Insight on The Complete Idiot's Guide to Knowledge Management*. The keys to successfully leveraging knowledge and education are: firstly, knowing what you need to learn; secondly knowing to what level you need to learn it; thirdly, being very focused and selective in your choices; and fourthly, in taking the time to earn the qualifications you need.

Even then, having more education or more knowledge isn't necessarily a point of leverage. These become advantages only when they can be directly applied to your career goals and aspirations—and when they're used actively and intelligently to do something useful.

Technology Leverage

Finding technology leverage is all about thinking about how you work, and using technology to automate as much of this as you can.

At a simple level, you might find that all you need to keep you in touch with home and work is a laptop computer. Alternatively, a personal digital assistant can help you maintain a single, convenient, properly-backed-up time management system. Cell phones that access email and browse the web are handy tools for making the best of your downtime during working hours or while traveling.

If you're a slow typist, voice recognition software can help you dictate documents and save time. Tools like Google Desktop Search can help you manage and find documents in such a way that you no longer need to file digital documents. And Google itself provides a great, quick way of finding relevant information online.

At a more sophisticated level, you may find that you can use simple desktop databases like Microsoft Access to automate simple work processes. If you do a lot of routine data processing you can find that this saves you a great deal of time. More than this, you only need to set up a process once with a tool like this - afterwards the process will be executed the same way each time, by whomever initiates the process

Businesses can choose from a wide array of software solutions. Some of these can automate or simplify tasks that are otherwise very time-consuming. Customer relationship management databases can bring tremendous benefits for sales and customer service organizations, as can point-of-sale inventory systems for organizations that need to track and manage inventory.

Websites and web-based catalogs can give clients easy access to up-to-date product information, and help them place orders simply and easily. And blogs and email-based newsletters help people stay in contact with thousands of people quickly and easily. All of these use technology to provide tremendous leverage.

KEY POINTS

Using leverage is the art and science of getting much more done with the same, or less, effort. At a simple level, this can free up your time to concentrate on things with the highest priority. At a more sophisticated level, it helps you achieve at a much higher level.

When you invest time and resources to leverage technology—as well as to leverage time, resources, and knowledge—you have a recipe for unprecedented success. Use what you and others have to your advantage, and see how far it will take you.

TIME MANAGEMENT

Time management refers to a range of skills, tools, and techniques used to manage time when accomplishing specific tasks, projects and goals.

This set encompasses a wide scope of activities, and these include planning, allocating, setting goals, delegation, analysis of time spent, monitoring, organizing, scheduling, and prioritizing.

Initially time management referred to just business or work activities, but eventually the term broadened to include personal activities as well. A time management system is a designed combination of processes, tools and techniques.

Some authors offered a categorization scheme for the hundreds of time management approaches that they reviewed:

- *First generation:* Reminders based on clocks and watches, but with computer implementation possible; can be used to alert a person when a task is to be done.
- *Second generation:* Planning and preparation based on calendar and appointment books; includes setting goals.

- *Third generation*: Planning, prioritizing, controlling activities on a daily basis. This approach implies spending some time in clarifying values and priorities.
- *Fourth generation*: Being efficient and proactive using any of the tools; places goals and roles as the controlling element of the system and favours importance over urgency.

Some of the recent general arguments related to “time” and “management” point out that the term “time management” is misleading and that the concept should actually imply that it is “the management of our own activities, to make sure that they are accomplished within the available or allocated time, which is an unmanageable continuous resource”.

Time management literature paraphrased:

- “*Get Organized*”: Paperwork and task triage
- “*Protect Your Time*”: Insulate, isolate, delegate
- “*Set gravitational goals*”: That attract actions automatically
- “*Achieve through Goal management Goal Focus*”: Motivational emphasis
- “*Work in Priority Order*”: Set goals and prioritize
- “*Use Magical Tools to Get More Out of Your Time*”: Depends on when written
- “*Master the Skills of Time Management*”
- “*Go with the Flow*”: Natural rhythms, Eastern philosophy
- “*Recover from Bad Time Habits*”: Recovery from underlying psychological problems, e.g. procrastination

TIME MANAGEMENT AND RELATED CONCEPTS

Time management has been considered as subsets of different concepts such as:

- *Project management*: Time Management can be considered as a project management subset and is more commonly known as project planning and project scheduling. Time Management has also been identified as one of the core functions identified in project management.
- *Attention management*: Attention Management relates to the management of cognitive resources, and in particular the time that humans allocate their mind to conduct some activities.
- Personal knowledge management.

PERSONAL TIME MANAGEMENT

Time management strategies are often associated with the recommendation to set goals. These goals are recorded and may be broken down into a project, an action plan, or a simple task list. For individual tasks or for goals, an importance rating may be established, deadlines may be set, and priorities assigned.

This process results in a plan with a task list or a schedule or calendar of activities. Authors may recommend a daily, weekly, monthly or other planning periods, usually fixed, but sometimes variable.

Different planning periods may be associated with different scope of planning or review. Authors may or may not emphasize reviews of performance against plan. Routine and recurring tasks may or may not be integrated into the time management plan and, if integrated, the integration can be accomplished in various ways.

Task List

A task list is a list of tasks to be completed, such as chores or steps towards completing a project. It is an inventory tool which serves as an alternative or supplement to memory.

Task lists are used in self-management, grocery lists, business management, project management, and software development. It may involve more than one list.

When you accomplish one of the items on a task list, you check it off or cross it off. The traditional method is to write these on a piece of paper with a pen or pencil, usually on a note pad or clip-board. Numerous digital equivalents are now available, including PIM applications and most PDAs. There are also several web-based task list applications, many of which are free.

Task List Organization

Task lists are often tiered. The simplest tiered system includes a general to-do list to record all the tasks the person needs to accomplish, and a daily to-do list which is created each day by transferring tasks from the general to-do list.

Task lists are often prioritized:

- An early advocate of "ABC" prioritization was Alan Lakein. In his system "A" items were the most important, "B" next most important, "C" least important.
- A particular method of applying the ABC method assigns "A" to tasks to be done within a day, "B" a week, and "C" a month.
- To prioritize a daily task list, one either records the tasks in the order of highest priority, or assigns them a number after they are listed which indicates in which order to execute the tasks. The latter method is generally faster, allowing the tasks to be recorded more quickly.

Alternatives to Prioritizing

A completely different approach which argues against prioritising altogether was put forward by British author Mark Forster in his book "Do It Tomorrow and Other Secrets of Time Management". This is based on the idea of operating "closed" to-do lists, instead of the traditional "open" to-do list. He argues that the traditional never-ending to-do lists virtually guarantees that some of your work will be left undone.

This approach advocates getting all your work done, every day, and if you are unable to achieve it helps you diagnose where you are going wrong and what needs to change.

Recently, Forster developed the "Autofocus Time Management System", which further systematizes working a to-do list as a series of closed sublists and emphasizes intuitive choices.

Software Applications

Modern task list applications may have built-in task hierarchy, may support multiple methods of filtering and ordering the list of tasks, and may allow one to associate arbitrarily long notes for each task.

In contrast to the concept of allowing the person to use multiple filtering methods, at least one new software product additionally contains a mode where the software will attempt to dynamically determine the best tasks for any given moment.

Many of the software products for time management support multiple users. It allows the person to give tasks to other users and use the software for communication.

Task list applications may be thought of as lightweight personal information manager or project management software.

Resistors

- *Fear of change*: Change can be daunting and one may be afraid to change what's proven to work in the past.
- *Uncertainty*: Even with the change being inevitable, one may be hesitant as being not sure where to start. Uncertainty about when or how to begin making a change can be significant.
- *Time pressure*: To save time, one has to invest time, and this time investment may be a cause of concern. Fearing that changing may involve more work at the start—and thus, in the very short term, make things worse—is a common resistor.

Attention Deficit Disorder

Excessive and chronic inability to manage time effectively may be a result of Attention Deficit Disorder. Diagnostic criteria include: A sense of underachievement, difficulty getting organized, trouble getting started, many projects going simultaneously and trouble with follow-through.

- *Prefrontal cortex*: The prefrontal cortex is the most evolved part of the brain. It controls the functions of attention span, impulse control, organization, learning from experience and self-monitoring, among others. Some authors argue that changing the way the prefrontal cortex works is possible and offers a solution.

Drivers

- *Increased effectiveness*: One may feel the need to make more time so as to be more effective in performing the job and carrying out responsibilities.
- *Performance improvement*: Time management is an issue that often arises during performance appraisals or review meetings.
- *Personal development*: One may view changing the approach to time management as a personal development issue and reap the benefit of handling time differently at work and at home.

- *Increased responsibilities:* A change in time-management approach may become necessary as a result of a promotion or additional responsibilities. Since there is more work to do, and still the same amount of time to do it in, the approach must change.
- *The end result:* Working towards the end goal. example completing an assignment.
- *Crossing task of the list:* The feeling you get when you have completed a task then you cross it off your list, and being able to see what has been completed

Caveats

Dwelling on the Llists

- Sandberg, task lists “aren’t the key to productivity [that] they’re cracked up to be”. He reports an estimated “30% of listers spend more time managing their lists than [they do] completing what’s on them”.
- This could be caused by procrastination by prolonging the planning activity. This is akin to analysis paralysis. As with any activity, there’s a point of diminishing returns.

Rigid Adherence

- Hendrickson asserts that rigid adherence to task lists can create a “tyranny of the to-do list” that forces one to “waste time on unimportant activities”.
- Again, the point of diminishing returns applies here too, but towards the size of the task. Some level of detail must be taken for granted for a task system to work. Rather than put “clean the kitchen”, “clean the bedroom”, and “clean the bathroom”, it is more efficient to put “housekeeping” and save time spent writing and reduce the system’s administrative load. The risk of consolidating tasks, however, is that “housekeeping” in this example may prove overwhelming or nebulously defined, which will either increase the risk of procrastination, or a mismanaged project.
- Listing routine tasks wastes time. If you are in the habit of brushing your teeth every day, then there is no reason to put it down on the task list. The same goes for getting out of bed, fixing meals, etc. If you need to track routine tasks to avoid the procedure of manually listing these items over and over.
- To remain flexible, a task system must allow for disaster. A disaster occurs constantly whether it is personal or business-related. A company must have a cushion of time ready for a disaster. Even if it is a small disaster, if no one made time for this situation, it can blow up bigger, causing the company to bankruptcy just because of poor time management.
- To avoid getting stuck in a wasteful pattern, the task system should also include regular planning and system-evaluation sessions, to weed out inefficiencies and ensure the user is headed in the direction he or she truly desires.

- If some time is not regularly spent on achieving long-range goals, the individual may get stuck in a perpetual holding pattern on short-term plans, like staying at a particular job much longer than originally planned.

Techniques for Setting Priorities

ABC Analysis

A technique that has been used in business management for a long time is the categorization of large data into groups.

These groups are often marked A, B, and C—hence the name. Activities are ranked upon these general criteria:

- A – Tasks that are perceived as being urgent and important.
- B – Tasks that are important but not urgent.
- C – Tasks that are neither urgent nor important.

Each group is then rank-ordered in priority. To further refine priority, some individuals choose to then force-rank all “B” items as either “A” or “C”. ABC analysis can incorporate more than three groups. ABC analysis is frequently combined with Pareto analysis.

Pareto Analysis

This is the idea that 80% of tasks can be completed in 20% of the disposable time. The remaining 20% of tasks will take up 80% of the time. This principle is used to sort tasks into two parts. This form of Pareto analysis it is recommended that tasks that fall into the first category be assigned a higher priority.

The 80-20-rule can also be applied to increase productivity: it is assumed that 80% of the productivity can be achieved by doing 20% of the tasks. If productivity is the aim of time management, then these tasks should be prioritized higher.

It depends on the method adopted to complete the task. There is always a simpler and easy way to complete the task. If one uses a complex way, it will be time consuming. So, one should always try to find out the alternate ways to complete each task.

Fit

Essentially, fit is the congruence of the requirements of a task with the available resources at the time. Often people are constrained by externally controlled schedules, locations, etc., and “fit” allows us to maximize our productivity given those constraints.

For example, if one encounters a gap of 15 minutes in their schedule, it is typically more efficient to complete a task that would require 15 minutes, than to complete a task that can be done in 5 minutes, or to start a task that would take 4 weeks.

This concept also applies to time of the day: free time at 7am is probably less usefully applied to the goal of learning the drums, and more productively a time to read a book. Lastly, fit can be applied to location: free time at home would be used differently from free time at work, in town, etc.

POSEC Method

POSEC is an acronym for *Prioritize by Organizing, Streamlining, Economizing and Contributing*.

The method dictates a template which emphasizes an average individual's immediate sense of emotional and monetary security. It suggests that by attending to one's personal responsibilities first, an individual is better positioned to shoulder collective responsibilities.

Inherent in the acronym is a hierarchy of self-realization which mirrors Abraham Maslow's "Hierarchy of needs".

- *Prioritize*: Your time and define your life by goals.
- *Organizing*: Things you have to accomplish regularly to be successful.
- *Streamlining*: Things you may not like to do, but must do.
- *Economizing*: Things you should do or may even like to do, but they're not pressingly urgent.
- *Contributing*: By paying attention to the few remaining things that make a difference.

The Eisenhower Method

All tasks are evaluated using the criteria important/unimportant and urgent/not urgent and put in according quadrants. Tasks in unimportant/not urgent are dropped, tasks in important/urgent are done immediately and personally, tasks in unimportant/urgent are delegated and tasks in important/not urgent get an end date and are done personally.

This method is said to have been used by US President Dwight D. Eisenhower, and is outlined in a quote attributed to him: *What is important is seldom urgent and what is urgent is seldom important.*

PROJECT MANAGEMENT

Project Management is a well-established approach to managing and controlling the introduction of new initiatives or organizational changes.

Projects are finite in length, usually one-time pieces of work involving a number of activities that must be completed within a given time frame, and often on a fixed budget. Common examples of projects are construction of a building, introduction of a new product, installation of a new piece of machinery in a manufacturing plant, creation of a new software tool, or the design and launch of a new advertising campaign.

While the very simplest projects can be managed easily by applying common sense and just getting on with things, projects that are more complex need a great deal of planning, and benefit from a formal, disciplined management approach. From making sure that activities will actually meet the specified need, to devising a workable schedule, developing systems for reporting progress, and managing requests for changes - all of these issues require thoughtful consideration.

Managing projects well requires a great deal of time, skill, and finesse. There are many sides to project management and this is what makes it so interesting and demanding.

Project managers are expected to take an uncertain event and make a certain promise to deliver. They are also expected to do this within a specified time and within a limited budget.

ATTENTION MANAGEMENT

Attention management refers to models and tools for supporting the management of attention at the individual or at the collective level and at the short term of at a longer terms.

APPROACHES FOR ATTENTION SUPPORT

Different researches have been conducted in using ICT for supporting attention, and in particular models have been elaborated for supporting attention.

Supporting the management of attention objective is to bring a certain number of solution to:

- People perception cognitive limitations, such as the limited capacity of the human short term memory or the theoretical cognitive limit to the number of people with whom one can maintain stable social relationships.
- Information overload
- Social interaction overload
- Interruption
- Multitasking

Tools can be designed for supporting attention:

- At the organizational level, by supporting organisation processes
- At the collective level
- At the individual level, for instance using attentive user interfaces.
- At the individual level by helping people to assess and analyse their attention related practices.

These tools are often adaptive hypermedia, and often rely on the profiling the user in order determine how to better support people attention.

PROJECTS

A certain number of projects have been conducted to investigate how to use ICT to support attention such as:

- AtGentive Attentive Agents for Collaborative Learners.
- SAKE - Semantic-enabled Agile Knowledge-based eGovernment
- Siitor

PERSONAL KNOWLEDGE MANAGEMENT

Personal knowledge management refers to a collection of processes that an individual carries out to gather, classify, store, search, retrieve, and share knowledge in his/her daily activities and how these processes support work activities.

It is a response to the idea that knowledge workers increasingly need to be responsible for their own growth and learning and represents a bottom-up approach to knowledge management, as opposed to more traditional, top-down KM.

Although as early as 1998 Davenport wrote on the importance to worker productivity of understanding individual knowledge processes, the term *personal knowledge management* appears to be relatively new.

PKM integrates personal information management, focused on individual skills, with knowledge management in addition to input from a variety of disciplines such as cognitive psychology, management, and philosophy.

From an organizational perspective, understanding of the field has developed in light of expanding knowledge about human cognitive capabilities and the permeability of organizational boundaries. From a metacognitive perspective, it compares various modalities within human cognition as to their competence and efficacy. It is an underresearched area.

PKM MODELS

Dorsey identified information retrieval, assessment and evaluation, organization, analysis, presentation, security, and collaboration as essential to PKM. Wright's model involves four interrelated domains: analytical, information, social, and learning. The analytical domain involves competencies such as interpretation, envisioning, application, creation, and contextualization.

The information dimension comprises the sourcing, assessment, organization, aggregation, and communication of information.

The social dimension involves finding and collaborating with people, development of both close networks and extended networks, and dialogue. The learning dimension entails expanding pattern recognition and sensemaking capabilities, reflection, development of new knowledge, improvement of skills, and extension to others. This model stresses the importance of both bonding and bridging networks.

In Nonaka and Takeuchi's SECI model of knowledge creation, knowledge can be tacit or explicit, with the interaction of the two resulting in new knowledge. Smedley has developed a PKM model based on Nonaka and colleagues' model in which an expert provides direction and a community of practice provides support for personal knowledge creation. Trust is central to knowledge sharing in this model.

Personal knowledge management can also be viewed along two main dimensions, personal knowledge and personal management. Zhang has developed a model of PKM

in relation to organizational knowledge management that considers two axes of knowledge properties and management perspectives, either organizational or personal. These aspects of organizational and personal knowledge are interconnected through the OAPI process, whereby organizational knowledge is personalized and individualized and personal knowledge is aggregated and operationalized as organizational knowledge.

CRITICISMS OF PKM

Not everyone agrees that the focus on the individual is a good thing, or that PKM is anything more than a new wrapper around personal information management. Dave Snowden has asserted that most individuals cannot manage their knowledge in the traditional sense of "managing" and has advocated thinking in terms of sensemaking rather than PKM.

Most notably, some argue that knowledge is never an individual product - that it emerges through connections, dialog and social interaction. However, in Wright's model, PKM involves the application to problem solving of analytical, information, social, and learning dimensions, which are interrelated, and so is inherently social.

An aim of PKM is "helping individuals to be more effective in personal, organisational and social environments", often through the use of technology such as networking software.

It has been argued, however, that equation of PKM with technology has limited the value and utility of the concept.

PKM SKILLS

Skills associated with personal knowledge management:

- *Reflection:* Continuous improvement on how the individual operates.
- *Manage learning:* Manage how and when the individual learns.
- *Information literacy:* Understanding what information is important and how to find unknown information.
- *Organizational skills:* Personal librarianship. Personal categorization and taxonomies.
- *Networking with others:* Knowing what your network of people knows. Knowing who might have additional knowledge and resources to help you
- Researching, canvassing, paying attention, interviewing and observational 'cultural anthropology' skills
- *Communication skills:* Perception, intuition, expression, visualization, and interpretation.
- *Creative skills:* Imagination, pattern recognition, appreciation, innovation, inference. Understanding of complex adaptive systems.
- *Collaboration skills:* Coordination, synchronization, experimentation, cooperation, and design.

PKM TOOLS

Some organizations are now introducing PKM 'systems' with some or all of four components:

- *Just-in-time Canvassing:* Templates and e-mail canvassing lists that enable people to identify and connect with the appropriate experts and expertise quickly and effectively
- *Knowledge harvesting:* Software tools that automatically collect appropriate knowledge residing on subject matter experts' hard drives
- *Content management tools:* Taxonomy processes and desktop search tools that enable employees to subscribe to, find, organize, and publish information that resides on their desktops
- *Personal Productivity Improvement:* Knowledge fairs and one-on-one training sessions to help each employee make more effective personal use of the knowledge, learning, and technology resources available in the context of their work

PKM has also been linked to these tools:

- Social bookmarking and enterprise social bookmarking
- Knowledge logs
- E-mail, calendars, task managers
- Online Web Assistants
- Wikis
 - Desktop wikis
 - Personal wikis
 - Semantic Wikis

Other useful tools include Open Space Technology, cultural anthropology, stories and narrative, mindmaps, concept maps and eco-language, and single frames and similar visualization techniques. Individuals use these tools to capture and ideas, expertise, experience, opinions, or thoughts, and this 'voicing' will encourage cognitive diversity and promote free exchanges away from a centralized policed knowledge repository. The goal is to facilitate knowledge sharing and personal content management.

BEATING PROCRASTINATION

If you've found yourself putting off important tasks over and over again, you're not alone. In fact, many people procrastinate to some degree – but some are so chronically affected by procrastination that it stops them fulfilling their potential and disrupts their careers. The key to controlling this destructive habit is to recognize when you start procrastinating, understand why it happens and take active steps to manage your time and outcomes better.

WHAT IS PROCRASTINATION?

In a nutshell, you procrastinate when you put off things that you should be focusing on right now, usually in favour of doing something that is more enjoyable or that you're

more comfortable doing. Clarry Lay, a prominent writer on procrastination, procrastination occurs when there's "a temporal gap between intended behaviour and enacted behaviour." That is, procrastination is occurring when there's a significant time period between when people intend to do a job, and when they actually do it.

HOW TO OVERCOME PROCRASTINATION

Follow these steps to deal with and control procrastination:

Step 1: Recognize That You're Procrastinating

If you're honest with yourself, you probably know when you're procrastinating. But to be sure, take our Are You a Procrastinator? self test.

Here are some useful indicators that will help you know when you're procrastinating:

- Filling your day with low priority tasks from your To Do List.
- Reading e-mails several times without starting work on them or deciding what you're going to do with them.
- Sitting down to start a high-priority task, and almost immediately going off to make a cup of coffee.
- Leaving an item on your To Do list for a long time, even though you know it's important.
- Regularly saying "Yes" to unimportant tasks that others ask you to do, and filling your time with these instead of getting on with the important tasks already on your list.
- Waiting for the "right mood" or the "right time" to tackle the important task at hand.

Step 2: Work Out Why You're Procrastinating

Why you procrastinate can depend on both you and the task. But it's important to understand which of the two is relevant in a given situation, so that you can select the best approach for overcoming your reluctance to get going.

One reason for procrastination is that people find a particular job unpleasant, and try to avoid it because of that. Most jobs have unpleasant or boring aspects to them, and often the best way of dealing with these is to get them over and done with quickly, so that you can focus on the more enjoyable aspects of the job.

Another cause is that people are disorganized. Organized people manage to fend off the temptation to procrastinate, because they will have things like prioritized to-do lists and schedules which emphasize how important the piece work is, and identify precisely when it's due.

They'll also have planned how long a task will take to do, and will have worked back from that point to identify when they need to get started in order to avoid it being

late. Organized people are also better placed to avoid procrastination, because they know how to break the work down into manageable “next steps”.

Even if you’re organized, you can feel overwhelmed by the task. You may doubt that you have the skills or resources you think you need, so you seek comfort in doing tasks you know you’re capable of completing.

Unfortunately, the big task isn’t going to go away – truly important tasks rarely do. You may also fear success as much as failure. For example, you may think that success will lead to you being swamped with more requests to do this type of task, or that you’ll be pushed to take on things that you feel are beyond you.

Surprisingly, perfectionists are often procrastinators, as they can tend to think “I don’t have the right skills or resources to do this perfectly now, so I won’t do it at all.”

One final major cause of procrastination is having underdeveloped decision-making skills. If you simply can’t decide what to do, you’re likely to put off taking action in case you do the wrong thing.

Step 3: Adopt Anti-Procrastination Strategies

Procrastination is a habit – a deeply ingrained pattern of behaviour. That means that you won’t just break it overnight. Habits only stop being habits when you have persistently stopped practising them, so use as many approaches as possible to maximize your chances of beating procrastination. Some tips will work better for some people than for others, and for some tasks than others. And, sometimes, you may simply need to try a fresh approach to beat the “procrastination peril”!

These general tips will help motivate you to get moving:

- Make up your own rewards. For example, promise yourself a piece of tasty flapjack at lunchtime if you’ve completed a certain task. And make sure you notice how good it feels to finish things!
- Ask someone else to check up on you. Peer pressure works! This is the principle behind slimming and other self-help groups, and it is widely recognized as a highly effective approach.
- Identify the unpleasant consequences of NOT doing the task.
- Work out the cost of your time to your employer. As your employers are paying you to do the things that they think are important, you’re not delivering value for money if you’re not doing those things. Shame yourself into getting going!
- Aim to “eat an elephant beetle” first thing, every day!

If you’re procrastinating because you’re disorganized, here’s how to get organized!:

- Keep a To-Do list so that you can’t “conveniently” forget about unpleasant or overwhelming tasks.
- Use an Urgent/Important Matrix to help prioritize your to-do list so that you can’t try to kid yourself that it would be acceptable to put off doing something

on the grounds that it's unimportant, or that you have many urgent things which ought to be done first when, in reality, you're procrastinating.

- Become a master of scheduling and project planning, so that you know when to start those all-important projects.
- Set yourself time-bound goals: that way, you'll have no time for procrastination!
- Focus on one task at a time.

If you're putting off starting a project because you find it overwhelming, you need to take a different approach.

Here are some tips:

- Break the project into a set of smaller, more manageable tasks. You may find it helpful to create an action plan.
- Start with some quick, small tasks if you can, even if these aren't the logical first actions. You'll feel that you're achieving things, and so perhaps the whole project won't be so overwhelming after all.

If you're procrastinating because you find the task unpleasant:

- Many procrastinators overestimate the unpleasantness of a task. So give it a try! You may find that it's not as bad as you thought!
- Hold the unpleasant consequences of not doing the work at the front of your mind.
- Reward yourself for doing the task.

Finally, if you're procrastinating because you can't decide what action to take, and are putting off making a decision because you're nervous about making the wrong choice. This teaches a range of powerful and effective decision-making techniques.

Remember: the longer you can spend without procrastinating, the greater your chances of breaking this destructive habit for good!

KEY POINTS

To have a good chance of conquering procrastination, you need to spot straight away that you're doing it. Then, you need to identify why you're procrastinating and taken appropriate steps to overcome the block.

Part of the solution is to develop good time management, organizational and personal effectiveness habits, such as those described in *Make Time for Success!* This helps you establish the right priorities, and manage your time in such a way that you make the most of the opportunities open to you.

ACTIVITY LOGS

How long do you spend each day on unimportant things; Things that don't really contribute to your success at work? Do you **KNOW** how much time you've spent reading junk mail, talking to colleagues, making coffee and eating lunch? And how often have you thought, "I could achieve so much more if I just had another half hour each day." And are you aware of when in the day you check your e-mail, write important

substances or do your long-term planning? Most people find they function at different levels of effectiveness at different times of day as their energy levels fluctuate. Your effectiveness may vary depending on the amount of sugar in your blood, the length of time since you last took a break, routine distractions, stress, discomfort, or a range of other factors.

Activity logs help you to analyse how you actually spend your time. The first time you use an activity log you may be shocked to see the amount of time that you waste! Memory is a very poor guide when it comes to this, as it can be too easy to forget time spent on non-core tasks.

Keeping an Activity Log for several days helps you to understand how you spend your time, and when you perform at your best. Without modifying your behaviour any further than you have to, note down the things you do as you do them on this template. Every time you change activities, whether opening mail, working, making coffee, gossiping with colleagues or whatever, note down the time of the change.

As well as recording activities, note how you feel, whether alert, flat, tired, energetic, etc. Do this periodically throughout the day. You may decide to integrate your activity log with a stress diary.

Once you have logged your time for a few days, analyse your daily activity log. You may be alarmed to see the amount of time you spend doing low value jobs!

You may also see that you are energetic in some parts of the day, and flat in other parts. A lot of this can depend on the rest breaks you take, the times and amounts you eat, and quality of your nutrition. The activity log gives you some basis for experimenting with these variables.

Your analysis should help you to free up extra time in your day by applying one of the following actions to most activities:

- Eliminate jobs that your employer shouldn't be paying you to do. These may include tasks that someone else in the organization should be doing, possibly at a lower pay rate, or personal activities such as sending non-work e-mails.
- Schedule your most challenging tasks for the times of day when your energy is highest. That way your work will be better and it should take you less time.
- Try to minimize the number of times a day you switch between types of task. For example, read and reply to e-mails in blocks once in the morning and once in the afternoon only.
- Reduce the amount of time spent on legitimate personal activities such as making coffee.

Activity logs are useful tools for auditing the way that you use your time. They can also help you to track changes in your energy, alertness and effectiveness throughout the day.

By analyzing your activity log you will be able to identify and eliminate time-wasting or low-yield jobs. You will also know the times of day at which you are most effective, so that you can carry out your most important tasks during these times.

TO-DO LISTS

Do you frequently feel overwhelmed by the amount of work you have to do? Do you face a constant barrage of looming deadlines? Or do you sometimes just forget to do something important, so that people have to chase you to get work done? All of these are symptoms of not keeping a proper "To-Do List". To-Do Lists are prioritized lists of all the tasks that you need to carry out. They list everything that you have to do, with the most important tasks at the top of the list, and the least important tasks at the bottom.

While this sounds a simple thing to do, it's when people start to use To-Do Lists properly that they often make their first personal productivity/time management breakthrough, and start to make a real success of their careers.

By keeping a To-Do List, you make sure that you capture all of the tasks you have to complete in one place. This is essential if you're not going to forget things. And by prioritizing work, you plan the order in which you'll do things, so you can tell what needs your immediate attention, and what you can quietly forget about until much, much later. This is essential if you're going to beat work overload. Without To-Do Lists, you'll seem dizzy, unfocused and unreliable to the people around you. With To-Do Lists, you'll be much better organized, and will seem much more reliable. This is very important!

PREPARING A TO-DO LIST

Start by writing down all of the tasks that you need to complete, and if they are large, break them down into their component elements. If these still seem large, break them down again. Do this until you have listed everything that you have to do, and until tasks are will take no more than 1-2 hours to complete. This may be a huge and intimidating list, but our next step makes it manageable!

Next, run through these jobs allocating priorities from A to F. If too many tasks have a high priority, run through the list again and demote the less important ones. Once you have done this, rewrite the list in priority order.

You will then have a precise plan that you can use to eliminate the problems you face. You will be able to tackle these in order of importance or urgency. This allows you to separate important jobs from the many time-consuming trivial ones.

USING YOUR TO-DO LISTS

Different people use To-Do Lists in different ways in different situations: if you are in a sales-type role, a good way of motivating yourself is to keep your list relatively short and aim to complete it every day.

In an operational role, or if tasks are large or dependent on too many other people, then it may be better to keep one list and 'chip away' at it.

It may be that you carry unimportant jobs from one To-Do List to the next. You may not be able to complete some very low priority jobs for several months. Only worry

about this if you need to – if you are running up against a deadline for them, raise their priority. If you have not used To-Do Lists before, try them now: They are one of the keys to being really productive and efficient.

KEY POINTS

Prioritized To-Do Lists are fundamentally important to efficient work.

If you use To-Do Lists, you will ensure that:

- You remember to carry out all necessary tasks
- You tackle the most important jobs first, and do not waste time on trivial tasks.
- You do not get stressed by a large number of unimportant jobs.

To draw up a Prioritized To-Do List, download our template and use it to list all the tasks you must carry out. Mark the importance of the task next to it, with a priority from A to F. Redraft the list into this order of importance.

Now carry out the jobs at the top of the list first. These are the most important, most beneficial tasks to complete.

ACTION PROGRAMMES

To-Do Lists are great for managing a small number of tasks. The problem is that, for most of us, our To-Do List is not really a planned, focused action list. Rather, it is a sort of a catch-all for a lot of things that are unresolved and not yet translated into outcomes.

Specific entries, such as “Call Tina,” exist along with vaguer aspirations, such as “Get started on house painting project.” Often, the real actionable details of what the list-maker has “to do” are actually missing.

What this means is that you tend to do the specific tasks, and fail to make progress with the big, important projects. And even if you do get beyond the quick actions, having a complete project as a “to do” can lead you to focus all of your attention on it. This makes multi-tasking difficult.

This can be a serious problem in a job where you need to make progress on many different projects at the same time - and this is exactly the situation most senior managers find themselves in.

This is where Action Programmes are useful. Action Programmes are “industrial strength” versions of To-Do Lists. Because they incorporate short-, medium- and long-term goals, they allow you to plan your time, without forgotten commitments coming in to blow your schedule apart.

Because priorities are properly thought through, you’ll be focusing on the things that matter, and not frittering your time away on low value activities. And because they support delegation, they help you get into the habit of delegating jobs where you can. All of this lets you save time - and get away on time - whilst also significantly increasing your effectiveness and productivity.

HOW TO USE THE TOOL

Follow this four-step procedure to create your Action Programme:

Step 1. Collection

First, make a list inventory of all the things in your world that require resolution. Try to collect and write down everything - urgent or not, big or small, personal or professional - that you feel is incomplete and needs action from you to get completed.

To an extent, this collection is taking place automatically. E-mail requests are getting stored in your email account, memos demanding attention are being delivered to your in-tray, mail is reaching your mailbox and messages asking for action are accumulating on your voice mail. But there is other stuff - stuff that is idling in your head, projects you want to run, things you intend to deal with lying at the bottom of the drawer, ideas written down on stray bits of paper - that need to be gathered and put in place too. Bring all of these actions and projects together and inventory them in one place. And - this is really important - make sure that your personal goals are brought onto this list.

Step 2. Pruning

Now, process the list you made in step 1, by looking carefully at each item.

Decide whether you should, actually, take action on it. A lot of what comes our way has no real relevance to us, or is really not important in the scale of things. If that is the case, then delete these things from your inventory.

Step 3. Organizing and Prioritizing

This comes in three parts.

First of all, review your inventory of items. For any which are separate, individual actions that make up part of a larger project, group these individual actions together into their projects. For example, at home, you may want to improve your bathroom, and repaint your living room: these can go into a "Home Renovation" project. At work, you may be providing input into the requirements for a new computer system, and may be expected to test and then train your team on this system at a point in the future: all of these go into a "computer system" project. What you'll find is that once you start, items will almost seem to "organize themselves" into coherent projects. You also need to make sure that your personal goals are included as individual projects. Second, review these projects, and allocate a priority to them depending on their importance. Clearly, your personal goals are exceptionally important projects!

Third, insert your projects into a formatted Action Programme.

The Action Programme is split up into three parts:

1. A "Next Action List," which shows the small next actions that you will take to move your projects forward.
2. A "Delegated Actions List," which shows projects and actions have delegated to other people.

3. A “Project Catalog” that shows all of the projects you are engaged in and the small individual tasks that you have identified so far that contribute to them.

The great news is that, by this stage, you’ve already created the largest part of this: the Project Catalog! This is the list of prioritized projects and activities that you’ve just completed. Typically, the Project Catalog is at the back of the Action Programme, as it’s often only referred to during a weekly review process.

Next, create the Delegated Actions List by working through your Project Catalog, and identifying tasks that you’ve delegated. Record these under the name of the person who you’ve delegated the activity to, along with the checkpoints you’ve agreed.

Typically, the Delegated Actions List sits in front of the Project Catalog in your Action Programme document, as it’s referred to quite often. Finally, create your Next Action List by working through the projects to which you’ve given the highest priority - the projects that you want and need to move forward on straight away - and extracting the small, logical next actions for these projects.

Now review the Next Action List. If it is too cluttered, move some of the less urgent/important jobs back into the project catalog. If it is thin and under-challenging, pull up some more Next Actions from the Project Catalog. Also, it makes sense to prioritize the items in the Next Action List so you know what to focus on.

Step 4. “Working” Your Action Programme

An Action Programme is typically fairly long. But you don’t have to run through the entire Programme every day!

Usually, you’ll only be dealing with the top page or pages. Some activities may be day-specific or time-specific. Depending of the way you work, these can be either maintained as the top page of your Action Programme or marked on your calendar.

In effect, these are just a new form of your old To-Do List. It is just that only specific short actions are outlined here, while the major projects to which the actions belong are stored in your Project Catalog. What you must do, however, is review your Action Programme periodically, for example, every week. Delete or archive items you’ve completed, move items from the Project Catalog to the front pages as you make progress on your project, and add any new actions that have come your way.

PRIORITIZATION

Prioritization is the essential skill you need to make the very best use of your own efforts, and those of your team.

It is particularly important when time is limited and demands are seemingly unlimited. It helps you to spend your time wisely, freeing you and your team up from less important tasks that can be attended to later – or quietly dropped. With good prioritization you can bring order to chaos, massively reduce stress, and move forwards successfully. Without it, you’ll flounder around, drowning in competing demands.

SIMPLE PRIORITIZATION

At a simple level, you can prioritize based on time constraints, on the potential profitability or benefit of the task you're facing, or on the pressure you're under to complete a job:

- Prioritization based on project value or profitability is probably the most commonly-used and rational basis for prioritization. Whether this is based on a subjective guess at value or a sophisticated financial evaluation, it often gives the most efficient results.
- Time constraints are important where other people are depending on you to complete a task, and particularly where this task is on the critical path of an important project. Here, a small amount of your own effort can go a very long way.
- And it's a brave person who resists his or her boss's pressure to complete a task, when that pressure is reasonable and legitimate.

PRIORITIZATION TOOLS

While these simple approaches to prioritization suit many situations, there are plenty of special cases where you'll need other prioritization and time management tools if you're going to be truly effective.

While these simple approaches to prioritization suit many situations, there are plenty of special cases where you'll need other tools if you're going to be truly effective.

We look at some of these are:

- *Paired Comparison Analysis:* Paired Comparison Analysis is most useful where decision criteria are vague, subjective or inconsistent. It helps you prioritize options by asking you to compare each item on a list with all other items on the list individually. By deciding in each case which of the two is most important, you can consolidate results to get a prioritized list.
- *Grid Analysis:* Grid Analysis helps you prioritize a list of tasks where you need to take many different factors into consideration.
- *The Action Priority Matrix:* This quick and simple diagramming technique asks you to plot the value of the task against the effort it will consume. By doing this you can quickly spot the "quick wins" which will give you the greatest rewards in the shortest possible time, and avoid the "hard slogs" which soak up time for little eventual reward. This is an ingenious approach for making highly efficient prioritization decisions.
- *The Urgent/Important Matrix:* Similar to the Action Priority Matrix, this technique asks you to think about whether tasks are urgent or important. Frequently, seemingly urgent tasks actually aren't that important. And often, really important activities just aren't that urgent. This approach helps you cut through this.

- *The Ansoff and Boston Matrices*: These give you quick “rules of thumb” for prioritizing the opportunities open to you. The Ansoff Matrix helps you evaluate and prioritize opportunities by risk. The Boston Matrix does a similar job, helping you prioritize opportunities based on the attractiveness of a market and your ability to take advantage of it.
- *Pareto Analysis*: Where you’re facing a flurry of problems needing to be solved, Pareto Analysis helps you identify the most important changes to make. It firstly asks you to group together the different types of problem you face, and then asks you to count the number of cases of each type of problem. By prioritizing the most common type of problem, you can focus your efforts on resolving it. This clears time to focus on the next set of problems, and so on.
- *Nominal Group Technique*: Nominal Group Technique is a useful technique for prioritizing issues and projects within a group, giving everyone fair input into the prioritization process. This is particularly useful where consensus is important, and where a robust group decision needs to be made. Using this tool, each group participant “nominates” his or her priority issues, and then ranks them on a scale, of say 1 to 10. The score for each issue is then added up, with issues then prioritized based on scores. The obvious fairness of this approach makes it particularly useful where prioritization is based on subjective criteria, and where people’s “buy in” to the prioritization decision is needed.

EFFECTIVE SCHEDULING

So far in this section of Mind Tools, we have looked at your priorities and your goals – these define what you aspire to do with your time. Scheduling is where these aspirations meet reality.

Scheduling is the process by which you look at the time available to you, and plan how you will use it to achieve the goals you have identified.

By using a schedule properly, you can:

- Understand what you can realistically achieve with your time;
- Plan to make the best use of the time available;
- Leave enough time for things you absolutely must do;
- Preserve contingency time to handle ‘the unexpected’; and
- Minimize stress by avoiding over-commitment to others.

A well thought-through schedule allows you to manage your commitments, while still leaving you time to do the things that are important to you. It is therefore your most important weapon for beating work overload.

HOW TO USE THE TOOL

Scheduling is best done on a regular basis, for example at the start of every week.

Go through the following steps in preparing your schedule:

- Start by identifying the time you want to make available for your work. This will depend on the design of your job and on your personal goals in life.
- Next, block in the actions you absolutely must take to do a good job. These will often be the things you are assessed against. For example, if you manage people, then you must make time available for coaching, supervision, and dealing with issues that arise. Similarly, you must allow time to communicate with your boss and key people around you.
- Review your To Do List, and schedule in the high-priority, urgent activities, as well as the essential maintenance tasks that cannot be delegated and cannot be avoided.
- Next, block in appropriate contingency time. You will learn how much of this you need by experience. Normally, the more unpredictable your job, the more contingency time you need. The reality of many people's work is of constant interruption: Studies show some managers getting an average of as little as six minutes uninterrupted work done at a time. Obviously, you cannot tell when interruptions will occur. However, by leaving space in your schedule, you give yourself the flexibility to rearrange your schedule to react effectively to urgent issues.
- What you now have left is your "discretionary time": the time available to deliver your priorities and achieve your goals. Review your Prioritized To Do List and personal goals, evaluate the time needed to achieve these actions, and schedule them in.

By the time you reach step 5, you may find that you have little or no discretionary time available.

If this is the case, then revisit the assumptions you used in the first four steps. Question whether things are absolutely necessary, whether they can be delegated, or whether they can be done in an abbreviated way.

Remember that one of the most important ways people learn to achieve success is by maximizing the 'leverage' they can achieve with their time.

They increase the amount of work they can manage by delegating work to other people, spending money outsourcing key tasks, or using technology to automate as much of their work as possible. This frees them up to achieve their goals.

Also, use this as an opportunity to review your To Do List and Personal Goals. Have you set goals that just aren't achievable with the time you have available? Are you taking on too many additional duties? Or are you treating things as being more important than they really are?

If your discretionary time is still limited, then you may need to renegotiate your workload. With a well-thought through schedule as evidence, you may find this surprisingly easy.

KEY POINTS

Scheduling is the process by which you plan your use of time. By scheduling effectively, you can reduce stress and maximize your effectiveness. This makes it one of the most important time management skills you can use.

Before you can schedule efficiently, you need an effective scheduling system. This can be a diary, calendar, paper-based organizer, PDA or a software package like MS Outlook. The best solution depends entirely on your circumstances.

Scheduling is then a five-step process:

1. Identify the time you have available.
2. Block in the essential tasks you must carry out to succeed in your job.
3. Schedule in high priority urgent tasks and vital “house-keeping” activities.
4. Block in appropriate contingency time to handle unpredictable interruptions.
5. In the time that remains, schedule the activities that address your priorities and personal goals.

If you have little or no discretionary time left by the time you reach step five, then revisit the assumptions you have made in steps one to four.

GOAL SETTING

The ability to set goals is at the very core of personal productivity, career success, and effective leadership; and the resources on this page help you learn how to do this.

PERSONAL GOAL SETTING

Why is personal goal setting so important in personal time management? From the time management perspective, your life is a sequence of big and small choices and decisions. It is those choices that you really manage, not the flow of time.

Personal goal setting is the wisdom that comes out of a lot of practical experience and psychology research to help you direct your conscious and subconscious decisions towards success, building up your motivation to achieve your personal or business goals.

LOCKE’S GOAL SETTING THEORY

Edwin Locke’s theory of goal setting has many practical applications, in and outside of the business environment. A professor at the University of Maryland, Locke’s theory defines characteristics that encourage success. While the theory rings of psychology, its applications in the business world have been profound and enduring.

The Influence of Ryan

Locke’s goal-setting theory was created on the premise, originally set forth by professor Thomas A. Ryan, that “conscious goals affect action.” As quoted in Locke’s

“Building a Practically Useful Theory of Goal Setting and Task Motivation,” Ryan argued that human behaviour is affected by conscious purposes, plans, intentions, tasks and the like.

Basic Definition

Locke’s theory operates on the premise that individuals create goals by making careful decisions to do so and are compelled towards those goals by virtue of the goal having been set. Basically, Locke’s theory states that if an individual sets goals, he will be motivated to achieve those goals by virtue of having set them.

Several elements must exist in order for the goal-setting effect to take place. Goals must be clear, challenging and attainable, and there must be some method of receiving feedback. Locke finds that the goal itself is not the motivator, but rather the perceived difference between what was actually attained and what had been planned for.

Goal Difficulty and Performance

Locke, and professors Steve Motowidlo and Phil Bobko found that “higher expectancies lead to higher levels of performance,” which is in accordance with Vroom’s valence-instrumentality-expectancy theory. Somewhat contradictorily, they also showed that when expectations are low but goal level is high, performance would be high also.

Goal Mechanisms

Goals serve four primary functions:

1. By specifying a goal, one must direct focus towards that goal and away from activities unrelated to that goal.
2. The setting of a goal is a behaviour-stimulating act. Locke, “high goals lead to greater effort than low goals.”
3. Goals have a positive effect on persistence. However, there is an inverse relationship between time and intensity.
4. Goals subconsciously direct the person towards discovering better ways of doing things, be they calculations or physical acts.

Goal Moderators

Locke’s theory states that, in order for a goal to be successful, the person must be committed to it wholly and possess self-efficacy.

This self-efficacy must be boosted initially by the fact that the person was assigned the task and thus believed to be capable of its completion. He also found that “for goals to be effective, people need summary feedback that reveals progress in relation to their goals.

If they do not know how they are doing, it is difficult or impossible for them to adjust the level or direction of their effort or to adjust their performance strategies to

match what the goal requires.” Task complexity also moderates the effects of goals because more complex goals require the review of more complex strategies than lower difficulty goals.

Lastly, more complex goals require proximal goals rather than a singular distal goal.

Basically, the complex goals should be broken down into several smaller goals. The setting of proximal goals also promotes progress feedback.

Limitations

As noted by Locke, his goal-setting theory has several limitations:

- *Goal conflict:* Sometimes an individual has several goals, some of which may be in conflict. When this occurs, performance will suffer.
- *Goals and risk:* More difficult goals/deadlines can spur riskier behaviours and strategies.
- *Personality:* Goal success is largely effected by self-efficacy. Also, personality plays a large role in goal determination and approach.
- *Goals and subconscious motivation:* Subconscious motivators affect people regularly, but how these subconscious motivators affect goal performance has not been studied.

GOLDEN RULES OF GOAL SETTING

If you want to succeed, you need to set goals. Without goals you lack focus and direction. Goal setting not only allows you to take control of your life’s direction; it also provides you a benchmark for determining whether you are actually succeeding.

Think about it: Having a million dollars in the bank is only proof of success if one of your goals is to amass riches. If your goal is to practice acts of charity, then keeping the money for yourself is suddenly contrary to how you would define success.

To accomplish your goals, however, you need to know how to set them. You can’t simply say, “I want.” and expect it to happen. Goal setting is a process that starts with careful consideration of what you want to achieve, and ends with a lot of hard work to actually do it.

In between there are some very well defined steps that transcend the specifics of each goal. Knowing these steps will allow you to formulate goals that you can accomplish. Here are our Five Golden Rules of Goal Setting:

The Five Golden Rules

Rule No. 1: Set Goals

Set Goals that Motivate You When you set goals for yourself, it is important that they motivate you: This means making sure it is something that’s important to you and there is value in achieving it.

If you have little interest in the outcome, or it is irrelevant given the larger picture, then the chances of you putting in the work to make it happen are slim. Motivation is key to achieving goals.

Set goals that relate to the high priorities in your life. Without this type of focus you can end up with far too many goals, leaving you too little time to devote to each one. Goal achievement requires commitment, so to maximize the likelihood of success, you need to feel a sense of urgency and have an “I must do this” attitude.

When you don’t have this “must do” factor, you risk putting off what you need to do to make the goal a reality. This in turn leaves you feeling disappointed and frustrated with yourself, both of which are de-motivating. And you can end up in a very destructive “I can’t do anything or be successful at anything” frame of mind.

Rule No. 2: Set Smart Goals

You have probably heard of “SMART goals” already. But do you always apply the rule? The simple fact is that for any goal to be achieved it must be designed to be SMART.

There are many variations on what SMART stands for, but the essence is this - Goals should be:

- Specific
- Measurable
- Attainable
- Relevant
- Time Bound

Set Specific Goals

Your goal must be clear and well defined. Vague or generalized goals are not achievable because they don’t provide sufficient direction. Remember, you need goals to show you the way.

How useful would a map of the United States be if there were only state borders marked on it and you were trying to get from Miami to Los Angeles? Do you even know which state you are starting from let alone which one you’re headed to? Make it as easy as you can to get where you want to go by defining precisely where it is you want to end up.

Set Measurable Goals

Include precise amounts, dates, etc in your goals so you can measure your degree of success. If your goal is simply defined as “To reduce expenses” how will you know when you are successful? In one month’s time if you have a 1% reduction or in two year’s time when you have a 10% reduction? Without a way to measure your success you miss out on the celebration that comes with knowing you actually achieved something.

Set Attainable Goals

Make sure that it's possible to achieve the goals you set. If you set a goal that you have no hope of achieving you will only demoralize yourself and erode your confidence.

However, resist the urge to set goals that are too easy. Accomplishing a goal that you didn't have to work very hard for can be an anticlimax at best, and can also make you fear setting future goals that carry a risk of non-achievement. By setting realistic yet challenging goals you hit the balance you need. These are the types of goals that require you to "raise the bar" and they bring the greatest personal satisfaction.

Set Relevant Goals

Goals should be relevant to the direction you want your life and career to take.

By keeping goals aligned with this, you'll develop the focus you need to get ahead and do what you want. Set widely scattered and inconsistent goals, and you'll fritter your time - and your life - away.

Set Time-Bound Goals

Your goals must have a deadline. This again, is so that you know when to celebrate your success. When you are working on a deadline, your sense of urgency increases and achievement will come that much quicker.

Rule No. 3: Set Goals in Writing

The physical animation of writing down a goal makes it real and tangible. You have no excuse for forgetting about it. As you write, use the word "will" instead of "would like to" or "might". For example, "I will reduce my operating expenses by 10% this year." Not, "I would like to reduce my operating expenses by 10% this year." The first goal statement has power and you can "see" yourself reducing expenses, the second lacks passion and gives you an out if you get sidetracked.

Post your goals in visible places to remind yourself everyday of what it is you intend to do. Put them on your walls, desk, computer monitor, bathroom mirror or refrigerator as a constant reminder. You can even post them in the Mind Tools Career Excellence Club forum and share them with other members, for added motivation.

Rule No. 4: Make an Action Plan

This step is often missed in the process of goal setting. You get so focused on the outcome that you forget to plan all of the steps that are needed along the way. By writing out the individual steps, and then crossing each one off as you complete it, you'll realise that you are making progress towards your ultimate goal. This is especially important if your goal is big and demanding, or long-term.

Rule No. 5: Stick With It!

Remember, goal setting is an ongoing activity not just a means to an end. Build in reminders to keep you on track and remember to review your goals continuously. Your

end destination may remain quite similar over the long term but the action plan you set for yourself along the way can change significantly. Make sure the relevance, value, and necessity remain high.

Key Points

Goal setting is much more than simply saying you want something to happen. Unless you clearly define exactly what you want and understand why you want it the first place, your odds of success are considerably reduced.

By following the Five Golden Rules of Goal Setting you can set goals with confidence and enjoy the satisfaction that comes along with knowing you achieved what you set out to do. What will you decide to accomplish today?

BACKWARD GOAL-SETTING

If your goal is to become an account executive within the next five years, where do you start your planning process? Or if your team needs to redesign the company's organizational structure, where do you begin?

In planning, most of us would usually start building our plan from start to finish. What do you have to do first, second, third, and so on? What milestones do you have to reach before you can continue on with the next step in the plan? By what date does each step need to be completed?

This is a solid form of Personal Goal Setting that works very well. When combined with the Golden Rules of Goal Setting, you have a motivating formula that can help you actively move yourself forward.

A New Approach

However, there's another, simple but lesser-used method of goal setting that can be equally as powerful. It can show you other ways to achieve the same result, and it can help you deal with the necessary unknowns of goal setting that can so often cause you to give up on your plan entirely.

It's called backward planning, backward goal-setting, or backward design, and it's used quite often in education and training.

The idea is to start with your ultimate objective, your end goal, and then work backward from there to develop your plan. By starting at the end and looking back, you can mentally prepare yourself for success, map out the specific milestones you need to reach, and identify where in your plan you have to be particularly energetic or creative to achieve the desired results.

It's much like a good presentation, when the presenter tells you where he's headed right at the beginning. Then, as the presentation unfolds, it's easy for you to follow the concepts and think critically about what's being said. If you have to figure out the main points as they come, your energy is often used up by just trying to keep up.

The Backward Planning Process

Here's how it works:

- Write down your ultimate goal. What specifically do you want to achieve, and by what date? *Example:* “By January 1, 2013, I will be the key accounts director for Crunchy Chips International.”
- Then ask yourself what milestone you need to accomplish just before that, in order to achieve your ultimate goal. What specifically do you have to do, and by when, so that you're in a position to reach your final objective?
Example: “By September 30, 2011, I will successfully complete the executive training programme offered by Crunchy Chips International.”
- Then work backward some more. What do you need to complete before that second-to-last goal?
Example: “By March 1, 2011, I will submit my application for the executive training programme, outlining my successes as a key accounts manager, and I will be accepted into the programme.”
- Work back again. What do you need to do to make sure the previous goal is reached?
Example: “By January 1, 2011, I will complete my second year as a key accounts manager with Crunchy Chips International, and I will earn the prestigious Key Accounts Manager of the Year award.”
- Continue to work back, in the same way, until you identify the very first milestone that you need to accomplish.
Example: “By January 1, 2010, I will complete my first year as a key accounts manager with Crunchy Chips International, and I will be rewarded for my performance by gaining responsibility for clients purchasing over \$10 million per year.”
“By January 1, 2009, I will be promoted to key accounts manager with Crunchy Chips International, and I will have responsibility for clients purchasing over \$1 million per quarter.”

When you read a backward plan, it doesn't look much different from a traditional forward plan. However, creating a backward plan is VERY different. You need to force yourself to think from a completely new perspective, to help you see things that you might miss if you use a traditional chronological process.

This can also help you avoid spending time on unnecessary or unproductive activities along the way. Furthermore, it highlights points of tension within the plan, showing where you'll need to be particularly creative to make the next step successfully.

KEY POINTS

On the surface, backward planning doesn't seem much different from traditional goal-setting processes. You start with a basic vision, and then you ask yourself what needs to be done to achieve that vision. You can read your plan from the beginning to

the end, or from the end back to the beginning. Backward planning, however, is more than reversing the direction of your traditional plan. It's about adopting a different perspective and, perhaps, identifying different milestones as a result. It's a great supplement to traditional planning, and it gives you a much fuller appreciation for what it may take to achieve success. After all, the more alternatives you have, the better your final plan will likely be.

Successfully manage your Time

To successfully manage your time you have to get organized both in your professional and personal life. Getting organized in an efficient way is a skill that not all people have. To manage your life and work you need to first manage your time.

In our days people spend most of their time working. There are times that they feel that they will never manage to escape from the four walls of the office and are lost in the various projects and tasks they have to finish.

Their personal life has become an old memory, which has been «locked in the drawer». The solution to this vicious circle is one: get organized and start managing your time. This article outlines 14 ways that can help you manage your time successfully and efficiently.

Make a list of what should be Done

Make a list of what to do and try to constantly renew the list and keep it up to date. Include in this list both urgent and non-urgent things so as never forget or ignore something again. Keep the list all the time with you, in your briefcase or in your daily agenda.

Allocate your time Correctly

Include an estimated time frame for each action and the date by which each task must be completed. If the order that each task must be completed does not matter it may be possible to complete something during an unexpected free time. For example, you can look for information on the Internet while you wait in your office to start a meeting.

Set your own deadlines and meet Them

Be realistic about the deadlines you set and try to meet them. It is true that any work gets exactly the time allocated for it. Have you ever noticed how quickly you can finish something you have to write, give assignments and take decisions on the last day before your vacation? Although we tend to complete many things when we are under pressure, is less stressful and much more professional to establish and follow an action plan.

Use your time Intelligently

Consider the case to check your e-mail only certain times of the day and let the answering machine respond to your calls so as not to interrupt your work for a couple

of hours. If possible, avoid dealing with the same job or the same e-mail again. Never open e-mail address if you do not have time to read and edit, that is, to answer it, send, or delete it.

Organize your Desktop

Organize your desktop; manage the copies of your files, your computer folders and e-mail folders so that you can easily find what you want. Minimize the time you spend when searching for information. *Benjamin Franklin once said: «A place for everything, everything in place».*

Insist in your Targets

You should have an “in tray” in your office so that others can give you what they want to give you and not just leave it on your desk. Have you ever come back from a meeting and find additional records, letters and documents all over your office? Rather than follow your own program, you are “forced” to follow someone else’s priorities.

Do not distract your Attention

If you have a door, you need to close it occasionally. If you have an open door policy that must always be open for your employees, but if you do not have time to really listen to their questions and concerns, then you will not manage to keep your promise. If a colleague comes to your office when you have a job and cannot discuss, seek to find another time to meet.

Co-operate with your Colleagues

Colleagues will expect you to finish the job on time, so make sure to avoid any delay. You would expect the same from them. To avoid any delays, give more time to the project so as to be able to handle unexpected complications, misunderstandings or missed deadlines. If the date of presentation is the 25th of the month, be sure to plan to finish everything by 23.

Avoid unnecessary Supervisions

If you authorize someone else for a job or a contract, do not deal any more with this, unless you have a specific responsibility to monitor. Many people spend precious time to listen or read reports of other projects. If the investigation of your colleagues or their professional responsibilities does not affect your daily work, your performance at work or objectives of your career, you could simply express an interest just to encourage them.

Cancel routine Meetings

Decide if the meeting is absolutely necessary. If, you have to attend, set an agenda and make sure that you follow it – start the meeting and finish it on time. If your presence is not necessary for the entire meeting then leave earlier.

Be constantly Busy

Keep your skills in shape by having at least one project to be involved. Two or more (projects) would be even better because you are given the opportunity to «change speed» and to focus on something else for variety. To deal simultaneously with different project assures that you will always have something on which to work. Also, it keeps your mind alert and renews your prospects.

Choose carefully your Projects

Make sure that your work has some value for the company and that it raises your skills. There are many good reasons why you cannot accept to take part in a meeting and refuse to take an additional project. Successful entrepreneurs know how to say «no». Ask yourself, «this will promote my career?» and «Can I give the necessary time to this assignment?» You will win more respect by working with a colleague, whose expertise and skills complements your own, rather than getting an extra work on your own and overloading yourself.

Do not waste your Time

It is an integral part of human nature to postpone unpleasant tasks. Plan some of the more pleasant tasks of the project to be made after any unpleasant tasks. If you do not like to work with numbers, plan to do the accounts in the morning when you are still fresh and there are not so many things to distract your attention.

Reward Yourself

To manage your time efficiently does not have to do only with your job. You should also include in your schedule time where you stop everything, relax and recharge your batteries. Think of a reward to give yourself when you finish your work. This may mean to make a break for coffee once finished reading a long report or to leave for vacation just after the promotion of the new product.

You must give greater attention to how you spend your time. Watch how successful businessmen allocate their time and emulate some of their time management practices. Success comes to those who know how to manage their time well.

8

Accommodation and Layout in Office

OFFICE LAYOUT

Office productivity is influenced by a number of factors, one of which is office layout. Because office layout influences the entire white-collar-employee segment of the organization, its importance to organizational productivity should never be underestimated.

Office layout is based on the interrelationships among three primary factors: employees, flow of work through the various work units, and equipment.

Efficient office layout results in a number of benefits to the organization, including the following:

- It affects how much satisfaction employees derive from their jobs.
- It affects the impression individuals get of the organization's work areas.
- It provides effective allocation and use of the building's floor space.
- It provides employees with efficient, productive work areas.
- It facilitates the expansion and/or rearrangement of work areas when the need arises.
- It facilitates employee supervision.

Planning the layout tends to occur in two steps, a preliminary stage and a final stage.

Office Location and Layout

Proper location and layout of an office is important to secure maximum efficiency. It should be located at a place where financial, transportation and communication facilities

are easily available. Usually the offices are located at the centre of the cities or towns, where all the required facilities can be easily availed of in case it is not possible to locate the office at the central place on account of absence of or high cost of accommodation it should be located at such a place from where it may be easier to have access to the city. It is essential to have efficient, adequate, and economic communication system available to the office.

With regard to the layout, it differs from office to office according to the need and availability of accommodation. The need of a small firm may be different from that of a large firm. A small hall or room may serve the purpose of a small firm but a large firm may require an area of several acres to house its office. Whatever its layout, it must be seen that the staff is able to work smoothly without any hindrance. Provision for proper ventilation, lighting and use of suitable colour must be made. As far as possible, natural lighting arrangement should be made, but if it is not possible, artificial lighting should be properly planned. Lighting should be sufficient, properly diffused and free from glares so that it may not cause any strain and fatigue.

Arrangement of various offices is usually made on a uniform pattern, depending upon the accommodation available. If the firm is large, there should be a general office and personal offices of the executives. Enough accommodation should be available to the chief executive with proper arrangement of the personnel office attached to it, with retiring room and conference room, if possible. It should be located at a place which may be free from noise and disturbances. There should be provision for reception room for the visitors, record room, stationery and stores room, rest rooms and, if possible, a dining room. There may be separate rooms for each department but they should be so arranged that intercommunication among different departments may be easily possible.

A general pattern followed in this connection is to provide for all the sections or departments in one common hall and to separate them from each other with the help of either half wooden or glass partitions. It brings about economy in space, facilitates supervision over the members of the staff and automatic checking. It is desirable that the cash department should be kept separate from other departments.

If accommodation is available, arrangement may be made for a common hall where meetings and conferences may be held. It is also necessary to keep in mind the future requirements of the firm at the time of making decision about the layout of the office. There should be enough room for future expansion, as far as possible.

PRELIMINARY PLANNING

When designing office layout, a number of factors need to be taken into consideration during the preliminary planning stage, which is generally carried out by administrative office managers, employees, or consultants.

Among the factors to consider during preliminary planning are these:

- *Work flow:* Studying the flow of work vertically and horizontally between individuals and work units is critical in designing office layout. The goal is to

design a layout pattern in which work moves in a straight-line direction with minimal backtracking or crisscrossing patterns. The major source documents found within the various work areas are often considered in analyzing work flow.

- *Organization chart*: Studying the organization chart, which visually depicts who reports to whom as well as the relationships among and between employees, is also considered in the preliminary planning stages. Generally, the organization chart helps determine which units should be physically located near one another.
- *Projection of number of employees needed in the future*: Having a good understanding of the possibility of expansion helps assure that layout is designed to accommodate future growth. Among the factors to be considered are the potential need for additional work units as well as the number of additional employees likely to be needed in both existing work units and new work units.
- *Communication network*: Studying the organization's communication network identifies who within the organization has considerable contact with whom. The more contact employees have, the greater is the likelihood that they or their work units need to be physically located near one another.
- *Departmental organization*: Studying departmental organization also helps determine which departments should be placed in close proximity to one another. For example, those departments with significant responsibilities for the accounting and financial aspects of the firm should be located near one another; those with frequent contact with outsiders should be located near the entrance to the structure; and noise-producing departments should be located near one another and away from areas where low noise levels are required.
- *Ratio of private to general offices*: Increasingly, many organizations are opting for more general offices and fewer private offices. This trend probably helps reduce the amount of total office space needed, and it certainly facilitates the rearrangement of office areas. A number of advantages result from using general offices rather than with private offices. General offices are more economical to build than private offices; general offices make it easier to accommodate change in office layout; and it is easier to design efficient heating, cooling, and lighting systems for general offices.
- *Space requirements*: The total amount of needed space is determined by the amount of space needed for each employee in each work unit as well as the amount of space needed for various specialized areas. The amount of space each employee needs is determined by the employee's furniture/equipment requirements, the location of such structural features as windows and pillars, and the employee's job functions and hierarchical position.
- *Specialized areas*: Many organizations have a number of specialized areas that must be taken into consideration in the preliminary planning of office layout.

Included are such needs as a reception area, board or conference rooms, a computer centre, a mailroom, a printing/duplicating room, a central records area, and a storage area.

- *Safety considerations:* A number of safety considerations play an important role in the preliminary planning of layout, including aisles/corridors of sufficient width, door openings, stairwells, and exits. Providing for quick evacuation of the premises in case of an emergency is a critical aspect of the preliminary planning of office layout.
- *Barrier-free construction:* A number of federal laws require that office layout accommodate individuals with disabilities. The 1990 Americans with Disabilities Act requires “reasonable accommodation” of individuals with disabilities. Perhaps most significant in office layout is designing office/work areas in which individuals can easily maneuver wheelchairs.
- *Expansion:* To stay abreast of developing space needs, many organizations undertake a yearly space analysis, just as they prepare a yearly budget. Doing so enables these organizations to be proactive rather than reactive in anticipating future space needs.
- *Equipment and furniture needs:* The amount of equipment and furniture that needs to be accommodated in an organization must be taken into consideration during the preliminary planning of office layout. Failure to take these needs into consideration often results in inefficient office layout.

PLANNING OFFICE LAYOUT

Perhaps the most critical decision that will be made in planning office layout is whether private offices only or a combination of private and general office areas will be used. The trend is towards a minimum of private office areas and maximum use of general office areas. Typically, the general office areas make use of the open office concept, which overcomes a number of the disadvantages of conventional private offices. Whereas private offices tend to be based on the hierarchical structure of the organization, open office areas are based on the nature of the relationship between the employee and his or her job duties.

Open office planning takes into account the cybernetics of the organization, meaning that information flows and processes are considered in the design process. Information flows pertain to paper flow, telephone communications, and face-to-face interaction.

Three different alternatives are used in designing space around the open office concept. These include the modular workstation approach, the cluster workstation approach, and the landscape approach. In each case, panels and furniture components comprise work areas. Typically, the panels and furniture components are prewired with both electrical and phone connections, which considerably simplifies their installation. Panels are available in a variety of colours and finishes, including wood, metal, plastic, glass, carpet, and fabric.

Modular workstation approach. A prime characteristic of the modular workstation approach is the use of panel-hung furniture components to create individual work areas. Storage cabinets and files of adjustable height are placed adjacent to desks or tables.

The design of modular workstations enables employees to have a complete office in terms of desk space, file space, storage space, and work-area lighting. Modular workstations are designed according to the specific job duties of their occupants.

In certain situations, the modular workstation approach is preferred to either of the other two open-space concepts. It is especially well suited for those situations that require considerable storage space, and the work area can be specifically designed around the specific needs of the user. Also, changes in layout can be made easily and quickly.

Cluster workstation approach. An identifying characteristic of the cluster workstation approach is the clustering of employee work areas around a common core, such as a set of panels that extend from a hub, much like the spokes in a wheel. The panels define each employee's work area, which typically includes a writing surface, storage space, and filing space.

As a rule, cluster workstations are not as elaborate as either modular workstations or landscaped alternatives. Cluster workstations work well for situations in which employees spend a portion of their workday away from their work area. Two distinct advantages of the cluster workstation are economics and the ease with which layout changes can be made. The cluster workstation is less expensive than either of the other two alternatives.

Landscape approach. Originally developed in Germany, office landscaping is now used extensively throughout the United States. In a way, office landscaping is a blend of the modular and cluster workstation approaches.

One significant difference, however, is the abundant use of plants and foliage in the decor. Plants and foliage, in addition to being aesthetically pleasing, provide a visual barrier. Whereas both the modular and the cluster approaches tend to align the components in rows, landscaping arranges work areas in clusters and at different angles.

In its original form, landscaping eliminated all private offices. However, most organizations that make use of landscaping use a hybrid approach in which a ratio of 80 per cent open office areas to 20 per cent private offices is common.

In conventional office layout, status was accorded employees through their assignment of a private office. Because the open-space concept removes a considerable number of private offices, employees are accorded status through such other aspects as their work assignments, their job duties, the location and size of their work area, and the type and amount of furniture they are given.

PREPARING THE LAYOUT

The actual preparation of the layout is carried out using a variety of tools, including templates, cut outs, plastic models, magnetic boards, and computer-aided design. For

more complex layout projects, CAD is most likely the tool of choice. For simple layout projects, any of the others work well. Regardless of which tool is used, a primary concern is making sure every aspect of the layout is scaled properly and consistently.

WORK SIMPLIFICATION

Work Simplification has generated billions of dollars through effectiveness and efficiency for organizations that focused on their people and gave them tools for continuous improvement. Over the past two decades, the glamour of electronics has seduced many organizations into treating their people as expenses rather than resources. For those organizations whose leaders truly believe that their people are their most valuable resource, the tools of Work Simplification are still available – and better than ever.

PRIORITISING

- Prioritising tasks ensures that the most important jobs get done before running out of time or energy.
- Setting priorities means taking a look at your activities for the day and putting them in order of importance.
- Be sure to include self care, work, and leisure activities.
- Examine your list and eliminate which activities are unnecessary and which are too difficult and can be delegated to someone else.
- You will then be left with a list of tasks which you need to do and like to do.

PLAN AHEAD

- Organise your list of essential activities into daily/weekly schedules
- Space heavy tasks evenly throughout the week rather than doing them on the same day
- *When planning ask:*
 - How am I going to do this activity?
 - When is the best time to do this activity?
 - Can the activity be broken down into smaller steps?
- It is important that each day's activities are carefully planned to alternate heavy jobs with light ones.

PLAN AHEAD FOR INDIVIDUAL ACTIVITIES

- Make sure that you have all of the necessary equipment within easy reach before beginning.
- This will prevent unnecessary walking, carrying, bending, and reaching.
- It is essential that your schedule is flexible so you can accommodate the unexpected.

INCORPORATE REST BREAKS

- Regular rest periods should be incorporated into your day
- A 10 minute rest each hour will help prevent fatigue.
- Don't involve yourself in a task that you cannot stop when you become tired/breathless
- Working at a moderate pace consumes the least energy.
- Playing slow music can help you maintain your pace.
- Pay attention to signals such as trembling, perspiration, shortness of breath, chest tightness stop to rest before you become fatigued.
- Be kind to yourself on days when your symptoms are increased.

Interior Designer

Interior Design as a Skill Branch: Building Engineering was the lead the way design field out of which many specialities like Architecture, Civil Engineering and Interior Designing have separated. All these skills deal with buildings using many common materials and techniques. Interior Design as a result has certain affinity to Architecture. In recent years many other design skills like Urban Design, Town Planning, Mass or Public housing, Landscape architecture, etc. have emerged from architecture. In future many other skills may also emerge from Interior Design.

Buildings and Design Interventions: A building once constructed is initially readied for occupation by the original designer. However, buildings last for ages and throughout the lifespan, must be altered and updated several times. Architects or Building Engineers are unavailable, or have no income incentive for such 'frivolity'. During early middle ages, or perhaps even earlier, low-skilled 'Art -Painters' were hired to paint and decorate old buildings inside and outside. The painters known as Decorators, worked along with their associates, to not only paint but undertake repairs, make furniture and update furnishings. Many crafts-persons like, Iron smiths, Guilders, Glass blowers, Weavers, Embroiders, Rug and Carpet makers, Sculptors, Mural makers, were associated with the Decorator, as jobbers and suppliers. Later all these services were handled by a person, the Interior Decorator. Interior Decoration, was a service for the buildings, but always was distinct from the Architecture or Building Engineering. Interior Decorator was neither a variant, nor subservient to the architect. Interior Decorator to Interior Designer: Interior decorators worked as a facilitator, scheduling and coordinating the behaviour, while supervising the quality of various vendors. The interior decorator now even offered comprehensive design solutions with alternatives to their clients. Interior decoration became a well-documented strategy, serving two basic reasons.

It helped creation of a functional system by coordinating skills, materials and objects, sourced from different agencies. It showed the user or client, in advance, the solution, in a representative form -a surrogate. Once the first objective was achieved without being continuously present on the site, it was possible for the Interior-in-charge person to devote more time and attention to the second objective. The Interior decorator began

to play a very active role of a professional interior designer rather than being simply a site bound interior agreementor.

Design + Execution Practice: Schematic documentation of design has been very difficult, and the most irritating aspect of business. Amateur Interior Designers (formally untrained - hobbyists) lack the capacity to document their design intentions, so prefer to work on the site, providing oral instructions to agreementors or their workers. Many Interior Designers, even to day, where practicable would like to execute their work by themselves. The tradition of combining design + execution persists for many reasons:

1. Interior components require complex details and materials for their sensorial qualities. These are difficult to present through formal design documentation, and must be effected only through personal involvement.
2. Interior designing involves improvisation. The coordinated effect can be achieved, only when components or systems are substantially produced by the designers themselves.
3. Amateur or untrained interior designers do not have such proficiencies.

Interior Designers are gradually warning their work to design matters only, and let other agencies handle the supply and execution. In very large, complex and remotely located projects it is not feasible for the designer to be present all the time to execute the scheme. For Corporate or Government types of Organised Clients, the practice of employing or appointing Third Party Venders or Agreementors to execute interior projects serves varying degree of efficiency, reliability and satisfaction.

The separation of design and execution, is also favourable arrangement from point of view of Taxation. Pure Design practice is liable for simple taxation like Service Tax. In Design + Supply practice, a designer may be liable to pay Sales Tax on the total turnover (on design fees and things sold). Whereas in Design + Execute practice, one is considered not only a producer, but also a seller. In this case one has to pay production related taxes such as Central Excise and in addition to the Sales Tax.

Though in many countries of the world, in many professional fields the combined, Design + Build (execution) practice is now an accepted norm. Typically Building Organisers / Estate Developers, do both, design as well as execute their housing and commercial projects. Many industrial products are designed by their producers.

Interior Design and other Design Professions: Interior Design like any other design profession, is an interdependent profession. Interior designers work in conjunction with other design professionals, who need interior design contribution in their work, such as Architects, Building engineers, Landscape designers, Furniture and Product designers, Exhibition and Event managers.

Interior designers also use expertise of other professionals for their work. These include Environmental Engineers, Ecologists, Furnishing experts, Textile designers, Painters, Sculptors, and an array of crafts persons. occupation in Interior Design: Interior designers like other professionals also, face a dilemma, should they specialize or be a generalist? To become a specialist one needs to limit the work to projects of particular

nature. But it is very difficult to get projects to suit a predefined field of specialization. In reality, as and when opportunities arise, a designer preferences project, that builds up the specific sphere of experience. The refined capability can then be used for handling similar but complex jobs.

Acute specialization in a particular field also leads to generalization, as one handles only one or few types of projects. Interior designers by handling only specific projects achieve an expertise in the field, but gradually lose the capacity to handle other projects. Whereas a generalist, by handling all sorts of projects, perhaps gains a wider experience, economics of scale (turnover), but at compromised quality.

Some degree of specialization is becoming apparent in Interior Design. Some of the major fields to have distinct identities within the ambit of Interior Design are: Hospitality or hotel design, Entertainment facilities, public space design (air ports, railway stations), Exterior design or Street architecture, Exhibitions and events planning, Retail designing, Transport interior design. These fields naturally demand a varied manner of design move toward and handling. opportunity for Interior Designers: Interior Designers get different professional opportunities. In each case, the styles of work, responsibilities, nature of compensation, job satisfaction, and scope of advancement, are different. It is not possible to compare or to evaluate, which one is superior. A designer sets a personal goal and charts the carrier.

Interior Designers have a variety of fields to employ their skills. One may work as an Independent Design Professional, as a Free Lancer, Conditional associate, or as a Profit-sharing Employee in any association. Interior designers also work in many parallel fields, such as a Product design, Prototypes, production of Interior parts and components, Maintenance person for Interior spaces and components, Advisor or consultant for Interior design related concepts, and as Administrator for Interior related management aspects.

Interior designers are sensitive to materials and finishes, and so are well qualified to be Conservators, Preservers, and Renovators of built spaces. Interior designers have the competence to mould and manipulate the built environments and are most suitable persons for Reformation and Adaptation (reuse) of redundant buildings.

Reformation skills of Interior Designers are very much in demand. A building is not only a very costly resource to acquire but would need equal or perhaps costlier effort to dispose it off. So renovations and alterations help reestablish old and redundant buildings. Miniaturization and modernization of systems and components make large-amounts of built spaces redundant.

Interior Designers have a very significant role to play in Product Design decisions. Interior products include everything used and housed in an interior space, like, furniture and furnishings, fixtures and fittings, tools, gadgets, equipments, etc.

The interior environment or setting for the designed products could be of a building, ship, aircraft, space station, automobile, bus or railway carriage. Interior Designers play a great role in defining the Contextual Interior Environment for the product setting.

With technological developments, Interior and Building components are no longer considered to be passive parts, but, have an active and participatory role in the buildings. Utilitarian success of buildings substantially depends on the furnishings and interior components. Interior designers beyond their role of furnishers are also ideal as maintenance persons and operators of buildings. Such job duties also include house keeping or interior space management.

Large associations (hotels, guest houses, corporate head offices, museums, showrooms, departmental stores) have estates, substantially consisting of buildings, furniture, furnishings, plants, equipments, utilities, gardens, and landscaped lands. Managements of these require an estate-in-charge person. Interior designers are preferred for such a role.

Interior Design training today includes design drafting and presentation technologies in digital media. Interior Designers with competence in computerized drafting (AUTOCAD), 3D modelling, animation, walk through, rendering, etc. find employment in many other design fields. Interior Design training consists of colour, rendering, graphics and presentation techniques, preparing them for the diversion to graphics related fields, like artwork, advertising, cinematography, exhibitions, publicity, etc.

Design Studio: The Interior designer now operated from a Design office or Studio, usually located in an urban area. The studio was used for create drawings, sketches, other presentations, models, pilots, prototypes, dummies, cartoons (replicas of artwork in full size), samples, etc. It contained samples of materials and catalogues. The studio was a fixed location facility where Interior designer was able to meet clients, suppliers and crafts-persons. The physical distancing of a studio from the site also detached the Design and Execution aspects of interior practice. In the combined practice of Design and Execution, the need for a documented scheme was never very acute, as decisions immediately turned into actions. However, in Pure Design practice, all decisions had to be not only communicated, but very often formally transmitted as an assignment to the site-based agency.

9

Effective Business Skills in Office Management

There is a need for people with strong administrative skills in any business. With business processes, equipment, documentation and communication becoming increasingly complicated, managers and professional administrators need a wide range of skills to run the office effectively. Often these skills are neglected or ignored, which results in ineffective office management. If you are unsure of the proficiencies you need to keep up with administrative tasks, here are 4 important skills required for efficient office management.

BUSINESS DOCUMENTATION

As an office manager, you will mostly likely need business writing skills, as you will be required to write up a number of business documents. Some documents may include business letters, reports, proposals, quotations, statements and invoices. It is imperative to understand what these documents are used for, and to know how to format, write and administer these documents.

COMMUNICATION STRATEGY

In the current business environment, communication is handled almost exclusively through computers. It is important for office administrators to feel comfortable communicating through various platforms, such as email, Skype or MSN, as it is mostly likely that you will communicate with employees or customers via these platforms. You

will need to learn to communicate appropriately depending on the platform used. Office managers are also required to communicate with employees and customers on the phone, so an appropriate telephone manner is essential.

Office Administration

General office administration is part-and-parcel of the day-to-day running of any business. As an office manager, you may be responsible for petty cash, managing the switchboard, dealing with delivery services, the administration of basic office facilities, and general management. The latter is vital, as staff rely heavily on office management in order to complete their tasks successfully.

Information Management

It is the information age, and humans are consuming more raw data today than in any other time in history. Information needs to be housed somewhere, and it is often kept in files so that you can make reference to specific documents at a later stage. As an office manager, it is important to manage the filing and indexing for both digital and hard copy documents. Arrange your digital folders effectively so that you are able to find certain documents with ease. Hard copies should be filed away and clearly marked so you can retrieve these documents at any time.

BECOME MORE EFFECTIVE OFFICE MANAGER

Self-improvement can be costly and time consuming. As an office manager, however, becoming more effective can make your job easier and make you more valuable in the eyes of management.

Office managers are expert multitaskers. If you're doing more than four things at once, that's probably still not enough. Your knowledge of the office is incomparable — you know exactly whom to call and when. Plus, you have a sixth sense about office crises. In other words, you're practically indispensable. What's your secret? You're organized, understanding (to a point), a good communicator, and can always see the big picture. Still, like any key employee, office managers are often looking for ways to become even more effective. Here are a few key tips:

Hone Your Oral Communication Skills

Knowing how to talk to people is paramount for office managers. In many cases, you're the go-to person, so your ability to listen well is critical. You're also the one responsible for making sure things get done. Knowing how to ask questions and obtain clarification will also help you to become more effective. For example, if you don't understand how an assignment is to be completed, seek clarification. You don't necessarily have to admit that you don't understand something; simply ask for

clarification. Likewise, if you're discovering that people don't understand your instructions, ask yourself if you need to be clearer in your communication.

Don't Neglect Your Email Skills

Just because e-mails often suffer from poor grammar and punctuation doesn't mean that your written communication should be anything less than professional. But knowing what to write and how to do it is just part of your mission; you also need to know about your reading audience. Do people tend to read your entire e-mail or will they stop reading after the first two lines? For the latter, you'll want to incorporate the most important information up front. Also, always remember that once you put anything in writing, it's there for the world to see. Be particularly sensitive in your e-mails and memos when informing staff about new equipment, a change of policy, or any report. You never want to patronize or insult anyone. Make sure your subject line has enough information to encourage reading further. Most important: Re-read your email before you hit the send button. And don't ever underestimate the power of misinterpretation. Consider the confusion — and bad feelings — that could arise if you were to write "I resent that" meaning you sent a report again versus you were offended by something that might have been said earlier. Clearly, you want to know where to insert hyphens (re-sent) and when you should simply pick up the phone or stop by someone's desk for a face-to-face conversation. We cover this topic more in-depth in the article *Communicating Effectively via E-Mail*.

Consult Your Internal Customers

Remember always that your primary role is to ensure the efficient operation of the office. Engaging in regular communication with your coworkers can help you avoid troublesome issues and attack the ones that do arise more creatively.

Treat Your Vendors Like Best Friends

As the purveyor of office supplies, it's in your best interest to cultivate and sustain solid, mutually beneficial relationships with your suppliers. It makes good sense to build a pleasant rapport with the companies that help keep your organization running smoothly. Just as you expect loyalty from them, you also need to demonstrate a commitment to the relationship. On the other hand, it's also important to maintain high (but fair) expectations. Try to do both and you're likely to experience above-average to excellent service. But don't forget to compare the supplier landscape. As the person overseeing costs, it's your responsibility to ask suppliers what they can do for you and your organization. Their job is to keep you a happy customer.

Maintain a Positive Attitude

This one's pretty obvious. Still, we sometimes forget how a smile or a clever remark can diffuse a troubling situation. Using humor in the workplace, smiling, and exuding

a positive attitude whenever possible are all good strategies for overcoming a variety of office situations. As the office manager, you have a tremendous opportunity to set the tone, and if people can rely on your professionalism, they'll be less worried and more committed to contributing to a positive work environment.

Ways to Become a Better Office Manager

As an admin, it usually falls on you to keep the office running as efficiently as possible. But when you combine a team of people with different personalities, various pieces of office equipment and software tools, and a never-ending list of distractions, office management can get a little tricky at times. But all this chaos shouldn't stop you. In fact, it should be motivation to get and keep your office in shape! If you want to be a better office manager and develop your management and leadership skills, here are some office management tips to keep things running smoothly.

1. **Sharpen your communication skills.** Being an effective communicator is critical to everything you do as an assistant, and it expands when you step into a management role. You have to be able to lead meetings, step in for your manager, and represent your executive at public functions. You also need to develop and polish your public speaking skills. If you're not comfortable doing any of these things, brush up on your skills! Attend networking events, accompany him or her to their next speaking engagement or conference, and volunteer to present something at the next office meeting. Find ways to practice every chance you get. All of these things will help you become a better communicator!
2. **Work on your people management skills.** Learning to manage people is very different from managing projects or tasks. It requires more patience and understanding. And it helps if you know a little about personality types and how they impact the way people work and communicate. If you aren't a natural networker, make a point to learn one new thing about each person you interact with daily. This will help you build relationships and gain a better understanding of each person's unique abilities and contributions to the team.
3. **Be an innovative thinker.** Being an effective office manager requires some innovative thinking, especially when it comes to problem solving. As a manager, there are going to be situations (and some times people) that you can't control, as well as challenges that you need to overcome. While it's easy to get stressed and frustrated in these situations, the better option is to approach them with an innovative mindset. You don't have to be a "creative type" to develop your innovative thinking skills. Surround yourself with innovative thinkers. Read as much as you possibly can – articles, books, newsletters! Listen to podcasts or audio courses during your commute. As the office manager, it's important to constantly expose ourselves to new ideas, methods, and industry trends if we want to excel. The new ideas and concepts you bring into your mind will positively impact the way you do your job!

4. Develop your business acumen. As an office manager, it's vital that you understand how every aspect of your company runs and your role in it. You must understand how your company makes money and where you can impact the bottom line. Being business savvy helps improve your ability to make good judgments and quick decisions each day. As the person responsible for keeping office operations flowing smoothly, it's your job to keep information flowing and projects moving forward. The more you know about how a business runs, and the intricacies of your company in particular, the more successful you'll be in your role!
5. Continue your education and professional development. The best office managers never stop learning, growing and expanding their knowledge base. Stay on top of technology. Make professional development part of your monthly strategic career plan so it's consistent and scheduled well in advance. There are lots of things you can do that are free and low fee if you look for them. Keep learning — it's part of your responsibility as a manager!

How to Be a Successful Office Manager

Education and Experience

Seek related education and work experience. Though some employers don't require a college education, you can improve your chances of landing this job by earning an associate's or bachelor's degree in a business or management major. Even if you don't earn a degree, you can make yourself a more attractive job candidate by taking business, accounting or management classes through a vocational school, community college or four-year college.

No matter what your level of education, you'll also need to gain experience working in an office environment and demonstrate your ability to work as part of a team and to lead others.

Organizational and Time-Management Skills

Keep physical items in their proper places, manage your time effectively and keep track of staff schedules and roles. Your organizational skills will prove critical in completing tasks on time and making sure each day runs smoothly. For example, arrange files, paperwork and equipment to allow easy access by any staff member who needs them. Make sure every office staff member understands his job description and performs to meet company expectations. In addition, create and adjust work schedules to ensure that all tasks get completed on time.

Decision-Making Skills

Make decisions that benefit your company and its workers. Other employees will turn to you for answers to questions and solutions to problems, expecting you to make

fair decisions quickly. You might also have to make decisions regarding customer or vendor matters. In addition, you may have the responsibility of interviewing, hiring and firing office staff members. Refer to company policy manuals when you feel unsure about the best course of action.

Math Skills

Use your math skills to oversee the processing of orders, creation of invoices, receipt of payments and bookkeeping. You may also have a role in securing or reviewing company contracts and ordering supplies for the office staff and other company departments. Your math skills will come into play when managing the office's petty cash, as well. Some companies also require office managers to handle employee time sheets and payroll accounts, both of which require math skills.

Multitasking Ability

Handle multiple tasks at one time. Often, being an office manager means taking on or overseeing several projects at once while also fielding requests and questions from employees and other managers.

For example, you might be called on to settle a dispute, speak to an irate customer, sign for a package and adjust a work schedule all at once. Always pay attention to detail as you work to avoid productivity-impairing errors.

Leadership Skills and Fairness

Model responsibility and productive behavior. Supervise and motivate your office staff, and treat all employees with the same level of respect. Arrive on time to begin your workday and complete scheduled tasks on time. Demonstrate teamwork by sharing information and resources with your employees. Listen to employee complaints and concerns, making improvements to the work environment when they will increase productivity and ensure that activities run smoothly. In addition, act as a mentor when doing so will benefit the company and other employees.

Communication Skills

Listen well and provide clear input, answers and advice. Miscommunication can lead to confusion and even dissension in the workplace, so good verbal skills play an important role. In addition, good writing skills will ensure that your instructions and written responses are easy to understand and follow. Though much of your communication will take place with company staff, your communication skills will also be important for dealing with customers and vendors.

Asks and Traits of a Successful Office Manager

On-point office managers prize efficiency, and are always on the lookout for methods and practices that can be improved on — from stocking office supplies and equipment,

to keeping a close eye on costs and staying under budget. An office manager worth their salary has superb communication skills and remains in contact with each and every organizational member. While certain employees and departments may seldom interact with one another, a good office manager deals with all of them. For this reason, their ability to imagine others' standpoints and help to solve problems is a quality worthy of your praise.

An active interest in your company's well-being is another trait of a strong office manager. Their overall goal is to help the business be the best it can be; so they drill down to troubleshoot areas of office life that can be improved on. Their strong project management skills and analytical mind enhance their performance. This personality trait helps him or her examine a broad range of processes with an eye toward streamlining them, and to thereby help your organization meet its goals and prosper.

Technological savvy is another asset in a successful office manager. They have intimate knowledge of your business' trade tools, which makes them an enormous boon to your company. This person understands exactly what's needed to get the job done, which is why they're so often the one to find new methods, and to expedite and enhance the value of new software and hardware.

The successful office manager's knowledge of finance and money management is another one of their assets, not to mention their familiarity with staffing and hiring. They are content to leave the hiring to the human resources department, but are always ready if called upon to secure support staffing — i.e., temps — for seasonal or one-off projects. This means they're a proficient interviewer and are good at assessing people's aptitude for certain projects and roles. This often proves valuable when you decide to stay within the company to create a support team.

The successful office manager understands the responsibility that comes with being charged with an office's physical well-being. This entails managing all of the office's common areas to ensure they're sanitary and continually equipped with the necessary supplies and goods. They also govern safety precautions and mechanisms in the workplace, including the maintenance of first-aid kits and fire extinguishers, and the creation and dissemination of disaster plans, which can include fire evacuations, and shelter-in-place plans for hurricanes and earthquakes.

Office Manager Job Description: Skills and Tools

Office managers are in demand. As an office manager, you are an integral part of company operations that is responsible for supervising staff and maintaining office systems. Introduction to Management teaches you how to supervise others effectively. Office managers must carry out numerous administrative tasks. In some companies, you are also responsible for basic IT related tasks. Depending on the size of the company and corporate structure you work for, you could be a "jack of all trades" or have more specialized duties such as hiring and training new employees or addressing human resource issues within the office environment.

Typical Workload

As a general rule, office managers are responsible for many aspects of a business. Where a secretary or accountant have very specific duties within the organization, you may dabble in all of these tasks as needed by upper management. As an office manager, you are primarily responsible for:

- Organizing office operations such as preparing payroll, maintaining filing systems, approving requisition requests, and monitoring clerical functions. Taking a course in business accounting such as Introduction to Business Accounting is always a good idea.
- Ensuring office efficiency using various hardware and software tools.
- Hiring and training new employees in office policies, procedures, and specialized tools or equipment used for daily operations. You are also responsible for evaluating the performance of these employees on a quarterly or semiannual basis to make sure they are still meeting the needs of the company and performing quality work.
- You may also be responsible for firing employees that no longer meet the company's standards or who have difficulty adjusting to the work environment.
- Coordinating team efforts and delegating work as necessary to make sure large projects are completed in a timely manner. Learning to manage projects is an important skill for any office manager.

Remember that these duties are typically expected of most office managers, but each employment opportunity is different. What makes being an office manager so exciting is that you have such a wide variety of tasks to perform on a daily basis. While some jobs may become tedious and boring over time, your work as an office manager is likely to keep you busy and motivated most of the time.

Skills and Tools

As part of management, you are required to have a specific set of skills that allows you to manage other employees and operations effectively. Being a manager is not always easy as you are often forced to make decisions that may not bode well with other employees (such as hiring/firing and payroll decisions).

It's important to learn how to effectively manage other people. Communication is another important part of effective management. Learning to communicate effectively will not only help you in your role as an office manager, but it translates very well to your life outside of work as well. Your responsibility as an office manager means you should be well versed in basic business practices. You may be required to perform basic accounting functions, administrative work, and other tasks that require a keen understanding of how business (in general and yours specifically) operate.

In most modern companies, office operations are run by computer networks. There are quite a few computer-related skills you should master if you are thinking of becoming an office manager. You may be required to perform basic IT related tasks. Learning the

basics of computer networking helps you to manage these tasks effectively. Report generation is another key component of office management. These reports could be generated using proprietary company software or using more standard office software such as the Microsoft Office suite. Microsoft Word is used to create written reports. For example, you might use of Microsoft Word to create an employee evaluation or an interoffice memo. Word 2013 should get you on the right track.

Office managers also rely on Microsoft Excel, a spreadsheet program. These spreadsheets may contain financial data or information about employees that will need to be updated periodically.

You can learn how to use Excel for business in Excel Essentials. PowerPoint is used to create slideshows and presentations. These are especially useful when training new employees. As an office manager, you may be directly responsible for training employees or at the very least, responsible for creating the training material that other employees will use when training new hires. Mastering PowerPoint is a good way to create training materials for new hires as well as current employees in need of remedial training.

Logical thinking is another skill that companies look for when hiring an office manager. You will be expected to “think outside the box” and make existing processes more efficient when possible. Time management is also important to the office manager.

Like any managerial position, you may find that there is simply not enough time in the day to complete all required tasks. Effective time management allows you to maximize the time that you do have and delegate tasks to others that you are unable to finish yourself.

This skill, probably more so than most of the others mentioned, is what sets a successful office manager apart from the crowd. Until the day when office employees are replaced by robots (hopefully not anytime soon), there will be a need for office managers in corporate America. It is certainly a career path with plentiful opportunities and may even offer advancement opportunities into upper levels of management in the future.

When interviewing for an office management position, it is perfectly acceptable to ask for specific details about the job description as different companies have different expectations for office managers. Once you understand exactly what the position entails, you can brush up on any topics that you may not feel comfortable with and move forward into your new career as a successful office manager.

Skills Needed in a Successful Office Manager

One of the hardest and most important positions you will fill in your office is the position of office manager. Why is this so hard? Because an effective manager is going to control the chaos and enable you to reach your goals. Obviously, every office's needs for a manager will vary. However, there are three core skills that every office leader needs.

Leadership Skills

Whether your office manager is leading one or twenty one, it is imperative that your manager be an effective leader and gain the respect of staff. It is the manager's duty to make sure that goals are being met and being able to get the staff to "buy in" to goals is essential. The manager ensures that the staff is motivated and on the right track, but also has to be able to delegate responsibilities to the team rather than handling everything on his or her own.

Communication Skills

Your office manager represents you and your practice. He or she works closely with individuals in various capacities-people that you want to continue having relationships with such as your staff, vendors, colleagues, and patients.

The importance of how this person communicates is invaluable. An effective communicator gives you and your practice credibility. In a leadership capacity, your office manager needs to be able to interact effectively with other people. This requires actively listening and responding appropriately-not acting purely on emotion.

Analytical Skills

A dental office is ever changing and you need someone who is not always caught up in the smaller details, but who can see the bigger picture. There is always something that can be improved upon to increase efficiencies and/or save the office money. Your manager should be able to gather information, when needed, and make appropriate decisions based upon information given. You should be able to trust their analytical skills and ability to make decisions. While the specific requirements for each position change, every office benefits when their manager possesses strong leadership, communication and analytical skills.

Hiring the Perfect Office Manager

Hiring an effective office manager is one of the most critical hiring decisions a business owner can make. The culture of an office can dictate the success and sometimes failure of the company. If a team cannot work together effectively, whether as a result of poor personal dynamics or poor leadership, there is a greater chance of internal business conflicts. One of the most overlooked, yet important role, in any office or business setting is the office manager. Hiring an effective and dynamic office manager is one of the most critical hiring decisions a company can make.

What are the biggest obstacles in growing your service business?

It's important to understand the temperament wanted for the position, according to Dennis Altman, founder of the Altman Initiative Group, a company that helps businesses hire, train and engage employees. Is the office looking for a rule enforcer, team builder or someone who straddles the line?

Characteristics

In addition to the right personality, you want to hire someone with the following characteristics: A generalist with varied skill sets. The office manager wears many different hats. On any given day, he or she may be mediating battling co-workers, calming upset clients or reviewing the latest budget. According to Andrea Ballard, career coach and founder of ExpectingChange.com, a great office manager has skills and experience in various areas of administration including human resources, facility operations, event planning, accounting, marketing and customer service. Additionally, Ballard suggests that a good office manager should already know the ins and outs of the business. Whether you run a medical office or a car dealership, the day-to-day intricacies vary from industry to industry.

Strong communication skills and the ability to diffuse drama. According to Heather Wagner, a certified human resources senior professional and founder of Form + Function (an HR provider for small businesses), successful managers are able to effectively communicate goals and expectations to their teams. Additionally, they must be able to address poorly performing employees in a fair and confident manner.

Interoffice gossip is often detrimental to the good of the office. The ability to remain impartial and stay out of the drama is critical. When things get out of control, a good office manager has the ability to rein in their team and get them back on track.

Sense of pride and organization. Ron Sturgen, an entrepreneur in Fort Worth, asks interviewees to show him their cars. “Everyone dresses for an interview, but few people wash and clean their cars, so I get a much more accurate picture of how the person will work in the workplace. A messy car often means a messy desk and may mean the person does not have the right pride of ownership in his or her work.”

Responsibilities

Running an office efficiently can prove to be one of the most challenging positions. Why? It is the office manager’s job to ensure that employees are working in an environment that encourages productivity while maintaining budgets, morale and the overall vision of the company.

Loren Kofsky, sales manager at MyCorporation.com has found success as an office manager by initiating a philosophy of “management by walking around” (MBWA). Observing your team while they are actively working allows you to not only develop relationships but acknowledge any productivity issues. “The staff will appreciate the effort and sometimes you will discover problems, which can be addressed to help make them more productive,” Kofsky says.

Here are just a few of the roles an office manager plays. Proactive staffing. Kofsky suggests cross-training employees to fill roles during absences and prepare for internal promotions as they come. He also is a proponent of consistently recruiting new staff, even if there are no open positions within the company. This tactic is a proactive approach to hiring and helps pad the candidate pool when openings arise. “This allows you to

keep a pipeline of potentials so you are prepared in case of an emergency. By doing this you are constantly in the spirit of improving your team.”

Maintaining the office space. Another important role for the office manager is the physical seating and space of the office. Not unlike a school teacher, the office manager needs to delegate office space in a strategic manner in order to maximize efficiency. In some settings it proves beneficial to remove physical barriers, allowing for an open workspace, while in others cubicles provide the optimal work environment. It’s often left to the office manager to suggest changes for the better.

Additionally, managers are often the go-to leader when something is not working. If the team is in need of anti-fatigue mats or new office equipment, they are often the first contacted in hopes of procuring upgrades. Managers must be able to calculate the ROI on purchases they make. Employee praise and recognition. According to TribeHR, engaging your employees is a monumental task for managers, one that helps reduce turnover and increase productivity. Encouraging personal and professional growth, recognizing achievements and providing positive or constructive feedback is an essential duty of an office manager.

Although it may seem like a trivial role, organizing recognition events, like injury-free day count, monthly birthdays and career milestones, enhances corporate culture. At the very least, be sure to give praise when praise is due. A pat on the back and recognition of a job well done goes a very, very long way. Whether managing a law office or a construction company, the basic challenges of an office manager remain the same. Having the right person in that role is paramount to keeping your office running smoothly.

Makes a Great Office Manager

A remodeling company owner recently nominated his office manager for an Office Manager of the Year Award that we at Remodelers Advantage present. On the application, he wrote: “Our office manager provides enthusiastic support for our entire team.

She is an intelligent sounding board for all of our thinking and has kept a massive amount of detail under constant control. She has become an expert user of Master Builder and has led the company in upgrading systems to be more efficient and productive. Meanwhile, as director of first impressions, she charms the clients, leads them through the selection process, and delivers precise and complete documentation to field crews. We all love her and our days are brightened by her cheerful hardworking presence.”

Who wouldn’t love to be able to write that nomination? In it, the owner mentions numerous traits that I hear again and again attributed to the best office managers. I talked to one office manager who has consistently received rave reviews from the owners of the company for which she works. Darci Mierendorf, office manager for Morris Builders, in Rockford, Mich., who got rave reviews in the same competition, describes the traits this way:

Be the eyes and ears of the team. "Even if I'm working on my own tasks" she says, "I listen to what's going on around me. The more I am aware of the workings of the company, the more assistance I can lend."

Truly love taking care of people. "I take it upon myself to be everyone's caregiver, to make sure that they have everything they need in order to be successful," Mierendorf comments. "For example, when [owner] Kirk is going on a sales call, I'll make sure that he has a map and accurate directions, the lead sheet so he is familiar with the prospect, tape measure, and anything else he will need on site."

Be organized and use systems to add predictability and consistency to the job. "I'm very good with both creating and following systems and procedures... In addition to following these systems myself, I also am proactive in helping the owners do the same." For example, Mierendorf will follow up after a sale to collect details about the meeting so that she can record next steps, agreements, and anything else that might help them all stay organized. "I'm not aggressive about how I follow up," she says, "but I know that the more information we can record, the faster and more accurately we can move forward. This helps us close more sales." Be able to multitask and handle constant interruptions. "I keep a notepad on my desk to record tasks as they are given to me," Mierendorf says. "It's up to me to get them done in a timely manner and to know which takes priority. With one owner, I know that tasks typically need to be done immediately. With another, there's often time to do it later. If I don't know, I ask." Because of the multitude of tasks, Mierendorf also says that office managers need to be fast-paced, in general. "I can't put my head down to focus on one thing at the expense of others," she says. "And I also have to be very careful to balance speed with accuracy. It does no one any good if it's done quickly but not accurately."

Have an attitude and personality that is upbeat while calm. "The person who is in this position has to have a pleasant, professional, upbeat manner on the phone or in person," Mierendorf says. "At the same time, he or she has to be able to handle conflicts that crop up with diplomacy and confidence."

Office Management Techniques

Effective management techniques are the driving force behind an efficient, well-run office and a productive staff. An office manager willing to make decisions for the team and work alongside employees is often the most effective. Sound judgment, proper motivation and the ability to work well under pressure are qualities a professional office manager should possess.

Change Management

Keeping an office running smoothly starts with a perspective that views change as constant and customary. Proactive change management techniques such as mandatory morning meetings, brief planning sessions and daily task lists provides structure and allows time for discussion and brainstorming. Delegating responsibilities and tasks is

also an important part of effective change management. For example, a cross-training policy and periodic skills assessments can help ensure the office runs smoothly on a day-to-day basis.

Time Factor

Effective time management is essential for accomplishing daily goals. The ability to prioritize, manage interruptions and say “no” when it’s necessary are basic stepping stones to success. While phone calls, meetings and impromptu conversations are common in any office environment, maintaining a degree of control over each is necessary to supporting productivity goals. Keep a list of employees whose meeting requests and phone calls receive top priority and schedule meetings rather than holding them on the spur of the moment.

Actions and Behaviors

It’s vital to maintain a working environment in which employees treat each other with respect. Techniques for managing staff actions and behaviors require assertiveness in setting, communicating and enforcing boundaries and expectations. A written policy that sets clear standards for behavior and defines consequences for violations is a good starting point. Well-written standard operating procedures are also vital. These guidelines should set clear expectations, establish accountability and provide fair, objective ways to evaluate actions and behaviors.

Resolution Regulations

Conflict resolution requires the ability to assess the situation and know when to step in or stand aside. Always engage in conflict resolution as an impartial third party. While neutrality is important, however, it isn’t always easy. Techniques that focus on preserving relationships, resolving issues through negotiation and dealing with the problem and the people involved is essential for a good outcome.

Improve Management Communication Skills

If you are in a leadership position it is more than likely you are interested in learning ways to improve management communication skills for yourself as well as others involved in management. This is good because when you improve management communication skills you improve the effectiveness of your business. So, making the decision to improve management communication skills is important. Fortunately, there are plenty of easy ways to immediately improve management communication skills and make your entire organization run better and more efficiently. Consider implementing the following tips in your daily work life and see how communication opens up among everyone in the organization.

Open Atmosphere: An open atmosphere in which to communicate is essential for a business to be successful. It encourages and helps to improve management

communication skills. You want to set the stage as the leader to allow individuals to express opinions, thoughts, recommendations, complaints, and any other statement without the fear it might be frowned upon. The more open the atmosphere means the more feedback you will receive, both positive and negative, which means you will be able to make the necessary changes in your organization to improve and make your team stronger and products better. Always encourage individuals to communicate because this helps to improve management communication skills.

Clear Communication: As a leader it is important for you to always communicate clearly to your employees. The reason for this is you want to eliminate confusion from occurring, so if you communicate clearly this is less likely to happen and this trait is common among those who want to improve management communication skills.

Be concise, specific, and very clear when communicating orally or in written documents. You should also encourage members of your organization to ask for clarification if it is necessary. Eliminating problems before they occur will make your company stronger and have less downtime, so encourage questions from members in your organization.

Listen: Always listen to your employees, the media, and competitors, but listen objectively.

The reason you need to listen objectively is so you can hear what is being said. When you know what is being said then you will be able to figure out why and for what purposes. Again, this is important if you want to improve management communication skills. This gives you the power to handle situations. Also, when you listen to your employees they will respect you, work harder, and feel more loyal to the company—all because you decide to improve management communication skills.

Respect: As a leader be sure to always respect everyone in your organization in order to set your expectations for other members' actions. When you are respectful of everyone it will be contagious and others in your organization will show respect to others as well. This really helps to improve management communication skills. Make sure you are always respectful in every situation, even difficult situations, and your employees will learn from your actions.

PRINCIPLES OF COMMUNICATION

Interpersonal communication is the groundwork of human interaction. Its importance for innovation and change can hardly be overemphasized. In this section, communication from different viewpoints including listening and speaking is ex.

Objectives:

- To introduce communication and to demonstrate the importance of communication in a variety of contexts including that of the manager of innovation and change.
- To evaluate and discuss the characteristics of good communication and how to improve our communication.

Communication is a two-way process of giving and receiving information through any number of channels. Whether one is speaking informally to a colleague, addressing a conference or meeting, writing a newsletter article or formal report, the following basic principles apply:

- Know your audience.
- Know your purpose.
- Know your topic.
- Anticipate objections.
- Present a rounded picture.
- Achieve credibility with your audience.
- Follow through on what you say.
- Communicate a little at a time.
- Present information in several ways.
- Develop a practical, useful way to get feedback.
- Use multiple communication techniques.

Communication is complex. When listening to or reading someone else's message, we often filter what's being said through a screen of our own opinions. One of the major barriers to communication is our own ideas and opinions.

There's an old communications game, telegraph, that's played in a circle. A message is whispered around from person to person. What the exercise usually proves is how profoundly the message changes as it passes through the distortion of each person's inner "filter."

Environmental Factors

Communication can be influenced by environmental factors that have nothing to do with the content of the message. Some of these factors are:

- the nature of the room, how warm it is, smoke, comfort of the chair, etc
- outside distractions, what is going on in the area.
- the reputation/credibility of the speaker/writer.
- the appearance, style or authority of the speaker.
- listener's education, knowledge of the topic, etc.
- the language, page layout, design of the message.

People remember:

- 10% of what they read
- 20% of what they hear
- 30% of what they see
- 40% of what they hear and see.

Communication with Decision Makers

Innovation and change often depends upon persuading potential users of the benefits of an innovation. To deal persuasively with decision makers, it is necessary to know

and understand their interests and opinions. The following questions are helpful in organizing technology transfer efforts:

- Who are the key people to persuade?
- Who will make the decisions about innovation and change?
- What are these decision makers' past experiences with innovation and change?
- What are the decision makers' current attitudes toward innovation and change? Are they neutral, friendly, hostile or apathetic?
- What is the most appropriate way to approach the decision maker?
- What are the work styles of the decision makers? Are they highly formal people who want everything in writing and all appointments scheduled in advance? Or are they more flexible, responding favourably to personal telephone calls and informal meetings?
- What networks or groups is the decision maker a part of?
- What programs or services will the new innovation improve?
- What programs or services will the new innovation cause problems with?
- How will the innovation or change benefit the decision maker?

Principles of Effective Persuasion

Whether making a formal presentation at a meeting or writing a report or fact sheet, the following principles hold.

- Do not oversell or overstate your case. Make effective use of understatement.
- Outline the topic you are trying to cover into two parts. The first part should give broad background information, while the second part provides a detailed summary.
- Persuasion depends on clarity and simplicity. Avoid the use of jargon and buzz words.
- Be prepared to back up claims or facts immediately.
- Incorporate major anticipated objections into your program or presentation.
- Address all relevant aspects of a topic, especially those that may affect the functioning of an organization.
- Use graphics and audiovisuals appropriately.
- Consider ways to get meaningful input from people. Find out what they think about the innovation or change.

Selling New Ideas

Creating Isn't Selling

Often the creators of an innovation feel that convincing others of the idea's value is somehow superfluous to their activities. To them, conceiving the idea is enough. This combines with their inner conviction that their idea will "sell itself." Change agents provide a link between creators of new techniques and users.

Ideas Need Selling

Someone must recognize when an idea is good. It is important that when an idea is good it is sold to those who can act on it—those who have the power to evaluate and adopt it. Understanding users is an important activity for any change agent. People must be convinced that a particular idea or innovation has enough merit to warrant adoption.

Selling Ideas Takes Effort

Selling innovations requires preparation, initiative, patience, and resourcefulness. It may take more effort than originating the idea. In an age of technical complexity and information overload, new ideas seldom stand out. Information on new ideas must be targeted to the appropriate users and relate to their needs and motivations.

Once is Not Enough

A new idea has to be suggested many times before it will “catch on.” Initial failures at promoting a new idea are to be expected, so don’t get discouraged if you don’t get the results you want the first time. Some ideas take years to catch on. However, first exposures are crucial to future prospects. Do it right the first time

Feedback (Listening)

Getting and giving feedback is one of the most crucial parts of good communication. Like any other activity, there are specific skills that can enhance feedback. Listening is a key part of getting feedback:

Listen to the Complete Message. Be patient. This is especially important when listening to a topic that provokes strong opinions or radically different points-of-view. In these situations, it’s important not to prejudge the incoming message. Learn not to get too excited about a communication until you are certain of the message.

Work at Listening Skills. Listening is hard work. Good listeners demonstrate interest and alertness. They indicate through their eye contact, posture and facial expression that the occasion and the speaker’s efforts are a matter of concern to them.

Most good listeners provide speakers with clear and unambiguous feedback.

Judge the Content, Not the Form of the Message. Such things as the speaker’s mode of dress, quality of voice, delivery mannerisms and physical characteristics are often used as excuses for not listening. Direct your attention to the message—what is being said—and away from the distracting elements.

Weigh Emotionally Charged Language. Emotionally charged language often stands in the way of effective listening. Filter out “red flag” words (like “liberal” and “conservative,” for instance) and the emotions they call up.

Specific suggestions for dealing with emotionally charged words include

- Take time to identify those words that affect you emotionally.
- Attempt to analyse why the words affect you the way they do.
- Work at trying to reduce the impact of these words on you.

Eliminate Distractions. Physical distractions and complications seriously impair listening. These distractions may take many forms: loud noises, stuffy rooms, overcrowded conditions, uncomfortable temperature, bad lighting, etc. Good listeners speak up if the room is too warm, too noisy, or too dark.

There are also internal distractions: worries about deadlines or problems of any type may make listening difficult. If you're distracted, make an effort to clear your head. If you can't manage it, arrange to communicate at some other time. Think Efficiently and Critically. On the average, we speak at a rate of 100 to 200 words per minute. However, we think at a much faster rate, anywhere from 400 to 600 words per minute. What do we do with this excess thinking time while listening to someone speak?

One technique is to apply this spare time to analysing what is being said. They critically review the material by asking the following kinds of questions:

- What is being said to support the speaker's point of view? (Evidence)
- What assumptions are being made by the speaker and the listener? (Assumptions)
- How does this information affect me? (Effect)
- Can this material be organized more efficiently? (Structure)
- Are there examples that would better illustrate what is being said? (Example)
- What are the main points of the message? (Summary)

Sending Messages

Messages should be clear and accurate, and sent in a way that encourages retention, not rejection.

- **Use Verbal Feedback Even If Nonverbal Is Positive And Frequent.** Everyone needs reassurance that they are reading nonverbal communication correctly, whether a smile means "You're doing great," "You're doing better than most beginners," or "You'll catch on eventually."
- **Focus Feedback On Behavior Rather Than On Personality.** It's better to comment on specific behavior than to characterize a pattern of behavior. For example, instead of calling a colleague inefficient, specify your complaint: "You don't return phone calls; this causes problems both in and outside your office."
- **Focus Feedback On Description Rather Than Judgment.** Description tells what happened. Judgment evaluates what happened. For example, in evaluating a report don't say, "This is a lousy report!!" Instead, try: "The report doesn't focus on the information that I think needs emphasis," or "This report seems to have a lot of grammatical and spelling mistakes."
- **Make Feedback Specific Rather Than General.** If feedback is specific, the receiver knows what activity to continue or change. When feedback is general, the receiver doesn't know what to do differently. For example, in an office

situation, instead of saying “These folders are not arranged correctly,” it’s better feedback to say, “These should be arranged chronologically instead of alphabetically.”

- In Giving Feedback, Consider the Needs and Abilities of the Receiver. Give the amount of information the receiver can use and focus feedback on activities the receiver has control over. It’s fruitless to criticize the level of activity, if the decision to grant the necessary monies for materials, personnel or technology is made at a different level.
- Check to See if the Receiver Heard What You Meant to Say. If the information is important enough to send, make sure the person understands it. One way of doing this is to say, “I’m wondering if I said that clearly enough. What did you understand me to say?” or “This is what I hear you saying. Is that right?”

Selecting the Best Communication Method

In communicating with decision makers, use the most appropriate communications method. One way to do this is to ask yourself the following questions.

- What is the purpose of your message? Do you plan to tell them something new? Inform? Do you plan to change their view? Persuade?
- What facts must be presented to achieve your desired effect?
- What action, if any, do you expect decision makers to take?
- What general ideas, opinions and conclusions must be stressed?
- Are you thoroughly familiar with all the important information on the innovation?
- What resources and constraints affect adoption of the innovation? How much time is available? How much money is available
- Which method, or combination of methods, will work most effectively for this situation? Personal contact—requires scheduling, time and interpersonal skills.

Telephone contact—requires good verbal skills and an awareness of voice tones as nonverbal communication.

Letter—requires writing skills.

e-mail-informal, needs to be short and to the point, but not get lost in clutter. May require frequent follow-up.

News release—requires writing skills and cooperation of the media and time.

Strategies To Improve Communication Skills

Effective communication is one of the biggest factors in successful leadership. Without good communication skills, managers often fail to gain commitment from employees, achieve business goals and develop rapport with the people on their team. In short, they can fail as leaders—no matter how good their intentions—if they fail to be good communicators. The good news? Managers can enhance their communication skills by committing to and practicing these five key strategies:

1. Listening.
2. Facilitating.
3. Questioning.
4. Using discretion.
5. Directing.

First and foremost, the most effective leaders know when to stop talking and start listening. This is especially important in three situations: when emotions are high, in team situations and when employees are sharing ideas. Extreme emotions, such as anger, resentment and excitement, warrant attention for both personal and business reasons.

On a personal level, people feel acknowledged when others validate their feelings, and when managers ignore feelings, they create distance between themselves and their employees. From a business perspective, emotions can also interfere with clear thinking. Allowing employees to address their emotions helps them move beyond the situation at hand and get back to business. Managers can develop stronger relationships with their employees while enhancing productivity simply by listening to their employees when emotions are high.

Listening also is critical in team situations, which involve multiple personalities, complex dynamics and competing agendas. By listening carefully, managers can ensure that everyone is working toward the same goal. Listening also helps managers identify and address conflicts early, as well as facilitate healthy working relationships among team members. Third, listening is vital when employees are sharing ideas. When managers stop listening to ideas, employees stop offering them, and managers are essentially cut off from the creativity and expertise of the people on their team. The basic fundamentals of good listening include the following:

- Attending closely to what's being said, instead of focusing on what you want to say next.
- Allowing others to finish speaking before taking a turn.
- Repeating back what you've heard to give the speaker the opportunity to clarify the message.

Facilitating communication goes beyond listening; you're actually leading a conversation. Good facilitation consists of a continuous cycle of three steps: hearing what is said, integrating it into the topic at hand and saying something to move the conversation forward. For example, imagine a manager facilitating a meeting in which she and her team are developing goals for the coming year. The conversation might sound something like this:

Manager: As we develop our goals for next year, it's important that we hear from everyone in the department. What are your ideas?

Employee 1: I think it's important that we get productivity up. I notice we have a pretty relaxed pace around here, and it gets frustrating when some people are working hard and others seem to be contributing less than others.

Manager: OK, so we need improved productivity. What would that look like as a goal?

Employee 2: Actually, I think it's more a matter of setting a higher sales goal than improving productivity in the office. We don't just need to be busier, we need to get better results.

Manager: I see. So the idea is that we should set higher sales goals for everyone, which would consequently address the productivity issue. Is that right?

Employees: Yes.

Note that the manager repeated what she heard so that the employees could verify its accuracy. She also integrated each comment into the topic at hand—tying the first employee's frustration with productivity to the task—goal-setting—and connecting the second employee's point about sales to the topic on the table—productivity. Although her employees were providing the input, the manager stayed focused on the task of preparing goals and led all comments in that direction.

Good facilitation skills help managers become leaders because they are able to garner the input of everyone in a group while keeping them focused on the task. It's especially useful when guiding a team toward a desired outcome, such as developing a strategic plan, putting together a joint project or coordinating activities.

Questioning is how we get information, but it's important to remember that different kinds of questions yield different kinds of results. For example:

- Closed questions elicit yes/no answers. Use them when you simply need to check the status of an issue. Has the report been completed? Do you know what to do? Can you get that to me by Friday?
- Open questions elicit longer responses. Use them almost anytime you want more than a yes/no answer, such as seeking input from others, looking for information about a particular topic or exploring a problem. What do you think would be the best way to go about this? How are you doing on that project? What went wrong? These kinds of questions give others the chance to provide the information they have and to avoid the innumerable consequences that can come when leaders make assumptions without becoming well-informed.
- Personal questions have a special role in leadership. Inappropriate personal questions, such as asking direct reports if they are dating anyone, can alienate employees. Appropriate personal questions, however, can create a sense of camaraderie between employee and boss. Ask whether employees had a nice weekend, inquire about their families or follow up on common interests to connect on a personal level.

Knowing when not to speak as a leader is just as important as speaking. Managers must understand that the moment they don a new title, they become a leader—one who others look to for guidance, direction and even protection. Good leaders adopt a policy of discretion, if not confidentiality, with their employees. Only then can they develop

the trust that is so vital to productivity. Confidential situations may arise in a number of areas, personal and professional, including the following:

- An employee involved in a direct conflict with another employee.
- An employee concerned about another employee's conduct.
- An employee's declining performance.
- An employee's health issue or personal problem.
- An employee's desire for advice on how to excel without being seen as cozying up to the boss.

In any of these cases, the employee is facing circumstances that affect him personally *and* could affect business if not addressed effectively. By inviting a confidential conversation, you could help your employee discuss a situation openly and develop strategies to handle it well. But if your trustworthiness is questionable, your employee won't believe a candid discussion is possible.

To communicate that you can be trusted, tell employees directly that you are always available for private conversations when needed. This further assures employees that the conversation will be kept confidential. Then keep that promise. Remember, actions speak louder than words. Employees doubt the discretion of managers who talk behind their employees' backs, gossip or show favoritism of any kind, which leads to communication shut down.

Directing comes last on the list of communication strategies because it is the one strategy that should be used less often. Many managers direct their employees because they believe it's the only way to get things done. It's not. The other forms of communication discussed above—listening, facilitating, questioning, using discretion—are better able to get employees working more productively in a spirit of cooperation and in a more friendly environment than directing.

But directing has its place, when you want to give directions clearly and unequivocally so that employees know exactly what to do and when. It's best used in times of confusion or when efficiency is the most important goal. Although it can be effective, directing also can lead to complacency on the part of employees who may adopt an "I just do what they tell me" attitude. Use it sparingly.

Improve managers' communication skills

From my observation, about 60% of corporate public relations effort is devoted to internal communication because good communication is at the heart of every good workplace.

Despite all the emphasis on electronic communication these days, the most frequent and important means of workplace communication is still face-to-face.

What's more, studies have shown that communication is the most common activity of management. Managers typically spend 60-80% of their time in operational communication. In large part, communication *is* their work – mainly face-to-face in meetings, or by telephone or email.

Unfortunately, most managers are poor communicators. In a 2002 survey of 1,104 employees in organizations around the United States, 86% said their bosses thought they were good communicators, but only 17% said their bosses actually communicated effectively.

A 2004 international survey conducted by Melcrum Publishing of 712 communication and HR practitioners found that the quality of communication of operational managers was generally poor. Only 14% of communicators rated operational managers in their organization as “good” or “very good”.

The managers were confident and knew their business but were poor at managing and representing their own staff. The biggest problem areas were reported to be managers’ skills at communicating upwards the views and concerns of their team, managers not acting as leaders, and not knowing their employees’ needs.

Respondents blamed the managers for the problems because they said the managers didn’t make the effort to communicate even though they had the time.

However, in most cases management policies allow communication problems to develop. Only 20% of respondents said their organization measured the communication performance of their managers. Of those organizations, the most common measure, 70%, was “changes in employee satisfaction”, which is only an indirect measure. The second most common measure was 360-degree feedback (59%), which depends heavily on the way it is administered. Another common measure was “changes to employees’ understanding of the business strategy/goals” (54%), but improvements in knowledge of business imperatives could occur for reasons other than communication from their manager.

More than half the organizations (54%) gave no communication training to any level of manager.

Respondents revealed three main barriers to rewarding and recognizing effective communication:

1. Lack of a method to measure communication performance (32% of the organizations).
2. The organizational culture didn’t include recognizing communication as a core competency for managers (32%).
3. A lack of buy-in from senior management to make communication a performance measure (25%). 2

But as a PR manager, you can hardly place *all* the blame at the feet of your operational managers – because the problem is partly of your own making! It is your job to push for communication competencies to be defined and measured, and it is your job to initiate communication training for managers.

Some ways to improve managers’ workplace communication

Good communication skills are not just the realm of PR people. The PR department provides a support service to management, but this service isn’t a substitute for people

who may lack the necessary communication skills. Managers and other leaders need to develop and use their own communication skills to be effective in their work and their relationships with others. They can't fall back on the PR department to do their communication for them, even though some people continue to think that the PR department is responsible in general terms for all formal organizational communication. They don't realize that every manager needs to take the responsibility for communicating within their own sphere of activities and especially with their own staff.

The job descriptions of almost all managers and supervisors include good communication skills as an essential component because everyone knows that good leadership depends on good communication. For example, 'highly developed communication and negotiation skills', 'strong communication skills', 'effective communication skills' are common.

This is fine, but what happens next?

- In what way are good communication skills necessary to being a good manager?
- What actually are good communication skills?
- Who should the skills be important to?
- How should communication skills be measured?

Most managers are poor communicators, but since communication is largely intangible and often not reinforced as a priority by senior management, poor communicators are largely unaccountable.

How can the managers be accountable? What can be done to improve their application of communication skills?

One answer is that good communication practices can be built into the performance requirements that most managers and supervisors have these days to cover their day-to-day work responsibilities. These practices can be measured in various ways.

The performance management agreements of these people should include acceptable targets and measures of communication activities. You can advise the HR department on suitable activity targets and measurement processes to set for managers.

For instance, the performance agreement for one divisional general manager included the following activities (the dates have been changed):

- Conduct a communication audit of managers and staff in the division by 15 December.
- Develop an internal communication strategy by 31 March.
- Prepare a stakeholder relations strategy by 1 July.
- Undertake an attitude survey of medium and high priority external stakeholder groups by 30 June [the following year].

You can arrange training for managers on interpersonal communication skills, which should include topics such as:

- How to measure the quality of your personal communication.
- Recognize barriers to good communication.

- Develop behaviors to enhance your working relationships.
- Understand the importance of non-verbal communication.
- How to develop active listening skills.
- How to deal with difficult people.
- How best to give and receive feedback.

Communication activities could include:

- conducting an annual communication audit of each manager's area of responsibility;
- conducting an annual stakeholder attitude survey;
- holding a periodic workshop or team session on staff communication;
- holding regular face-to-face team briefings for the staff who report directly to the managers (their 'direct reports');
- producing a regular newssheet or informal email newsletter for their staff, depending on the number of people in their area of responsibility;
- establishing a hotline in which staff can telephone them directly about any concerns or suggestions;
- setting aside a regular available time for staff to see them about any concerns;
- conducting regular work progress review meetings;
- regular informal review meetings with staff members rather than the standard formal quarterly or six monthly performance review;
- organizing a minimum number of staff recognition activities within their area.

Improve Communication Skills in the Workplace

Communication skills are an essential component of a productive workplace, allowing employees to work together cohesively and professionally. Small business owners can do well to hire employees with solid communication skills, and there are also ways to improve communications skills in the workplace to boost employee productivity. Improving employee communication skills through training exercises and behavior modeling can give your company a competitive edge.

Step 1: Include communication skills in employee training programs. Some people are inherently more social than others, but anyone can learn and practice effective communication skills to increase personal effectiveness on the job. Teach new employees the fundamentals of good communication, including listening skills, the concept of encoding and online communication challenges.

Step 2: Model excellent communication skills to leverage the social learning theory. The individual personalities of small business owners can have a large impact on the culture that develops in their companies. Employees who spend a lot of time working alongside company owners may begin to model the communication style of their bosses. Take an inventory of your personal communication habits to gain insight into any communication problems your employees are having. If you consistently provide a model of professional, respectful communication, your employees will take notice.

Step 3: Promote your most effective communicators into supervisory positions to set the tone in the company. Your managers set the bar for employee performance just as you do as the business owner. Make sure all your managers understand your commitment to modeling effective communication skills. Your managers should be confident and develop their own communication styles as they gain experience on the job.

Step 4: Include communication skills in performance appraisals. Tying company objectives into performance appraisals is a proven way to motivate employees to achieve organizational goals. If communication is a significant issue in your workplace, consider setting personal goals for improving communication skills for each employee, and giving incentive awards to employees who meet these goals.

Step 5: Develop team-building exercises to strengthen intra-office communication. High-performance teams become more cohesive over time as they gain experience working and communicating with each other. Exciting activities that require employees to work together can speed up the team-building process, allowing team members to learn the best ways to communicate with others in the team through experience.

How to Manage a Business Effectively

Manage a business effectively, manage a company, is the key to the establishment and growth of the business. The key to successful management is to examine the marketplace environment and create employment and profit opportunities that provide the potential growth and financial viability of the business. Despite the importance of management, this area is often misunderstood and poorly implemented, primarily because people focus on the output rather than the process of management.

Toward the end of the 1980s, business managers became absorbed in improving product quality, sometimes ignoring their role vis-a-vis personnel. The focus was on reducing costs and increasing output, while ignoring the long-term benefits of motivating personnel. This shortsighted view tended to increase profits in the short term, but created a dysfunctional long-term business environment.

Simultaneously with the increase in concern about quality, entrepreneurship attracted the attention of business. A sudden wave of successful entrepreneurs seemed to render earlier management concepts obsolete. The popular press focused on the new cult heroes Steve Jobs and Steve Wozniack (creators and developers of the Apple Computer) while ignoring the marketing and organizing talents of Mike Markula, the executive responsible for Apple's business plan. The story of two guys selling their Volkswagen bus to build the first Apple computer was more romantic than that of the organizational genius that enabled Apple to develop, market and ship its products while rapidly becoming a major corporation.

In large businesses, effective manage business skills requires planning. Planning is essential for developing a firm's potential. However, many small businesses do not recognize the need for long-range plans, because the small number of people involved

in operating the business implies equal responsibility in the planning and decision-making processes. Nevertheless, the need for planning is as important in a small business as it is in a large one.

This guide focuses on the importance of good management practices. Specifically, it addresses the responsibilities of managing the external and internal environments.

Managing The External Environment

Five decades ago, Alvin Toffler suggested that the vision of the citizen in the tight grip of an omnipotent bureaucracy would be replaced by an organizational structure of ad-hocracy. The traditional business organization implied a social contract between employees and employers. By adhering to a fixed set of obligations and sharply defined roles and responsibilities, employees received a predefined set of rewards.

The organizational structure that Toffler predicted in 1970 became the norm 20 years later, and with it came changed concepts of authority. As organizations became more transitory, the authority of the organization and firm was replaced by the authority of the individual manager. This entrepreneurial management model is now being replicated throughout society. As a result, the individual business owner must internalize ever increasing organizational functions.

Another change in today's business environment is dealing with government agencies. Their effect on the conduct of business most recently appears to have increased. As industries fail to achieve high levels of ethical behavior or individual businesses exhibit specific lapses, the government rushes in to fill the breach with its regulations.

Managing The Internal Environment

Human Resource Issues

Ensuring Open Communications

Effective communications play an integral role in managing and operating any successful business. With open communications changes and their effects on the organization are quickly shared. Your firm then has the time and skills needed to respond to changes and take advantage of evolving opportunities.

The following checklist addressing how you would respond to an employee's suggestion provides an assessment of the communication process in your business. Place a check next to the statements that are commonly heard in your business.

Statement

Face facts it's unrealistic. ——

Who else has done it? ——

It's not your problem. ——

Fill out form XX/xx revised. ——

It won't work. ——
Bring it to the committee. ——
We don't have the time. ——
We tried it before and it failed. ——
You think what? You're joking! ——
Everybody knows that that's foolish. ——
We can't afford to think about it. ——
Don't you have better things to do? ——
Are you some kind of a radical? ——
We're too small/big for that. ——
Impossible; our main product line would be obsolete. ——
The boss would never consider it. ——
It's contrary to company policy. ——

Carefully consider any statements that you have checked. This may indicate that management is inflexible and unresponsive to employee suggestions. Management that is unable to respond immediately to changes in the market signals an inflexible unstable firm. In the rapidly changing business environment such management can mean eventual failure for your business. If you haven't developed such a checklist do so. It will help you determine if and where adjustments are needed in your management staff.

Balancing Schedules Stress and Personnel

Without organization and good management the compressed time schedules associated with modern business can cause stress and make extraordinary demands on people. An effective management structure can reduce stress and channel the productive capacity of employees into business growth and profits.

Setting Duties Tasks and Responsibilities

An organization is characterized by the nature and determination of employees' duties tasks and responsibilities. While many organizations use different methods for determining these it is essential that they be clearly defined.

The core of any organization is its people and their functions. Duties tasks and responsibilities often evolve in an ad hoc manner. A typical firm starts with a few people often one performing all duties. As the firm grows others are hired to fill specific roles often on a functional basis. Roles that were handled by consultants and specialists outside the firm now are handled internally. As new needs emerge new roles are developed.

Just as an emerging business develops an accounting system it should also develop a human resource system. For instance the following employee information should be available and checked for accuracy at least once each year.

- Name
- Address

- Nationality (immigration status)
- Marital status and dependents
- Hire date
- Company job history:
- Title and code
- Performance
- Location
- Salary rate and history
- Education including degrees
- Specialty training
- Transcripts as appropriate
- Pre-employment work experience:
- Key responsibilities and levels
- Professional licenses or certificates
- Professional publication and speaking engagements
- Teaching experience
- Language abilities:
- Reading
- Writing
- Speaking
- Leadership evidence:
- Company
- Civic
- Other
- Relocation preferences and limitations
- Travel experience and preferences
- Career goals

Review your personnel files periodically to ensure that the information is correct and current. Implement a system that will make updating personnel files a fairly simple routine yet confidential process.

Business Team

The apex of an effective organization lies in developing the business team. Such a team involves delegating authority and increasing productivity. Assess the effectiveness of your business team with the following checklist:

The leader of the team is respected by the members. ——

The abilities of all team members are respected. ——

A team spirit is evident through activities. ——

Individual members compensate for weaknesses in each other. ——

Jokes are not disparaging. ——

A genuine feeling of being part of the best is exuded. —

The work area is self-delineated and reflects a spirit. ——
Mistakes result in corrective action not retribution. ——
Each member understands the importance of his or her contribution. ——
The team can explore new areas of activity. ——
Security of employment is evident. ——

Controlling Conflict

Another key to successful management lies in controlling conflict. Conflict cannot be eliminated from either the business or the interpersonal activities of the enterprise. A measure of the organization's success is the degree to which conflict can be exposed and the energies associated with it channeled to develop the firm. Although establishing policies and procedures represents the tangible aspect of organization and management the mechanisms to tolerate and embody challenges to the established operation serve as the real essence of a firm that will survive and prosper.

Structural Issues

Organization

The effectiveness of a particular organizational form depends on a variety of internal and external events for example:

- Competitors (number or activity)
- Technology (internal or external)
- Regulatory environment
- Customer characteristics
- Supplier characteristics
- Economic environment
- Key employees
- Growth
- Strategy (including new products and markets)

Even though you may discover that certain events are affecting your business be careful not to change the organizational structure of your firm without discussing it with your management team. Employees generally can accomplish goals despite organizational structures imposed by management. Because restructuring involves spending a lot of time learning new rules implementing a new organizational structure is costly.

Structure

The essence of a successful organization can be more simply summarized than implemented. The following checklist can help you determine measures to ensure your management structure is adequate. Check the entries that apply to your firm and also find out what measures your company needs to take to improve its management structure.

- Key market and customers are understood. ——
- Technology is mastered. ——
- Key objectives are articulated and shared. ——
- Major functions are identified and staffed. ——
- A hierarchy of relationships is established. ——
- A business team is in place and functioning. ——
- Measurable results are well above industry standards. ——
- Employees are the best source of new hires. ——

Policy and Procedural Issues

Authority

The central element of organizational management is authority. Through authority your firm develops the structure necessary to achieve its objectives. A. L. Stinchcombe summarized the role of authority succinctly when he stated any administrative system that decides on the use of resources is also a system of authority directing the activities of people. The authority that once was conferred by either owning a small business or having a position in the bureaucracy of a larger firm has been replaced by technical competence (including that of forming and running the business).

Forces external to your business may emphasize the elements of granted versus earned authority. Once the owner-manager controlled the entire business but suppliers customers unions and the government have severely limited the ability of the business owner-manager to take independent action.

A primary component of authority is the exercise of control within the organization. A thorough system of controls ensures the firm's operation and provides a mechanism for imposing authority. Internal controls include the provision that authority be delegated and circumscribed; examples of these provisions follow. Place a check by the provisions that apply to your firm. Consider implementing controls over areas that you have not checked.

- Approval for disbursements of cash and regular accounting. ——
- Reconciliation of bank statements. ——
- Periodic count and reconciliation of inventory records. ——
- Approval of pricing policies and exemptions. ——
- Approval of credit policies and exemptions. ——
- Review of expense and commission accounts. ——
- Approval of purchasing and receiving policies. ——
- Review of payments to vendors and employees. ——
- Approval of signature authorities for payments. ——
- Review of policies. ——

Delegation is a key to the effective exercise of authority in your business. By delegating limited authority to accomplish specific tasks the talents of employees in the

organization can be used to upgrade the skills and experience of the manager. The following checklist enables you to determine if you are taking advantage of opportunities to delegate authority.

Is your time consumed by daily chores? ——

Do you have time for the following:

- Training and development of subordinates? ——
- Planning? ——
- Coordinating and controlling work of subordinates? ——
- Visiting customers and subordinates regularly? ——
- Remaining involved in new product development? ——
- Visiting branch locations regularly? ——
- Attending business meetings outside your business? ——
- Participating in civic affairs? ——

Is no one on your staff as good as you are? ——

To effectively delegate responsibility and authority in your organization you must:

- Accept the power of delegation.
- Know the capabilities of subordinates.
- Ensure that specific training is available.
- Select specific responsibilities to be delegated.
- Clearly define the extent and limits of delegation.
- Match each with necessary authority.
- Provide periodic monitoring and interest.
- Restrain the impulse to insist on how to do something.
- Remember there are many ways to accomplish a specific objective.
- Assess results and provide appropriate feedback.
- Praise and criticize.

The skills and abilities of each level of authority can be increased by effectively delegating authority throughout any organization.

Operating Reports

Operating reports form the organizational basis of your business. Such reports mirror the organization its structure and function. They define key relationships between employees and can either minimize or increase organizational stress.

For many businesses the following reports form the basis for analyzing the specific areas of a business (the frequency of each report depends on the nature size and organization of your business). Check the reports your firm currently generates.

Consider creating reporting systems where they are lacking.

- Case reports (daily, weekly, monthly) ——
- New orders and backlog (weekly, monthly) ——
- Shipments/sales (weekly, monthly) ——
- Employment (monthly) ——

- Inventory out of stock (weekly, monthly) ——
- Product quality (weekly, monthly) ——
- Accounts receivable aging accounts (monthly) ——
- Weekly overdue accounts ——
- Returns and allowances (monthly) ——
- Production (weekly, monthly) ——

Reporting must be kept current to allow for timely identification and correction of problems before serious damage to the organization occurs.

Too much reporting as well as inappropriate reporting can be as destructive as too little reporting. For instance the CEO of a major industrial firm who receives daily production and inventory reports by model can lose his or her ability to maintain an overall perspective.

Thus operating managers must attempt to identify and solve local problems and take advantage of local opportunities within their own authority. Inappropriate reporting compromises management's ability to leverage individual skills and abilities.

Operating reports not only provide essential data that enable management to accomplish its objectives they also focus staff's attention on the organization's goals.

If reporting is not taken seriously employees may deal with customers suppliers and each other in a similarly trivial manner.

To avoid inappropriate reporting review reporting policies annually to ensure that reports are appropriate and contain the information needed to make sound management decisions.

Conclusion

Successful management is founded on the mastery of a myriad of details. While management schools teach the importance of focusing attention on major issues affecting the business practical managers realize the major issues are the variety of small aspects that form the business. In an increasingly structured society inattention to even one minor detail can result in significant disruption of the business or even its failure.

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